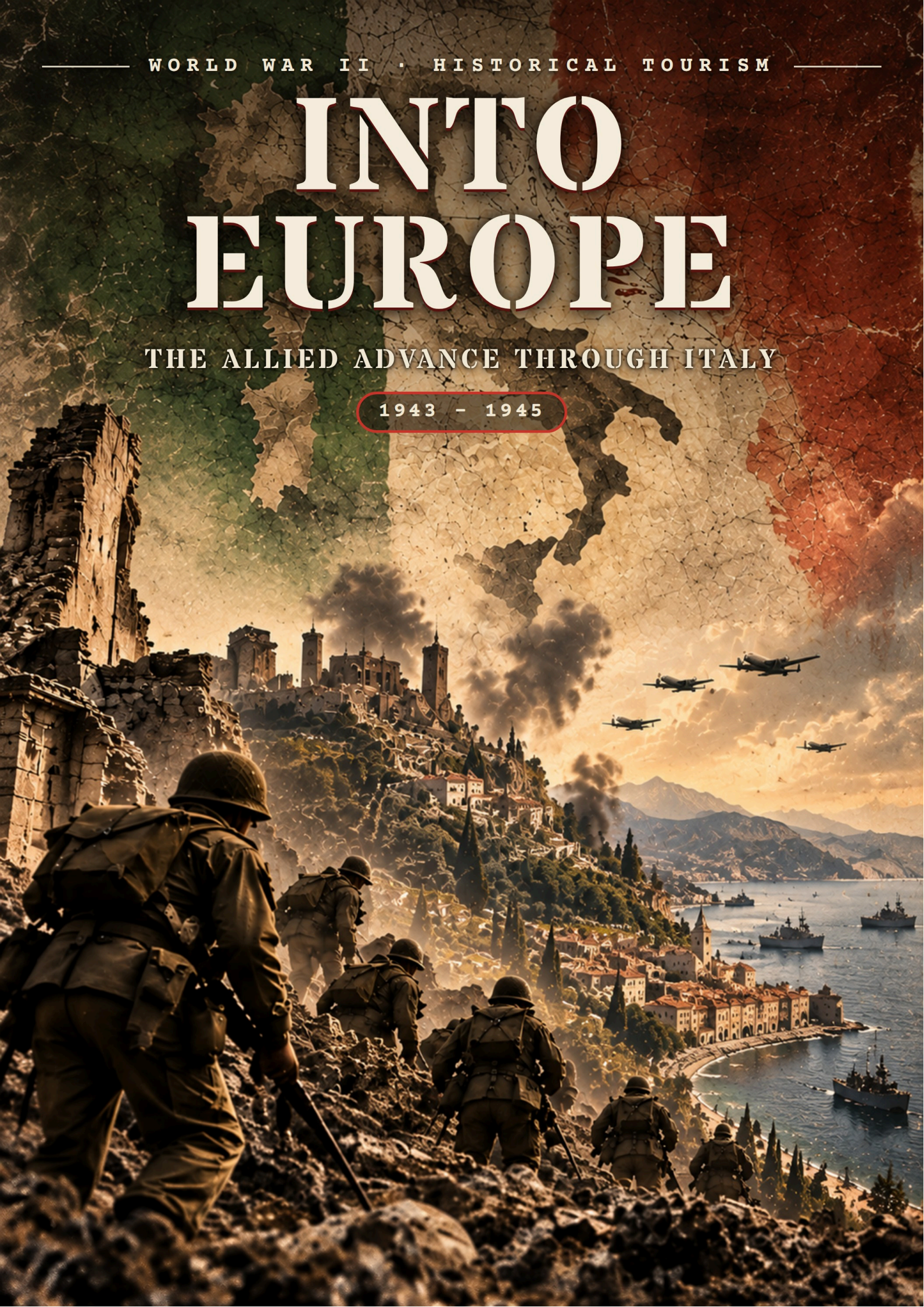
WORLD WAR II · HISTORICAL TOURISM

INTO EUROPE

THE ALLIED ADVANCE THROUGH ITALY

1943 - 1945



INTO EUROPE

The Allied advance through Italy · Sicily · Salerno · Cassino · Anzio · Rome · the Gothic Line · the Po

10 JUL 1943 – 2 MAY 1945



Overview · red dots = key sites · red lines = the Gustav and Gothic Lines (approx.) · tap to enlarge

Twenty-two months, a thousand miles of mountains and rivers, and soldiers from five continents. From the Sicilian beaches of July 1943 to the German surrender of 2 May 1945, the Allied advance through Italy lasted almost two

years — about twice as long as the campaign in north-west Europe that began on D-Day. This guide takes you the whole way — landing beaches, mountain battlefields, liberated cities, war cemeteries and museums — and tells you what happened where, and how sure we can be.

ORDERS — WHERE TO GO FROM HERE

STANDING ORDERS

Accuracy. A pin marked LOW is the centre of a search area, not a foxhole. **Respect.** The war cemeteries and memorials are places of remembrance first; many battlefields are farms and private land — view from the road. **Safety.** Mountain roads are slow and narrow: allow extra time, and never pick up old ammunition.

Read the Briefing first: it explains the Timeline and Tour tabs, the HIGH, MEDIUM and LOW accuracy labels and the words the soldiers used. Then follow the campaign in date order on the Timeline, or plan the drive on the Tour — up to 21 days from Sicily to the Po. Allow extra time on mountain roads, check museum hours before you go, and at every cemetery and memorial, remembrance first, tour second.

BRIEFING

ORDERS OF THE DAY · READ BEFORE MOVING OUT

This guide follows the Allied armies through Italy for twenty-two months, from the landings on the beaches of Sicily on 10 July 1943 to the German surrender that came into force on 2 May 1945. It is a long road — well over 1,500 km by car from the Sicilian beaches to the plain of the Po — and two sets of positions are kept apart on purpose:

TIMELINE — historical positions in date order: what happened, where and when, and who was there. **TOUR** — driving stops in road order across up to 21 days: where to go, how long to stay and where to sleep. Drive the whole route or pick the days that suit you; each day stands on its own. Every stop opens directly in Google Maps.

THE ACCURACY RULE

A GPS coordinate can locate a museum, cemetery, bridge or town precisely; it cannot turn the confusion of a mountain battle into an exact point. When the records only place a battalion "somewhere on the ridge", this guide says so rather than invent a spot, and where historians disagree — over numbers, times or motives — the text tells you. Each position carries a coloured label:

HIGH	exact spot known — a landmark, museum, cemetery, memorial, bridge or town, or a position fixed by the records
MEDIUM	well supported, but the exact spot is uncertain
LOW	general area only — the pin is the centre of a search area

WORDS TO KNOW

15th Army Group	the Allied headquarters that ran the land war in Italy under Gen. Sir Harold Alexander — called Allied Armies in Italy for most of 1944
Fifth Army	the American-led army, usually on the western (Tyrrhenian) side, under Mark Clark and from December 1944 Lucian Truscott; it also included British, French, Brazilian and South African troops
Eighth Army	the British-led army of El Alamein fame, mostly on the eastern (Adriatic) side, with Canadian, New Zealand, Indian, Polish and other formations
Army Group C	the German command in Italy from November 1943 under Field Marshal Albert Kesselring, with the 10th and 14th Armies
Winter Line	the Allies' name for the belt of German positions south of Rome in late 1943, of which the Gustav Line was the strongest

Gustav Line	the main German defence line across Italy's narrow waist, anchored on the Garigliano and Rapido rivers and Monte Cassino
Gothic Line	Germany's last great defence line, across the northern Apennines from near La Spezia to the Adriatic near Pesaro
Co-belligerent	Italy's status after it declared war on Germany on 13 October 1943 — fighting on the Allied side without being a formal ally
RSI	the Italian Social Republic, Mussolini's German-backed state in the occupied north, often called the Republic of Salò
Partisans	armed Italian resistance fighters in the mountains and cities of the occupied centre and north
CLN	Committee of National Liberation — the alliance of anti-fascist parties that led the Resistance; in the north, the CLNAI in Milan
Goumier	a Moroccan soldier of the goums, lightly equipped units of the French Expeditionary Corps, famed for mountain fighting
DUKW	the "Duck" — a six-wheeled American amphibious truck, first used in large numbers in Sicily
LST	Landing Ship, Tank — a sea-going ship that ran onto a beach to unload tanks and lorries; there were never enough
Nebelwerfer	a German multi-barrelled rocket launcher — "Moaning Minnie" to British soldiers, for its howl
Schu-mine	a German anti-personnel mine in a small wooden box, almost invisible to metal detectors
Bailey bridge	the prefabricated steel bridge that carried the Allies over Italy's hundreds of blown crossings

Respect the ground. The war cemeteries on this route — Commonwealth, American, Polish, French, German and Italian — are places of remembrance first and tour stops second; dress and behave accordingly, and remember that the abbey of Monte Cassino is a working monastery with a dress code. In the Apennines and along the old river lines, shells, grenades and mines still surface every year: never touch or pick up a metal object — leave it, mark the spot in your mind and call 112. Many hilltop positions, farmhouses and river banks are private land: view them from roads and marked paths, and ask before crossing a field.

THE STORY IN BRIEF

Sicily. On 10 July 1943 the US Seventh Army under Patton and the British Eighth Army under Montgomery landed on 26 beaches along the south and east coasts of Sicily, after airborne drops that the wind scattered across the island. Patton swept west to Palermo while Montgomery ground up the east coast under Mount Etna; on 17 August American troops

entered Messina. By then more than 100,000 German and Italian troops had slipped across the Strait to the mainland. In Rome, the invasion brought down Mussolini on 25 July.

Salerno and Naples. Montgomery crossed to Calabria on 3 September — the day Italy secretly signed an armistice. It was announced on 8 September, and next morning Clark's Fifth Army, American and British divisions side by side, landed in the Gulf of Salerno. Germany was ready: it seized Rome, disarmed the Italian army and counter-attacked the beachhead on 12–14 September, coming close to splitting it. Naval gunfire, bombers and reinforcements held the line. Naples, which had risen against the Germans in the Four Days, was entered on 1 October.

The Winter Line and Ortona. Kesselring now made the Allies pay for every valley. Through the autumn rains the Fifth Army crossed the Volturno and fought for the mountain positions of the Winter Line — Monte Camino, San Pietro, Monte Lungo, where Italy's new co-belligerent troops fought their first battle — while the Eighth Army crossed the Sangro and the Moro on the Adriatic side. Over Christmas 1943 the 1st Canadian Division fought German paratroopers house by house through Ortona. By January the Allies stood in front of the Gustav Line.

Cassino and Anzio. To break the deadlock the Allies attacked the Gustav Line around Cassino from 17 January 1944 and landed behind it at Anzio on 22 January. Neither went to plan. The Anzio beachhead was sealed off and fought for its life for four months; three battles for Cassino — first by American, British and French troops, then twice by the New Zealand Corps with New Zealand, Indian and British units — broke down below the monastery, which Allied bombers destroyed on 15 February. The fourth battle, Operation Diadem, opened on 11 May; French colonial troops broke through the Aurunci mountains and on 18 May Polish soldiers raised their flag over the ruined abbey.

Rome and the pursuit. The Anzio force broke out on 23 May and met the main front on 25 May. Clark then turned most of it towards Rome instead of cutting the German line of retreat at Valmontone — a decision still argued over — and entered the city on 4 June, two days before D-Day in Normandy. Through the summer the pursuit ran north past Lake Trasimeno to Siena, Ancona, Livorno and Florence on the Arno. But seven American and French divisions were taken away for the landings in the south of France.

The Gothic Line and the winter. On 25 August the Eighth Army attacked the Gothic Line near the Adriatic; in September the Fifth Army struck through the mountain passes north of Florence. Both broke in, and Rimini fell on 21 September, but rain, exhaustion and German reserves stopped the Americans a few miles short of Bologna and the British in the flooded Romagna. Behind the front, SS and army units massacred civilians in anti-partisan sweeps —

at Sant'Anna di Stazzema in August and around Monte Sole (Marzabotto) at the turn of September and October. A hard mountain winter followed.

Victory in Italy. In spring 1945 the rebuilt armies struck again: the Eighth Army across the Senio on 9 April and through the Argenta Gap, the Fifth Army out of the mountains from 14 April. Polish and Italian troops entered Bologna on 21 April, the Allies raced over the Po, and the Resistance rose across the north, freeing Milan and Genoa. Mussolini was caught and shot by partisans on 28 April. German envoys signed the surrender at Caserta on 29 April; it came into force at 2 p.m. local time (12:00 GMT) on 2 May 1945, six days before VE Day.

WHY THE WHOLE ROUTE

Italy was not one battle but a chain of them, and each makes sense only beside the others. Driving it end to end shows the problem the armies faced: a long, narrow peninsula of mountains cut by rivers, where every ridge could become a new defence line. It shows who fought here — Americans and British, Canadians, New Zealanders, Indians and Gurkhas, Poles, French, Moroccans and Algerians, South Africans, Brazilians, Greeks, the Jewish Brigade, and Italians on both sides — and how heavily civilians paid. The tour follows their road north, stop by stop.

USING YOUR LOCATION

Tap the 📍 button at the top right and allow location when your phone asks. You then get a blue **YOU** dot on the maps, the distance and direction to every stop, a **Near me** list of the ten closest waypoints, and a pop-up when you reach one — within about 120 m of a green HIGH pin, 300 m of a yellow MEDIUM and 800 m of a red LOW area. The app has to be open on screen, and it works when opened from its web address (https://…). Mountain roads and deep valleys can make GPS jumpy, so treat distances as a guide. **Your location never leaves your phone** — nothing is sent or stored anywhere. Tap **Turn off** to stop.

USING THE MAP BUTTONS

The **Google Maps** button on every stop opens a pin on the exact waypoint — not directions from where you are — so you can see the spot first and ask for directions when you want them. On the Tour tab each day also has a big **Google Maps route** button that loads the whole day's stops, in order, as one route; in the mountains check that the route does not send you up an unpaved track. Tap ✓ on a stop to mark it visited — the tick is remembered on this device only.

WHERE THE SOURCES DISAGREE

This guide was written and then checked by independent researchers against official histories, war-graves and museum records and other sources. Where they could not agree, or a story is disputed, the text says so. The main cases:

- **Casualty figures.** Totals for the campaign differ between sources. Allied losses are usually given as about 310,000–330,000 killed, wounded and missing (60,000–70,000 dead); German losses were at least as high. Where sources disagree, this guide gives a range.
- **The bombing of Monte Cassino abbey.** On 15 February 1944 Allied bombers destroyed the abbey. The British and final US official histories conclude that German troops were not using the abbey before the bombing; some veterans and older accounts maintain otherwise. Most of the people killed inside were Italian civilians sheltering there; about 230 is one widely cited count.
- **Clark and Rome.** In late May 1944 General Mark Clark turned most of the Anzio breakout towards Rome instead of Valmontone, where it might have cut off the retreating German Tenth Army. Historians still argue whether this let the Germans escape; the guide gives both views and no verdict.
- **The Marocchinate.** In May–June 1944 soldiers of the French Expeditionary Corps, mostly Moroccan colonial troops, committed mass rapes and killings of Italian civilians. Estimates of the number of victims range from about 2,000 to 12,000 or more, depending on the source.
- **Prisoner killings and massacres.** US soldiers killed about 70 Italian and German prisoners near Biscari, Sicily, on 14 July 1943. German reprisal massacres such as the Fosse Ardeatine, Sant'Anna di Stazzema and Monte Sole (Marzabotto) killed hundreds at a time; victim counts vary between older and newer research, and the guide gives the ranges.
- **The Mafia and the invasion of Sicily.** A post-war story says the Mafia and Lucky Luciano smoothed the American advance. Historians have found no evidence that they influenced the fighting, though the Allied military government did later appoint some Mafia-linked figures to local posts.
- **Quotes and phrases.** Famous phrases such as Churchill's “soft underbelly” are hard to pin to a written source. The guide uses a quotation only where the wording and who said it could be checked; otherwise it paraphrases.
- **Map pins and battle maps.** Every pin carries an accuracy label. The battle maps are schematic: front lines, arrows and unit positions are drawn by hand from historical maps and are approximate.

ORIGINS — WHY THE ALLIES WENT INTO ITALY

BACKGROUND BRIEFING · READ BEFORE THE TIMELINE

In May 1943 the war in North Africa ended in an Allied victory, and the Allies found themselves with a great army in the Mediterranean and no agreement on what to do with it next. This page explains why they chose Sicily and then the Italian mainland, how Italy changed sides in the middle of the campaign, how the armies on both sides were organised, and what happened when — from the first landing to the last surrender.

1 · AFTER NORTH AFRICA

Victory in Tunisia. The last Axis forces in Tunisia surrendered on 13 May 1943. Around a quarter of a million German and Italian soldiers went into captivity (sources give figures between roughly 230,000 and 275,000), a loss on the scale of Stalingrad. The southern shore of the Mediterranean was now in Allied hands, and Italy — its fleet, its cities and its airfields within reach of Allied bombers — lay across a narrow sea.

Casablanca, January 1943. Roosevelt and Churchill and their chiefs of staff had met at Casablanca from 14 to 24 January 1943, while the fighting in Tunisia was still going on. The American planners, led by General George C. Marshall, wanted to concentrate everything on an invasion of France across the Channel as soon as possible. The British, led by Churchill and his army chief General Sir Alan Brooke, argued that it could not succeed in 1943 and that the forces already in the Mediterranean should not stand idle. The compromise was to invade Sicily next — Operation Husky — to reopen the Mediterranean to shipping and, it was hoped, to shake Italy out of the war. The conference also agreed a combined bomber offensive against Germany, and Roosevelt announced that the Allies would demand unconditional surrender.

Churchill against the planners. Churchill spoke of southern Europe as the Axis's "soft underbelly" — a phrase that stuck, although it comes from his conversation rather than his speeches or books, and the idea owed as much to Brooke. Knocking Italy out, the British argued, would force Germany to replace Italian troops in Italy and the Balkans, pull German divisions away from Russia and France, and give the Allies airfields close to southern Germany. The Americans feared an open-ended drain on the men and landing craft needed for France. At the Trident conference in Washington in May 1943 they compromised again: the cross-Channel invasion was fixed for May 1944, seven divisions would leave the Mediterranean for Britain that autumn, and Eisenhower was to plan operations to eliminate Italy from the war. The decision to land on the Italian mainland was taken in July, with the Sicilian campaign already under way.

Was it worth it? Historians still argue. Supporters of the campaign point to the German divisions held in Italy for almost two years, the airfields around Foggia from which the US Fifteenth Air Force bombed Austria, southern Germany and the Romanian oilfields, and Italy's surrender. Critics answer that a peninsula of mountains and rivers suited the defender, that the Allies tied down as many of their own troops as they did German ones, and that the cost — for soldiers and Italian civilians alike — was out of proportion to the result. Both views are found in the official histories and in modern accounts.

2 · ITALY LEAVES THE WAR

The fall of Mussolini. Defeat in Africa, invasion and bombing broke the regime's credibility. At a session of the Fascist Grand Council that ran through the night of 24–25 July 1943, a majority voted for Dino Grandi's motion asking the King to resume his full powers. On the afternoon of 25 July King Victor Emmanuel III dismissed Mussolini, had him arrested as he left the royal villa, and appointed Marshal Pietro Badoglio head of government. Crowds celebrated the end of Fascism in the streets — but Badoglio announced that the war would go on alongside Germany, and Germany poured divisions into Italy.

The armistice. Badoglio's envoys negotiated in secret. On 3 September 1943, in an army camp at Cassibile near Syracuse, General Giuseppe Castellano signed a short armistice with Eisenhower's chief of staff, Major General Walter Bedell Smith. It was made public by Eisenhower and Badoglio on the evening of 8 September, on the eve of the Salerno landing. Before dawn on 9 September the King, Badoglio and the high command left Rome for Brindisi, leaving the armed forces without clear orders.

Operation Achse. Germany had prepared for exactly this. In little more than two weeks its forces disarmed the Italian army in Italy, southern France and the Balkans and took Rome after brief fighting at Porta San Paolo. Some Italian units fought back: on the Greek island of Cephalonia the Acqui Division resisted, and thousands of its men were shot after they surrendered (the exact number is disputed). Somewhere between 600,000 and 700,000 Italian soldiers who refused to go on fighting for Germany were deported as "Italian Military Internees"; most estimates put their dead at roughly 37,000–50,000.

Two Italys. On 12 September German paratroopers freed Mussolini from his mountain prison on the Gran Sasso, and Hitler set him up at the head of the Italian Social Republic (RSI) — a Fascist state in the German-occupied north, run from Salò on Lake Garda under close German control. In the south the King's government declared war on Germany on 13 October 1943 and the Allies accepted Italy as a "co-belligerent". Its first troops, the 1st Motorised Group, fought at Monte Lungo in December 1943; by 1945 six Italian Combat Groups and

many thousands of support troops served alongside the Allied armies. Italians therefore fought on both sides until the end.

The Resistance. On 9 September 1943 the anti-fascist parties in Rome formed the Committee of National Liberation (CLN); in the occupied north its counterpart, the CLNAI in Milan, came to direct partisan bands of Communists, Socialists, the Action Party, Catholics, monarchists and former soldiers. Common estimates speak of around 100,000 partisans by summer 1944 and more than 250,000 at the rising of April 1945. They paid heavily — estimates of partisan dead range from about 35,000 to 50,000 — and German and Fascist reprisals deliberately killed at least 15,000 civilians. The war in the north was in part a civil war between Italians, and memories of it are still sensitive.

3 · How the armies were organised

Every rung is built from about three of the rung below it, plus a headquarters. British and Commonwealth divisions were built of brigades and battalions; American divisions of three regiments, each of three battalions. The example on the right follows the Canadian battalions that fought through Ortona at Christmas 1943. Figures are approximate establishments — units in Italy were usually under strength. Above the army group sat Allied Force Headquarters in the Mediterranean: Eisenhower, then General Sir Henry Maitland Wilson from January 1944, then Alexander from December 1944.

Army Group
2 armies + army troops · several hundred thousand men · General

15th Army Group (Allied Armies in Italy in 1944) — Gen. Sir Harold Alexander; Lt. Gen. Mark W. Clark from December 1944

IS MADE OF ▼

Field Army
2–4 corps · 100,000+ · Lieutenant General

Eighth Army — Gen. Sir Bernard Montgomery; Lt. Gen. Sir Oliver Leese from the end of 1943; Lt. Gen. Sir Richard McCreery from October 1944 · Fifth Army (US) — Lt. Gen. Mark W. Clark; Lt. Gen. Lucian K. Truscott from December 1944

IS MADE OF ▼

Corps
2–4 divisions · 30,000–60,000 · Lieutenant General

British V Corps — Lt. Gen. Charles Allfrey (Moro River and Ortona, December 1943)

IS MADE OF ▼

Division
3 brigades + artillery, engineers, signals, medics · ~17,000–18,000 · Major General

1st Canadian Infantry Division — Maj. Gen. Chris Vokes

IS MADE OF ▼

Brigade
3 infantry battalions + HQ · ~2,500 · Brigadier (US equivalent: a regiment under a colonel)

2nd Canadian Infantry Brigade — Brig. Bert Hoffmeister

IS MADE OF ▼

Battalion
4 rifle companies + support company (mortars, carriers, anti-tank guns) · ~800 · Lieutenant Colonel

The Loyal Edmonton Regiment and the Seaforth Highlanders of Canada — the two battalions that fought through Ortona's streets, 20–28 December 1943

IS MADE OF ▼

Company
3 rifle platoons + HQ · ~120 · Major or Captain

Rifle companies A–D — at Ortona they "mouseholed" from house to house through the walls rather than cross the streets

IS MADE OF ▼

Platoon · Section
Platoon: 3 sections · ~37 · Lieutenant. Section: ~10 riflemen around a Bren light machine gun · Corporal

The section was the Commonwealth equivalent of the American rifle squad of 12 under a sergeant

WHO FOUGHT ON THE ALLIED SIDE

Eighth Army at various times: British corps and divisions; I Canadian Corps (until it left for north-west Europe in February–March 1945); the 2nd New Zealand Division; the 4th, 8th and 10th Indian Divisions, with Gurkha battalions; Lt. Gen. Władysław Anders's Polish II Corps; the 3rd Greek Mountain Brigade; the Jewish Brigade; and Italian co-belligerent Combat Groups. **Fifth Army:** American divisions — among them the African-American 92nd Division, the Japanese-American 442nd Regimental Combat Team and the 10th Mountain Division — British corps at Salerno, Anzio and later; Gen. Alphonse Juin's French Expeditionary Corps of French, Moroccan, Algerian and Tunisian troops until the summer of 1944; the Brazilian Expeditionary Force from 1944; and the 6th South African Armoured Division from late summer 1944.

In the air and at sea the Allied air forces in the Mediterranean — British, American, Commonwealth, and from 1943 the Italian co-belligerent air force — and the Royal and US Navies supported every landing and much of the land fighting.

The German side. Kesselring convinced Hitler in autumn 1943 to fight for Italy south of Rome rather than fall back to the northern Apennines as Rommel advised; in November 1943 he took command of the whole theatre.

FORMATION	COMMANDER(S)	WHERE IT FOUGHT
Army Group C (Commander-in-Chief South-West)	FM Albert Kesselring, Nov 1943 – Mar 1945 (Gen. Heinrich von Vietinghoff stood in after Kesselring was injured in a road accident in October 1944); Vietinghoff from March 1945	All German forces in Italy; its envoys signed the surrender at Caserta

Army Group B	FM Erwin Rommel	Occupied northern Italy in Operation Achse; its headquarters left for France in November 1943, when Army Group C took over the whole of Italy
10th Army	Vietinghoff, Aug 1943 – Oct 1944; then Joachim Lemelsen; Traugott Herr from Feb 1945	Salerno, the Winter and Gustav Lines, Cassino, the Adriatic front, the Gothic Line, the Argenta Gap
14th Army	Eberhard von Mackensen, Nov 1943 – Jun 1944; Lemelsen and others after	Anzio, the retreat from Rome, the western Gothic Line and the Bologna front
Army Liguria	Marshal Rodolfo Graziani (RSI)	Mixed German–Italian army guarding the Ligurian coast and the French frontier from August 1944
Key corps	XIV Panzer Corps — Fridolin von Senger und Etterlin; I Parachute Corps — Alfred Schlemm	Cassino; Anzio
Key divisions	1st Parachute (Richard Heidrich); Hermann Göring Panzer Division; 16th SS Panzergrenadier "Reichsführer-SS"	Ortona and Cassino; Sicily, Salerno and Anzio; the 16th SS carried out the Sant'Anna and Monte Sole massacres

4 · THE CAMPAIGN AT A GLANCE

The whole campaign, in order. Where sources disagree the more cautious figure is used and the disagreement is noted.

10 JUL 1943

Sicily. Operation Husky: the US Seventh and British Eighth Armies land on 26 beaches on the south and east coasts, under Alexander's 15th Army Group. Scattered airborne drops precede them.

25 JUL 1943

Mussolini falls. After the Grand Council votes against him, the King dismisses and arrests him. Marshal Badoglio takes over and secretly seeks terms.

17 AUG 1943

Messina. American troops enter the city, ending the 38-day campaign — but over 100,000 German and Italian troops have already been ferried to the mainland.

3 – 9 SEP 1943

Italy changes sides; the mainland invaded. The Eighth Army crosses to Calabria (3 Sep); the armistice signed that day at Cassibile is announced on 8 September; Clark's Fifth Army lands at Salerno and British paratroops sail into Taranto (9 Sep). Germany disarms the Italian army.

1 OCT 1943

Naples. After the Salerno beachhead survives German counter-attacks, the Allies enter Naples, whose people had risen in the Four Days (27–30 September). The Foggia airfields fall on the Adriatic side.

13 OCT 1943

Italy declares war on Germany. The Fifth Army is fighting across the Volturno. Kesselring falls back from line to line towards the Gustav Line.

NOV – DEC 1943

The Winter Line. Mountain battles at Monte Camino, San Pietro and Monte Lungo; on the Adriatic the Sangro and Moro crossings and the street fight for Ortona (20–28 December). Montgomery leaves for England at the turn of the year.

17 – 22 JAN 1944

Cassino and Anzio. The first battle for Cassino opens, and the US 36th Division's crossing of the Rapido fails at heavy cost. On 22 January VI Corps lands at Anzio almost unopposed — then is sealed in.

15 FEB 1944

The abbey destroyed. Allied bombers flatten the monastery of Monte Cassino, believing it part of the German defence. Post-war evidence indicates German troops were not inside it; they occupied the ruins afterwards. The attacks that followed failed.

11 – 18 MAY 1944

Operation Diadem. A combined offensive along the Gustav Line. The French corps breaks through the Aurunci mountains; the Poles take the monastery on 18 May. In the weeks that follow French colonial troops commit mass rapes of civilians — the *Marocchinate*; estimates of the number of victims range from about 2,000 to 12,000 or more, depending on the source.

4 JUN 1944

Rome. The Anzio breakout (23 May) links with the main front (25 May); Clark turns for Rome rather than blocking the German retreat at Valmontone, and enters the capital two days before D-Day. Historians still debate the choice.

JUN – AUG 1944

The pursuit north. Siena, Ancona, Livorno and, in August, Florence on the Arno. Seven divisions are withdrawn for the landings in southern France on 15 August. On 12 August an SS unit massacres the villagers of Sant'Anna di Stazzema.

25 AUG – OCT 1944

The Gothic Line. Operation Olive on the Adriatic; Rimini falls on 21 September; the Fifth Army breaks through the passes north of Florence but stalls short of Bologna. Around Monte Sole (29 Sep – 5 Oct) the SS kill some 770 civilians.

NOV 1944 – MAR 1945

Winter. Stalemate in the mountains and the flooded Romagna. On 13 November Alexander broadcasts that partisans should hold back for the winter. The Brazilians take Monte Castello on 21 February; the Canadians leave for the Netherlands.

9 – 25 APR 1945

The spring offensive. The Eighth Army attacks across the Senio (9 Apr), the Fifth out of the mountains (14 Apr). Bologna falls on 21 April; the Allies cross the Po; on 25 April the Resistance proclaims the general insurrection.

28 APR – 2 MAY 1945

The end. Partisans shoot Mussolini on 28 April. The German surrender signed at Caserta on 29 April takes effect at 2 p.m. local time (12:00 GMT) on 2 May — six days before VE Day. What happens place by place is the **Timeline** tab.

Counting the cost. Figures vary widely with who is counted and when. Allied casualties in Italy are usually put at around 310,000–330,000, of whom roughly 60,000–70,000 were killed; German losses are estimated at over 330,000, excluding the men who surrendered in May 1945. Italian losses — soldiers on both sides, partisans, internees and civilians killed by bombing, shelling and massacres — ran to many tens of thousands more. Allied bombing alone is estimated to have killed some 60,000 Italian civilians during the war, about two-thirds of them after the armistice.

READ MORE

SOURCES FOR THIS PAGE

Italian campaign, 1943–45 (Wikipedia)

Armistice of Cassibile (Wikipedia)

Sicily 1943 — US Army Center of Military History

Naples–Foggia — US Army CMH

Anzio 1944 — US Army CMH

Rome–Arno 1944 — US Army CMH

North Apennines — US Army CMH

Po Valley 1945 — US Army CMH

Monte Cassino — Imperial War Museums

Canada in Italy, 1943–45 — Veterans Affairs Canada

The Italian campaign — NZHistory

Was "soft underbelly" Churchill's phrase? — Hillsdale Churchill Project

Further reading: the British and Commonwealth official histories of the Mediterranean campaign, and the US Army "Green Books" on Sicily and Italy.

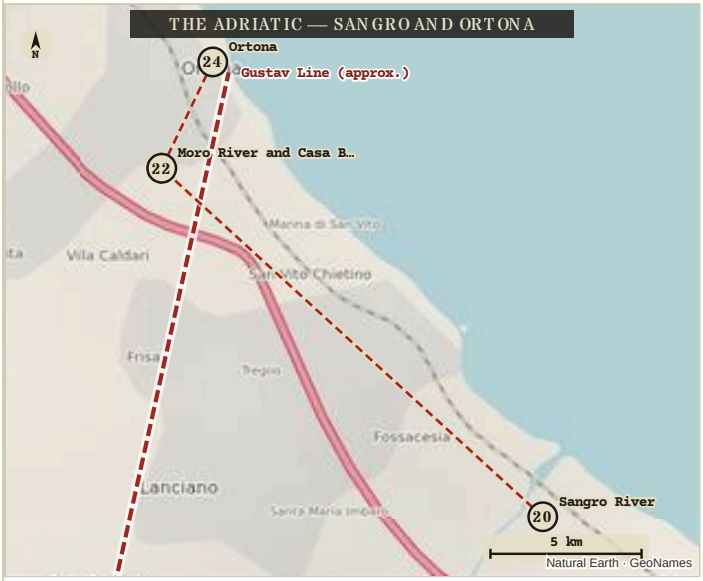
THE CAMPAIGN IN DATE ORDER

48 dated positions, from the Sicily landings of 10 July 1943 to the German surrender of 2 May 1945, in seven phases. On the maps the dashed line joins the points in date order — it is not the route the armies took. Pick a phase to see it on its own map.

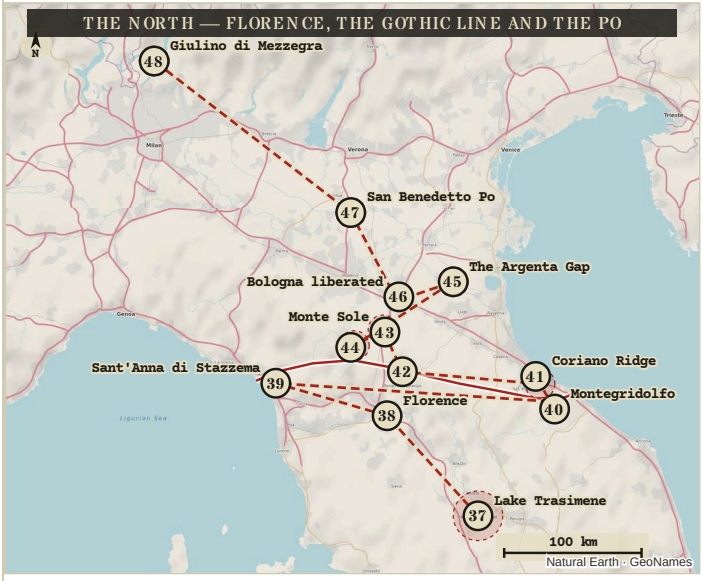
THE CAMPAIGN IN DATE ORDER, 1943 – 1945











Regional panels from south to north · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames · dashed line = order of visit, not the road · dashed circle = uncertain spot · tap ⤢ to enlarge

PHASE 1 — SICILY, JULY–AUGUST 1943

1 Ponte Grande — gliders seize the bridge

9–10 Jul 1943, night

HIGH

Operation Ladbroke sent 144 gliders of the British 1st Airlanding Brigade to seize this bridge over the Anapo south of Syracuse. In a gale, 65 came down in the sea and some 252 men drowned; only a handful landed near the target. A single platoon of the South Staffords took the bridge and, reinforced to about 87 men, held it until mid-afternoon. The Royal Scots Fusiliers of 5th Division retook it intact at 16:15.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Operation Ladbroke, on the night of 9–10 July 1943, was the first large Allied glider operation of the war. The British 1st Airlanding Brigade under Brigadier Philip Hicks set off from Tunisia in 136 American Waco and 8 Horsa gliders to seize Ponte Grande, the bridge carrying the main road over the Anapo south of Syracuse. Released too early in a strong wind and under anti-aircraft fire, 65 gliders came down in the sea and about 252 men drowned. Only twelve landed in the right place.

A single Horsa-load of the 2nd Battalion, South Staffordshire Regiment, took the bridge and removed the demolition charges. By 06:30 on 10 July about 87 men held it against Italian counterattacks. By 14:45 only fifteen were unwounded; with their ammunition gone they surrendered at 15:30. At 16:15 the 2nd Battalion, Royal Scots Fusiliers, from the British 5th Division landing at Cassibile, arrived and recaptured the bridge intact. Syracuse and its port fell that evening, giving Eighth Army a harbour on the first day. The brigade lost 313 dead and 174 missing or wounded, plus many glider pilots.

Today the road bridge on the SS115 at the southern edge of Syracuse still crosses the Anapo near its mouth. There is little to mark the action; the Syracuse War Cemetery, where many of the glider men lie, is only a few minutes away.

On the ground: The road bridge over the Anapo and the flat, canal-cut ground around it. Imagine the few glider men firing from the ditches, with Syracuse harbour behind you.

DIG DEEPER

Operation Ladbroke (Wikipedia) ↗

US Army CMH: The Assault ↗

37.05444, 15.26500 HIGH exact spot known

2 Gela — Rangers and 1st Division storm ashore

10 Jul 1943, 02:45

MEDIUM

At 02:45 the US 1st Infantry Division landed on the beaches east of Gela while Darby's 1st and 4th Ranger Battalions went straight at the town, whose pier the Italians blew up. The destroyer USS Maddox was sunk offshore by an air attack just before 05:00. That morning nine or ten Italian tanks of Mobile Group E dashed into Gela's streets before Rangers and engineers drove them out with bazookas and grenades.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Gela was the centre of the American landings. At 02:45 on 10 July the US 1st Infantry Division, the 'Big Red One' under Major General Terry Allen, landed on the beaches east of the town while Lieutenant Colonel William Darby's Force X, the 1st and 4th Ranger Battalions, assaulted Gela itself. The Italians blew up the pier, and the destroyer USS Maddox was sunk offshore by an air attack just before 05:00.

The same morning about twenty Italian tanks of Mobile Group E drove down the roads from Niscemi and Ponte Olivo; nine or ten reached the town's streets before Rangers and engineers forced them out. On 11 July the Livorno Division attacked from the west in close formation and was shattered by artillery, mortars, captured Italian guns and some 500 six-inch shells from the cruiser USS Savannah, while German tanks broke into the plain to the east. That night American anti-aircraft gunners, after a day of air raids, shot down 23 of 144 transport planes bringing the 504th Parachute Infantry over the beachhead, a disaster that led to new rules for airborne operations.

Modern Gela is dominated by its oil refinery, but the seafront, the pier and the old town on its ridge still let you read the battle. The beaches to the east, now edged with greenhouses, are where the 1st Division came ashore.

On the ground: Stand on the seafront by the pier and look along the flat beaches to the east, where the landing craft grounded, then up at the old town on its low ridge.

DIG DEEPER

Battle of Gela (Wikipedia) ↗

US Army CMH: The Axis Threat (11 July) ↗

37.06600, 14.24700 MEDIUM close — exact spot uncertain

3 Bark West — the Canadians land near Pachino

10 Jul 1943, early morning

MEDIUM

The 1st Canadian Infantry Division (Major-General Guy Simonds) and the 1st Canadian Army Tank Brigade came ashore on 'Bark West' beach near Maucini, with Royal Marine Nos. 40 and 41 Commandos landing alongside. Opposition from the Italian coastal troops was light and Pachino was reached the same day. It was the start of a month-long campaign that cost Canada some 562 dead.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Canada's war in Italy began on this beach. Early on 10 July 1943 the 1st Canadian Infantry Division under Major-General Guy Simonds, with the 1st Canadian Army Tank Brigade, landed on 'Bark West' near Maucini, on the left flank of Montgomery's Eighth Army. Royal Marine Nos. 40 and 41 Commandos landed on the western sector; the British 51st Highland Division and 231st (Malta) Brigade landed on the east side of the Pachino peninsula. Opposition from Italian coastal units was light, some landing craft grounded on sandbars, and the Canadians took Pachino the same day.

The Canadians had come straight from Britain; 58 men drowned when ships of their convoys were sunk on the way and are named on the Cassino Memorial. Over the next month the division marched and fought across the centre of the island, through Grammichele, Piazza Armerina, Assoro, Leonforte and Agira to the Etna line, before being withdrawn on 6 August. About 562 Canadians died in Sicily.

Today the beach is quiet, with low dunes and shallow water much as in 1943. A Canadian flag is the only marker. It is well worth the detour for Canadian visitors and gives a feel for the flat coast the Eighth Army landed on.

On the ground: A low, sandy beach at the south-eastern tip of Sicily, today marked only by a Canadian flag. Look west along the Roger and Sugar sectors.

DIG DEEPER

Veterans Affairs Canada: the Italian campaign ↗

Canadian Army official summary, Sicily ↗

36.67545, 15.05265 MEDIUM close — exact spot uncertain

4

Piano Lupo — the Gela counterattack

11 Jul 1943, 06:15

LOW

At 06:15 the Hermann Göring Panzer Division and the Italian Livorno Division struck at the Gela beachhead. German tanks rolled down the Niscemi road past Piano Lupo, held by the 1st and 2nd Battalions of the 16th Infantry with scattered paratroopers of the 505th, and across the Gela plain to within about 2,000 yards of the water. Artillery landed by DUKW (a six-wheeled amphibious truck), anti-tank guns and naval gunfire stopped them; sixteen German tanks were left burning and the attack was called off after 14:00.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Piano Lupo is a road junction on the low hills east of Gela where the road from Niscemi meets the SS115. It was the objective of the US 505th Parachute Regimental Combat Team under Colonel James Gavin, dropped on the night of 9–10 July. Strong winds and inexperienced crews scattered more than 3,000 paratroopers over a huge area; only a few hundred landed near their targets. Captain Edwin Sayre's small group nonetheless took the complex of Italian pillboxes at the junction and, joined by 1st Division infantry, held it.

On 11 July the Axis made its one serious attempt to crush a beachhead. Tanks of the Hermann Göring Panzer Division under General Paul Conrath came down the Niscemi road past Piano Lupo and across the Gela plain to within about 2,000 yards of the sea, firing on supply dumps and landing craft. Field artillery brought ashore by DUKW, anti-tank guns, infantry cannon, engineers and naval gunfire stopped them. Sixteen German tanks were left burning and the attack ended after 14:00. The American foothold, and with it the invasion, was safe.

Today greenhouses cover much of the plain, but some concrete Italian pillboxes still stand on the slopes of the Niscemi road. The junction is busy; view the ground from a safe spot.

On the ground: The junction where the Niscemi road meets the SS115. Some Italian concrete pillboxes survive on the slope among greenhouses; look south across the plain to the sea.

DIG DEEPER

Battle of Gela (Wikipedia) ↗

US Army CMH: The Axis Threat (11 July) ↗

37.05500, 14.34500 LOW general area only

5

Biazza Ridge — Gavin stops the Tigers

11 Jul 1943, afternoon

LOW

Colonel James Gavin, commander of the 505th Parachute Infantry, gathered paratroopers, engineers, cooks and clerks on this low ridge east of the Acate river and met a German battle group with Tiger tanks. Pack howitzers fired over open sights; in the evening, reinforced by Sherman tanks, Gavin counterattacked and the Germans fell back. The stand stopped the eastern arm of the counterattack and won Gavin the Distinguished Service Cross.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Biazza Ridge is a low ridge about three kilometres east of the Acate (Dirillo) river, astride the SS115 between Vittoria and Gela. On the morning of 11 July Colonel James Gavin, still gathering his scattered 505th paratroopers, found the eastern battle group of the Hermann Göring Division, with infantry, artillery and a company of Tiger tanks, moving towards the 45th Division beaches. He attacked with whatever he had: paratroopers, engineers, clerks and cooks.

The Americans took the ridge but came under heavy fire from the Tigers. Paratroopers fired a pack howitzer at a Tiger at point-blank range and used bazookas against others. In the evening, reinforced by Sherman tanks of the 753rd Tank Battalion, naval gunfire and more men, Gavin counterattacked and the Germans withdrew in the evening. The German commander, General Conrath, gave up the attack on the beachhead. Gavin received the Distinguished Service Cross.

The ridge is not marked; it lies among farms and greenhouses. The 82nd Airborne memorial at Ponte Dirillo is the place to stop. Nearby, on 14 July, men of the 45th Division killed about 70 Italian and German prisoners near Biscari airfield. Two were court-martialled; one was convicted and the other acquitted. It is one of several documented killings of prisoners and civilians by Allied troops in Sicily.

On the ground: Look east from the Ponte Dirillo memorial along the SS115 to the low ridge line among vineyards and greenhouses, about three kilometres away.

DIG DEEPER

Armchair General: the battle for Biazza Ridge ↗

37.02000, 14.44000 LOW general area only

6

Primosole Bridge — paratroops against paratroops

13–16 Jul 1943

HIGH

Operation Fustian dropped the British 1st Parachute Brigade to seize this bridge over the Simeto, the gateway to the Catania plain. Scattered by flak, including Allied naval fire, only about 295 of 1,856 men reached the objective. They took the bridge but were driven off on 14 July by German paratroopers. The Durham Light Infantry of 50th Division needed until 16 July to secure it; the plain beyond held Eighth Army for three weeks.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Primosole Bridge carries the coast road over the Simeto river south of Catania. Montgomery planned to seize it with the British 1st Parachute Brigade (Brigadier Gerald Lathbury) in Operation Fustian on the night of 13–14 July and then push 50th (Northumbrian) Division through to Catania. Allied naval gunners shot down four transports and Axis flak eleven more; many others turned back or dropped wide, and only about 295 of 1,856 men reached the bridge. About fifty men of the 1st Parachute Battalion captured it and removed the charges.

By bad luck, German paratroopers of the 1st Fallschirmjäger Division had been flown into the same area only hours earlier. On 14 July they and the Italians attacked from several sides; at about 17:00 the British, out of ammunition, pulled back to the high ground south of the river. The Durham Light Infantry of 50th Division reached the area on 15 July and after costly attacks secured the bridge on 16 July. The brigade lost 141 dead and 168 missing or wounded.

The bridgehead did not open the road to Catania. German paratroopers and the Hermann Göring Division held the Catania plain until 5 August. Today the SS114 still crosses the Simeto here, and roadside memorials honour the fallen of all nations of the battles for the plain.

On the ground: The SS114 still crosses the Simeto here. Look at the flat riverbanks and the roadside memorial to the fallen of all nations; Etna rises to the north.

DIG DEEPER

Operation Fustian (Wikipedia) ↗

ParaData: Primosole Bridge ↗

37.39944, 15.06500 HIGH exact spot known

7 Palermo falls; three days later Mussolini is deposed

22 Jul 1943, 19:00

HIGH

Patton's Provisional Corps swept across western Sicily and at 19:00 on 22 July accepted Palermo's surrender at the royal palace; Patton arrived that night. The drive took some 53,000 prisoners, mostly Italian. In Rome the Fascist Grand Council voted 19 to 8 against Mussolini in the early hours of 25 July, and that afternoon the King dismissed and arrested him. Marshal Badoglio's new government announced that the war would go on.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

After the beachhead was secure, Alexander gave Montgomery the main road north and left Seventh Army a flank role. Patton turned west instead. His Provisional Corps under Major General Geoffrey Keyes, with the 2nd Armored and 3rd Infantry Divisions, drove more than 100 miles through western Sicily against collapsing Italian resistance. At 19:00 on 22 July, General Giuseppe Molinero's surrender of Palermo was accepted at the royal palace, and Patton arrived that night. The sweep took some 53,000 prisoners, mostly Italian, for 272 American casualties.

Three days later the regime that had taken Italy into the war fell. The Fascist Grand Council met on 24 July and at about 02:00 on 25 July voted 19 to 8 for Dino Grandi's motion against Mussolini. That afternoon King Victor Emmanuel III dismissed him at Villa Savoia and had him arrested. Marshal Pietro Badoglio formed a government, announced that 'the war continues', and secretly began talks that led to the armistice of 3 September.

A myth grew after the war that the Mafia and Lucky Luciano smoothed the American advance; historians have found no evidence that they influenced the fighting, though Allied military government did appoint some Mafia-linked figures to local posts. The Norman royal palace is now Sicily's regional parliament.

On the ground: The Norman royal palace, today Sicily's regional parliament. Palermo is off the three-day route; a separate city visit shows the palace, the port and the bomb-scarred old quarters.

DIG DEEPER

US Army CMH: The Drive to the Climax (Palermo) ↗

Fall of the Fascist regime in Italy (Wikipedia) ↗

38.11056, 13.35333 HIGH exact spot known

8 Agira — the Canadians' hardest fight

24–28 Jul 1943

MEDIUM

Advancing east from Leonforte, the 1st Canadian Division attacked Agira, a hill town held by German Panzergrenadiers. Five days of fighting through Nissoria and along the surrounding ridges, ending in house-to-house combat, cost the division about 438 casualties, its heaviest of the Sicilian campaign. The town fell on 28 July, opening the road east towards Regalbuto and Adrano and the western end of the German Etna line.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Agira is a hill town in the centre of Sicily on the road from Leonforte to Regalbuto and Adrano. After the landings Montgomery sent the 1st Canadian Division on a wide inland sweep round the western side of Etna. The Canadians fought through Grammichele, Piazza Armerina, the cliff-top town of Assoro, scaled at night by the Hastings and Prince Edward Regiment, and Leonforte, then attacked east towards Agira on 24 July.

The approach through Nissoria and over the ridges beyond was held by German Panzergrenadiers. For five days battalions of the Royal Canadian Regiment, the Hastings and Prince Edward Regiment, 48th Highlanders, Princess Patricia's Canadian Light Infantry, Seaforth Highlanders and Edmonton Regiment attacked in turn, backed by the Three Rivers Regiment's tanks and heavy artillery. The town fell on 28 July after house-to-house fighting. It cost the division about 438 casualties, the most of any Canadian battle in Sicily.

The victory pushed the western end of the German line back towards Regalbuto and Troina and helped set up the final Allied offensive against the Etna line. Agira's streets climb to a ruined castle; the Canadian war cemetery lies a few kilometres east.

On the ground: The steep hill town with its castle on top. From the Canadian War Cemetery east of the town, look back at the ridges the battalions climbed.

DIG DEEPER

Veterans Affairs Canada: Agira Canadian War Cemetery ↗

Terry Copp: From Leonforte to Agira ↗

37.65580, 14.51972 MEDIUM close — exact spot uncertain

9 Troina — the battle of the Big Red One

31 Jul–6 Aug 1943

MEDIUM

At 1,100 metres, Troina anchored the western end of the German Etna line. The US 1st Infantry Division under Terry Allen, with the 39th Infantry and a Moroccan Tabor of Goums, attacked the German 15th Panzergrenadier Division and Italian troops of the Aosta Division. The defenders made about two dozen counterattacks; bombers and artillery wrecked the town. The Germans slipped away on the night of 5–6 August; Allen was relieved of command soon afterwards.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Troina, one of the highest towns in Sicily at about 1,100 metres, was the western anchor of the German Etna line. The US 1st Infantry Division under Major General Terry Allen attacked it from 31 July, expecting a light rearguard. Instead it met the 15th Panzergrenadier Division under General Eberhard Rodt, with Italian troops of the Aosta Division, on a ring of hills: Monte Acuto, Monte Basilio, Monte Pellegrino and Hill 1034.

For almost a week the 16th, 18th and 26th Infantry, the 39th Infantry of the 9th Division and a Tabor of French Moroccan Goums fought for the hills, beating off about two dozen counterattacks. Artillery and fighter-bombers pounded the town, killing civilians and wrecking houses. On the night of 5–6 August the Germans withdrew, having lost about 1,600 men. Bradley then relieved Allen and his deputy, Brigadier General Theodore Roosevelt Jr, a decision still debated.

Troina is the most important American battlefield in Sicily. Robert Capa's photographs of its ruins and people, published in Life, are shown in the Palazzo Pretura museum, and the upper town gives wide views over the hills the infantry had to take.

On the ground: The ridge-top town with views over the hills the infantry crossed. Robert Capa's photographs of the ruined town and its civilians hang in the museum here.

DIG DEEPER

US Army CMH: The Battle of Troina ↗

Museo della fotografia Robert Capa ↗

37.78450, 14.59750 MEDIUM close — exact spot uncertain

10

Brolo — Patton's end run behind the lines

11 Aug 1943, 02:43

LOW

To outflank the German line on the Naso ridge, Patton put Lieutenant Colonel Lyle Bernard's 2nd Battalion, 30th Infantry, with tanks and two artillery batteries, ashore behind the enemy at Brolo. They seized Monte Cipolla above the coast road and, supported by the cruiser USS Philadelphia, held out all day against counterattacks by the 29th Panzergrenadier Division. Relieved at 07:30 on 12 August, the force had lost 177 men.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Along the north coast the German 29th Panzergrenadier Division fought a series of delaying actions on the ridges that run down to the sea. Patton used his few landing craft for amphibious 'end runs' behind them. The second, on 11 August, landed Lieutenant Colonel Lyle Bernard's 2nd Battalion, 30th Infantry, reinforced with a platoon of tanks, engineers and two field artillery batteries, at Brolo; the first wave touched down at 02:43.

The force climbed Monte Cipolla, a steep hill between the Naso and Brolo rivers that commands the coast road. The cruiser USS Philadelphia and destroyers supported it, but the Germans attacked from both sides all day. Several mistaken Allied air attacks hit the Americans; the tanks and guns on the low ground were lost. The rest of the 3rd Division broke through the Naso ridge and made contact at 07:30 on 12 August. Bernard's force lost 177 killed, wounded and missing.

Historians still argue whether the landings achieved much: the Germans escaped each time, but the pressure helped keep their withdrawal on the move. Monte Cipolla still overlooks the coast road and railway; the landing beach is below the town.

On the ground: The steep hill between the Naso and Brolo rivers that overlooks the coast road and railway. Imagine the landing craft on the beach below.

DIG DEEPER

US Army CMH: Brolo ↗

38.15000, 14.81500 LOW general area only

11 The Strait — the Axis gets away

11–17 Aug 1943

LOW

In Operation Lehrgang German ferries, landing craft and barges carried troops from the beaches north of Messina to Calabria night after night from 11 to 17 August, under an umbrella of some 500 anti-aircraft guns. The Allied air forces and navies failed to stop them. Estimates run from about 40,000 to 60,000 German troops, with some 10,000 vehicles, plus 62,000–75,000 Italians carried in their own operation. The same divisions would fight at Salerno.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The Germans had planned their escape well before the end. Kesselring approved Operation Lehrgang on 8 August and Hube issued the order on 10 August; on the night of 11–12 August the ferrying began across the Strait of Messina, only about three kilometres wide here at Capo Peloro. Four main routes ran from beaches north of Messina to Calabria, with a spare route south of the city. Colonel Ernst-Günther Baade gathered some 500 anti-aircraft guns, heavy and light, on both shores.

The German ferries, landing craft and barges could carry about 8,000 men a night. Allied bombers and warships were kept at a distance by the flak and coastal guns, and the Allied commanders never mounted a coordinated effort to stop the crossing. By the morning of 17 August some 40,000–60,000 German troops, depending on the source, had crossed with about 10,000 vehicles and dozens of tanks and guns. The Italians evacuated some 62,000–75,000 men (the US official history gives 70,000–75,000) in their own operation.

The same divisions fought the Allies again at Salerno three weeks later. Today Torre Faro is a fishing village and beach resort; the view across to Calabria shows how short the crossing was.

On the ground: At Torre Faro the Strait is only about three kilometres wide. Look across at the Calabrian shore at Villa San Giovanni and picture the nightly shuttle.

`38.26500, 15.64500` LOW general area only

12

Messina — Patton wins the race

17 Aug 1943, 10:00

MEDIUM

A patrol of the US 3rd Division's 7th Infantry entered the bomb-wrecked city on the evening of 16 August. At 10:00 next morning Patton drove down from the hills to accept its surrender, just ahead of British commandos arriving from the south. The last German boats had left hours earlier. The 38-day campaign was over; Allied troops crossed the Strait to Calabria on 3 September.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Messina, badly damaged by Allied bombing, was the prize in the 'race' between Patton and Montgomery. On the evening of 16 August a reinforced platoon of Company L, 7th Infantry, US 3rd Division, entered the city. At 10:00 on 17 August Patton arrived on the ridge above the city and drove in to accept its surrender, just as British commandos who had landed south of the city, near Scaletta and Capo d'Alì, reached the southern outskirts. The last German boats had already crossed.

The 38-day campaign cost the Americans 7,402 casualties and the British and Canadians 11,843. German losses are given as anything from about 12,000 to 28,000 depending on what is counted; Italian losses were far greater, about 147,000, most of them prisoners. Sicily gave the Allies the Mediterranean sea lanes and airfields close to Italy, toppled Mussolini, and led to the armistice with Italy and the landings in Calabria on 3 September and at Salerno on 9 September.

The Sacrario di Cristo Re, built in 1937 on the site of a medieval castle, holds about 1,288 Italian soldiers of the Second World War and 110 of the First. Its bell, cast from bronze of captured guns, rings at sunset. The terrace overlooks the harbour and the Strait.

On the ground: From the terrace of the Cristo Re shrine you see the harbour, the city rebuilt after the bombing, and the Calabrian coast across the Strait.

DIG DEEPER

US Army CMH: The End of the Campaign ↗

Visit Sicily: Sacrario di Cristo Re ↗

38.19860, 15.54970 MEDIUM close — exact spot uncertain

PHASE 2 — SALERNO AND THE ROAD TO NAPLES, SEP–OCT 1943

13 Reggio Calabria — Eighth Army crosses to the mainland

3 Sep 1943, dawn

LOW

Before dawn on 3 September 1943, after a barrage from more than 600 guns firing across the Strait of Messina, British XIII Corps landed on the beaches north of Reggio in Operation Baytown: the 1st Canadian Division aimed for Reggio and its airfield, the British 5th Division for Villa San Giovanni. The Germans had already pulled back, and Italian coastal troops surrendered. Six days later the British 1st Airborne Division sailed into Taranto (Operation Slapstick).

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Operation Baytown began before dawn on 3 September 1943, exactly four years after Britain declared war on Germany. Under Lieutenant-General Miles Dempsey, British XIII Corps sent the 1st Canadian Division (Major-General Guy Simonds) and the British 5th Division (Major-General Gerard Bucknall) across the Strait of Messina in landing craft, covered by more than 600 guns on the Sicilian shore and by battleships offshore. The Canadians took Reggio and its airfield; the British 5th Division took Villa San Giovanni. Resistance was almost nil: the Germans had withdrawn and Italian coastal units gave up.

Baytown mattered less for what happened on the beaches than for what it began: the Allied campaign on the Italian mainland, which lasted until 2 May 1945. Montgomery's Eighth Army then advanced slowly up Calabria, held back more by demolished bridges and mountain roads than by the enemy, although the Italian 'Nembo' parachute regiment fought on the Aspromonte until 8 September. On 9 September the British 1st Airborne Division landed from warships at Taranto (Operation Slapstick); the minelayer HMS Abdiel struck a mine there the next day and sank with heavy loss of life.

Today the landing shore between Catona and Gallico is a suburban seafront beside the ferry route from Messina. There is little to see, but the view explains everything: Sicily is so close that the guns could fire straight across.

On the ground: Stand on the Gallico–Catona shore and look across the narrow strait to Sicily, where the guns were lined up. The ferry you arrived on crosses roughly the same water.

DIG DEEPER

Operation Baytown (Wikipedia) ↗

Operation Baytown (History of War) ↗

38.16500, 15.65200 LOW general area only

14 Paestum beaches — US 36th Division lands at Salerno

9 Sep 1943, 03:30

HIGH

Hours after the Italian armistice was announced on the evening of 8 September, the US 36th Infantry Division, in battle for the first time, landed on four beaches (Red, Green, Yellow, Blue) below the Greek temples of Paestum at 03:30. There was no preliminary bombardment, and the 16th Panzer Division was waiting. By nightfall the Texans held Capaccio and the slopes of Monte Soprano, at a cost of about 500 casualties.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

At 03:30 on 9 September 1943 the US 36th Infantry Division, a Texas National Guard formation that had never been in battle, landed on four beaches south of the Sele: Red and Green in the north for the 142nd Infantry, Yellow and Blue in the south for the 141st. There was no preparatory bombardment, in the hope of surprise, but the 16th Panzer Division was waiting in the dunes and on the hills. Sergeant James M. Logan won the Medal of Honor clearing machine-gun posts inland from here. By evening the 143rd Infantry had reached Capaccio and Monte Soprano, and the division had suffered about 500 casualties.

The Salerno landing, Operation Avalanche, was the main Allied landing on the Italian mainland and the first US attack on the European mainland; only the Sicily landings two months earlier had been larger in the Mediterranean. The armistice announced on the evening of 8 September made many soldiers expect an easy landing; instead the Germans had disarmed the Italian coastal troops and taken over the defences.

The memorial to the 36th Division stands near the beach, a few hundred metres south of the Torre di Paestum. The beach, dunes and pinewood are largely unchanged, although holiday camps now fill the coast. From the sand you can see why the Germans on Monte Soprano had such a clear view.

On the ground: The flat beach, the pine belt behind it and the medieval Torre di Paestum are much as the assault waves saw them. Look inland to the temples and the grey ridge of Monte Soprano.

DIG DEEPER

Salerno to Cassino, ch. 6: The Landings (US Army official history) ↗

Operation Avalanche (Wikipedia) ↗

Paestum and Velia archaeological parks ↗

40.41553, 14.99061 HIGH exact spot known

15 Battipaglia — British X Corps fights for the northern plain

9–18 Sep 1943

MEDIUM

North of the Sele, the British 46th and 56th Divisions of X Corps landed on 9 September while Commandos seized Vietri and US Rangers the passes above Maiori. The 56th took Montecorvino airfield and on 10 September pushed into Battipaglia, a vital road junction, but was thrown out that evening; after two more days of fighting, German counter-attacks drove the division off the edge of the town on 12 September. The British held on just south of the town; Battipaglia, largely destroyed, was finally entered on 18 September.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The British X Corps under Lieutenant-General Richard McCreery landed north of the Sele on 9 September 1943, with the 46th Division on the left and the 56th on the right, while two Commando units took Vietri and three US Ranger battalions under Lieutenant-Colonel William Darby seized the Chiunzi pass above Maiori. The 56th Division captured Montecorvino airfield, but German guns kept it under fire and it could not be used. Battipaglia, the road and rail junction on the plain, was entered by the Royal Fusiliers on 10 September but lost again that evening; after heavy fighting on 11 September, German counter-attacks drove the 56th Division off the edge of the town on 12 September.

The British sector saw some of the hardest fighting at Salerno: X Corps lost more men than the Americans, around 5,500 against 3,500 according to the US official history, while other sources give higher Allied totals. On 16 September some 500–600 British reinforcements, sources differ, refused to join units that were not their own; 192 were later charged with mutiny, in what became known as the Salerno mutiny.

Battipaglia was reduced to rubble by bombing, shelling and street fighting, and was rebuilt as a modern town. The airfield survives as Salerno's airport at Pontecagnano, and the Salerno War Cemetery lies between the two.

On the ground: Modern Battipaglia was rebuilt almost from scratch. From the SS18 look north to the airport (the old Montecorvino airfield) and east to the hills that gave German

observers their view.

DIG DEEPER

Operation Avalanche, 9–18 September 1943 (History of War) ↗

Salerno to Cassino, ch. 7: The Beachhead ↗

`40.60800, 14.98400` **MEDIUM** close — exact spot uncertain

16 Altavilla and Hill 424 — the heights above the beachhead

10–19 Sep 1943

MEDIUM

The hill village of Altavilla and Hill 424 behind it overlook the whole Sele plain. Men of the 36th Division occupied the village by 11 September, lost it to German counter-attacks on 12 September, and failed to retake Hill 424 the next day; the 1st Battalion, 142nd Infantry was almost destroyed. Naval gunfire and bombing wrecked the village, and 85 civilians died on its territory. The Americans only reoccupied it on 18–19 September.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Altavilla Silentina and Hill 424, just behind it, dominate the Sele plain from the south-east. Men of the 36th Division occupied the village by 11 September 1943, but on 12 September troops of the German 29th Panzergrenadier Division drove them out, and the 1st Battalion, 142nd Infantry was almost destroyed. On 13 September the 3rd Battalions of the 142nd and 143rd Infantry attacked Hill 424 again and failed.

Altavilla shows how the Germans used high ground to watch and shell the beachhead, and how the Allies answered with overwhelming naval and air firepower. The village was pounded from the sea and the air, and 85 civilians were killed on its territory during these days. The town was later awarded the Silver Medal for Civil Merit (conferred in 2000, presented in 2008). The Americans only reoccupied Altavilla on 18–19 September, after the German withdrawal.

Today the village, partly rebuilt, is a quiet place above olive groves. From the upper streets the view west over the plain to Paestum and the sea is exactly the one German observers had in September 1943.

On the ground: From the upper village look west over the plain to the sea: this is the view that let German gunners direct fire onto every beach and road. Hill 424 rises just behind the houses.

DIG DEEPER

Salerno to Cassino, ch. 8: The Crisis ↗

40.53300, 15.13300 **MEDIUM** close — exact spot uncertain

17 Sele–Calore corridor — the German counter-attack is stopped

13 Sep 1943, 15:30

LOW

At 15:30 on 13 September German tanks and infantry drove down the corridor between the Sele and Calore rivers, into a gap between the US and British corps. The 2nd Battalion, 143rd Infantry was overrun, and the attack headed for the beaches. Near a burned bridge over the Calore, the 158th and 189th Field Artillery Battalions fired about 3,650 rounds in four hours, their crews fighting as infantry. It was the crisis of the Salerno battle.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

On the afternoon of 13 September 1943 the German LXXVI Panzer Corps, with elements of the 29th Panzergrenadier and 16th Panzer Divisions, launched the counter-attack that was meant to split the beachhead. At 15:30 tanks and infantry drove south-west down the corridor between the Sele and Calore rivers, where the boundary between the US VI Corps and British X Corps left a gap. The 2nd Battalion, 143rd Infantry, placed in the corridor, was overrun and ceased to exist as a unit. The Germans headed for the burned bridge over the Calore and the beaches behind it.

They were stopped by the 158th and 189th Field Artillery Battalions of the 45th Division, which fired about 3,650 rounds in some four hours while their crews and every spare man defended the guns with rifles and machine guns. The US official history calls it the most serious breakthrough attempt of the whole battle. That evening General Mark Clark ordered plans to be prepared for re-embarking part of the army; by the evening of 14 September, with paratroopers of the 82nd Airborne Division flown in, heavy bombers overhead and warships firing inland, evacuation was no longer being considered.

The corridor today is flat farmland, much of it given to buffalo dairies and fields of tomatoes. Nothing marks the stand of the gunners: the landscape itself is the memorial.

On the ground: Flat farmland of buffalo-milk dairies and tomato fields between two tree-lined rivers: imagine it without cover, the guns firing over open sights from the low ground near La Cosa creek.

DIG DEEPER

Salerno: The German Counterattack (US Army CMH) ↗

Salerno to Cassino, ch. 9: The End of the Battle ↗

40.53000, 15.04000 LOW general area only

18

Naples — the Four Days and the arrival of the Allies

27 Sep – 1 Oct 1943

HIGH

After the German commandant, Colonel Walter Schöll, declared a state of siege and ordered men aged 18–33 to report for labour, Neapolitans rose up on 27 September. For four days civilians, soldiers and teenagers fought German troops in the Vomero, Materdei, Capodimonte and elsewhere. Death tolls vary widely: from 155 to more than 600 Italians, and several dozen Germans. On 1 October British armoured cars of the King's Dragoon Guards entered a city with a wrecked port.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

After the armistice the German command in Naples, under Colonel Walter Schöll, declared a state of siege, ordered the evacuation of the coastal strip and on 22 September decreed compulsory labour for all men aged 18 to 33. Round-ups followed. On 27 September Neapolitans began to fight back, first in the Vomero, then across the city: at Materdei, Porta Capuana, Capodimonte and the sports ground in the Vomero where hostages were held. On 30 September Schöll negotiated the release of prisoners in exchange for a free withdrawal.

The Four Days are often described as the first rising of a large European city against the German occupiers, and the city was later awarded the Gold Medal for Military Valour. Figures remain uncertain: official commissions counted 155 dead, cemetery registers more than 560, some accounts more; German losses are put at several dozen. Among the dead was Gennaro Capuozzo, aged 11 or 12, killed throwing grenades at a German tank. On 1 October 1943 the King's Dragoon Guards entered the city, followed by the Royal Scots Greys with troops of the US 82nd Airborne Division. They found a port wrecked by German demolition and a population exhausted by some 200 Allied air raids.

Marino Mazzacurati's monument on Piazza della Repubblica, inaugurated in 1969 and restored in 2022, shows the uprising in four carved panels.

On the ground: The stone panels of Marino Mazzacurati's monument (inaugurated 1969) show fighters of every age. It is popularly, if loosely, called the monument to the scugnizzo, the street boy, though it honours all who fought.

DIG DEEPER

Four Days of Naples (Wikipedia) ↗

Bombing of Naples in World War II (Wikipedia) ↗

40.83179, 14.22633 HIGH exact spot known

PHASE 3 — THE WINTER LINE AND ORTONA, OCT 1943 – JAN 1944

19 Volturno — Fifth Army crosses the river in flood

12–13 Oct 1943, 01:00

LOW

The Volturno, swollen by autumn rain, was the first German river line north of Naples. At 01:00 on 13 October Fifth Army's guns opened fire and six divisions, three American and three British, attacked. The US 3rd Division feinted at the Triflisco gap and crossed near Monte Caruso; the 34th took Caiazzo. The British 56th Division failed at Capua and later used an American bridge, while the 46th crossed near the sea. The Germans fell back to the Barbara Line.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The Volturno was the first defensive line the Germans held north of Naples. By early October 1943 autumn rain had swollen the river to 45–65 metres wide and one to one and a half metres deep, between banks up to four and a half metres high. Fifth Army attacked on the night of 12–13 October, its guns opening at 01:00. The US 3rd Division (Major-General Lucian Truscott) made a feint at the Triflisco ridge and its main crossing near Monte Caruso; the 34th Division crossed further east and took Caiazzo; the 45th cleared Monte Acero.

The British X Corps had a harder time: the 56th Division failed to cross at Capua and later used an American bridge, the 7th Armoured Division struggled to cross near Grazzanise, and the 46th Division crossed near the sea with naval gunfire support, while landing craft carried tanks round the river mouth. By 14–15 October all the crossings held, and the German XIV Panzer Corps fell back to the Barbara Line and then the Winter Line.

The Volturno crossing was the first of many river battles in Italy. Today the river still runs deep and brown past Capua, and the ridges to the north show how well the Germans could watch the crossings.

> **On the ground:** Near Capua the river runs deep between high banks, 45–65 metres wide. Picture assault boats and rafts crossing in the dark under fire from the ridges to the north.

DIG DEEPER

Salerno to Cassino, ch. 12: The Volturno Crossing ↗

Battle of the Volturno Line (History of War) ↗

`41.14000, 14.24500` LOW general area only

20 Sangro River — Eighth Army storms the Adriatic end of the Winter Line

24–30 Nov 1943

HIGH

On the Adriatic, Montgomery's Eighth Army reached the Sangro in November. Small bridgeheads had been won by 24 November and, after days of rain and flooding, the main attack by the British 78th Division, 8th Indian Division and 2nd New Zealand Division took the ridge beyond the river by nightfall on 30 November. The German 65th Infantry Division was badly mauled, but mud, rain and fresh German divisions slowed the advance towards the Moro and Ortona.

> ITS ROLE IN THE WAR
>
> In November 1943 Montgomery's Eighth Army reached the Sangro, where the eastern end of the German Winter Line followed the ridge above the river. Rain turned the valley into a swamp and floods repeatedly swept away bridges. By 24 November small bridgeheads had been won, and in the main attack from the night of 27–28 November the British 78th Division, the 8th Indian Division and the 2nd New Zealand Division cleared the ridge by nightfall on 30 November.
>
> The Sangro was a clear victory, but not the breakthrough Montgomery wanted. Fresh German divisions, including the 1st Parachute and 26th Panzer Divisions, arrived, and the advance towards Pescara stalled at the Moro and at Orsogna, where the New Zealanders fought through December. The campaign on the Adriatic showed the pattern of the whole Italian war: every river and ridge a new defence line.
>
> The Sangro River War Cemetery holds 2,617 Commonwealth graves, including soldiers from Britain, New Zealand, India and other Commonwealth countries, and escaped prisoners of war killed trying to reach Allied lines. The Cremation Memorial commemorates more than 500 Indian servicemen whose remains were cremated according to their faith.

On the ground: The war cemetery sits on the valley floor facing the ridge the Germans held. Look north-west up the Sangro to Mozzagrogna and Fossacesia on the heights above the river.

DIG DEEPER

CWGC: Sangro River War Cemetery ↗

42.21841, 14.53559 HIGH exact spot known

21 Monte la Difensa — the Special Service Force climbs the cliffs

2–9 Dec 1943

HIGH

Operation Raincoat opened Fifth Army's attack on the Winter Line at the Mignano gap. On the night of 2–3 December the US–Canadian 1st Special Service Force scaled the cliffs of Monte la Difensa (Hill 960) and took the summit at dawn, while the British 56th Division fought for Monte Camino (Hill 963), secured on 6 December. In six days of cold and rain the Force suffered 511 casualties, including 73 dead.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The Winter Line (the Germans called its main belt the Bernhardt or Reinhard Line) blocked the Mignano gap, the valley route to Cassino and Rome. Its western wall was the Camino massif: Monte Camino (Hill 963), Monte la Difensa (Hill 960) and Monte Maggiore. Operation Raincoat opened on 2 December 1943 with a huge bombardment: 346 guns fired more than 22,000 rounds on la Difensa in an hour. That night the 1st Special Service Force, a joint US–Canadian commando unit in its first battle, climbed the cliffs with ropes and took the summit at dawn on 3 December.

The Force then held the mountain for six days of rain and cold against counter-attacks by the 15th Panzergrenadier Division, losing 511 men: 73 dead, 9 missing, 313 wounded or injured and 116 evacuated with exhaustion. Beside them the British 56th Division fought for Monte Camino and its hilltop monastery, finally securing the summit on 6 December, while the US 142nd Infantry took Monte Maggiore.

Some sources date Raincoat from 1 December. Today la Difensa can be climbed on a steep trail from the valley, a hike of several hours; memorials to the Force stand near the summit. From the Via Casilina below, the cliffs show what the men faced.

On the ground: The summit, reached by a steep hike of several hours, carries memorials to the Force. From the valley, look at the rock faces the men climbed with ropes at night.

DIG DEEPER

Salerno to Cassino, ch. 15: In the Winter Line ↗

41.38228, 13.93301 HIGH exact spot known

22 Moro River and Casa Berardi — Canada’s December battle

6–20 Dec 1943

MEDIUM

PRIVATE — VIEW FROM THE ROAD

The 1st Canadian Division crossed the Moro on 6–9 December at Villa Rogatti, San Leonardo and near the coast, then ran into 'the Gully', a ravine about 60 metres deep held by German paratroopers and panzergrenadiers. On 14 December Captain Paul Triquet's company of the Royal 22e Régiment fought through to the farmhouse of Casa Berardi, reaching it with only 14 to 17 men fit to fight (sources differ). Triquet received the Victoria Cross. The Germans left the Gully on 20 December.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The 1st Canadian Division attacked across the Moro on 6 December 1943: the Princess Patricia's Canadian Light Infantry took Villa Rogatti, the Seaforth Highlanders of Canada fought for San Leonardo, and the Hastings and Prince Edward Regiment attacked near the coast. By 9 December the division was across. Beyond lay 'the Gully', a ravine about 60 metres deep, held by the German 90th Panzergrenadier Division and then the 1st Parachute Division.

On 14 December C Company of the Royal 22e Régiment, led by Captain Paul Triquet and supported by a handful of tanks, fought its way to the farmhouse of Casa Berardi, on the far side of the Gully. Only 14 to 17 men of the company remained fit to fight when they reached it (his Victoria Cross citation speaks of two sergeants and 15 men), and they held it against counter-attacks until relieved. Triquet was awarded the Victoria Cross. The Germans left the Gully on 20 December, opening the road to Ortona. Canadian battle casualties from the Moro to Ortona are given as about 2,300 to 2,600, with more than 500 killed; sources differ.

Casa Berardi is a private farmhouse today, with a memorial to the Van Doos, as the regiment is known. Visitors should view it from the road.

On the ground: Casa Berardi is a private farmhouse with a memorial at the gate; view it from the road. The flat fields around it were the killing ground between the Gully and the

crossroads.

DIG DEEPER

CWGC: Moro River Canadian War Cemetery ↗

Veterans Affairs Canada: Moro River Canadian War Cemetery ↗

CWGC: the Moro River campaign ↗

42.32163, 14.38319 MEDIUM close — exact spot uncertain

23 San Pietro Infine — a village destroyed in the Winter Line

8–17 Dec 1943

HIGH

San Pietro sat on the slopes of Monte Sammucro, covering the road through the Mignano gap. From 8 December the US 36th Division attacked across terraced olive groves; on the same day the Italian 1st Motorised Group made its first attack for the Allies, on nearby Monte Lungo, and failed. A tank attack on 15 December lost 12 of 16 Shermans. The Germans withdrew on the night of 16–17 December, leaving the village in ruins.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

San Pietro Infine stood on the lower slopes of Monte Sammucro, overlooking Highway 6 as it ran through the Mignano gap. Held by a battalion of the 29th Panzergrenadier Division, it was attacked by the US 36th Division from 8 December 1943. That morning the 143rd Infantry took Hill 1205 on Sammucro and the 3rd Ranger Battalion took Hill 950, but attacks on the village across terraced olive groves were stopped. On 15 December sixteen Shermans of the 753rd Tank Battalion tried the narrow mountain road; only four returned. Night attacks by the 141st and 143rd Infantry also failed.

The Germans withdrew on the night of 16–17 December, after Monte Lungo fell, and the Americans entered a village where only the dead remained. The 36th Division lost about 1,200 men, some 150 killed, over 800 wounded and 250 missing, according to the US official history. Villagers had sheltered for weeks in caves; an unknown number died. John Huston's documentary 'The Battle of San Pietro', partly re-enacted after the fighting, became one of the most famous war films ever made.

The ruins were left as a memorial, and a new village was built below. The Parco della Memoria Storica museum, opened in 2008, tells the story.

On the ground: The old village was never rebuilt: walk its roofless streets, church and cave shelters. John Huston filmed the battle here, and the museum screens his footage.

DIG DEEPER

Salerno to Cassino, ch. 16: San Pietro ↗

Museo Parco della Memoria Storica (Ministero della Cultura) ↗

Battle of San Pietro Infine (Wikipedia) ↗

41.44604, 13.96727 HIGH exact spot known

24 Ortona — street fighting in “Little Stalingrad”

20–28 Dec 1943

HIGH

From 20 December the Loyal Edmonton Regiment and the Seaforth Highlanders of Canada, with Three Rivers tanks, fought house by house against the German 1st Parachute Division. Streets were rubble-blocked and mined, so the Canadians 'mouse-holed', blasting through walls from house to house. On Christmas Day companies rotated through a dinner in the church of Santa Maria di Costantinopoli. The paratroopers withdrew on the night of 27–28 December. 1,314 of Ortona's people died in the battle and the bombardments.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Ortona, a small Adriatic port with a deep-water harbour, was defended in December 1943 by the German 1st Parachute Division under Generalleutnant Richard Heidrich. From 20 December the 2nd Canadian Infantry Brigade (Brigadier Bert Hoffmeister), with the Loyal Edmonton Regiment, the Seaforth Highlanders of Canada and tanks of the Three Rivers Regiment, fought its way in. The Germans had blown houses into the side streets to channel the attackers into killing zones along the main Corso, so the Canadians 'mouse-holed': they blasted holes through the walls with anti-tank weapons and explosives and moved from house to house without entering the street.

The battle lasted eight days. On the night of 27–28 December the paratroopers withdrew. Canadian casualties in the town are given as about 650 killed and wounded; German losses are uncertain. Correspondents called Ortona 'Little Stalingrad', and it became Canada's best-known battle in Italy. It also showed that the Italian winter had stopped the Allied advance: Eighth Army got no further than the Arielli, and Montgomery left for England at the end of the month.

About 80 per cent of the town was destroyed, and 1,314 civilians died. The rebuilt old town, the cathedral of San Tommaso and the MUBA museum recall the battle.

On the ground: Walk Corso Vittorio Emanuele, the Canadians' main axis, to the rebuilt cathedral of San Tommaso, which German engineers blew up on 21 December 1943, according to most accounts (some blame Allied shelling). Most of the old town was rebuilt after the war.

DIG DEEPER

Battle of Ortona (Wikipedia) ↗

MuBa43, Comune di Ortona ↗

42.35306, 14.40361 HIGH exact spot known

PHASE 4 — CASSINO AND ANZIO, JAN–MAY 1944

25

Garigliano, Minturno — British X Corps crosses the river

17 Jan 1944, 21:00

MEDIUM

At 21:00 on 17 January 1944 British X Corps opened the first battle for the Gustav Line. The 5th and 56th (London) Infantry Divisions crossed the fast, flooded Garigliano near its mouth, in assault boats and DUKWs, and fought their way up to Minturno, Tufo and the slopes towards Castelforte. The bridgehead held, but cost about 4,000 casualties in the first weeks. Alarmed, Kesselring rushed two panzergrenadier divisions south from Rome, just before the Anzio landing.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The Garigliano formed the western end of the Gustav Line, the German winter position that ran across Italy from the mouth of this river to the Adriatic. At 21:00 on 17 January 1944, after a heavy bombardment, Lieutenant General Richard McCreery's British X Corps began crossing near the coast: the 5th Infantry Division towards Minturno and Tufo, the 56th (London) Division further upstream towards Castelforte and Monte Damiano. The river was 50–100 metres wide and in winter flood; boats were swept away, and Royal Engineers built the first bridges under fire. Upstream the 46th Division's crossing near Sant'Ambrogio failed on 19–20 January.

X Corps gained a bridgehead several kilometres deep but could not break into the Liri valley, and the first weeks cost around 4,000 casualties. Its strategic effect was larger than its gains: Field Marshal Kesselring sent the 29th and 90th Panzergrenadier Divisions from

reserve near Rome to seal it off, just days before the Allies landed at Anzio behind his back.

Today the Via Appia still crosses the river here. The Real Ferdinando bridge of 1832, one of the first iron suspension bridges in Europe, was blown up by the Germans in 1943 and restored in 1998. Beside it lie the ruins of Roman Minturnae, with the Commonwealth war cemetery a short walk away.

On the ground: Stand by the restored Real Ferdinando suspension bridge beside the Roman ruins of Minturnae. Look north to the hill town of Minturno: every ridge between the river and the town was fought over.

DIG DEEPER

First Battle of Monte Cassino (Wikipedia) ↗

London Irish Rifles at the Garigliano ↗

41.24444, 13.77111 MEDIUM close — exact spot uncertain

26 Sant'Angelo in Theodice — the US 36th Division fails at the Rapido

20 Jan 1944, evening

HIGH

On the foggy night of 20 January the 141st and 143rd Infantry Regiments of the US 36th (Texas) Division tried to cross the Gari (Rapido) river on either side of Sant'Angelo in Theodice, under German guns on the far bank. Boats were holed, footbridges broke and minefields waited on both banks. After two nights the survivors were back where they started. Sources give between about 1,700 and 2,100 American casualties in 48 hours, against light German losses.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The Gari, which the Allies called the Rapido, is a narrow but deep and fast river flowing south from Cassino. On the night of 20 January 1944, in fog, the US 36th Infantry Division under Major General Fred L. Walker tried to cross it either side of Sant'Angelo in Theodice, to open the Liri valley for armour. The German 15th Panzergrenadier Division held the far bank with machine-gun posts, wire and minefields, and could see the whole area from the village bluff and Monte Cassino.

The 141st and 143rd Infantry Regiments got some companies across but could not bridge the river, and the men on the far bank were cut off and destroyed. By 22 January the

attack had failed. Casualty figures differ: the US Army's official history gives about 1,700, other sources over 2,100, killed, wounded and missing, against light German losses. Texas veterans blamed Mark Clark; a Congressional inquiry in 1946 did not find him at fault.

Today memorials to the 36th Division, placed by Texan veterans and Italian friends, stand in the village square overlooking the crossing area. The river, the meadows and the steep eastern bank look much as they did.

On the ground: From the piazza memorials look down on the narrow, fast river and the flat meadows on the far side, with Monte Cassino filling the skyline to the north.

DIG DEEPER

Battle of Rapido River (Wikipedia) ↗

Sant'Angelo in Theodice memorials (US War Memorials) ↗

`41.44480, 13.83260` HIGH exact spot known

27 Anzio — Operation Shingle lands behind the Gustav Line

22 Jan 1944, 02:00

MEDIUM

At 02:00 on 22 January 1944 US VI Corps under Major General John P. Lucas landed at Anzio and Nettuno, about 60 km south of Rome: the British 1st Infantry Division north of the town, US Rangers and paratroopers at the harbour, and the US 3rd Infantry Division to the east. Surprise was complete. By midnight some 36,000 men and 3,200 vehicles were ashore for 13 killed. Lucas dug in rather than dash inland, and the Germans reacted fast.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Operation Shingle was meant to land behind the Gustav Line, cut German communications and speed the capture of Rome while the Fifth Army attacked at Cassino. At 02:00 on 22 January 1944 Major General John P. Lucas's US VI Corps came ashore: the British 1st Infantry Division and commandos at Peter Beach north-west of Anzio, US Rangers and the 509th Parachute Infantry Battalion in Anzio harbour, and the US 3rd Infantry Division at X-Ray Beach east of Nettuno. Surprise was complete. By midnight about 36,000 men and 3,200 vehicles were ashore, for 13 killed and 97 wounded.

Lucas chose to build up his beachhead rather than strike for the Alban Hills, fearing a counter-attack. Kesselring reacted with extraordinary speed, and within days General Eberhard von Mackensen's Fourteenth Army surrounded the beachhead. Churchill later

complained that he had hoped to hurl 'a wildcat' ashore and got 'a stranded whale'. Historians still debate whether a bolder advance could have succeeded or would have been destroyed.

Anzio harbour, now full of fishing boats and ferries to the Pontine islands, was the lifeline of the beachhead for four months, under constant shelling and air attack. The museum at Villa Adele is a few minutes' walk away.

On the ground: Walk the harbour front of Anzio, where the Rangers and the 509th Parachute Infantry Battalion came ashore, then imagine hundreds of ships lying off this flat coast.

DIG DEEPER

Battle of Anzio (Wikipedia) ↗

Operation Shingle (US Navy History) ↗

Museo dello Sbarco di Anzio ↗

41.44600, 12.62900 MEDIUM close — exact spot uncertain

28 Cisterna — two Ranger battalions destroyed

30 Jan 1944, dawn

LOW

Before dawn on 30 January the 1st and 3rd Ranger Battalions crept along a drainage ditch towards Cisterna, leading a US 3rd Division attack. At first light they were caught in open fields near Isola Bella by German troops and tanks. Of 767 Rangers, only six got back to Allied lines; the rest were killed or captured. The same day the British 1st Division pushed towards Campoleone but ended in an exposed salient. The beachhead was now under siege.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Cisterna, a town on the Via Appia north-east of the beachhead, was an early objective of the US 3rd Division. Before dawn on 30 January 1944 the 1st and 3rd Ranger Battalions of Colonel William O. Darby's Ranger Force infiltrated along the Pantano ditch to seize it by surprise. At first light, near Isola Bella, they found themselves among strong German forces with tanks in open fields. Of 767 men, 761 were killed or captured; only six returned. The 4th Ranger Battalion and the 3rd Division, trying to reach them, also lost heavily.

The same day the British 1st Division attacked towards Campoleone and ended up in a narrow, exposed salient. The attacks of 30 January were VI Corps' last chance to break out before the German counter-offensive, and Cisterna stayed German until the breakout of May. On 23 May the 3rd Infantry Division, 1st Armored Division and 1st Special Service Force attacked towards it at great cost, and the ruined town was finally taken on 25 May.

A marker and a 'Via dei Rangers' road sign near Isola Bella remember the Rangers. The flat drained farmland of the Pontine plain, with its straight roads and ditches, explains how exposed the attackers were in daylight.

On the ground: At the roadside Rangers memorial near Isola Bella, look across the flat, open farmland of the reclaimed Pontine marshes: there was nowhere to hide once day broke.

DIG DEEPER

Cisterna–Isola Bella memorials (US War Memorials) ↗

41.57000, 12.80000 LOW general area only

29

Monte Cassino — the abbey is destroyed from the air

15 Feb 1944, morning

HIGH

On the morning of 15 February 1944, at the request of the New Zealand Corps, 229 American bombers (142 B-17s, 47 B-25s and 40 B-26s) dropped about 1,150 tonnes of bombs on the 6th-century Benedictine abbey, and artillery joined in. Allied commanders believed German troops were using it. They were not: the abbey was sheltering civilians, of whom about 230 died by one widely cited count. German troops then moved into the ruins and made them a fortress.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Saint Benedict founded the abbey around 529, and it had already been destroyed and rebuilt several times before 1944. Its position on a 500-metre height above Cassino made it the symbol of the Gustav Line. Kesselring ordered his troops in December 1943 to keep out of the buildings, and monks moved art and archives to safety with German help. On 15 February 1944, after the New Zealand Corps commander Lieutenant General Bernard Freyberg had requested it, 229 American bombers dropped about 1,150 tonnes of bombs (some sources give 1,400); artillery followed.

The buildings were wrecked. The official US and British histories later concluded that the Germans had made no military use of the abbey before the bombing; the only dead inside

were Italian civilians sheltering there, about 230 by one widely quoted count. The ground attacks of the 4th Indian Division that followed failed, and German troops occupied the ruins, which proved an even better fortress. The bombing remains a byword for the dilemma between protecting soldiers and protecting heritage.

Abbot Gregorio Diamare survived and led survivors out on 17 February. The abbey was rebuilt after the war and its basilica was consecrated by Pope Paul VI in 1964. Visitors today see a working monastery, photographs of the ruins, and one of the finest views over any battlefield in Europe.

On the ground: From the rebuilt cloisters look down the 500 m drop to Cassino town and the Liri valley: you see exactly why both sides thought this height controlled the road to Rome.

DIG DEEPER

Monte Cassino (Wikipedia) ↗

Abbazia di Montecassino: hours ↗

41.49000, 13.81389 HIGH exact spot known

30

Aprilia, 'the Factory' — the German counter-offensive

16 Feb 1944

MEDIUM

The brick-built new town of Aprilia, called 'the Factory' by Allied soldiers, and nearby Carroceto were lost by the British 1st Division on 9–10 February. On 16 February General von Mackensen's Fourteenth Army launched Operation Fischfang down the Via Anziate, the Albano–Anzio road, to split the beachhead. For four days British and American troops held on near the Flyover bridge, helped by massed artillery and bombers, and the attack was stopped only a few kilometres from the sea.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Aprilia was one of the Fascist 'new towns' built on the drained Pontine marshes, founded in April 1936 and inaugurated in 1937. Its brick buildings and tower looked industrial to Allied soldiers, who called it 'the Factory'. The British 1st Division took it on 25 January 1944 and pushed on towards Campoleone, but German attacks from 3 February pinched off the salient and retook the Factory and Carroceto station on 9–10 February.

On 16 February General von Mackensen's Fourteenth Army launched Operation Fischfang, a full-scale offensive down the Via Anziate intended to split the beachhead and drive the Allies into the sea. The US 45th Division and the British 56th and 1st Divisions

held a final line near the Flyover, the overpass where the Via Anziate crossed a lateral road, supported by massed artillery and bombers. By 20 February the attack was spent. Lucas was replaced by Major General Lucian Truscott on 22 February, and a last German attack towards Cisterna early in March also failed.

Aprilia was rebuilt after the war and has grown into a large modern town, but the central square and the straight Via Anziate running south to Anzio still trace the battlefield. In 2014 a memorial to Lieutenant Eric Fletcher Waters, killed near here, was unveiled in the area.

On the ground: Stand on Aprilia's central square, rebuilt after the war, and look south along the straight Via Anziate towards Anzio: this was the axis of every German attack.

DIG DEEPER

Battle of Anzio (Wikipedia) ↗

41.59470, 12.65440 MEDIUM close — exact spot uncertain

31

Cassino town and Castle Hill — the third battle

15 Mar 1944, 08:30

HIGH

From 08:30 on 15 March 1944 Allied bombers dropped about 750 tonnes of bombs on Cassino town for three and a half hours, followed by a massive artillery barrage. The 2nd New Zealand Division attacked through the rubble and took Castle Hill (Rocca Janula); Gurkhas of the 4th Indian Division reached Hangman's Hill just below the abbey. But German paratroopers survived in cellars and ruins, rain flooded the craters and tanks could not pass. The battle was called off on 23 March.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The Rocca Janula, a castle built around the year 1000 to guard the abbey, stands on a spur above Cassino town. In the third battle, after about 750 tonnes of bombs had flattened the town from 08:30 on 15 March 1944, New Zealand infantry of the 2nd New Zealand Division took Castle Hill that evening. Gurkhas of the 1/9th Gurkha Rifles then reached Point 435, Hangman's Hill, just below the abbey, and held on there for days, supplied by air drops.

The Germans of the 1st Parachute Division had survived the bombing in cellars and caves, and fought back in the rubble of the town around the Continental Hotel and the Hotel des Roses. On 19 March they counter-attacked the castle, which the 1/4th Essex

Regiment and others held in desperate fighting. Heavy rain filled the craters, tanks could not move through the rubble, and the battle was called off on 23 March. The 4th Indian and 2nd New Zealand Divisions had lost around 3,000 and 1,600 men respectively in the second and third battles.

Restored and reopened in 2015, the castle has a memorial to the 4th Essex and fine views over the town, the zigzag road to the abbey and Hangman's Hill.

On the ground: From the walls of the Rocca Janula look up to the abbey and across the town below: the Continental Hotel, the railway station and Hangman's Hill are all in view.

41.49511, 13.82522 HIGH exact spot known

32

Fosse Ardeatine, Rome — 335 men murdered in reprisal

24 Mar 1944

HIGH

On 23 March 1944 Roman partisans of the GAP exploded a bomb in Via Rasella, killing 33 men of the German police regiment 'Bozen'. Within 24 hours, on Hitler's order, passed down through Kesselring and General von Mackensen, SS officer Herbert Kappler had 335 men and boys taken to disused quarries on the Via Ardeatina and shot in the back of the head, five more than the ten-for-one ratio demanded. The victims included 75 Jews. The caves were then blown shut.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

On 23 March 1944 the partisan attack in Via Rasella killed 33 German policemen. In Rome General Kurt Mälzer and SS Obersturmbannführer Herbert Kappler proposed killing ten Italians for each German; General von Mackensen endorsed it, Hitler authorised it that night, and Kesselring treated the order as binding. The next afternoon, 24 March, 335 men and boys, aged 15 to 70 — political prisoners, members of the Resistance, Jews, soldiers and people picked up at random — were taken to disused pozzolana quarries on the Via Ardeatina. In groups of five they were shot in the back of the head by SS men led by Erich Priebke and Karl Hass. The caves were then blown up.

It was the worst massacre of the occupation of Rome and has become the central symbol of German reprisals in Italy, comparable to Sant'Anna di Stazzema and Marzabotto later that year. Kappler was sentenced to life imprisonment in 1948; Kesselring was sentenced to death in 1947, commuted, and released in 1952; Priebke was convicted only in 1998.

The Mausoleo delle Fosse Ardeatine, inaugurated on 24 March 1949, is a landmark of Italian postwar architecture. Visitors pass bronze gates by Mirko Basaldella and

Francesco Coccia's statue of three men, walk through the tunnels and enter the shrine where 335 identical tombs lie under a single enormous concrete slab. A small museum explains the events.

On the ground: Walk through the tunnels where the shootings took place and into the low, dim shrine where the 335 lie in identical granite tombs under a single vast concrete slab.

DIG DEEPER

Mausoleo delle Fosse Ardeatine: visit ↗

Ardeatine massacre (Wikipedia) ↗

41.85705, 12.51008 HIGH exact spot known

33 Monte Maio — the French break through the Aurunci mountains

13 May 1944

LOW

Operation Diadem opened at 23:00 on 11 May with more than 1,600 guns. While the British and Poles were held at Cassino, General Alphonse Juin's French Expeditionary Corps, mostly Moroccan and Algerian troops, stormed the Aurunci mountains. Monte Maio fell on 13 May and the Moroccan goumiers then crossed trackless heights behind the German line. This was the decisive breakthrough. In the villages beyond, such as Esperia, the following days also brought the Marocchinate: mass rapes and killings of Italian civilians by some of these troops.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Operation Diadem, the fourth battle for Cassino, began at 23:00 on 11 May 1944 with more than 1,600 guns firing along the front. In the south, General Alphonse Juin's French Expeditionary Corps attacked into the Aurunci mountains, which the Germans held only thinly because they thought them too rugged for a major offensive. Monte Maio (940 m) fell to the 2nd Moroccan Infantry Division on 13 May, and the Germans' 71st Infantry Division front began to collapse.

About 7,800 Moroccan goumiers, irregular mountain troops, then pushed across trackless heights on foot and with mules, reaching positions behind the Gustav Line by 16 May. This outflanked the defences of the Liri valley and made the Polish and British attacks at Cassino finally possible. Many historians regard it as the decisive move of the battle.

It must be remembered alongside a crime. In the villages of the Aurunci and Ciociaria, soldiers of the French corps, above all goumiers, committed mass rapes and killings of civilians, the Marocchinate. Figures are disputed: the Italian Ministry of Defence estimated 2,000–3,000 victims, victims' associations far more. The French courts-martial convicted over 150 men. Monte Maio is best seen from the roads around Ausonia and Castelforte.

On the ground: Monte Maio (940 m) is the high summit north of Castelforte and Ausonia. From the Ausonia road, look at the steep, scrubby slopes the goumiers crossed on foot and by mule.

DIG DEEPER

Operation Diadem (Wikipedia) ↗

French Expeditionary Corps (Wikipedia) ↗

Marocchinate (Wikipedia) ↗

`41.35500, 13.79000` LOW general area only

34

Point 593, Monte Cassino — the Poles take the heights

18 May 1944, morning

HIGH

Point 593, the rocky summit north-west of the abbey, had defeated Americans, Indians and British since January. From 12 May General Władysław Anders' Polish II Corps attacked it and the nearby Albaneta farm, losing heavily. After the German paratroopers had been outflanked in the valley and ordered out, a patrol of the 12th Podolian Uhlan (cavalry) Regiment raised a Polish pennant over the abbey ruins on the morning of 18 May (about 10:20 by most accounts). Monte Cassino had fallen after four months.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Point 593 is the rocky summit of the ridge running north-west from the abbey, known to the Allies as Snakeshead. In late January and early February 1944 the US 34th Infantry Division fought its way across the Rapido north of Cassino, took Caira and climbed into these hills, reaching within a few hundred metres of the abbey before exhaustion stopped it; its infantry battalions lost about 80 per cent of their strength. In February the 4th Indian Division, with the Royal Sussex Regiment and Gurkha and Rajputana Rifles battalions, attacked the same ground and was repulsed.

In May it was the turn of the Polish II Corps. Its soldiers took and lost Point 593 several times against German paratroopers of the 1st Parachute Division, dug into rock and ruins.

Only after the French and British had broken through in the valleys were the Germans ordered to withdraw, and on the morning of 18 May a patrol of the 12th Podolian Uhlans raised a Polish pennant over the abbey.

Today a white obelisk-cross to the 3rd Carpathian Division stands on the summit, reached by a steep path from the Polish cemetery. From here you understand the problem of every attack: bare limestone, no cover, and the abbey only a short distance away across a saddle swept by fire.

On the ground: Climb the short, steep path from the Polish cemetery to the white cross on Point 593 and look east: the abbey is just across the saddle, under 1 km away.

DIG DEEPER

Memorial 3rd Carpathian Division, Hill 593 (TracesOfWar) ↗

41.49706, 13.80228 HIGH exact spot known

35

Pontecorvo and Aquino — the Hitler Line broken

23 May 1944

LOW

Behind the Gustav Line the Germans had built a second barrier across the Liri valley, the Hitler Line (renamed Senger Line), from Piedimonte through Aquino to Pontecorvo. On 23 May the 1st Canadian Infantry Division attacked it between Pontecorvo and Aquino, at heavy cost, and broke through; the Poles took Piedimonte on 25 May. The same morning, 23 May, VI Corps began its breakout from the Anzio beachhead. Two days later the two fronts joined up.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Behind the Gustav Line, 10–15 km to the west, the Germans had prepared the Hitler Line, renamed the Senger Line in 1944 so that a defeat there would not carry the Führer's name. It ran from Monte Cairo through Piedimonte San Germano, Aquino and Pontecorvo, with concrete bunkers, anti-tank guns, wire and Panther tank turrets set in concrete. After the Gustav Line broke in mid-May, the Germans fell back to it.

On 23 May 1944 the 1st Canadian Infantry Division, part of I Canadian Corps under Lieutenant General E. L. M. Burns, attacked between Pontecorvo and Aquino. The 2nd Canadian Infantry Brigade suffered very heavy losses, making it one of the costliest days of the campaign for Canada, but the 3rd Brigade broke through, and the 5th Canadian Armoured Division exploited up the Liri valley. The Poles took Piedimonte on 25 May. On

the same morning of 23 May, VI Corps broke out of the Anzio beachhead, and on 25 May the two Allied fronts met.

Today little remains to see beyond the landscape of the valley and the rebuilt towns. Most of the Canadians killed in the Liri valley are buried in the Cassino War Cemetery.

On the ground: Drive the minor roads between Pontecorvo and Aquino: this flat, wooded valley floor, crossed by streams, was covered by concrete tank-turret emplacements and anti-tank guns.

DIG DEEPER

Operation Diadem (Wikipedia) ↗

41.45800, 13.66400 LOW general area only

PHASE 5 — ROME AND THE PURSUIT NORTH, JUN–AUG 1944

36

Rome — the first Axis capital to fall

4 Jun 1944

HIGH

After the breakout, Lieutenant General Mark Clark turned most of VI Corps north-west towards Rome instead of driving on to Valmontone to cut off the retreating German Tenth Army, a decision still argued over. With Hitler forbidding a defence of the city, Kesselring pulled his troops out and left Rome undefended as an open city. On 4 June 1944 American troops, including the 88th Division and the US–Canadian 1st Special Service Force, entered from the south-east; next morning Clark held a press conference on the Capitoline Hill. Two days later came D-Day.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

After the breakout from Anzio and the link-up of 25 May 1944, General Alexander's plan was for VI Corps to drive north-east to Valmontone on Route 6 and cut off the German Tenth Army retreating from Cassino. Instead Lieutenant General Mark Clark turned the main weight of VI Corps north-west towards the Alban Hills and Rome, leaving a smaller force towards Valmontone. The Germans held the Caesar Line long enough for much of the Tenth Army to escape. Critics say Clark put the glory of taking Rome before a decisive victory; his defenders argue that the trap could never have been closed completely. The debate continues.

Hitler had forbidden a defence of Rome, and on 3 June Kesselring pulled his troops out, leaving it an undefended open city. On 4 June American troops, among them the 88th Infantry Division and the US–Canadian 1st Special Service Force, entered from the south-east along the Via Casilina and other roads against German rearguards, reaching the centre by nightfall. Rome was the first Axis capital to be liberated. On the morning of 5 June Clark held a press conference on the Capitoline Hill.

Rome escaped the destruction suffered by Cassino and so many other towns, although Allied bombing of its railway yards, notably at San Lorenzo on 19 July 1943, had killed many civilians. Michelangelo's square is a fitting place to reflect on the liberation, which was overshadowed within 48 hours by D-Day.

On the ground: Stand in Michelangelo's Piazza del Campidoglio, where Clark spoke on 5 June, and look down over the Forum: Rome was spared the destruction of so many Italian towns.

`41.89340, 12.48270` HIGH exact spot known

37 Lake Trasimene — the Trasimene Line

20 Jun – 2 Jul 1944

LOW

Two weeks after Rome fell, Kesselring's rearguards turned to fight on the Trasimene Line, a belt of hill villages running west from the lake towards Chiusi. Their aim was time: every day bought let engineers finish the Gothic Line. British 4th and 78th Divisions, the South African 6th Armoured Division and Canadian tanks fought village by village against 1st Parachute, 334th and Hermann Göring divisions until the line broke on 28 June.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

After Rome fell on 4 June 1944 the Allies pursued a German army that was retreating fast but not beaten. Field Marshal Kesselring's plan was to trade ground for time with a series of delaying lines while the Todt Organisation finished the Gothic Line in the northern Apennines. The first serious stand was the Trasimene (or Albert) Line, anchored on the lake and running west towards Chiusi. From about 20 June the British XIII Corps, with the 4th and 78th Divisions, the South African 6th Armoured Division and the 1st Canadian Armoured Brigade, fought against German paratroopers, the 334th Infantry and the Hermann Göring Division.

The fighting was village by village. On 21 June the London Irish Rifles of the 38th (Irish) Brigade spent nearly six hours clearing Sanfatucchio, just south of here; in the Trasimene

battles the battalion had well over a hundred casualties. At Sanfatucchio they counted some 90 to 100 German dead and took about 110 prisoners. The line broke on 28 June and the Germans pulled back on 2 July, having gained the time they wanted.

Castiglione del Lago stands on a promontory above the western shore. From its walls you look south over the low ridges and farm villages that formed the German line. The landscape is gentle, but every hamlet was a strongpoint and every ridge an observation post, which is why the advance slowed here after the rush north from Rome.

On the ground: From the lakeside walls of Castiglione del Lago look south over the low ridges towards Sanfatucchio, where the London Irish Rifles fought house to house on 21 June 1944.

DIG DEEPER

Trasimene Line (Wikipedia) ↗

Battle of the Trasimeno or Albert Line (History of War) ↗

London Irish Rifles at Lake Trasimeno ↗

43.12764, 12.05346 LOW general area only

38

Florence — the night of the bridges

3–4 Aug 1944, from 22:00

HIGH

As Eighth Army closed on Florence, German engineers blew every bridge over the Arno from about 22:00 on 3 August — alle Grazie, Santa Trinita, alla Carraia, San Niccolò and alla Vittoria. Only the Ponte Vecchio was spared, but the medieval streets at both ends were demolished to block it. Allied troops reached the south bank on 4 August; the partisan rising in the centre began on 11 August.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Florence was the first great art city on the Allied road after Rome, and both sides knew the world was watching. As Eighth Army approached, the Germans declared a security zone along the Arno and evacuated riverside houses. From about 22:00 on 3 August 1944 their engineers destroyed the Ponte alle Grazie, Ponte Santa Trinita, Ponte alla Carraia, Ponte San Niccolò and Ponte alla Vittoria. The Ponte Vecchio was left standing, but the streets at both ends, Por Santa Maria and Via dei Bardi, Borgo San Jacopo and Via Guicciardini, were blown up to block it.

Allied troops reached the south bank on 4 August. For a week the river was the front line; on 11 August the Germans pulled back to the northern suburbs and the partisans rose in the centre. Fighting, shelling and sniping went on into early September. Popular memory says Hitler personally spared the bridge; historians point out that blocking it with rubble served the German aim just as well, so treat the story with care.

Today the bridge is crowded with jewellers' shops. Look at the buildings on either bank: the plain post-war blocks mark the demolition zone. Downstream, Ponte Santa Trinita was rebuilt in 1958 with stones raised from the riverbed; the missing head of its statue of Spring was fished out of the Arno in 1961.

On the ground: Stand mid-bridge and look at the rebuilt blocks along Via Por Santa Maria and Borgo San Jacopo: their plainer post-war façades mark exactly where the demolitions fell.

43.76799, 11.25316 HIGH exact spot known

39

Sant'Anna di Stazzema — massacre in the Apuan hills

12 Aug 1944, morning

HIGH

On the morning of 12 August 1944 soldiers of II Battalion, SS Panzergrenadier Regiment 35 (16th SS Division Reichsführer-SS), guided by Italian Fascist collaborators, climbed to this mountain village, which was crowded with refugees. In a few hours they killed about 560 people, sources give 540–560, among them more than 100 children (sources give 107 to 130); the youngest, Anna Pardini, was 20 days old. Ten former SS men were convicted in absentia at La Spezia in 2005; none served a sentence.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

In August 1944 the Apuan Alps above the Versilia coast lay just behind the German front on the Arno and the western end of the Gothic Line. Partisans were active, and the hill village of Sant'Anna di Stazzema was full of refugees who believed it was safe. At dawn on 12 August soldiers of II Battalion, SS Panzergrenadier Regiment 35 of the 16th SS Division Reichsführer-SS, with Italian Fascist collaborators as guides, climbed from several directions and surrounded it.

In a few hours they killed about 560 people; the local museum gives about 540. More than 100 were children, 107 by one count and 130 by others, the youngest a baby of 20 days. Many were shot in the church square and their bodies burned. Nobody was tried for decades: the files lay hidden in Rome until the 1990s. In 2005 a military court at La Spezia

sentenced ten former SS men to life imprisonment in absentia, but Germany refused extradition, and a German investigation was closed in 2012 for lack of proof of individual guilt.

Sant'Anna is now the National Park of Peace, with the Historical Museum of the Resistance, the church square, a Via Crucis path and the ossuary monument above the sea. The same mountains saw the US 92nd Division and the Japanese-American 442nd Regimental Combat Team break the western Gothic Line in April 1945.

On the ground: Walk from the church square, where many were shot and burned, up the Via Crucis path to the ossuary monument overlooking the Versilia coast.

DIG DEEPER

Sant'Anna di Stazzema massacre (Wikipedia) ↗

Historical Museum of Sant'Anna di Stazzema ↗

Sant'Anna di Stazzema (NS-Täter in Italien) ↗

43.97417, 10.27361 HIGH exact spot known

PHASE 6 — THE GOTHIC LINE AND THE WINTER, AUG 1944 – MAR 1945

40 Montegridolfo — the Gothic Line broken

30–31 Aug 1944

HIGH

Operation Olive opened on 25 August 1944 when Eighth Army, secretly shifted to the Adriatic, crossed the Metauro. By 30 August British, Canadian and Polish troops faced the main Gothic Line positions on the ridges above the Foglia. On 31 August the walled village of Montegridolfo fell to 1/4th Hampshires; Lieutenant Gerard Norton, a South African, won the Victoria Cross clearing machine-gun posts single-handed. The Line had been breached in days.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Operation Olive was General Leese's plan to break the Gothic Line where it met the Adriatic, on ground better suited to tanks than the high Apennines. Eighth Army's bulk was moved across Italy in secret, and on 25 August 1944 the Polish II Corps, I Canadian Corps and British V Corps crossed the Metauro. The Germans, caught thinning out their

line, were slow to react. By 30 August the attackers stood before the main Green I positions on the ridges north of the Foglia.

Montegridolfo, a walled Malatesta village, was one of those strongpoints. On 31 August the 1/4th Battalion, Hampshire Regiment attacked it. Lieutenant Gerard Norton, a South African officer attached to the battalion, went forward alone, destroying two machine-gun posts with grenades and his Thompson gun and clearing a fortified house although wounded. He was awarded the Victoria Cross. Within days, the Line that had taken a year to build was broken along this sector.

The village has been carefully restored and is one of the prettiest in the Rimini hills. The small Museo della Linea dei Goti on Via Borgo displays newspapers, photographs, weapons and everyday objects given by local families. From the walls you can follow the Foglia valley the attackers crossed.

On the ground: Walk the ramparts of this restored Malatesta hill village and look south over the Foglia valley: the attack came up those open slopes towards you.

DIG DEEPER

Museo della Linea dei Goti (Riviera di Rimini) ↗

Gerard Norton VC (Wikipedia) ↗

Operation Olive (Wikipedia) ↗

43.85826, 12.68995 HIGH exact spot known

41 Coriano Ridge — the last ridge before Rimini

4–13 Sep 1944

MEDIUM

Beyond the broken Gothic Line the Germans rushed reserves onto Coriano Ridge, the last high ground before the Romagna plain. British 1st Armoured Division's attack on 4–5 September stalled with heavy tank losses. After a bombardment by some 700 guns, the 5th Canadian and British 1st Armoured Divisions took the ridge on 12–13 September; in the week of fighting that followed towards Rimini, Eighth Army lost some 150 killed a day, according to the CWGC (Commonwealth War Graves Commission).

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Breaking the Gothic Line did not open the road to the plain. Behind it the Germans rushed panzer and infantry divisions onto a last set of ridges, and the highest was Coriano, between the Conca and Marano rivers. On 4 and 5 September 1944 British 1st Armoured

Division attacked and was stopped with heavy losses; autumn rain then turned the valleys to mud. Leese regrouped and on the night of 12–13 September launched a set-piece assault behind the fire of some 700 guns.

The 5th Canadian Armoured Division and British troops cleared Coriano house by house on 13 September, and the Germans fell back to the San Fortunato ridge and the Marecchia. The Canadian 1st Division lost 2,511 men and the 5th Armoured 1,385 between 25 August and 22 September. Eighth Army as a whole had about 14,000 casualties by the end of September; the German LXXVI Panzer Corps lost some 16,000.

Coriano was almost completely destroyed and has been rebuilt. From the crest you can see Rimini and the coast, and understand why the ridge mattered: whoever held it could watch every Allied move on the plain below. The Commonwealth war cemetery lies on the slopes of the ridge north of the village.

On the ground: From the rebuilt village on the crest, face north-east: Rimini and the sea are only ten kilometres away, the prize both armies could see.

DIG DEEPER

Coriano Ridge War Cemetery (CWGC) ↗

Coriano Ridge War Cemetery (Veterans Affairs Canada) ↗

Coriano Ridge War Cemetery (Wikipedia) ↗

43.96907, 12.60055 MEDIUM close — exact spot uncertain

42 Il Giogo Pass — the Americans break the Apennines

12–18 Sep 1944

HIGH

While Eighth Army fought on the Adriatic, US Fifth Army struck the mountain Gothic Line. Instead of the heavily fortified Futa Pass on Highway 65, II Corps attacked the lesser Il Giogo Pass. For six days the 338th Infantry (85th Division) fought up Monte Altuzzo and the 363rd (91st Division) up Monticelli against the 4th Parachute Division. Both summits fell on 17–18 September at a cost of 2,731 casualties.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The Gothic Line in the central Apennines guarded the two main roads from Florence to Bologna. The Futa Pass on Highway 65 was the obvious route and was the most heavily fortified, with an anti-tank ditch and gun positions. General Clark instead sent US II Corps

against the Il Giogo Pass a few kilometres east, held more thinly by the German 4th Parachute Division. The attack began on 12 September 1944.

For six days the 338th Infantry of the 85th Division fought up Monte Altuzzo and the 363rd Infantry of the 91st Division up Monticelli, company by company, against well-sited bunkers. Private Oscar Johnson won the Medal of Honor holding the flank on Monticelli. Both heights fell on 17–18 September; II Corps had 2,731 casualties. The Futa Pass, outflanked, was taken on 22 September. The Americans then pushed north towards Imola; at Monte Battaglia the 88th Division and partisans held a mountaintop against counterattacks from 27 September until British Guards relieved them.

Today the pass is a quiet crossing on the SP503 at 882 m. A 5.2 km ring trail climbs Monte Altuzzo past trenches and positions, and the MuGot museum at Ponzalla can arrange guided battlefield walks.

On the ground: From the pass (882 m) look west to the wooded crest of Monte Altuzzo and east to Monticelli: the attackers climbed these slopes under fire from bunkers on the skyline.

DIG DEEPER

Cassino to the Alps, ch. 19: Battle for the Pass (US Army CMH) ↗

Break-Through at Monte Altuzzo (US Army CMH) ↗

Gothic Line trail at the Giogo Pass (Mugello tourism) ↗

`44.04680, 11.38803` HIGH exact spot known

43 Monte Sole — the Marzabotto massacre

29 Sep – 5 Oct 1944

MEDIUM

Behind the German front south of Bologna, around 1,000 troops under SS Major Walter Reder swept the Monte Sole massif, stronghold of the Stella Rossa partisan brigade. In a week they killed about 770 people in 115 places, among them 216 children, 316 women and 142 elderly people; older counts give much higher totals. At Casaglia, villagers sheltering in the church with their priest were shot in the cemetery on 29 September.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Monte Sole is a wooded massif between the Reno and Setta valleys, just behind the German front south of Bologna in autumn 1944. It was the base of the Stella Rossa partisan brigade led by Mario Musolesi, known as Lupo. To clear it, the Germans

assembled about 1,000 men, chiefly SS Reconnaissance Battalion 16 under Major Walter Reder, with other SS, army and Fascist units.

Between 29 September and 5 October 1944 they swept the mountain from several sides. The Monte Sole Peace School counts about 770 victims in 115 places, among them 216 children, 316 women and 142 people over 60; commemorations long used a higher figure of 1,830 that included all war deaths in the area. At Casaglia, villagers took refuge in the church with their priest, Don Ubaldo Marchioni; they were driven into the cemetery and machine-gunned, and the priest was killed at the altar; Italian sources count 197 dead at Casaglia, 52 of them children. Reder was sentenced to life by an Italian military court in 1951; ten more men were convicted in absentia at La Spezia in 2007.

The Monte Sole Historical Park, created in 1989, preserves the ruined churches and hamlets. Walk softly: families still come here to remember their dead.

On the ground: Walk up to the roofless church of Casaglia and the small cemetery beside it, where the killings took place. Keep voices low; this is still a place of mourning.

DIG DEEPER

Marzabotto massacre (Wikipedia) ↗

Historical context (Scuola di Pace Monte Sole) ↗

Casaglia (Scuola di Pace Monte Sole) ↗

`44.31102, 11.21793` MEDIUM close — exact spot uncertain

44 Monte Castello — the Brazilians take their mountain

21 Feb 1945, 06:00–17:30

MEDIUM

Monte Castello (977 m) overlooked the Brazilian sector all winter; attacks on 24–25 and 29 November and 12 December 1944 failed against the German 232nd Infantry Division. In Operation Encore the US 10th Mountain Division first scaled Riva Ridge by night on 18–19 February 1945 and stormed Monte Belvedere; then, on 21 February, the Brazilian 1st Infantry Division attacked at 06:00 and held the summit by about 17:30.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The Brazilian Expeditionary Force, about 25,900 men under General João Baptista Mascarenhas de Morais, was the only Latin American ground force to fight in Europe. It reached Italy from July 1944 and joined US IV Corps in the Reno valley. Its soldiers adopted the motto 'the snake will smoke', mocking the saying that Brazil would enter the

war when snakes smoked pipes. Monte Castello, 977 m, dominated its sector; attacks on 24–25 and 29 November and 12 December 1944 failed against the German 232nd Infantry Division.

In February 1945 Operation Encore solved the problem from the flank. On the night of 18–19 February about 700 men of the 1st Battalion, 86th Mountain Infantry, US 10th Mountain Division, climbed the cliffs of Riva Ridge and surprised its defenders. The 10th then stormed Monte Belvedere and neighbouring peaks, and on 21 February the Brazilians attacked Monte Castello at 06:00 and held the summit by about 17:30.

The Brazilians went on to take Montese on 14 April and, at Fornovo on 28–29 April, received the surrender of more than 13,000 German and Italian troops (figures up to about 15,000 are published). A modern monument to the Brazilian dead stands on Monte Castello's slopes above Gaggio Montano.

On the ground: From the Brazilian monument on the slopes above Gaggio Montano look up the bare ridge to the summit, then west to the long wall of Riva Ridge and Monte Belvedere.

DIG DEEPER

Battle of Monte Castello (Wikipedia) ↗

Brazilian Expeditionary Force (Wikipedia) ↗

Mountaineers take the Ridge: Riva Ridge (US Army) ↗

`44.21260, 10.96502` MEDIUM close — exact spot uncertain

PHASE 7 — VICTORY IN ITALY, APR–MAY 1945

45

The Argenta Gap — the door to the Po valley

12–19 Apr 1945

MEDIUM

Operation Grapeshot opened on 9 April 1945 with a massive air and artillery bombardment on the Senio. The key was Argenta, a strip of dry land a few kilometres wide between Lake Comacchio's flooded marshes and the Reno. British V Corps forced it with commandos, amphibious Fantails and Kangaroo armoured carriers against the 42nd Jäger and 29th Panzergrenadier Divisions. Argenta fell on 18 April and British armour broke out towards the Po.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

By spring 1945 the Allies faced a German army still holding a line of rivers and floodbanks across the Romagna. The plan for Operation Grapeshot was for Eighth Army to break through the Argenta Gap, a strip of dry land a few kilometres wide between the flooded Valli di Comacchio and the Reno, while Fifth Army came down from the mountains west of Bologna. On 9 April heavy bombers carpeted the ground between the Senio and the Santerno, and the infantry crossed the Senio that night.

British V Corps pushed north along the Reno and across the flooded land with commandos, amphibious Fantails and Kangaroo armoured carriers. The German 42nd Jäger Division, reinforced by the 29th Panzergrenadier Division, fought hard along the Fossa Marina canal, but the line broke on 17 April and Argenta fell on 18 April. The 6th Armoured Division then drove north-west towards the Po, and the whole German defence on the rivers began to collapse.

The town was badly damaged and largely rebuilt. The Commonwealth cemetery lies two kilometres to the north. Stand on the Reno embankment to see how narrow the corridor was, with water on both sides.

On the ground: Look round the flat reclaimed land outside Argenta: canals, embankments and the Reno levees were the only cover, and the floods on either side made them lethal funnels.

DIG DEEPER

Argenta Gap War Cemetery (CWGC) ↗

Battle of the Argenta Gap (Wikipedia) ↗

Spring 1945 offensive in Italy (Wikipedia) ↗

44.61397, 11.83547 MEDIUM close — exact spot uncertain

46 Bologna liberated

21 Apr 1945, early morning

HIGH

After six months of stalemate within sight of the city, the German front south of Bologna collapsed on 20 April 1945. Early on 21 April troops of the Polish II Corps and the US 34th Division entered from east and south, joined by the Italian Legnano Combat Group and partisans. On the wall of Palazzo d'Accursio, where partisans had been executed, families began pinning photographs of their dead that same day.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Bologna had been almost within reach since October 1944, when Fifth Army's autumn offensive stalled in the mountains south of the city. The winter was hard for its people: Allied bombing killed 2,481 civilians, and the Germans and Italian Fascists executed partisans in the city, many against the wall of Palazzo d'Accursio in Piazza del Nettuno.

In April 1945 Fifth Army attacked from the mountains on 14 April and Eighth Army pressed along the Via Emilia from the east. The German front broke on 20 April. Early on 21 April soldiers of the Polish II Corps and a battalion of the US 34th Division's 133rd Infantry entered the city, with the Italian Legnano Combat Group and partisans; Polish accounts put their troops in first, while the US Army history has the Americans arriving at 08:51 and the Poles later that morning. That same day women began pinning photographs of fallen partisans on the execution wall; an American war artist, Edward Reep, was so struck that he painted it as 'Italian Shrine'.

The permanent memorial by Giuseppe Vaccaro was unveiled on 25 April 1955. Its ceramic tiles carry the names, and often the faces, of more than 2,000 partisans from the Bologna area who died between 1943 and 1945.

On the ground: In Piazza del Nettuno study the wall of ceramic tiles bearing the names and faces of more than 2,000 fallen partisans, beside the Salaborsa library.

`44.49444, 11.34250` HIGH exact spot known

47 San Benedetto Po — first across the Po

22–23 Apr 1945

MEDIUM

Breaking onto the plain, US IV Corps raced north. Spearheads of the 10th Mountain Division reached the Po at San Benedetto at 18:00 on 22 April and crossed in assault boats on 23 April without losing a man. Downstream the 88th Division, British and South Africans followed, trapping thousands of Germans south of the river; the bridges were gone and heavy weapons were abandoned on the banks.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Once Fifth Army was out of the mountains on 20 April 1945, the campaign became a race. General Truscott's divisions drove north across the plain towards the Po, bypassing German rearguards. The 10th Mountain Division moved fastest, and its spearhead reached the river at San Benedetto Po at 18:00 on 22 April.

On 23 April the mountain infantry crossed the Po in assault boats; according to the US Army history not a man was lost in the crossing itself. The 88th Division reached the river

further east the same day, taking about 11,000 prisoners, and the 85th Division and 6th South African Armoured Division followed. To the south, British and South African armour met at Finale Emilia on 23 April, closing a sieve-like trap. With every bridge down, German units abandoned tanks, guns and vehicles and tried to swim or ferry across; organised resistance south of the Alps was finished.

San Benedetto Po is an attractive town grown around the great abbey of Polirone. Climb the embankment to see the width of the river. From here the 10th Mountain drove on north past Verona and up Lake Garda, where its assistant commander, Colonel William Darby, was killed on 30 April.

On the ground: Climb the Po embankment near the abbey town and look across the wide brown river: this is what the retreating German armies had to cross with no bridges left.

`45.04612, 10.93367` **MEDIUM** close — exact spot uncertain

48

Giulino di Mezzegra — the end of Mussolini

28 Apr 1945, about 16:10

MEDIUM

On 25 April 1945 the partisan committee called the general insurrection; Genoa, Milan and Turin rose as the Germans pulled out. Mussolini, fleeing towards Switzerland with a German column, was caught at Dongo on 27 April and, by the official account, shot with Clara Petacci outside Villa Belmonte here the next afternoon; details remain disputed. On 29 April the surrender of German forces in Italy was signed at Caserta, effective 2 May.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

On 25 April 1945 the Committee of National Liberation for Northern Italy called a general insurrection. Partisans rose in Milan, Genoa and Turin as the Germans prepared to leave; in Genoa the German garrison surrendered to the partisans before Allied troops arrived. The day is now Italy's Liberation Day. Mussolini left Milan and, travelling with a German convoy along Lake Como, was recognised and arrested by partisans of the 52nd Garibaldi Brigade at Dongo on 27 April.

According to the official version, on the afternoon of 28 April Walter Audisio, known as 'Colonel Valerio', shot Mussolini and his companion Clara Petacci outside the gate of Villa Belmonte at Giulino di Mezzegra. About fifteen Fascist leaders were shot at Dongo. On 29 April the bodies were hung in Piazzale Loreto in Milan, where fifteen partisans had been shot in August 1944. Historians have proposed many alternative accounts of who fired and where, so the spot is traditional rather than proven.

That same day, 29 April, German envoys signed the unconditional surrender of their forces in Italy at the Royal Palace of Caserta, after secret talks in Switzerland. The fighting stopped at 14:00 local time on 2 May 1945.

On the ground: A memorial at the gate of Villa Belmonte marks the traditional spot. This is a quiet residential lane between private houses: be brief and respectful.

DIG DEEPER

Death of Benito Mussolini (Wikipedia) ↗

Surrender of Caserta (Wikipedia) ↗

Cassino to the Alps, ch. 30: The Capitulation (US Army CMH) ↗

`45.98111, 9.20333` **MEDIUM** close — exact spot uncertain

PLAN YOUR TOUR

The planner ranks every site by its importance to the story, fills your days in south-to-north driving order — Sicily first, then the mainland, Cassino, Anzio and Rome, and the Gothic Line and the Po — with about 7 hours of visits a day, and picks an overnight base for each night. 14 days is the classic drive; 15 or more adds the extras. From Sicily to the mainland you cross the Strait of Messina by ferry (Messina – Villa San Giovanni, about 20 minutes, frequent sailings).

The whole campaign · 14 days · 88 stops · 71 h of visits · 0 visited

DAY 1 — THE LANDING BEACHES



Map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames · dashed line = order of visit, not the road · dashed circle = uncertain spot · tap a number to read about it · tap the map to enlarge · defence lines are approximate

1. Gela seafront and pier, Gela Visit 45 min · Landing beach · Timeline 2 37.06600, 14.24700

2. Piano Lupo crossroads, near Gela Visit 30 min · Battlefield · Timeline 4 37.05500, 14.34500

3. 82nd Airborne memorial, Ponte Dirillo Visit 60 min · Memorial · Timeline 5 37.02325, 14.40814

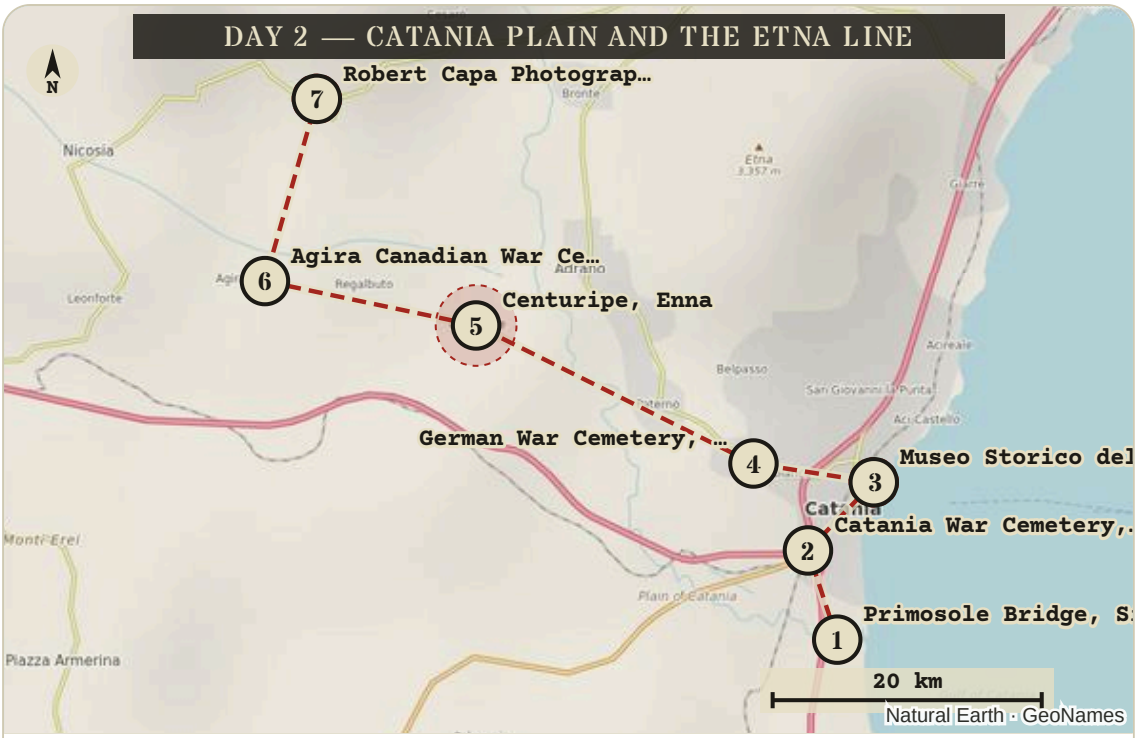
4. Bark West beach, Maucini Visit 45 min · Landing beach · Timeline 3 36.67545, 15.05265

5. Operation Husky monument, Pachino Visit 15 min · Memorial 36.71558, 15.09352

6. Syracuse War Cemetery, Syracuse Visit 45 min · War cemetery (CWGC) 37.07502, 15.25794

7. Ponte Grande, Syracuse Visit 30 min · Bridge · Timeline 1 37.05444, 15.26500

DAY 2 — CATANIA PLAIN AND THE ETNA LINE



Map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames · dashed line = order of visit, not the road · dashed circle = uncertain spot · tap a number to read about it · tap the map to enlarge · defence lines are approximate

1. Primosole Bridge, Simeto river Visit 30 min · Bridge and memorial · Timeline 6 37.39944, 15.06500

2. Catania War Cemetery, Catania Visit 45 min · War cemetery (CWGC) 37.46303, 15.03864

3. Museo Storico dello Sbarco in Sicilia 1943, Catania Visit 90 min · Museum 37.51170, 15.09780

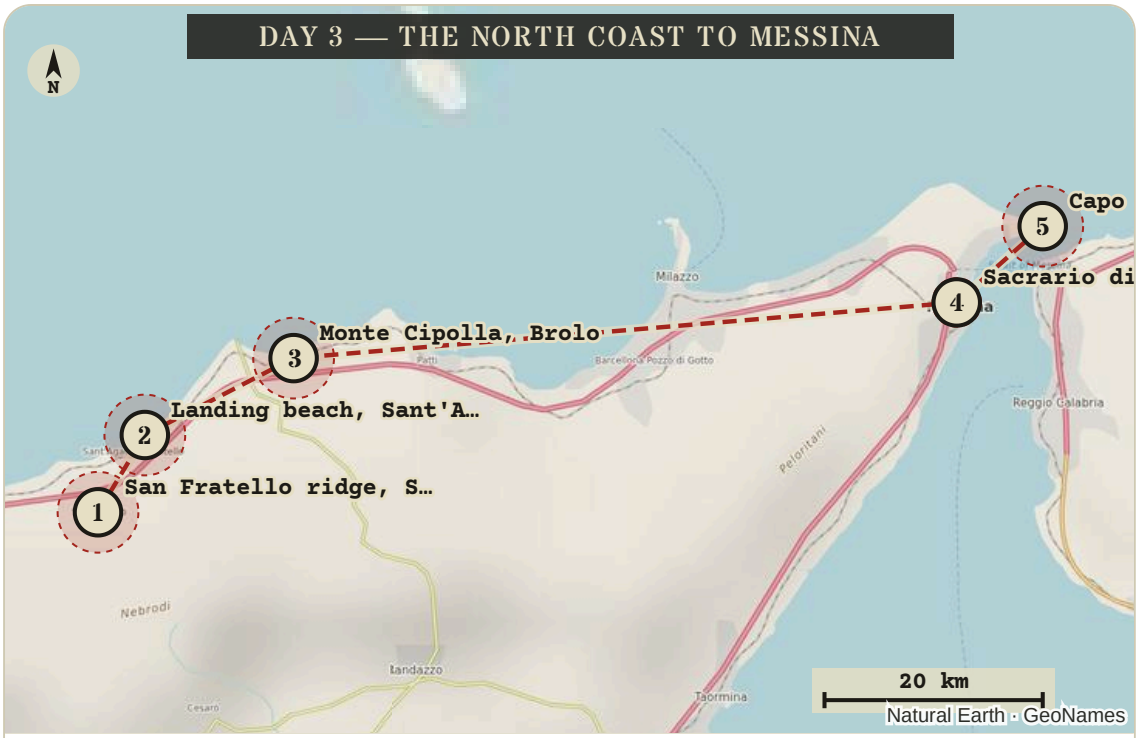
4. German War Cemetery, Motta Sant'Anastasia Visit 45 min · War cemetery (Volksbund) 37.52510, 14.98976

5. Centuripe, Enna Visit 30 min · Viewpoint · Hill town 37.62336, 14.74049

6. Agira Canadian War Cemetery, Agira Visit 45 min · War cemetery (CWGC) · Timeline 8 37.65491, 14.55086

7. Robert Capa Photography Museum, Troina Visit 75 min · Museum · Timeline 9 37.78450, 14.59750

DAY 3 — THE NORTH COAST TO MESSINA



Map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames · dashed line = order of visit, not the road · dashed circle = uncertain spot · tap a number to read about it · tap the map to enlarge · defence lines are approximate

1. San Fratello ridge, San Fratello Visit 30 min · Viewpoint · Battlefield 38.01556, 14.59818

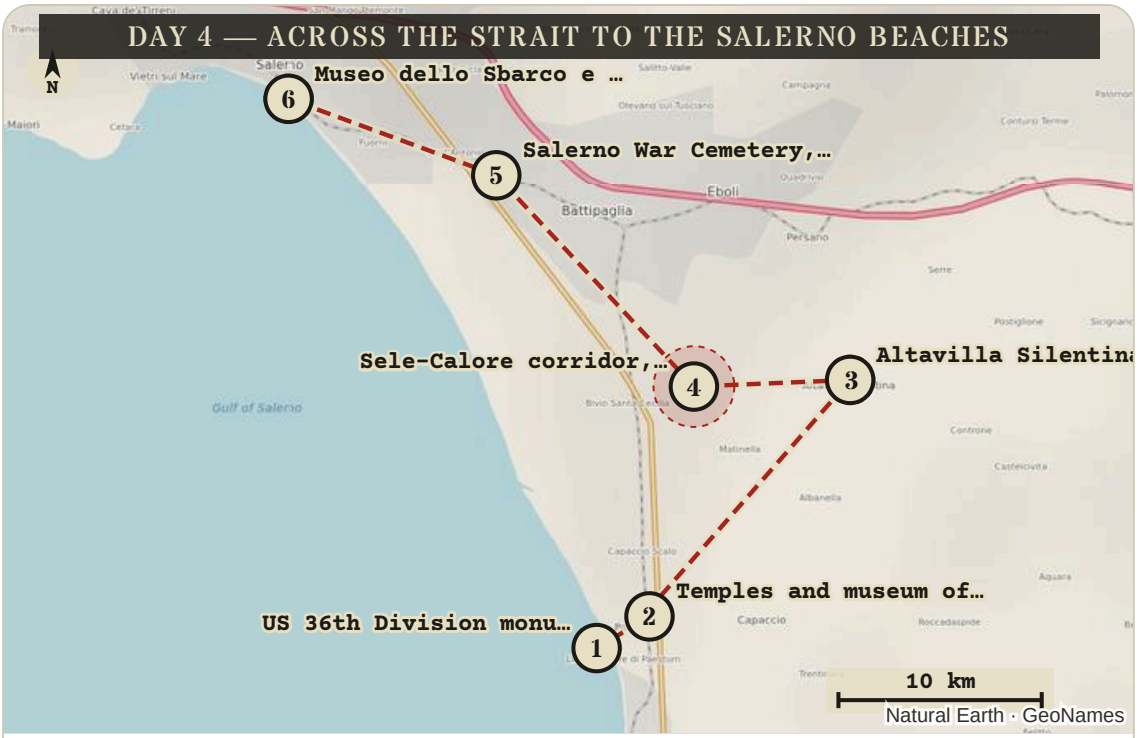
2. Landing beach, Sant'Agata di Militello Visit 30 min · Landing beach 38.08300, 14.65000

3. Monte Cipolla, Brolo Visit 45 min · Battlefield · Timeline 10 38.15000, 14.81500

4. Sacrario di Cristo Re, Messina Visit 45 min · Military shrine · Timeline 12 38.19860, 15.54970

5. Capo Peloro, Torre Faro Visit 30 min · Coastline · Timeline 11 38.26500, 15.64500

DAY 4 — ACROSS THE STRAIT TO THE SALERNO BEACHES



Map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames · dashed line = order of visit, not the road · dashed circle = uncertain spot · tap a number to read about it · tap the map to enlarge · defence lines are approximate

1. US 36th Division monument, Paestum beach Visit 30 min · Memorial · Timeline 14 40.41553, 14.99061

2. Temples and museum of Paestum Visit 90 min · Archaeological site · Timeline 14 40.42222, 15.00528

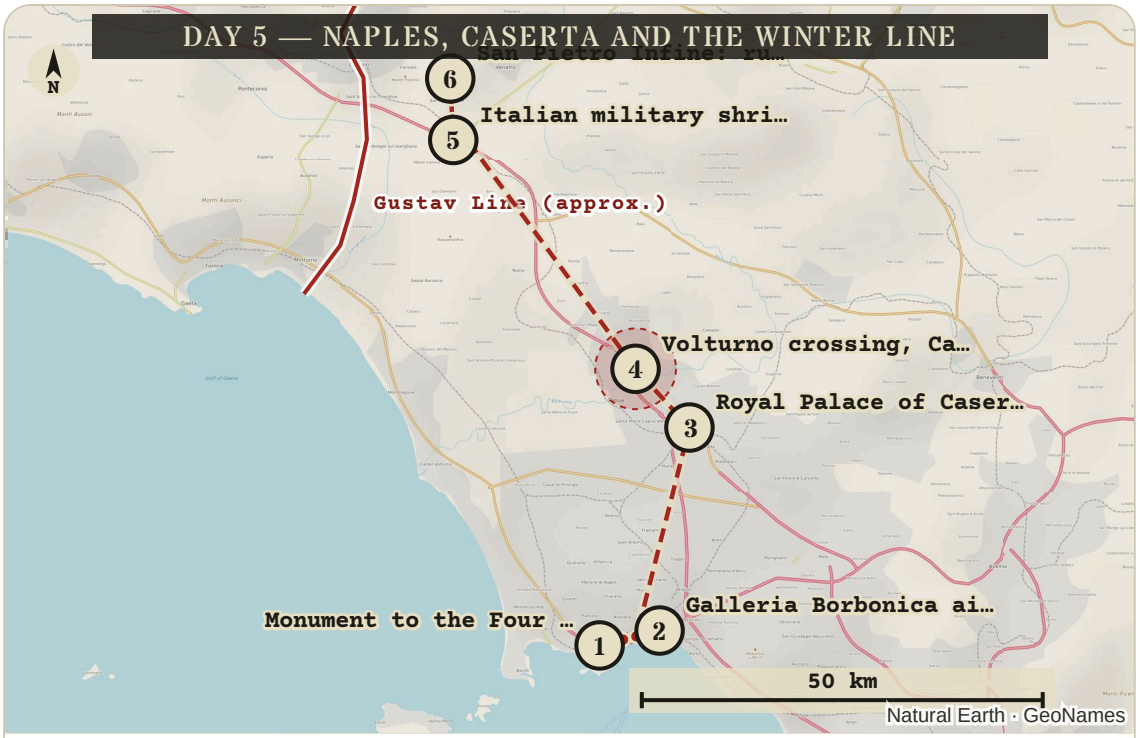
3. Altavilla Silentina and Hill 424 Visit 40 min · Viewpoint · Timeline 16 40.53300, 15.13300

4. Sele–Calore corridor, near Ponte Barizzo Visit 20 min · Battlefield (drive-through) · Timeline 17 40.53000, 15.04000

5. Salerno War Cemetery, Bivio Pratole (Montecorvino Pugliano) Visit 45 min · CWGC war cemetery · Timeline 15 40.62551, 14.92251

6. Museo dello Sbarco e Salerno Capitale, Salerno Visit 60 min · Museum 40.66000, 14.79900

DAY 5 — NAPLES, CASERTA AND THE WINTER LINE



Map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames · dashed line = order of visit, not the road · dashed circle = uncertain spot · tap a number to read about it · tap the map to enlarge · defence lines are approximate

1. Monument to the Four Days of Naples, Piazza della Repubblica Visit 20 min · Memorial · Timeline 18 40.83179, 14.22633

2. Galleria Borbonica air-raid shelter, Naples Visit 75 min · Museum / shelter 40.83552, 14.24626

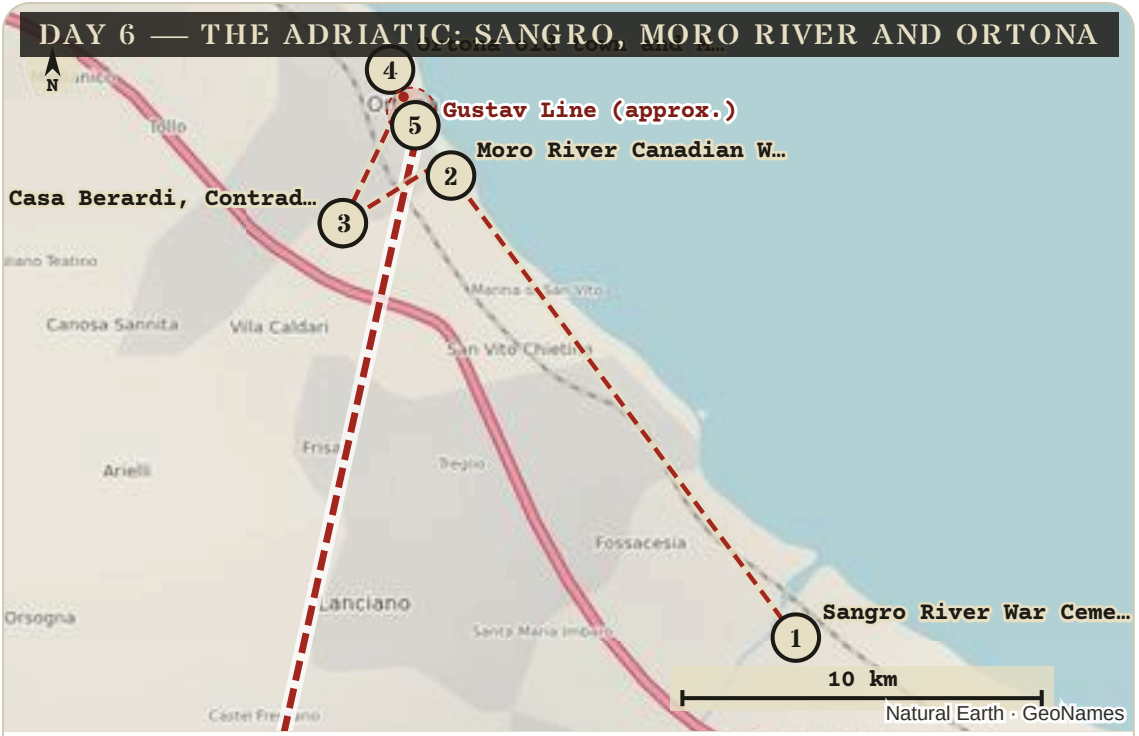
3. Royal Palace of Caserta (Reggia) Visit 120 min · Palace / museum · Allied HQ 41.07333, 14.32639

4. Volturno crossing, Capua–Triflisco Visit 20 min · River crossing · Timeline 19 41.14000, 14.24500

5. Italian military shrine and museum, Mignano Monte Lungo Visit 45 min · Italian war cemetery & museum · Timeline 23 41.42249, 13.96877

6. San Pietro Infine: ruined village and Parco della Memoria Storica Visit 90 min · Ruined village & museum · Timeline 23 41.44604, 13.96727

DAY 6 — THE ADRIATIC: SANGRO, MORO RIVER AND ORTONA



Map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames · dashed line = order of visit, not the road · dashed circle = uncertain spot · tap a number to read about it · tap the map to enlarge · defence lines are approximate

1. Sangro River War Cemetery, Torino di Sangro Visit 40 min · CWGC war cemetery · Timeline 20 42.21841, 14.53559

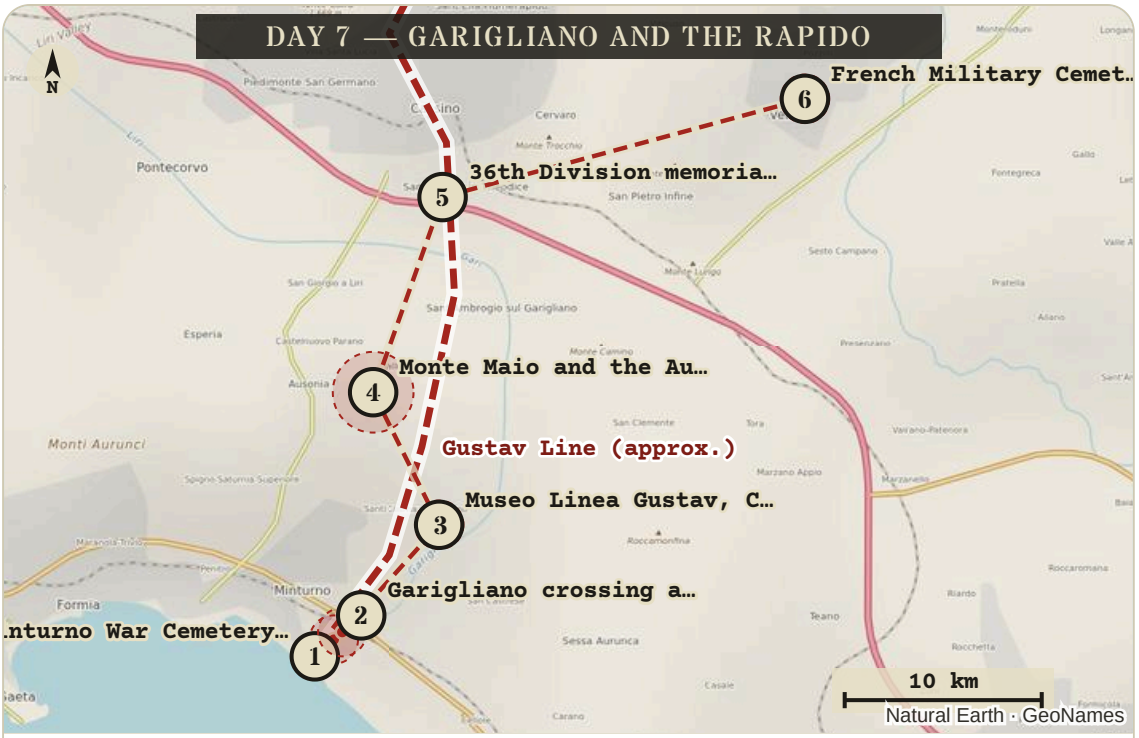
2. Moro River Canadian War Cemetery, San Donato Visit 45 min · CWGC war cemetery · Timeline 22 42.33694, 14.41644

3. Casa Berardi, Contrada Alboreto (Ortona) Visit 30 min · Battle site (private) · Timeline 22 42.32163, 14.38319

4. Ortona old town and MUBA battle museum Visit 90 min · Town battlefield & museum · Timeline 24 42.35306, 14.40361

5. Santa Maria di Costantinopoli, Ortona Visit 20 min · Church · Timeline 24 42.34929, 14.40624

DAY 7 — GARIGLIANO AND THE RAPIDO



Map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames · dashed line = order of visit, not the road · dashed circle = uncertain spot · tap a number to read about it · tap the map to enlarge · defence lines are approximate

1. Minturno War Cemetery, Marina di Minturno Visit 45 min · War cemetery (Commonwealth) 41.24097, 13.76589

2. Garigliano crossing and Real Ferdinando bridge, Minturno Visit 45 min · Battlefield · Timeline 25 41.24444, 13.77111

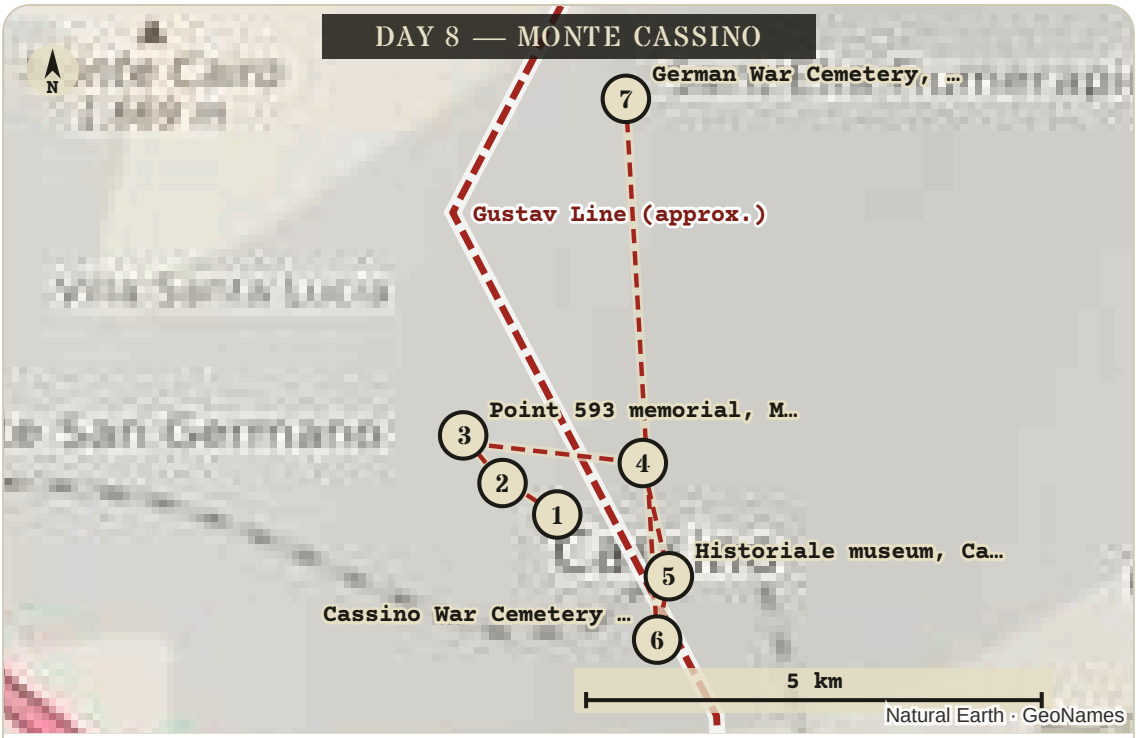
3. Museo Linea Gustav, Castelforte Visit 60 min · Museum 41.29390, 13.83060

4. Monte Maio and the Aurunci mountains, near Ausonia Visit 30 min · Viewpoint · Timeline 33 41.35500, 13.79000

5. 36th Division memorials and the Rapido, Sant'Angelo in Theodice Visit 60 min · Memorial and battlefield · Timeline 26 41.44480, 13.83260

6. French Military Cemetery, Venafro Visit 45 min · War cemetery (French) 41.49002, 14.05492

DAY 8 — MONTE CASSINO



Map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames · dashed line = order of visit, not the road · dashed circle = uncertain spot · tap a number to read about it · tap the map to enlarge · defence lines are approximate

1. Abbey of Monte Cassino Visit 105 min · Abbey · Timeline 29 41.49000, 13.81389

2. Polish War Cemetery and Memorial Museum, Monte Cassino Visit 60 min · War cemetery (Polish) and museum · Timeline 34 41.49391, 13.80575

3. Point 593 memorial, Monte Cassino Visit 45 min · Battlefield and memorial · Timeline 34 41.49706, 13.80228

4. Rocca Janula (Castle Hill), Cassino Visit 45 min · Castle and battlefield · Timeline 31 41.49511, 13.82522

5. Historiale museum, Cassino Visit 60 min · Museum 41.48386, 13.82869

6. Cassino War Cemetery and Memorial Visit 60 min · War cemetery (Commonwealth) 41.47756, 13.82714

7. German War Cemetery, Caira Visit 45 min · War cemetery (German) 41.53130, 13.82299

DAY 9 — ANZIO AND NETTUNO



Map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames · dashed line = order of visit, not the road · dashed circle = uncertain spot · tap a number to read about it · tap the map to enlarge · defence lines are approximate

1. Piana delle Orme museum, near Latina Visit 120 min · Museum 41.44000, 13.00500

2. Rangers memorial, Isola Bella near Cisterna Visit 20 min · Memorial · Timeline 28 41.57000, 12.80000

3. Aprilia ('the Factory') and the Via Anziate Visit 30 min · Battlefield · Timeline 30 41.59470, 12.65440

4. Beach Head War Cemetery, Anzio Visit 45 min · War cemetery (Commonwealth) 41.48194, 12.62500

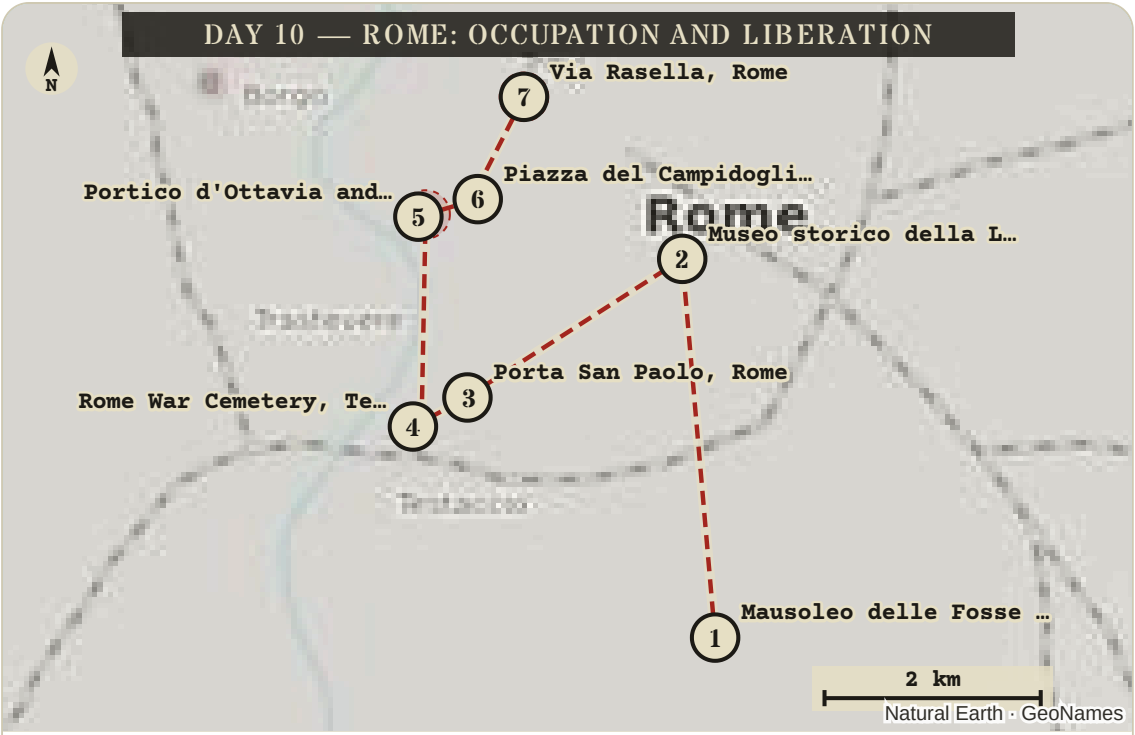
5. Anzio War Cemetery Visit 30 min · War cemetery (Commonwealth) 41.45547, 12.62318

6. Museo dello Sbarco di Anzio (Villa Adele) Visit 60 min · Museum · Timeline 27 41.44991, 12.63126

7. Museo dello Sbarco Alleato, Forte Sangallo, Nettuno Visit 45 min · Museum 41.45540, 12.65800

8. Sicily–Rome American Cemetery and Memorial, Nettuno Visit 75 min · War cemetery (American) 41.46528, 12.65833

DAY 10 — ROME: OCCUPATION AND LIBERATION



Map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames · dashed line = order of visit, not the road · dashed circle = uncertain spot · tap a number to read about it · tap the map to enlarge · defence lines are approximate

1. Mausoleo delle Fosse Ardeatine, Rome Visit 75 min · Memorial and museum · Timeline 32 41.85705, 12.51008

2. Museo storico della Liberazione, Via Tasso Visit 75 min · Museum 41.88861, 12.50639

3. Porta San Paolo, Rome Visit 30 min · Battle site and memorial 41.87667, 12.48139

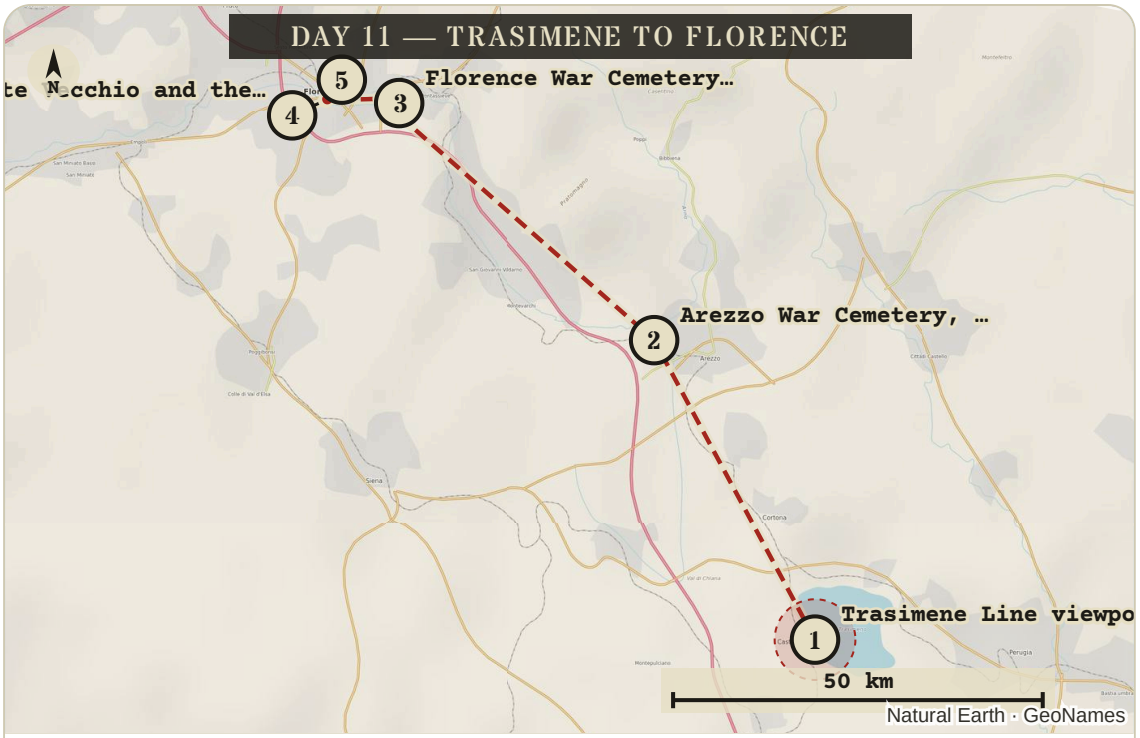
4. Rome War Cemetery, Testaccio Visit 30 min · War cemetery (Commonwealth) 41.87502, 12.47724

5. Portico d'Ottavia and the Jewish Ghetto Visit 30 min · Memorial site 41.89230, 12.47770

6. Piazza del Campidoglio, Rome Visit 20 min · Liberation site · Timeline 36 41.89340, 12.48270

7. Via Rasella, Rome Visit 20 min · Resistance site 41.90210, 12.48870

DAY 11 — TRASIMENE TO FLORENCE



Map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames · dashed line = order of visit, not the road · dashed circle = uncertain spot · tap a number to read about it · tap the map to enlarge · defence lines are approximate

1. Trasimene Line viewpoint, Castiglione del Lago Visit 60 min · Battlefield · Timeline 37 43.12764, 12.05346

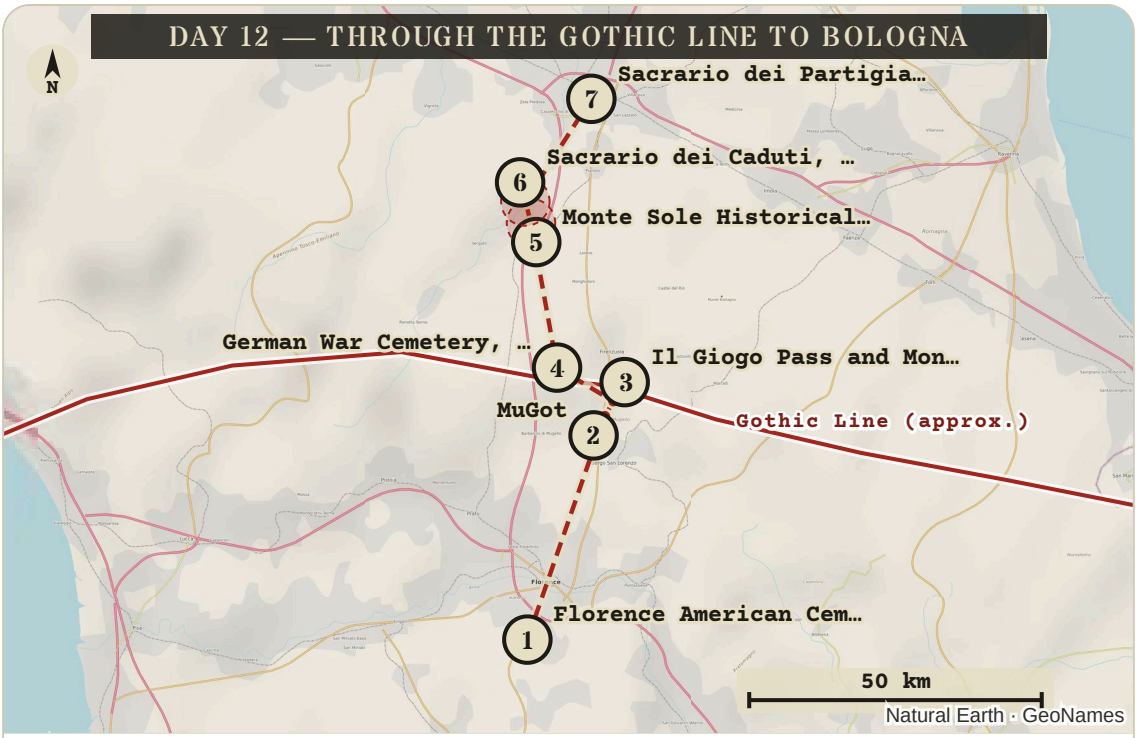
2. Arezzo War Cemetery, Indicatore Visit 45 min · Commonwealth war cemetery 43.48407, 11.79036

3. Florence War Cemetery, Girone Visit 45 min · Commonwealth war cemetery 43.76976, 11.34258

4. Ponte Vecchio and the demolished quarter, Florence Visit 60 min · Historic bridge · Timeline 38 43.76799, 11.25316

5. Palazzo Vecchio and Piazza della Signoria, Florence Visit 60 min · Civic palace · Timeline 38 43.76940, 11.25610

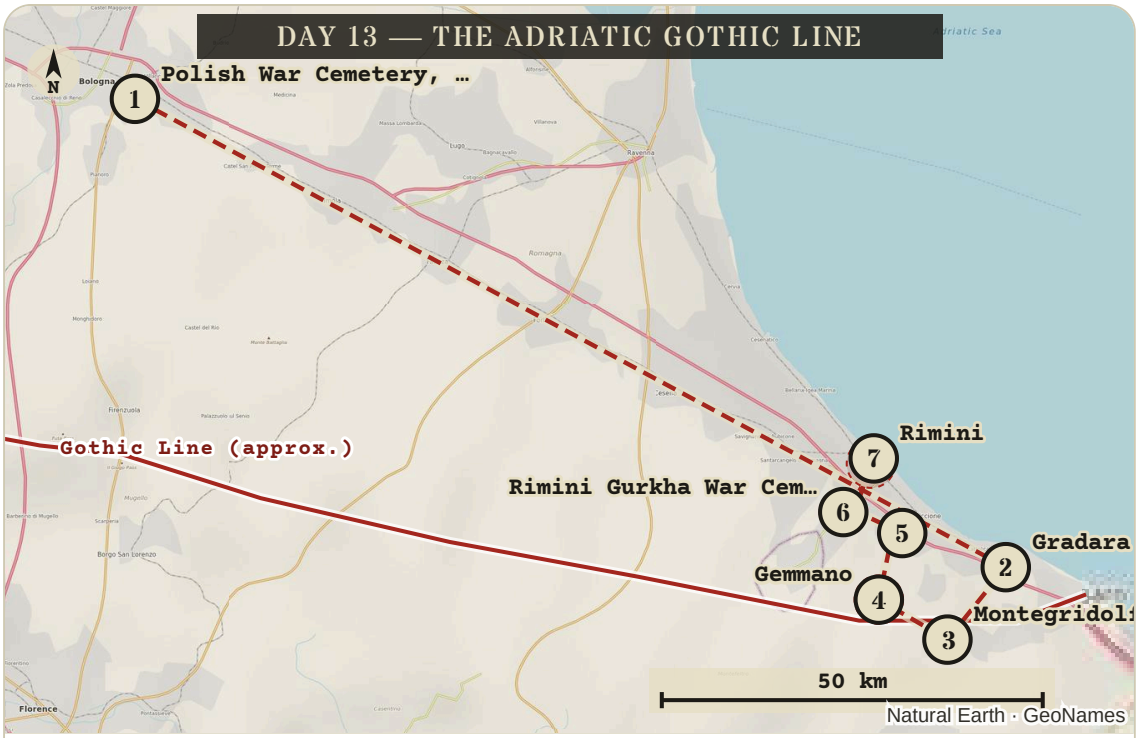
DAY 12 — THROUGH THE GOTHIC LINE TO BOLOGNA



Map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames · dashed line = order of visit, not the road · dashed circle = uncertain spot · tap a number to read about it · tap the map to enlarge · defence lines are approximate

1. **Florence American Cemetery, Tavarnuzze** Visit 60 min · American war cemetery 43.69183, 11.21043
2. **MuGot — Museo Gotica Toscana, Ponzalla** Visit 60 min · Museum 44.02491, 11.37020
3. **Il Giogo Pass and Monte Altuzzo** Visit 45 min · Battlefield · Timeline 42 44.04680, 11.38803
4. **German War Cemetery, Futa Pass** Visit 45 min · German war cemetery 44.09678, 11.27165
5. **Monte Sole Historical Park — Casaglia** Visit 75 min · Memorial site · Timeline 43 44.31102, 11.21793
6. **Sacrario dei Caduti, Marzabotto** Visit 30 min · Memorial crypt · Timeline 43 44.34297, 11.20593
7. **Sacrario dei Partigiani, Piazza del Nettuno, Bologna** Visit 30 min · Memorial · Timeline 46 44.49444, 11.34250

DAY 13 — THE ADRIATIC GOTHIC LINE



Map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames · dashed line = order of visit, not the road · dashed circle = uncertain spot · tap a number to read about it · tap the map to enlarge · defence lines are approximate

1. Polish War Cemetery, Bologna (San Lazzaro) Visit 30 min · Polish war cemetery · Timeline 46 44.47408, 11.40051

2. Gradara War Cemetery Visit 40 min · Commonwealth war cemetery 43.94106, 12.78238

3. Montegridolfo and the Museo della Linea dei Goti Visit 75 min · Battlefield and museum · Timeline 40 43.85826, 12.68995

4. Gemmano — "the Cassino of the Adriatic" Visit 45 min · Battlefield 43.90393, 12.58091

5. Coriano Ridge War Cemetery Visit 45 min · Commonwealth war cemetery · Timeline 41 43.98485, 12.60404

6. Rimini Gurkha War Cemetery, Cerasolo Visit 30 min · Commonwealth (Indian Army) war cemetery 44.00523, 12.54311

7. Rimini — the liberated city Visit 60 min · Town · Timeline 41 44.05944, 12.56833

DAY 14 — THE LAST OFFENSIVE — SENIO, ARGENTA AND THE PO



Map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames · dashed line = order of visit, not the road · dashed circle = uncertain spot · tap a number to read about it · tap the map to enlarge · defence lines are approximate

1. Museo della Battaglia del Senio, Alfonsine Visit 60 min · Museum 44.50768, 12.03743

2. Lake Comacchio — the commandos' battlefield Visit 45 min · Battlefield 44.69478, 12.18194

3. Argenta Gap War Cemetery Visit 45 min · Commonwealth war cemetery · Timeline 45 44.63414, 11.83190

4. Argenta — the Gap Visit 30 min · Town and battlefield · Timeline 45 44.61397, 11.83547

5. The Po at Pontelagoscuro, Ferrara Visit 30 min · River crossing 44.89000, 11.60800

THE CAMPAIGN: WHY ITALY, AND HOW

For twenty-two months the Allies fought their way up a peninsula of mountains and rivers that favoured the defender at every step. This tab shows the main battles step by step, explains the forces that shaped the fighting, and sets the campaign beside what was happening elsewhere in the war.

BATTLE MAPS

8 battles, from the Sicily landings to the final offensive of April 1945. Pick a battle and tap each moment to see how the armies moved. Below each map are the guide's stops that belong to that battle.

German line · red shading = German-held ground

Allied line · arrows = attacks and moves

Explosion or bombing

Key place at this moment

1 Related guide stops (list below)

OPERATION HUSKY: THE LANDINGS AND THE GELA COUNTERATTACK

9–16 Jul 1943

The largest Allied amphibious operation yet put two armies ashore on 150 kilometres of Sicilian coast in a single night. Everything depended on holding the beaches against the Axis mobile divisions in the first 48 hours.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

9–10 JULY · AIRBORNE DROPS AND LANDINGS

In high winds, US paratroopers of the 505th scatter across the south-east and British gliders fall into the sea off Syracuse; a handful seize Ponte Grande. From 02:45 Seventh Army lands at Licata, Gela and Scoglitti, and Eighth Army between Pachino and Cassibile. Italian coastal divisions give way almost everywhere; by evening the British hold Syracuse and its port.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

10–11 JULY · THE GELA COUNTERATTACK

Italian tanks break into Gela on 10 July. At 06:15 on 11 July the Hermann Göring Division attacks down the Niscemi road and the Livorno Division from the west. German tanks reach within 2,000 yards of the sea before artillery and naval gunfire stop them. East of the Acate, Gavin's paratroopers hold Biazza Ridge. That night friendly fire downs 23 transports carrying the 504th.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

12–16 JULY · BREAKOUT AND THE ROAD TO CATANIA

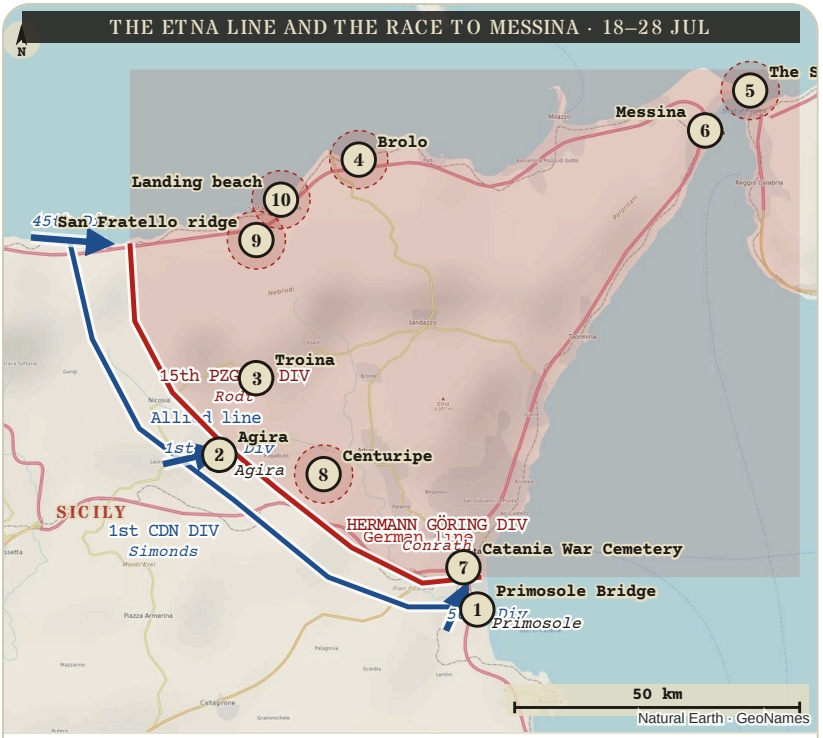
The beachheads join up. Eighth Army takes Augusta on 13 July and that night drops the 1st Parachute Brigade on Primosole Bridge; German paratroopers throw them off and the bridge is only secured on 16 July. The Canadians push inland to Grammichele and the Americans take the airfields around Comiso, Biscari and Ponte Olivo. On 14 July prisoners are murdered near Biscari.

Guide stops: 1. Ponte Grande — gliders seize the bridge · 2. Gela — Rangers and 1st Division storm ashore · 3. Bark West — the Canadians land near Pachino · 4. Piano Lupo — the Gela counterattack · 5. Biazza Ridge — Gavin stops the Tigers · 6. Primosole Bridge — paratroops against paratroops · 7. Landing beaches, Licata · 8. 82nd Airborne memorial, Ponte Dirillo · 9. Operation Husky monument, Pachino · 10. Syracuse War Cemetery, Syracuse

THE ETNA LINE AND THE RACE TO MESSINA

18 Jul–17 Aug 1943

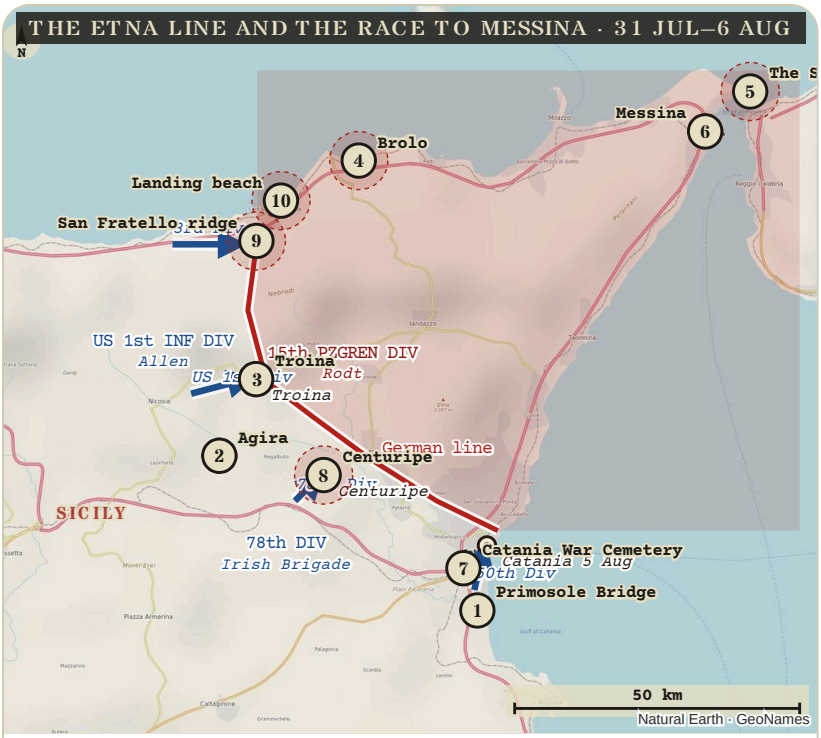
After the landings the Germans fell back to a line round Mount Etna and fought for time. The Allies needed Messina to trap them; the Germans needed only to hold long enough to cross the Strait.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

18–28 JULY · STALEMATE ON THE PLAIN, THE CANADIANS SWING WEST

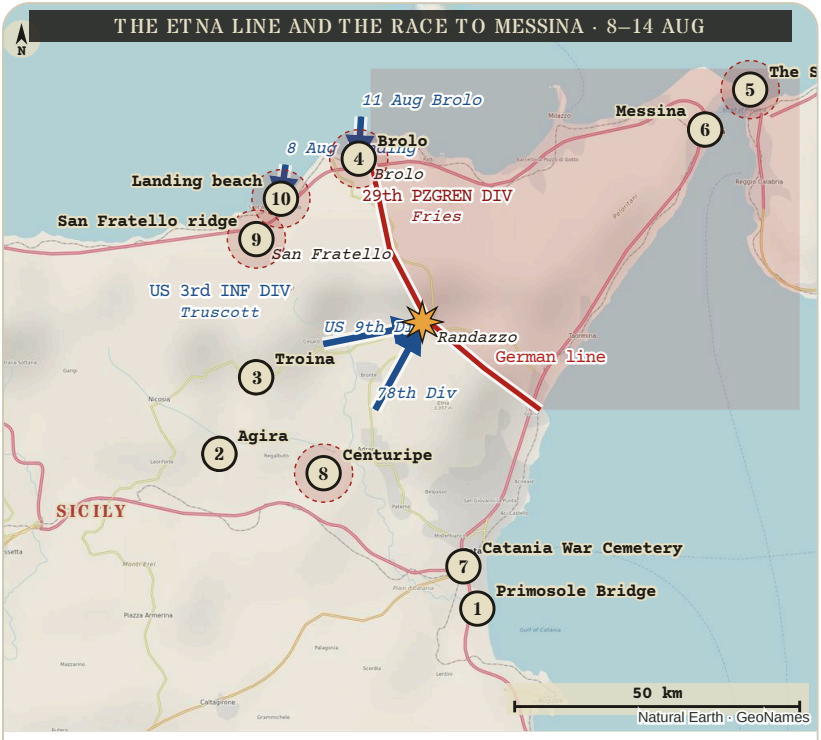
Eighth Army is stopped on the Catania plain by the Hermann Göring Division and German paratroopers. Montgomery shifts the weight inland: the Canadians fight through Leonforte to Agira, taken on 28 July. Seventh Army reaches the north coast, and the 45th Division pushes east along the coast road. In Rome, Mussolini falls on 25 July.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

31 JULY–6 AUGUST · TROINA AND CENTURIPE

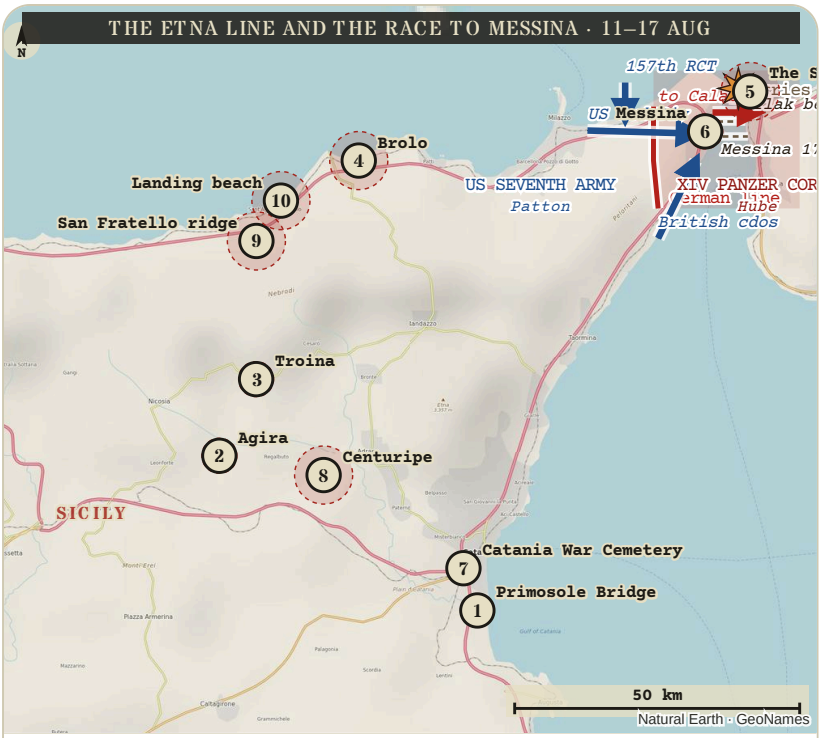
The Allies attack the Etna line. At Troina the US 1st Division fights the 15th Panzergrenadier Division for six days. The British 78th Division storms Centuripe on 2–3 August, and the German line cracks: Catania is abandoned and Eighth Army enters it on 5 August. On the north coast the 3rd Division is held at San Fratello.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

8–14 AUGUST · END RUNS ON THE NORTH COAST

Patton lands a battalion behind the San Fratello line at Sant'Agata on 8 August and again at Brolo on 11 August, where it holds Monte Cipolla for a day. Inland, Americans and British converge on Randazzo, taken on 13–14 August after heavy bombing. The Germans fall back in stages towards Messina, now shortening their line every night.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

11–17 AUGUST · EVACUATION AND MESSINA

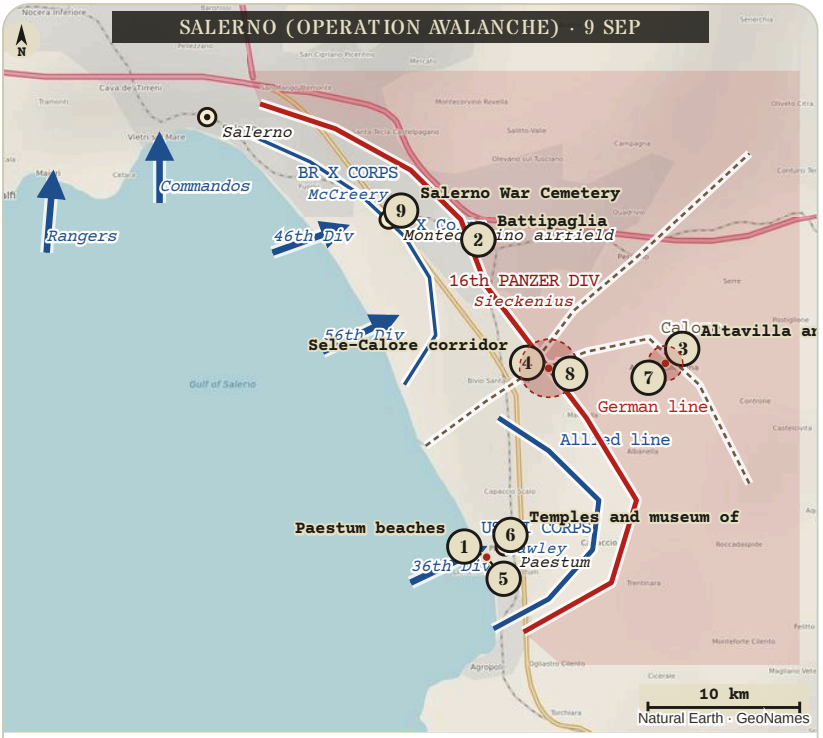
Under a belt of some 500 flak guns, German ferries carry the army across the Strait night after night, while the Italians run their own evacuation. A US landing near Bivio Salica on 16 August and British commandos landed south of Messina arrive too late. American troops enter Messina on the evening of 16 August; Patton arrives at 10:00 on 17 August.

Guide stops: 1. Primosole Bridge — paratroops against paratroops · 2. Agira — the Canadians' hardest fight · 3. Troina — the battle of the Big Red One · 4. Brolo — Patton's end run behind the lines · 5. The Strait — the Axis gets away · 6. Messina — Patton wins the race · 7. Catania War Cemetery, Catania · 8. Centuripe, Enna · 9. San Fratello ridge, San Fratello · 10. Landing beach, Sant'Agata di Militello

SALERNO (OPERATION AVALANCHE)

9–18 Sep 1943

The Allies' first large landing on the Italian mainland aimed to seize Naples quickly, but the Germans reacted fast and came close to splitting the beachhead at the Sele. Whether the Fifth Army could hold on decided whether the Allies would stay on the mainland at all.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

9 SEPTEMBER · THE LANDINGS

At 03:30 the US 36th Division lands at Paestum and the British 46th and 56th Divisions north of the Sele, with Commandos at Vietri and Rangers at Maiori. There is no preliminary bombardment and the 16th Panzer Division is waiting. By evening the Americans hold Capaccio and the slopes of Monte Soprano; the British are close to Montecorvino airfield. A gap separates the two corps along the Sele.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

10–12 SEPTEMBER · INLAND, THEN PUSHED BACK

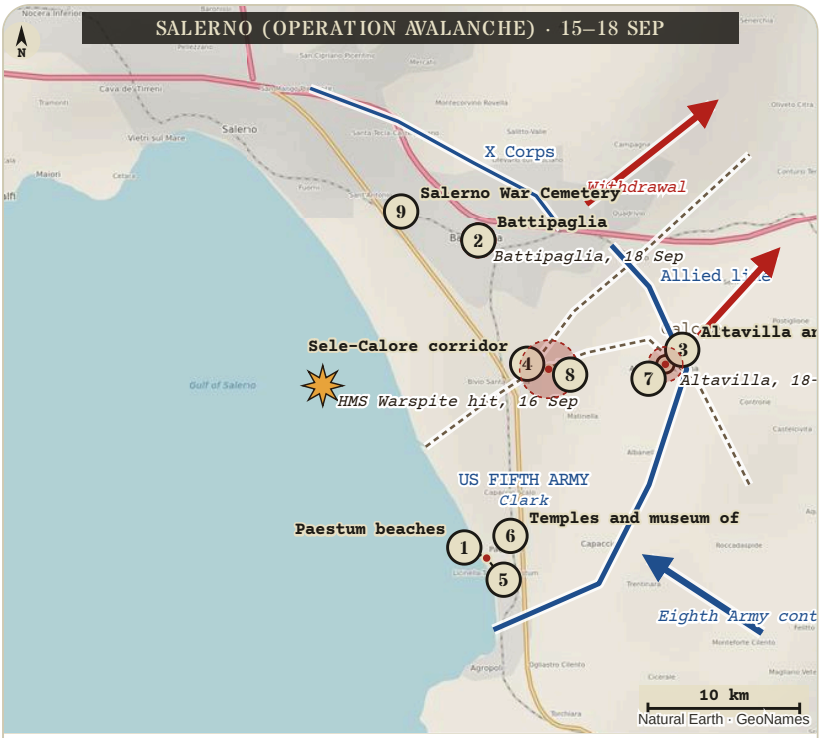
The Americans take Altavilla, Persano and the Tobacco Factory, while the British enter Battipaglia. German reinforcements arrive: the 29th Panzergrenadier Division, the Hermann Göring Division and part of the 15th and 26th. On 12 September counter-attacks drive the 36th Division out of Altavilla and the British 56th Division off the edge of Battipaglia.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

13–14 SEPTEMBER · THE CRISIS

At 15:30 on 13 September German tanks and infantry drive down the Sele–Calore corridor, overrun the 2nd Battalion, 143rd Infantry and head for the beaches. Two artillery battalions stop them near the burned Calore bridge. Clark orders evacuation plans; the 82nd Airborne's 504th and 505th Parachute Infantry drop into the beachhead on two nights, bombers and warships pound the German attacks, and by 14 September's evening the line holds.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

15–18 SEPTEMBER · THE GERMANS PULL BACK

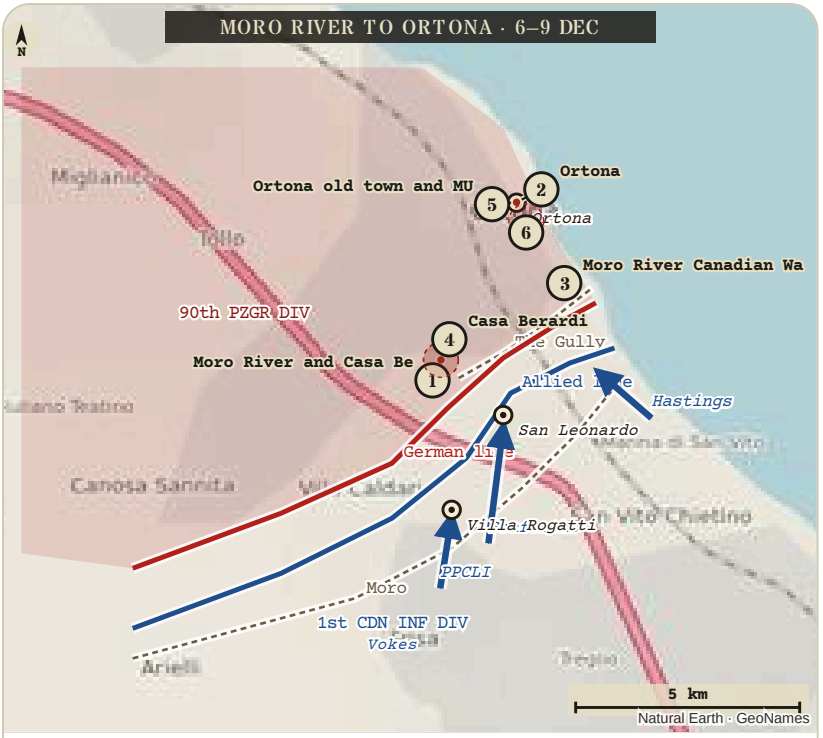
Final German attacks fail. On 16 September radio-guided bombs badly damage the battleship HMS Warspite, but the same day patrols of Eighth Army's 5th Division make contact with the 36th Division far to the south. Vietinghoff decides he cannot destroy the beachhead and withdraws north from 16–18 September. Battipaglia is entered on 18 September and Altavilla reoccupied by 19 September; Naples is the next objective.

Guide stops: 1. Paestum beaches — US 36th Division lands at Salerno · 2. Battipaglia — British X Corps fights for the northern plain · 3. Altavilla and Hill 424 — the heights above the beachhead · 4. Sele–Calore corridor — the German counter-attack is stopped · 5. US 36th Division monument, Paestum beach · 6. Temples and museum of Paestum · 7. Altavilla Silentina and Hill 424 · 8. Sele–Calore corridor, near Ponte Barizzo · 9. Salerno War Cemetery, Bivio Pratole (Montecorvino Pugliano)

MORO RIVER TO ORTONA

6–28 Dec 1943

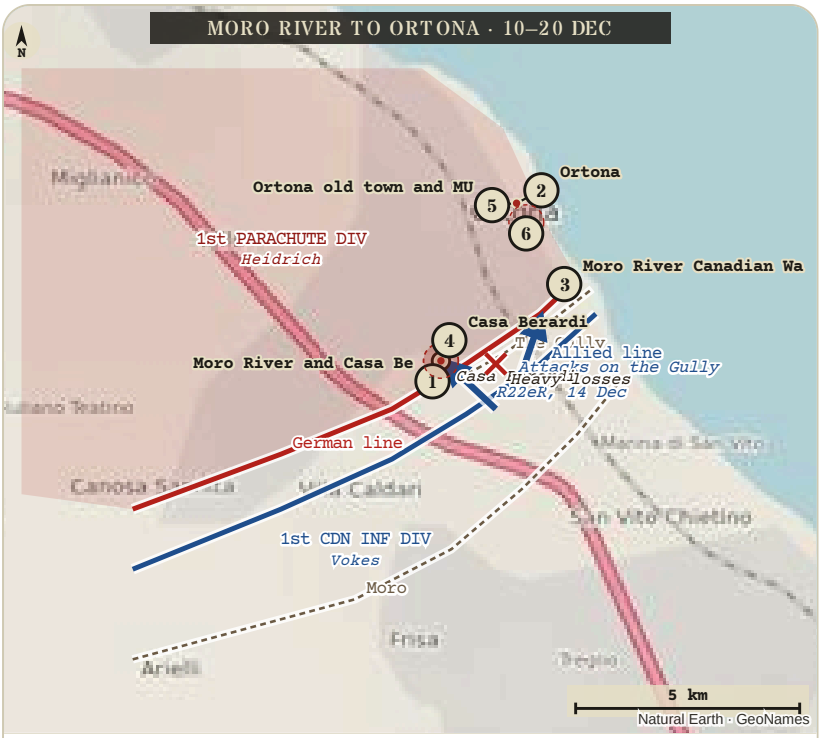
Montgomery hoped to break through on the Adriatic to Pescara and then turn towards Rome before winter. The 1st Canadian Division had to cross the Moro, clear a deep ravine and take the port of Ortona from some of Germany's best troops.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

6–9 DECEMBER · ACROSS THE MORO

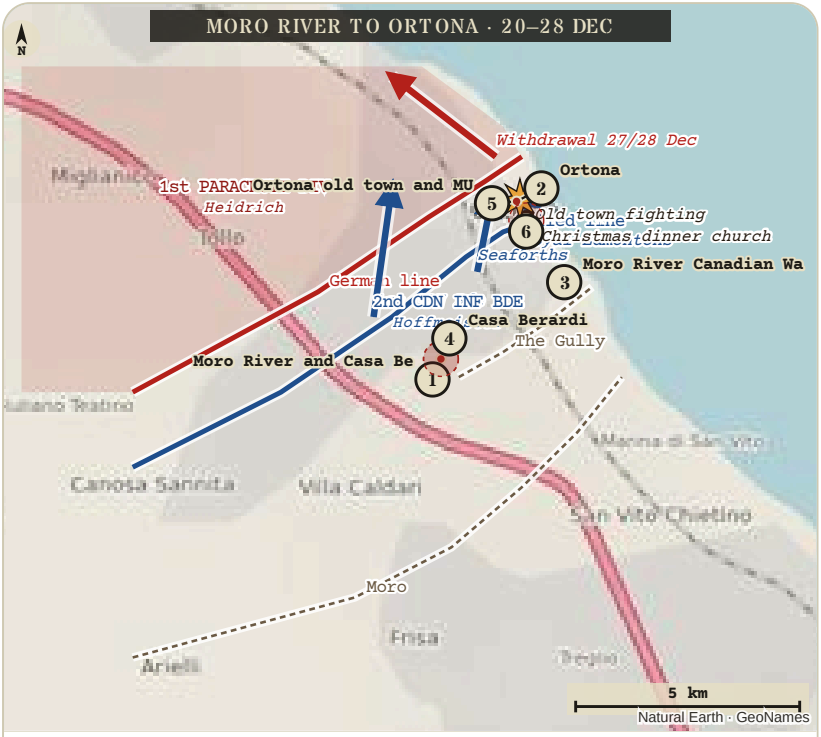
The 1st Canadian Division attacks across the Moro at three points: the Princess Patricia's at Villa Rogatti, the Seaforth Highlanders at San Leonardo, and the Hastings and Prince Edward Regiment near the coast. The German 90th Panzergrenadier Division counter-attacks hard. By 9 December, with tanks across, the Canadians hold a bridgehead on the northern bank.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

10–20 DECEMBER · THE GULLY AND CASA BERARDI

North of the Moro lies the Gully, a ravine about 60 metres deep. Repeated Canadian attacks fail with heavy losses as German paratroopers take over the defence. On 14 December Captain Paul Triquet's company of the Royal 22e Régiment reaches Casa Berardi beyond the Gully with only 14 to 17 men fit to fight; he wins the Victoria Cross. Outflanked, the Germans abandon the Gully on 20 December.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

20–28 DECEMBER · ORTONA

The Loyal Edmonton Regiment and the Seaforth Highlanders of Canada, with Three Rivers tanks, fight into Ortona along the main street. The paratroopers have blocked side streets with rubble and mines, so the Canadians mouse-hole from house to house. The Seaforths hold their Christmas dinner in Santa Maria di Costantinopoli. Outflanked by the 1st Canadian Brigade to the west, the Germans slip away on the night of 27–28 December.

Guide stops: 1. Moro River and Casa Berardi — Canada's December battle · 2. Ortona — street fighting in "Little Stalingrad" · 3. Moro River Canadian War Cemetery, San Donato · 4. Casa Berardi, Contrada Alboreto (Ortona) · 5. Ortona old town and MUBA battle museum · 6. Santa Maria di Costantinopoli, Ortona

THE FOUR BATTLES OF MONTE CASSINO

17 Jan – 18 May 1944

The Gustav Line, anchored on Monte Cassino and the Garigliano and Rapido rivers, barred the road to Rome for five months. Four Allied offensives by soldiers of a dozen nations were needed to break it.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

17 JANUARY – 11 FEBRUARY · THE FIRST BATTLE

British X Corps crosses the lower Garigliano on 17 January and takes Minturno, but the 46th Division fails upstream. On 20–22 January the US 36th Division is shattered at the Rapido near Sant'Angelo. From 24 January the US 34th Division crosses north of Cassino and claws into the massif, and the French fight for the Belvedere, but the abbey height holds.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

15–18 FEBRUARY · THE ABBEY IS BOMBED

The New Zealand Corps under Freyberg takes over. On 15 February 229 bombers destroy the abbey. The 4th Indian Division attacks from Snakeshead ridge towards Point 593 and the monastery on the nights of 15–18 February, while the Maori battalion takes Cassino railway station but is thrown out by tanks. The Germans occupy the ruins.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

15–23 MARCH · THE BATTLE FOR THE TOWN

After some 750 tonnes of bombs flatten Cassino town, the New Zealanders attack from the north. They take Castle Hill, and Gurkhas reach Hangman's Hill below the abbey, but German paratroopers hold the ruins around the Continental Hotel. Rain floods the craters, tanks cannot pass, and the battle is called off on 23 March.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

11–18 MAY · OPERATION DIADEM

At 23:00 on 11 May more than 1,600 guns open fire. British XIII Corps crosses the Rapido; the Polish II Corps attacks Point 593 and loses heavily; the French storm Monte Maio on 13 May and goumiers cross the Aurunci behind the Germans. Outflanked, the paratroopers withdraw and the Poles raise their flag over the abbey on 18 May. Next barrier: the Hitler Line.

Guide stops: 1. Garigliano, Minturno — British X Corps crosses the river · 2. Sant'Angelo in Theodice — the US 36th Division fails at the Rapido · 3. Monte Cassino — the abbey is destroyed from the air · 4. Cassino town and Castle Hill — the third battle · 5. Monte Maio — the French break through the Aurunci mountains · 6. Point 593, Monte Cassino — the Poles take the heights · 7. Pontecorvo and Aquino — the Hitler Line broken · 8. Minturno War Cemetery, Marina di Minturno · 9. Garigliano crossing and Real Ferdinando bridge, Minturno · 10. Museo Linea Gustav, Castelforte · 11. Monte Maio and the Aurunci mountains, near Ausonia · 12. 36th Division memorials and the Rapido, Sant'Angelo in Theodice · 13. Abbey of Monte Cassino · 14. Polish War Cemetery and Memorial Museum, Monte Cassino · 15. Point 593 memorial, Monte Cassino · 16. Rocca Janula (Castle Hill), Cassino · 17. Historiale museum, Cassino · 18. Cassino War Cemetery and Memorial · 19. German War Cemetery, Caira

ANZIO–NETTUNO: OPERATION SHINGLE

22 Jan – 4 Jun 1944

A landing behind the Gustav Line was meant to unlock the road to Rome in days. Instead VI Corps was besieged for four months on a flat coastal plain before breaking out in May.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

22 JANUARY · THE LANDING

At 02:00 VI Corps lands almost unopposed: the British 1st Division at Peter Beach north-west of Anzio, Rangers and paratroopers in Anzio harbour, the US 3rd Division at X-Ray Beach east of Nettuno. By midnight 36,000 men are ashore. Lucas consolidates a beachhead about 25 km wide instead of racing for the Alban Hills, and German units pour in.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

30 JANUARY – 3 MARCH · ATTACK AND COUNTER-ATTACK

On 30 January the British push to Campoleone and the Rangers are destroyed near Cisterna. The Germans retake the Factory (Aprilia) and Carroceto on 9–10 February. On 16 February Operation Fischfang drives down the Via Anziate; it is stopped near the Flyover by 20 February. Truscott replaces Lucas on 22 February, and a last German attack near Cisterna fails in early March.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

23 MAY – 4 JUNE · BREAKOUT AND THE TURN TO ROME

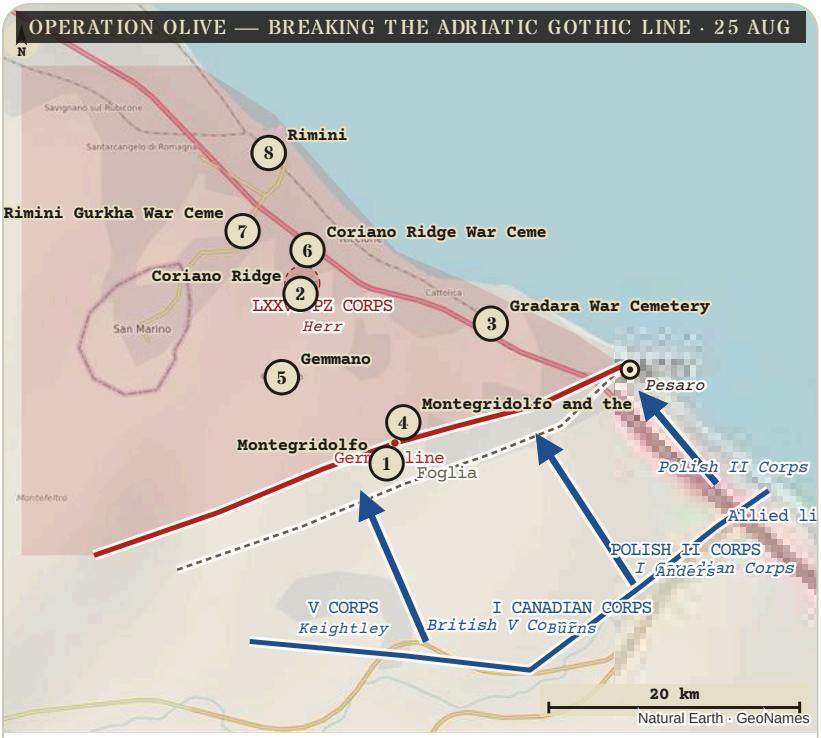
On 23 May VI Corps attacks towards Cisterna, which falls on 25 May; the same day its patrols meet II Corps coming up from the south near Borgo Grappa. Clark then turns most of VI Corps north-west towards Rome rather than on to Valmontone. The 36th Division slips through the Caesar Line at Monte Artemisio on 30–31 May, and Rome falls on 4 June.

Guide stops: 1. Anzio — Operation Shingle lands behind the Gustav Line · 2. Cisterna — two Ranger battalions destroyed · 3. Aprilia, 'the Factory' — the German counter-offensive · 4. Piana delle Orme museum, near Latina · 5. Rangers memorial, Isola Bella near Cisterna · 6. Aprilia ('the Factory') and the Via Anziate · 7. Beach Head War Cemetery, Anzio · 8. Anzio War Cemetery · 9. Museo dello Sbarco di Anzio (Villa Adele) · 10. Museo dello Sbarco Alleato, Forte Sangallo, Nettuno · 11. Sicily–Rome American Cemetery and Memorial, Nettuno

OPERATION OLIVE — BREAKING THE ADRIATIC GOTHIC LINE

25 Aug – 21 Sep 1944

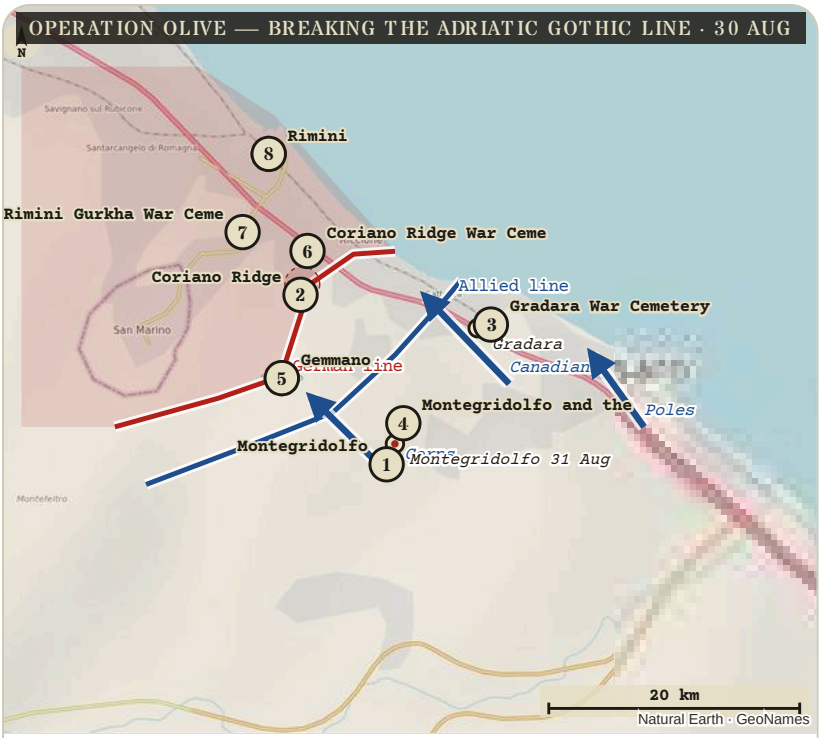
Eighth Army switched secretly to the Adriatic to break the Gothic Line where the Apennines meet the sea and burst into the Romagna plain before winter. It broke the Line in a week, but German reserves on the ridges before Rimini turned the breakthrough into a costly slogging match.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

25–29 AUGUST · ACROSS THE METAURO

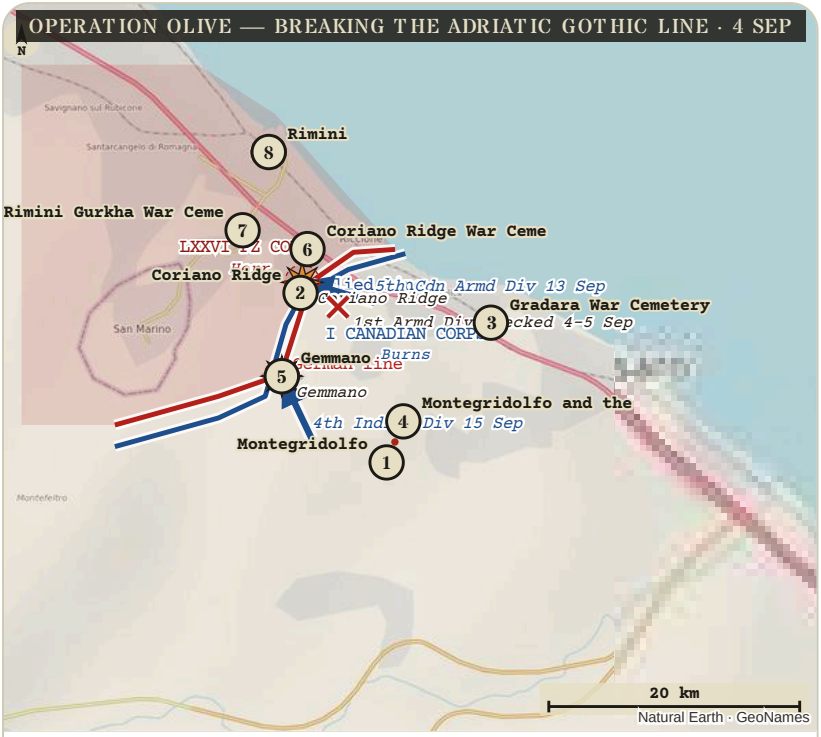
On 25 August 1944 three corps of Eighth Army cross the Metauro on a front from the foothills to the sea: Polish II Corps on the coast, I Canadian Corps in the centre and British V Corps inland. The Germans, pulling back to their prepared line, are caught off balance. By 29–30 August the attackers are closing on the Foglia and the main Gothic Line positions on the ridges beyond.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

30 AUGUST – 3 SEPTEMBER · GREEN I BROKEN

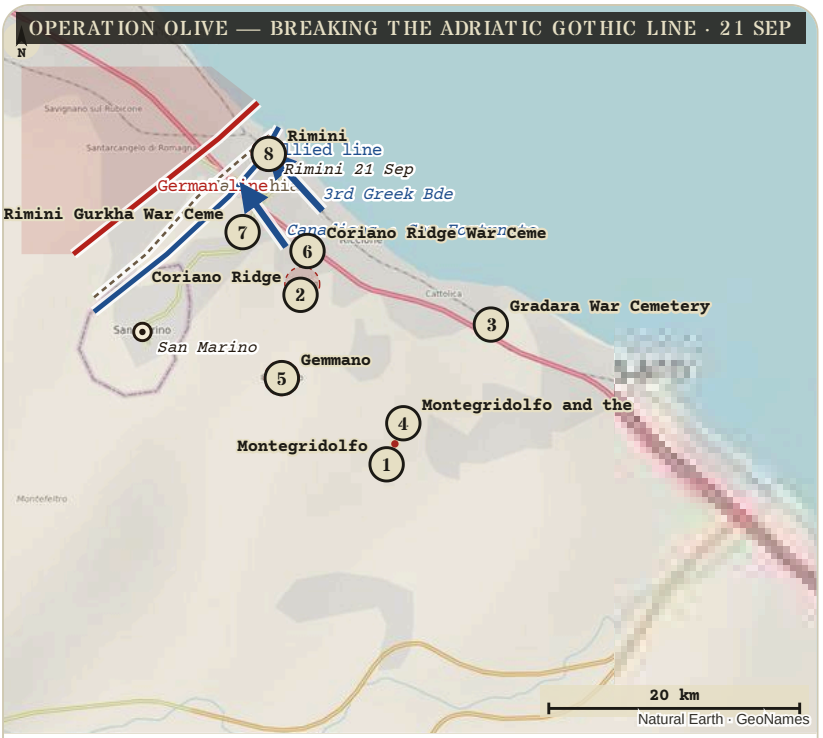
Canadian and British infantry storm the ridges above the Foglia. Montegridolfo falls to the 1/4th Hampshires on 31 August, where Lieutenant Norton wins the Victoria Cross, and the Canadians break through towards the Conca. By 3 September they have advanced some 15 miles to the coast near Riccione. The Poles clear Pesaro. But German reserves are arriving on the next ridges.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

4–15 SEPTEMBER · CORIANO AND GEMMANO

On 4–5 September British 1st Armoured Division attacks Coriano Ridge and is stopped with heavy losses; rain turns the valleys to mud. Inland, Gemmano changes hands again and again. On 12–13 September, behind some 700 guns, the 5th Canadian Armoured Division and British troops take Coriano; the 4th Indian Division finally clears Gemmano on 15 September.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

14–21 SEPTEMBER · SAN FORTUNATO AND RIMINI

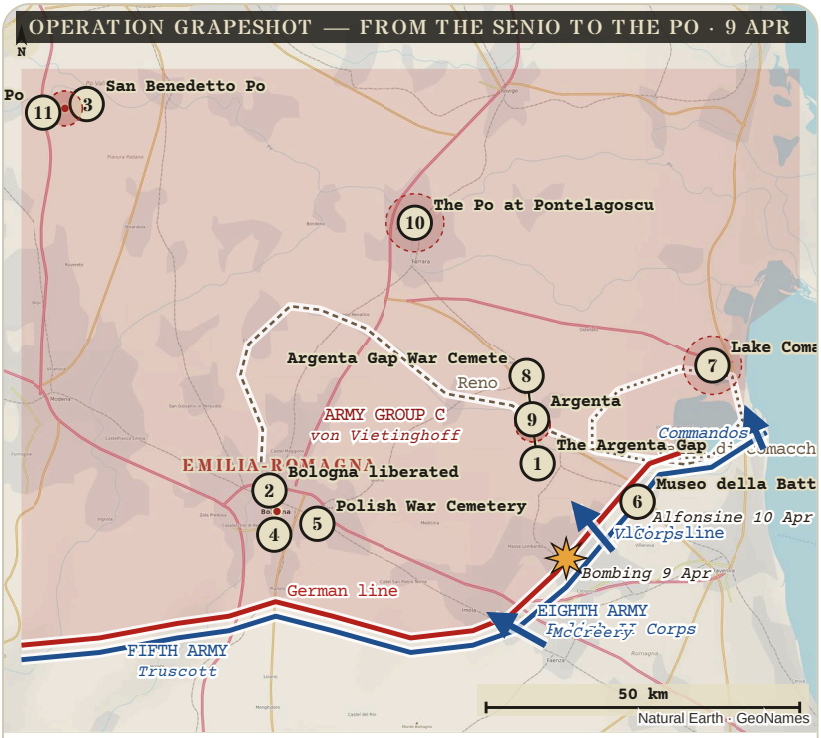
The Germans fall back to the San Fortunato ridge and the Marecchia. San Marino is isolated by 19 September. After hard fighting the ridge falls, and on the morning of 21 September the 3rd Greek Mountain Brigade enters a Rimini left in ruins. Eighth Army has lost about 14,000 men; the German LXXVI Panzer Corps about 16,000. The autumn rains now close in.

Guide stops: 1. Montegridolfo — the Gothic Line broken · 2. Coriano Ridge — the last ridge before Rimini · 3. Gradara War Cemetery · 4. Montegridolfo and the Museo della Linea dei Goti · 5. Gemmano — "the Cassino of the Adriatic" · 6. Coriano Ridge War Cemetery · 7. Rimini Gurkha War Cemetery, Cerasolo · 8. Rimini — the liberated city

OPERATION GRAPESHOT — FROM THE SENIO TO THE PO

9–25 Apr 1945

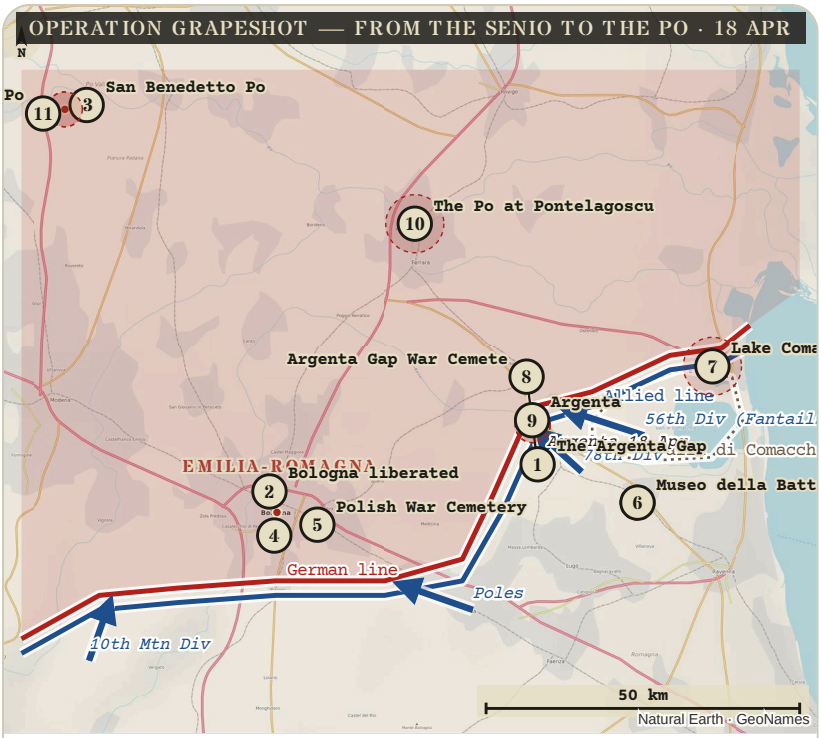
After a winter of stalemate, the Allies planned to destroy the German armies south of the Po rather than simply push them back. Eighth Army would force the Argenta Gap while Fifth Army broke out of the mountains west of Bologna, closing a trap on the river.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

1–10 APRIL · THE SENIO AND LAKE COMACCHIO

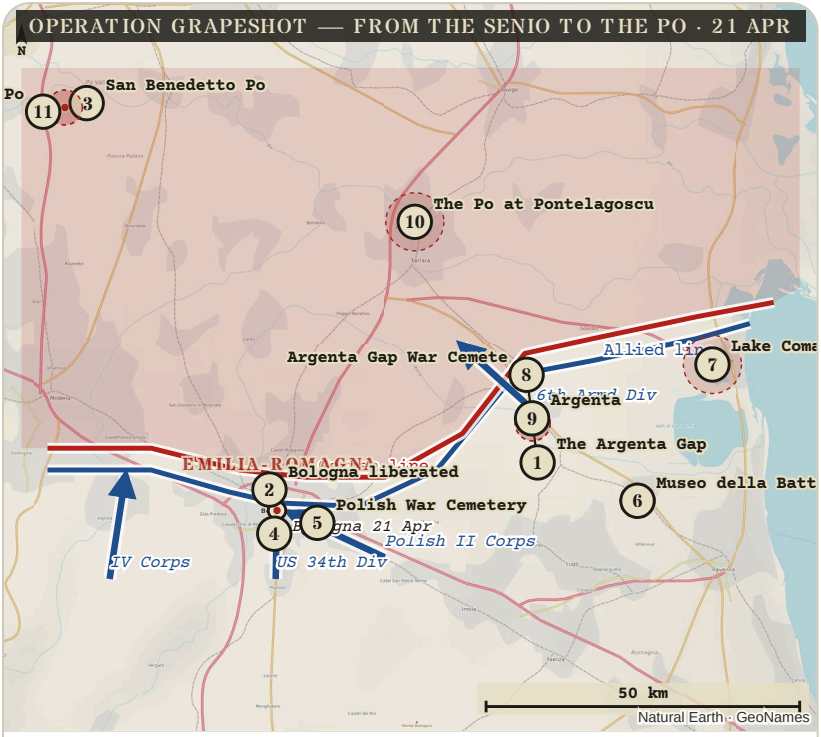
Commandos open the offensive on the Comacchio spit from 1 April. On 9 April heavy bombers and massed artillery pound the ground between the Senio and the Santerno, and that night Eighth Army's infantry cross the Senio with assault boats and flame-throwers; Alfonsine is freed on 10 April. The Polish II Corps drives along the Via Emilia towards Imola.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

12–19 APRIL · THE ARGENTA GAP

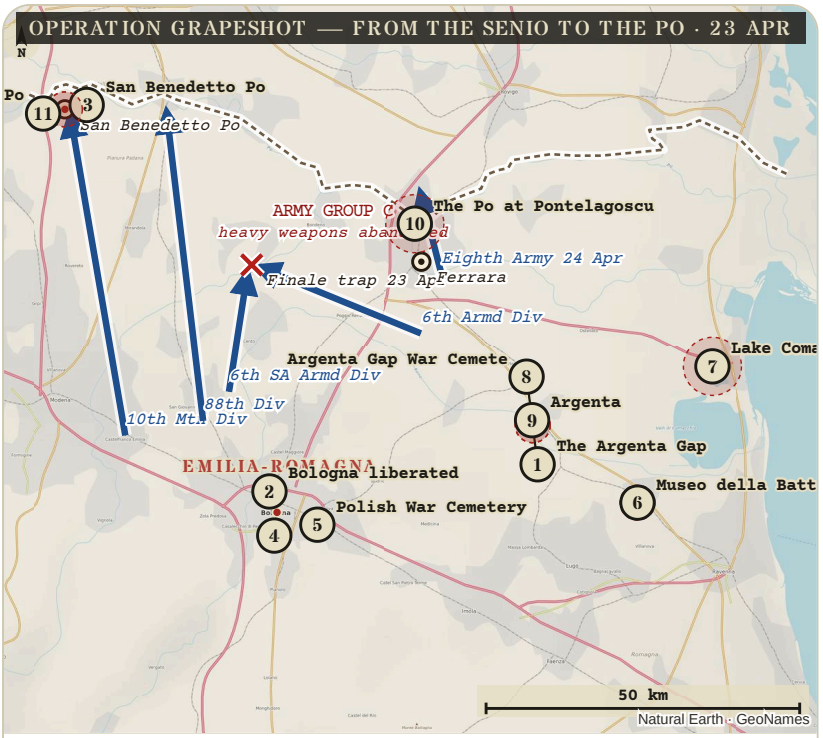
British V Corps pushes up the Reno and across the flooded fields with Fantails and Kangaroos against the 42nd Jäger and 29th Panzergrenadier Divisions. The Fossa Marina line breaks on 17 April and Argenta falls on 18 April. In the mountains Fifth Army attacks from 14 April, the 10th Mountain Division leading; it loses 553 men on the first day.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

20–21 APRIL · BOLOGNA

The German front in the mountains collapses on 20 April and Fifth Army pours onto the plain across Highway 9. Early on 21 April Polish troops and the US 34th Division enter Bologna with the Italian Legnano Group and partisans. East of the city British armour breaks out of the Argenta Gap towards Ferrara and the Po.



Battle sketch: approximate, drawn from historical maps · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames

22–25 APRIL · THE RACE TO THE PO

Allied columns race north. The 10th Mountain Division reaches the Po at San Benedetto on the evening of 22 April and crosses on 23 April; the 88th Division takes some 11,000 prisoners. British and South African armour meet at Finale Emilia, trapping thousands of Germans. With the bridges gone, Germans abandon their heavy weapons; Eighth Army crosses on the night of 24 April.

Guide stops: 1. The Argenta Gap — the door to the Po valley · 2. Bologna liberated · 3. San Benedetto Po — first across the Po · 4. Sacrario dei Partigiani, Piazza del Nettuno, Bologna · 5. Polish War Cemetery, Bologna (San Lazzaro) · 6. Museo della Battaglia del Senio, Alfonsine · 7. Lake Comacchio — the commandos' battlefield · 8. Argenta Gap War Cemetery · 9. Argenta — the Gap · 10. The Po at Pontelagoscuro, Ferrara · 11. San Benedetto Po — the 10th Mountain crossing

THE DECISIVE FACTORS

A country built for defence

Italy is a mountain spine, the Apennines, with narrow coastal strips on either side and rivers running down to the sea across every line of advance — the Volturno, Garigliano, Rapido, Sangro, Moro, Arno, Senio and finally the Po. Each river was a moat and each ridge a rampart. Tanks, the Allies' great advantage, were tied to valley roads overlooked from the heights, so the fighting fell to infantry, mule trains and engineers. The retreating Germans blew every bridge and culvert and mined the verges; the Allies answered with thousands of Bailey bridges. An attacker could rarely go round a position. He had to go over it, one ridge at a time.

Volturno · Rapido · Sangro · Arno · Senio · Po

Kesselring's defence lines

Rommel advised Hitler to give up southern Italy and hold the northern Apennines; Kesselring argued he could stop the Allies south of Rome, and in November 1943 Hitler gave him command of the whole theatre. The result was a sequence of prepared lines, built with forced Italian labour and the Organisation Todt: the Volturno, Barbara and Bernhardt lines, the Gustav Line at Cassino, the Hitler (Senger) Line behind it, then the Caesar, Trasimene, Arno and Gothic Lines. Each was held long enough to finish the next one. It cost the Allies months at every stage and turned a pursuit into a siege war.

Gustav Line · 4 battles · Jan–May 1944

A strategy still argued over

Italy was a British idea that the Americans accepted with reluctance. Its aims shifted: first to knock Italy out of the war, then to seize the Foggia airfields and Rome, and finally to hold down German divisions that might otherwise fight in France or Russia. It did all three, but slowly and at a heavy price, and critics argue that the Allies tied down as many troops as the Germans did. Supporters reply that without Italy there was no way to fight the Germans on land in 1943. Both views have serious defenders; this guide presents the evidence rather than a verdict.

Allied casualties c. 310,000–330,000 · sources vary

Rival commanders

Coalition war bred rivalries. In Sicily Patton raced Montgomery to Messina. At Salerno and Anzio British and American commanders doubted each other; Lucas, criticised for caution at Anzio, was replaced by Truscott in February 1944. Clark, ambitious and suspicious of British motives, turned his forces towards Rome in May 1944 instead of trying to trap the German 10th Army at Valmontone, as Alexander had planned. Some historians call that a grave error that let the Germans escape; others argue the trap would not have closed anyway. Alexander's light, consensual style of command smoothed the coalition but did not always impose a single plan.

4 June 1944 · Clark enters Rome

Rain, mud and mountain winters

Sunny Italy was a myth for the soldiers. The autumn rains of 1943 and 1944 turned roads to mud, rivers to torrents and valleys to swamps; snow closed the high passes. Two mountain winters, 1943–44 and 1944–45, brought trench foot, frostbite and exhaustion, and supplies went forward on mules and on men's backs. Summer brought dust and malaria — worst in Sicily and in the Pontine Marshes near Anzio, which the Germans had deliberately flooded. Even the landscape struck back: the eruption of Vesuvius in March 1944 wrecked dozens of American bombers on an airfield below the volcano.

Two mountain winters · 1943–44 and 1944–45

Landing craft and the priority of France

From the start Italy came second to the invasion of France. Landing ships were the scarcest item in the Allied arsenal: their departure for Britain shaped every plan, and Anzio was launched with only enough to land two divisions. Seven veteran divisions left the Mediterranean for Britain in late 1943; in summer 1944 seven more, the US VI Corps and the French Expeditionary Corps, were taken from Italy for the landings in Provence just as the Germans were in retreat. In early 1945 the Canadians left too. Behind the front, wrecked ports, blown railways and the German air raid on Bari in December 1943 strained supply.

7 divisions withdrawn for southern France · Aug 1944

An army of many nations

No Allied campaign was more international. Americans and British fought beside Canadians, New Zealanders, Indians and Gurkhas, South Africans, Poles, French, Moroccans, Algerians and Tunisians, Brazilians, Greeks, the Jewish Brigade and, from late 1943, Italian co-belligerent troops. That brought strengths — the French goumiers' mountain skills, the Poles' determination at Cassino — and problems of language, supply, reinforcement and politics. The Poles fought on while their country's future was being settled at Yalta; America's segregated units fought for a country that denied them equality at home; and Italians fought on both sides.

US · UK · Canada · NZ · India · Poland · France · Brazil · South Africa · Greece · Italy

Air power and bombing

The Allies held the skies over Italy for almost the whole campaign. Fighter-bombers hunted German transport by day, forcing movement to the night, and Operation Strangle (March–May 1944) tried to cut the railways feeding the Gustav Line. Heavy bombers flying from Foggia struck deep into Germany, Austria and the Romanian oilfields. But bombs could not dig paratroopers out of the rubble of Cassino, and bombing of Italian cities — ports, rail yards and centres like Naples, Rome, Milan and Treviso — killed many thousands of civilians, most of them after Italy had changed sides. Historians disagree about how much it achieved.

Operation Strangle · Mar–May 1944

Partisans and civilians

From September 1943 the Resistance grew from scattered bands into a force of well over 100,000, gathering intelligence, sabotaging railways, rescuing Allied escapers and, in 1945, liberating cities before the Allies arrived. The Germans answered with reprisals: the Fosse Ardeatine in Rome, Sant'Anna di Stazzema, Monte Sole and hundreds of smaller massacres. Civilians lived through bombing, hunger, forced labour, deportation of Jews and displacement as the front crossed their valleys twice a year. Some suffered from their liberators too, above all the women of southern Lazio in the Marocchinate of May 1944, whose true numbers remain disputed.

25 April 1945 · the general insurrection

TWO CLOCKS: ITALY AND THE REST OF THE WAR

Key dates of the Italian campaign, beside what was happening at the same time on the other fronts.

DATE	IN ITALY	ELSEWHERE IN THE WAR
1943		
10 Jul	Operation Husky: the US Seventh and British Eighth Armies land in Sicily, with the Canadians among Montgomery's divisions.	Kursk: the great German offensive in Russia has been under way since 5 July; Hitler calls it off on 13 July, citing the danger in the Mediterranean.
25 Jul	After the Fascist Grand Council's vote, the King dismisses and arrests Mussolini. Badoglio forms a government.	Operation Gomorrah: RAF and US bombers begin a week of raids on Hamburg; the firestorm of 27–28 July kills tens of thousands.
17 Aug	US troops enter Messina. The Sicilian campaign is over, but over 100,000 Axis troops have escaped to the mainland.	The US Eighth Air Force raids Schweinfurt and Regensburg the same day and loses 60 bombers. Roosevelt and Churchill are meeting at Quebec.
3 Sep	The Eighth Army crosses the Strait of Messina into Calabria. At Cassibile, Italy	In New Guinea, Australian troops land near Lae the next day, 4 September.

	secretly signs the armistice.	
8–9 Sep	The armistice is announced; the Fifth Army lands at Salerno. Germany launches Operation Achse and the King flees Rome.	On the Eastern Front the Red Army is liberating the Donbas; Smolensk falls to it on 25 September.
1 Oct	The Allies enter Naples after the city's Four Days rising. The Foggia airfields are already in British hands.	In occupied Denmark, most of the country's Jews are smuggled across to neutral Sweden in the first days of October.
13 Oct	Italy declares war on Germany and becomes a co-belligerent. The Fifth Army fights across the Volturno.	On 14 October — 'Black Thursday' — the US Eighth Air Force loses 60 bombers over Schweinfurt; the Sobibor death camp revolt breaks out.
2 Dec	German bombers sink some 17–28 Allied ships (sources count differently) in Bari harbour; a ship carrying mustard gas bombs is among them.	The Tehran conference (28 Nov – 1 Dec) has just fixed the invasion of France for May 1944.
20–28 Dec	The 1st Canadian Division fights house by house through Ortona. In the mountains, San Pietro and Monte Lungo have fallen.	On 26 December the Royal Navy sinks the battleship Scharnhorst off North Cape, Norway.
1944		
22 Jan	VI Corps lands at Anzio; the first battle of Cassino and the failed Rapido crossing have just been fought.	On 27 January the Red Army finally lifts the siege of Leningrad, after almost 900 days.
15 Feb	Allied bombers destroy the abbey of Monte Cassino; the second battle, by the New Zealand Corps, fails. At Anzio the Germans counter-attack.	'Big Week' (20–25 February): US and British bombers attack the German aircraft industry.
15–18 Mar	The third battle of Cassino begins with the bombing of the town. On 18 March Vesuvius begins to erupt; within days its hot ash wrecks dozens of US bombers on an airfield near Pompeii.	On 19 March German troops occupy Hungary, their wavering ally.
24 Mar	In reprisal for a partisan bomb attack, the Germans shoot 335 men and boys in the Fosse Ardeatine caves outside Rome.	The 'Great Escape' from Stalag Luft III, Silesia, that night; 50 recaptured airmen are later shot on Hitler's orders.
11 May	Operation Diadem opens along the Gustav Line; within a week the French break through the mountains and the Poles take the abbey.	On 9 May the Red Army liberates Sevastopol in the Crimea.
25 May	The Anzio breakout links with the main front; Clark turns north-west for Rome instead of Valmontone.	In Yugoslavia German paratroopers raid Tito's headquarters at Drvar; Tito escapes.

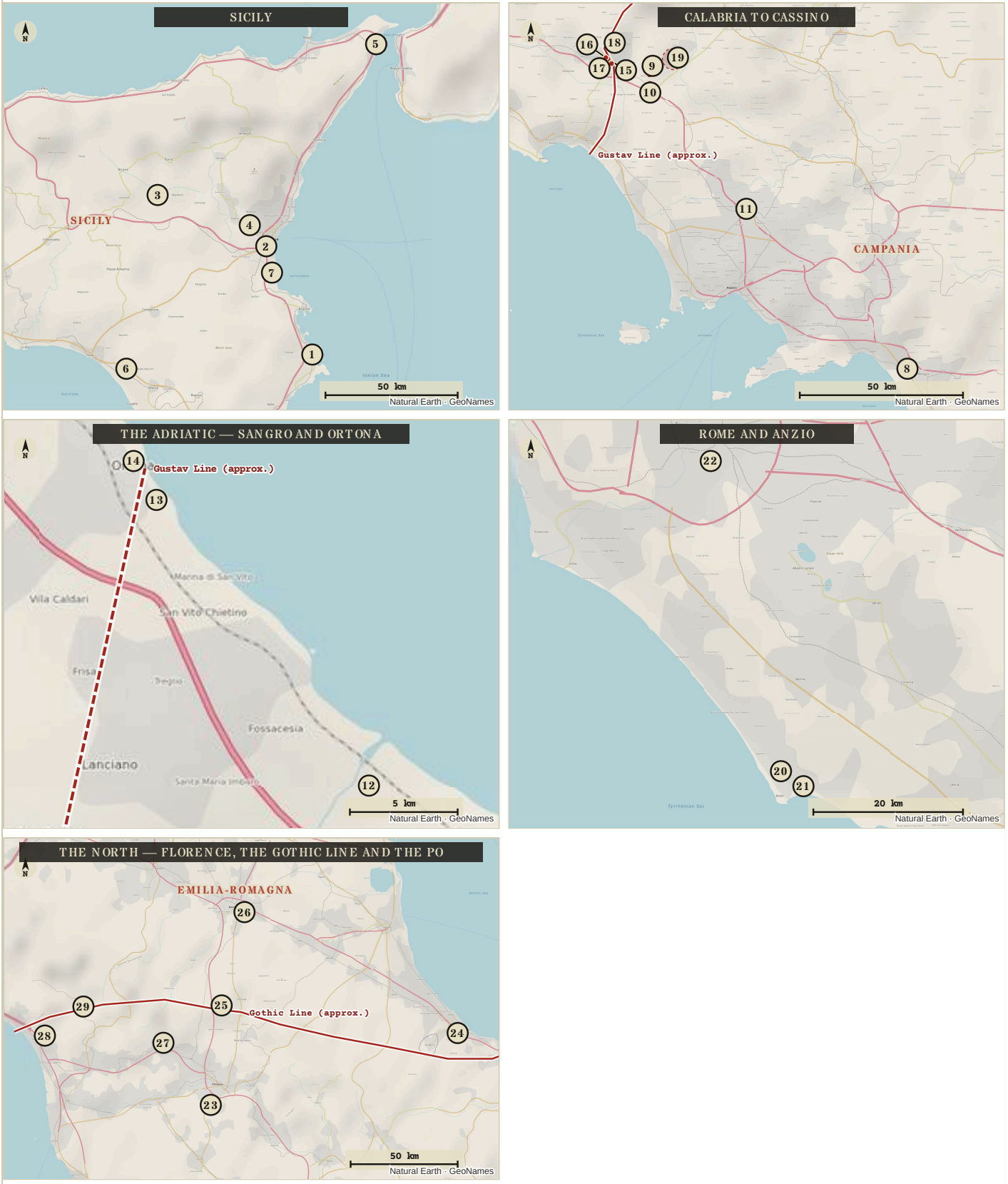
4 Jun	The Fifth Army enters Rome, the first Axis capital to fall.	Two days later, on 6 June, the Allies land in Normandy.
18 Jul	The Polish II Corps takes Ancona; the Americans enter Livorno the next day.	On 20 July Stauffenberg's bomb fails to kill Hitler at his East Prussian headquarters.
4 Aug	The Germans blow Florence's bridges, sparing only the Ponte Vecchio, as the Allies reach the south bank; the city rises on 11 August.	The Warsaw Uprising has begun on 1 August. In Amsterdam, Anne Frank's family is arrested.
12 Aug	SS troops massacre hundreds of villagers at Sant'Anna di Stazzema in the Apuan Alps.	The Allies are closing the Falaise pocket in Normandy; on 15 August divisions taken from Italy land in Provence.
25 Aug	Operation Olive: the Eighth Army attacks the Gothic Line on the Adriatic.	Paris is liberated the same day.
21 Sep	Greek and Canadian troops enter Rimini; in the mountains the Fifth Army has broken through the Giogo Pass.	Operation Market Garden in the Netherlands is failing at Arnhem.
29 Sep	SS troops begin the massacres around Monte Sole (Marzabotto): about 770 civilians killed in a week.	On 2 October the Warsaw Uprising surrenders after 63 days.
Late Oct	The Fifth Army's offensive stalls a few miles short of Bologna. Kesselring is injured in a road accident.	The Battle of Leyte Gulf (23–26 October), by many measures the largest naval battle in history, in the Philippines.
13 Nov	Alexander's broadcast tells the partisans to stand down for the winter, a hard blow to the Resistance.	On 12 November RAF bombers sink the battleship Tirpitz in Norway.
16 Dec	Clark takes over 15th Army Group, Truscott the Fifth Army. The Canadians have taken Ravenna on 4 December.	The Germans launch their Ardennes offensive — the Battle of the Bulge — the same day.
1945		
21 Feb	The Brazilian Expeditionary Force takes Monte Castello, alongside the US 10th Mountain Division's attack on the ridges.	On 19 February US Marines land on Iwo Jima; the Yalta conference ended on 11 February.
9 Apr	Operation Grapeshot: the Eighth Army attacks across the Senio; the Fifth Army follows on 14 April.	On 12 April President Roosevelt dies; the Soviets open the battle for Berlin on 16 April.
21 Apr	Polish and Italian troops enter Bologna, followed by the Americans.	Soviet troops are fighting into the suburbs of Berlin.
25 Apr	The CLNAI proclaims a general insurrection; partisans free Milan and Genoa as the Allies	American and Soviet troops meet on the Elbe at Torgau.

	cross the Po.	
28 Apr	Partisans shoot Mussolini near Lake Como; the Brazilians trap a German division at Fornovo.	US troops liberate Dachau concentration camp the next day, 29 April.
29 Apr	German envoys sign the unconditional surrender of Army Group C at Caserta.	On 30 April Hitler kills himself in his Berlin bunker.
2 May	The surrender takes effect at 2 p.m. local time (12:00 GMT). The war in Italy is over; New Zealanders have reached Trieste.	Berlin surrenders to the Red Army the same day. VE Day follows on 8 May.

KEY SITES OF THE WHOLE CAMPAIGN

War cemeteries of every nation and the places that explain the campaign, south to north. Sites already on the classic tour are marked; the others you can add to your route. Tap a map to enlarge it.

ITALY 1943 – 1945 — KEY SITES



Regional panels from south to north · map data: Natural Earth, GeoNames · numbers match the list below

1 Syracuse War Cemetery

1943 · Commonwealth war cemetery · on the classic tour

HIGH

About 1,060 Commonwealth burials, mostly from the landings between Pachino and Syracuse and from the glider operation that ended in the sea. British, Indian, South African, Canadian and Australian graves lie side by side.

> ITS ROLE IN THE WAR
>
> Syracuse War Cemetery lies on the road to Floridia on the western edge of the city, close to Ponte Grande. It was begun in 1943 and holds about 1,060 Commonwealth burials of the Second World War, sources giving 1,059 to 1,063, of which 134 are unidentified. Most died in the landings on 9–10 July between Pachino and Syracuse and in the first days ashore.
>
> Many of the graves belong to men of the 1st Airlanding Brigade and the Glider Pilot Regiment lost in Operation Ladbroke, when gale-force winds put dozens of gliders into the sea; the bodies recovered from the coast were buried here. The cemetery also holds Indian soldiers, South Africans, Australians, a few Canadians and men from the High Commission Territories of southern Africa, reflecting the many nations in Eighth Army. Graves were brought in from smaller burial grounds around south-east Sicily after the war.
>
> It is a peaceful, well-kept CWGC cemetery with a Cross of Sacrifice and Stone of Remembrance. Allow time to walk the rows and read the ages and regiments; it makes a fitting end to a day on the landing beaches.

On the ground: Glider Pilot Regiment and airlanding brigade headstones, the rows of Indian graves, and the Cross of Sacrifice near the entrance.

DIG DEEPER

CWGC: Syracuse War Cemetery ↗

37.07502, 15.25794 HIGH exact spot known

2 Catania War Cemetery

1943 · Commonwealth war cemetery · on the classic tour

HIGH

About 2,135 Commonwealth soldiers killed in the battles for the Simeto bridgehead and the Catania plain, including most of the 1st Parachute Brigade dead from Primosole and many

men of the 50th and 51st Divisions.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Catania War Cemetery, at Stradale Passo del Fico on the south-western edge of the city, holds about 2,135 Commonwealth soldiers of the Second World War, 112 of them unidentified. It contains the dead of the later stages of the campaign, especially the battles for Primosole Bridge, the Simeto bridgehead and the Catania plain from mid-July to early August 1943.

Here lie most of the men of the 1st Parachute Brigade killed in Operation Fustian, and soldiers of the 50th (Northumbrian) Division, including the Durham Light Infantry, and of the 51st Highland Division, which fought at Gerbini and Sferro on the plain. The plain, overlooked by Etna and by German observers on its slopes, was a malarial trap in the summer heat; Eighth Army lost thousands of men to sickness as well as to enemy fire before Catania was entered on 5 August.

The cemetery is close to Catania airport, so it can be visited on arrival or departure. Its layout, walls and shrubs are typical of CWGC cemeteries in Italy; the view of Etna to the north explains why the plain was so hard to cross.

On the ground: The paratroopers' graves, the Durham Light Infantry headstones and the view of Etna over the plain.

DIG DEEPER

CWGC: Catania War Cemetery ↗

37.46303, 15.03864 HIGH exact spot known

3

Agira Canadian War Cemetery

1943 · Canadian war cemetery · on the classic tour

HIGH

The resting place of 490 Canadians who died in Sicily, gathered into a single cemetery after the campaign. It stands on a hill east of Agira, where the 1st Canadian Division fought its costliest battle of the campaign.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Agira Canadian War Cemetery stands on a small hill beside the SS121 east of Agira, looking across Lake Pozzillo to the town and to Etna. All the Canadians killed in the island

fighting were deliberately gathered here. The Canadian dead of the Sicilian campaign were brought here from their field graves after the fighting.

It holds 490 Canadians: 477 soldiers and 13 airmen of the Royal Canadian Air Force, six of them unidentified. They fell between the landing at Pachino on 10 July and the division's withdrawal on 6 August 1943, at Grammichele, Piazza Armerina, Assoro, Leonforte, Nissoria, Agira, Regalbuto and on the approaches to Adrano. About 562 Canadians died in Sicily in all; those lost at sea on the way are commemorated on the Cassino Memorial.

The cemetery is laid out in terraces around the hill. It is visited every year by Canadian groups, including walkers who retrace the division's route. Sign the visitors' book and take in the view: the ridges around Agira show why the battle was so costly, and why the Canadians remember it.

On the ground: Terraced rows on the hilltop looking across Lake Pozzillo to Agira and Etna; the visitors' book.

DIG DEEPER

Veterans Affairs Canada: Agira Canadian War Cemetery ↗

Terry Copp: From Leonforte to Agira ↗

37.65491, 14.55086 HIGH exact spot known

4 German War Cemetery Motta Sant'Anastasia

1965 · German war cemetery · on the classic tour

HIGH

4,561 German soldiers killed in Sicily, 451 unknown, gathered into a walled building of five courtyards at the foot of Etna. It is maintained by the German war graves commission, the Volksbund.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The German war cemetery for Sicily lies on the SP13 between Motta Sant'Anastasia and Misterbianco, about four kilometres from Motta, at the foot of Etna. Designed by the architect Diez Brandi, it was inaugurated on 25 September 1965 and reopened after full restoration on 29 April 2011. It is run by the Volksbund, the German war graves commission.

It holds 4,561 German soldiers, 451 of them unidentified, gathered from all over the island. Most died in the battles of July and August 1943 against the Americans, British and

> Canadians: at Gela, Primosole, Catania, Centuripe, Troina and on the north coast. Among them is Luz Long, silver medallist in the long jump at the 1936 Berlin Olympics, remembered for his friendship with Jesse Owens; he died in Sicily on 14 July 1943.
>
> The cemetery is a vault-like, almost square building with high brick walls, five raised courtyards, four of them named after Sicilian provinces, and burial chambers below. It is a sober place that shows the other side of the campaign; many of the dead were very young. Opening hours change with the season.

On the ground: Five raised courtyards, four named after Sicilian provinces,, the bronze memorial sculpture and the grave of Olympian Luz Long.

DIG DEEPER

Volksbund: Motta Sant'Anastasia ↗

`37.52510, 14.98976` HIGH exact spot known

5 Sacrario di Cristo Re, Messina

1937 · Italian military shrine · on the classic tour

MEDIUM

Italy's military shrine in Messina holds 1,288 Italian dead of the Second World War and 110 of the First. Most of the Italian soldiers killed in Sicily lie in communal cemeteries or shrines elsewhere; this is the main one on the tour.

Its role in the war: see this same place earlier in the guide.

On the ground: The crypt with its wall niches, the huge bell that rings at sunset and the view over the Strait.

DIG DEEPER

US Army CMH: The End of the Campaign ↗

Visit Sicily: Sacrario di Cristo Re ↗

`38.19860, 15.54970` MEDIUM close — exact spot uncertain

6

82nd Airborne memorial, Ponte Dirillo

10–11 Jul 1943 · US memorial · on the classic tour

HIGH

The main US memorial to the campaign in Sicily, near Biazza Ridge; it names some 39 paratroopers. American dead from Sicily were moved to the Sicily-Rome American Cemetery at Nettuno, near Anzio, so there is no US war cemetery on the island.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The 82nd Airborne memorial stands beside the SS115 where it crosses the Acate, or Dirillo, river between Gela and Vittoria. It lists paratroopers killed in the area in July 1943, a reminder of how costly and chaotic the first large American airborne operation was. The 505th and later the 504th Parachute Infantry fought here, with the 45th Infantry Division, which landed on beaches near Scoglitti a few kilometres to the south.

Ponte Dirillo was also an Italian strongpoint, part of the Italian coastal defences, and several round concrete bunkers survive nearby. About three kilometres east is Biazza Ridge, where on 11 July Colonel James Gavin's improvised force stopped the eastern battle group of the Hermann Göring Division and its Tiger tanks. American dead from Sicily now lie in the Sicily-Rome American Cemetery at Nettuno, so there is no American war cemetery on the island and this memorial is the main place of American remembrance.

Every July a ceremony, broadened since 1999 by the community relations office of the US naval air station at Sigonella, gathers American, Italian and other visitors here. The bunkers can be visited; take care with traffic on the highway.

On the ground: The names tablet, the restored Italian bunkers of the Ponte Dirillo strongpoint and the view east to Biazza Ridge.

DIG DEEPER

DVIDS: Ponte Dirillo, remembering the 82nd Airborne ↗

TracesOfWar: 82nd Airborne monument ↗

37.02325, 14.40814 HIGH exact spot known

7 Primosole Bridge

13–16 Jul 1943 · airborne battle · on the classic tour

HIGH

The bridge over the Simeto where British and German paratroopers fought each other for three days. Its capture opened the Catania plain, but the German line beyond it held until early August.

Its role in the war: see this same place earlier in the guide.

> **On the ground:** The bridge, the flat river banks where the paratroops fought, and the roadside memorials to the fallen of all nations.

DIG DEEPER

Operation Fustian (Wikipedia) ↗

ParaData: Primosole Bridge ↗

37.39944, 15.06500 HIGH exact spot known

8 Salerno War Cemetery

Sep 1943 · Commonwealth graves of the Salerno landings · on the classic tour

HIGH

Burial ground of 1,851 Commonwealth servicemen, most of them killed in the Salerno beachhead between 9 and 18 September 1943. The site was chosen in November 1943; later burials came from a wide area of south-west Italy and from the nearby 59th General Hospital.

> ITS ROLE IN THE WAR
>
> The Salerno War Cemetery lies on the old coast road between Battipaglia and Pontecagnano, in the middle of the sector fought over by the British X Corps between 9 and 18 September 1943. Its site was chosen in November 1943. Most of those buried here were killed in the beachhead battles around Salerno, Battipaglia, the airfield and the hills above Vietri; others died in the 59th General Hospital nearby, and some graves were moved in from a wide area of south-western Italy.
>
> The cemetery contains 1,851 Commonwealth burials of the Second World War, 109 of them unidentified. It was designed by Louis de Soissons, principal architect of the Commonwealth war cemeteries in Italy. The dead of the Salerno landings are scattered in other ways too: most American dead were later concentrated at the Sicily–Rome

American Cemetery at Nettuno, while German dead from southern Italy were gathered in German cemeteries such as the one near Cassino.

Salerno cost the Allies around 9,000 casualties in the US official history's reckoning, and more by other counts. Walking these rows is the best way to give that number a face. The cemetery is open at all times and has parking at the gate.

On the ground: Row upon row of X Corps headstones in a calm Louis de Soissons design, a few minutes from the old airfield.

DIG DEEPER

CWGC: Salerno War Cemetery ↗

`40.62551, 14.92251` HIGH exact spot known

9 San Pietro Infine ruins

8–17 Dec 1943 · village destroyed in the Winter Line · on the classic tour

HIGH

The abandoned ruins of a village fought over by the US 36th Division and the German 29th Panzergrenadier Division. Left as a memorial, it is one of the few places in Italy where the destruction of 1943 can still be seen as it was.

Its role in the war: see this same place earlier in the guide.

On the ground: Roofless streets, the shattered church, and the caves where villagers sheltered through weeks of shelling in December 1943.

DIG DEEPER

Salerno to Cassino, ch. 16: San Pietro ↗

Museo Parco della Memoria Storica (Ministero della Cultura) ↗

Battle of San Pietro Infine (Wikipedia) ↗

`41.44604, 13.96727` HIGH exact spot known

10

Italian military shrine of Monte Lungo

8 & 16 Dec 1943 · the new Italian army's first battle · on the classic tour

HIGH

The shrine holds 974 Italian dead, 784 of them from the battles of Monte Lungo and Cassino. It marks the moment Italian troops returned to battle on the Allied side, at a heavy cost, three months after the armistice.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

After the armistice of 8 September 1943, the Royal Italian Army that remained loyal to the King formed a new force to fight beside the Allies. Its first unit in battle was the 1st Motorised Group (Primo Raggruppamento Motorizzato) under General Vincenzo Dapino. On 8 December 1943 it attacked Monte Lungo, the bare ridge beside Highway 6 in the Mignano gap. The attack failed: the US official history records 84 killed, 122 wounded and 170 missing out of some 1,600 men engaged.

On 16 December, with the US 142nd and 143rd Infantry attacking from the flank, the Italians took the hill. The battle had great symbolic weight: it was the first time the co-belligerent Italian army, fighting for the Allies, had shed blood against the Germans, and it earned the Italians a greater role later, up to the Corps of Liberation and the Combat Groups of 1944–45.

The military shrine, built beside the Via Casilina at the foot of Monte Lungo, holds 974 Italian dead, 784 of them from the battles of Monte Lungo and Cassino. Across the road a small museum displays weapons, vehicles and guns.

On the ground: Terraced graves facing the bare ridge of Monte Lungo, with the museum and its vehicles across the Via Casilina.

DIG DEEPER

Sacrario militare di Montelungo (Wikipedia, Italian) ↗

Salerno to Cassino, ch. 16: San Pietro ↗

41.42249, 13.96877 HIGH exact spot known

11

Royal Palace of Caserta

Oct 1943 – May 1945 · Allied HQ; surrender signed 29 Apr 1945 · on the classic tour

HIGH

From the autumn of 1943 the palace housed the US Fifth Army's headquarters, and later Allied Force Headquarters. On 29 April 1945 German envoys signed the surrender of German and Italian Fascist forces in Italy here, effective on 2 May, a week before the general German surrender.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The Reggia di Caserta, built from 1752 for the Bourbon kings of Naples, is one of the largest palaces in Europe. In the autumn of 1943 it became an Allied headquarters, first for the US Fifth Army and later for Allied Force Headquarters, which directed the war in the Mediterranean under General Sir Henry Maitland Wilson and then Field Marshal Sir Harold Alexander. Its park housed a rest camp for Fifth Army troops. A bombing raid in September 1943 had badly damaged the palace chapel.

Here, at 14:00 on 29 April 1945, Lieutenant-Colonel Viktor von Schweinitz, for General Heinrich von Vietinghoff, and Major Eugen Wenner, for SS General Karl Wolff, signed the unconditional surrender of German and Italian Fascist forces in Italy, before Lieutenant-General William Morgan for Alexander. It followed secret talks known to the Allies as Operation Sunrise and took effect on 2 May 1945, ending the campaign that began at Reggio and Salerno. In 1945 the palace also saw the trial of General Anton Dostler, described as the first Allied war crimes trial.

Today the palace and park are a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Little inside speaks of the war, so bring the story with you.

On the ground: The royal apartments, the grand staircase and the long park where Allied soldiers once camped and rested.

DIG DEEPER

- **Reggia di Caserta: opening times ↗**
- **Reggia di Caserta: tickets ↗**
- **Surrender at Caserta (Wikipedia) ↗**

41.07333, 14.32639 HIGH exact spot known

12 Sangro River War Cemetery

Nov 1943 – 1944 · British, New Zealand and Indian graves · on the classic tour

HIGH

With 2,617 burials, the Commonwealth's main cemetery for the Adriatic winter of 1943–44. It includes the Sangro River Cremation Memorial to more than 500 Indian soldiers, and graves of escaped prisoners of war killed trying to reach Allied lines.

Its role in the war: see this same place earlier in the guide.

> **On the ground:** The cremation memorial, the New Zealand silver fern on headstones, and the German-held ridge across the river.

DIG DEEPER

CWGC: Sangro River War Cemetery ↗

`42.21841, 14.53559` HIGH exact spot known

13 Moro River Canadian War Cemetery

Dec 1943 · 1,375 Canadian graves · on the classic tour

HIGH

Canada's largest war cemetery in Italy: 1,615 graves, 1,375 of them Canadian, from the Moro, the Gully and Ortona. It was begun in January 1944, on high ground between the battlefield and the town the Canadians took.

> ITS ROLE IN THE WAR
>
> The Moro River Canadian War Cemetery was begun in January 1944 on high ground at San Donato, south of Ortona, between the Moro valley and the town. It was set up for the dead of the fighting at the Moro and at Ortona, and of the weeks before and after, when the 1st Canadian Infantry Division and the 1st Canadian Armoured Brigade fought their way north along the Adriatic.
>
> It contains 1,615 Commonwealth burials, 1,375 of them Canadian, more than 50 unidentified. December 1943 was Canada's most costly month in Italy: the 1st Canadian Division suffered roughly 2,300 to 2,600 battle casualties from the Moro to Ortona, more than 500 of them killed, figures that vary between sources. In all, some 93,000 Canadians served in Italy and more than 5,900 died there, most of them buried in cemeteries along the length of the country.

> The cemetery looks over olive groves towards the sea, close to the ground where many of those buried were killed. It is the centre of Canadian remembrance in Italy.

On the ground: Terraces of maple-leaf headstones, with the Moro valley below and the town of Ortona to the north.

DIG DEEPER

CWGC: Moro River Canadian War Cemetery ↗

Veterans Affairs Canada: Moro River Canadian War Cemetery ↗

CWGC: the Moro River campaign ↗

`42.33694, 14.41644` HIGH exact spot known

14 Ortona

20–28 Dec 1943 · house-to-house battle · on the classic tour

HIGH

The Adriatic port where the 1st Canadian Division and the German 1st Parachute Division fought an eight-day street battle. About 80 per cent of the town was destroyed and 1,314 civilians died; the town received the Gold Medal for Civil Valour.

Its role in the war: see this same place earlier in the guide.

On the ground: The Corso, the rebuilt cathedral of San Tommaso and the castle over the harbour, all reconstructed after 1943.

DIG DEEPER

Battle of Ortona (Wikipedia) ↗

MuBa43, Comune di Ortona ↗

`42.35306, 14.40361` HIGH exact spot known

15 Abbey of Monte Cassino

15 Feb 1944 · abbey destroyed by bombing · on the classic tour

HIGH

The Benedictine mother house founded around 529 sat on the height that dominated the road to Rome. Its destruction by 229 Allied bombers on 15 February 1944 killed civilians sheltering inside, handed the Germans a ready-made fortress and remains the campaign's most debated decision. Rebuilt, it was reconsecrated in 1964.

Its role in the war: see this same place earlier in the guide.

> **On the ground:** Photographs of the ruins, the rebuilt basilica and the terrace view over the Liri valley and the town.

DIG DEEPER

Monte Cassino (Wikipedia) ↗

Abbazia di Montecassino: hours ↗

`41.49000, 13.81389` HIGH exact spot known

16

Polish War Cemetery, Monte Cassino

18 May 1944 · 1,000+ Polish graves · on the classic tour

HIGH

Built by the Polish II Corps between 1944 and 1946 on the slope between Point 593 and the abbey, it holds just over 1,000 soldiers (sources give 1,051 to 1,072). General Anders was buried here beside his men in 1970. For Poles it is one of the most important national shrines outside Poland.

> ITS ROLE IN THE WAR
>
> The Polish II Corps under General Władysław Anders had been formed largely from Poles released from Soviet prisons and labour camps in 1941, who reached Italy via Iran and the Middle East. In May 1944 its 3rd Carpathian and 5th Kresowa Divisions attacked the heights north-west of the abbey, Point 593, Albaneta and Phantom Ridge, on 12 May and again on 17 May. Losses were very heavy; for the whole battle, sources give about 3,800 to over 4,000 casualties, more than 900 of them killed.
>
> On 18 May a Polish patrol raised its pennant over the ruins. For Poles the victory became a symbol of sacrifice for a country that the Yalta settlement then handed to Soviet control; most of these soldiers never went home. The cemetery was built on the slope facing the abbey from 1944 and consecrated on 1 September 1945. It contains just over 1,000 graves, and General Anders, who died in London in 1970, was buried here at his own wish.
>
> The inscription at the entrance, in Polish and other languages, reads roughly: 'Passer-by, tell Poland that we fell faithful in her service'. The Memorial Museum of the 2nd Polish Corps, opened on 17 May 2014 at the entrance, tells the corps' whole journey with films and relics.

On the ground: The terraces, the tall cross with the Polish eagle, Anders' grave and the memorial museum at the entrance.

DIG DEEPER

Monte Cassino Polish war cemetery (Wikipedia) ↗

Memorial Museum of the 2nd Polish Corps ↗

41.49391, 13.80575 HIGH exact spot known

17

Cassino War Cemetery and Memorial

Jan–May 1944 · 4,271 Commonwealth graves · on the classic tour

HIGH

The largest Commonwealth war cemetery in Italy, designed by Louis de Soissons, with 4,271 burials (289 unidentified). The Cassino Memorial within it names more than 4,000 Commonwealth soldiers of the whole Italian campaign who have no known grave, including 194 Canadians.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Cassino War Cemetery holds 4,271 Commonwealth servicemen, 289 of them unidentified. The site was chosen in January 1944, but could be used only after the Germans withdrew in May. Most of the dead fell in the battles for the town and Monastery Hill between January and May 1944: British, New Zealanders, Indians, Gurkhas, Canadians and South Africans.

Within the cemetery the Cassino Memorial names more than 4,000 Commonwealth soldiers who died in the whole Italian campaign, from Sicily to the Alps, and have no known grave, 194 of them Canadians. They include Naik Yeshwant Ghadge of the 5th Mahratta Light Infantry, awarded a posthumous Victoria Cross for an action in the upper Tiber valley in July 1944. Another name on it is Lieutenant Eric Fletcher Waters of the Royal Fusiliers, killed at Anzio in February 1944, father of the musician Roger Waters.

The cemetery and memorial were designed by Louis de Soissons. The setting is extraordinary: the rows of headstones lie on flat ground by the Rapido, and the rebuilt abbey rises directly above them, so that every visitor sees what these soldiers were trying to take.

On the ground: The green memorial panels, the Indian and Gurkha graves, and the view of the abbey above.

DIG DEEPER

Cassino War Cemetery (CWGC) ↗

Cassino Memorial (CWGC) ↗

41.47756, 13.82714 HIGH exact spot known

18 German War Cemetery, Caira

1944 · about 20,000 German graves · on the classic tour

HIGH

Laid out by the Volksbund on Colle Marino north of Cassino and inaugurated on 4 May 1965, it holds about 20,000 German dead of the southern Italian campaign, 3,100 of them unidentified, reburied here from field graves in 1959–60.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

About 20,000 German soldiers who died in the fighting in southern Italy are buried at Caira, 3 km north of Cassino, on the slopes of Colle Marino. The Volksbund, the German war graves commission, collected them in 1959–60 from countless small cemeteries and field graves; about 3,100 remain unidentified. The cemetery was inaugurated on 4 May 1965.

Among the dead are paratroopers of the 1st Parachute Division, who held the town and abbey from late February to May 1944, and soldiers of the panzergrenadier and infantry divisions that defended the Gustav Line, the Garigliano and the Liri valley. Many were very young. The design, with an entrance building housing the sculpture 'Mourning and Consolation' by Suse Müller-Diefenbach and terraces of stone crosses climbing to a large bronze cross, reflects the postwar German emphasis on mourning and reconciliation rather than glory.

From the top of the cemetery there is a sweeping view down the Rapido valley to Cassino and the abbey. Visiting both this cemetery and the Commonwealth and Polish ones on the same day shows the scale of the losses on all sides.

On the ground: Terraces of stone crosses rising to a bronze cross, with a wide view of the Rapido valley.

DIG DEEPER

Cassino military cemetery (Volksbund) ↗

41.53130, 13.82299 HIGH exact spot known

19

French Military Cemetery, Venafro

1943–44 · French Expeditionary Corps · on the classic tour

MEDIUM

The largest French war cemetery in Italy, for soldiers of General Juin's French Expeditionary Corps, most of them North African. Published figures differ: 3,414 graves in several heritage listings, about 5,200 in French sources since graves from the Miano cemetery in Naples were moved here in 1990–91. Their breakthrough in the Aurunci in May 1944 decided the battle for the Gustav Line.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Venafro, east of Cassino in Molise, lay behind the Allied lines in the winter of 1943–44 and became the rear base of the French Expeditionary Corps. General Juin's corps, about 112,000 strong at its peak and roughly 60 per cent North African, fought in the mountains north of Cassino in January 1944, where it took the Colle Belvedere at great cost, and in May led the breakthrough in the Aurunci mountains.

The French military cemetery here is the largest French war cemetery in Italy. Heritage listings give 3,414 graves; French sources give about 5,200 since the graves of the Miano cemetery in Naples were moved here in 1990–91, and the corps' dead are also buried at the French cemetery at Monte Mario in Rome. The Moroccan, Algerian and Tunisian soldiers of the Armée d'Afrique made up a large share of the dead, and their headstones reflect their Christian or Muslim faith.

The cemetery is a place to remember a part of the Italian campaign that is often forgotten in English-language accounts: without the French, Cassino might not have fallen in May. It is also a reminder of colonial soldiers whose own countries became independent soon after, and, just as honestly, of the crimes against Italian civilians committed by some of these troops.

On the ground: Rows of crosses and Muslim headstones, and the names of the Moroccan, Algerian and Tunisian regiments.

DIG DEEPER

French War Cemetery Venafro (Liberation Route) ↗

41.49002, 14.05492 MEDIUM close — exact spot uncertain

20

Beach Head War Cemetery, Anzio

Jan–May 1944 · 2,316 Commonwealth graves · on the classic tour

HIGH

The main Commonwealth cemetery of the Anzio beachhead, with 2,316 burials, 2,025 of them identified, mostly British soldiers killed in the February and March battles along the Via Anziate, with Canadians, South Africans and others among them. It stands on the road the German offensive was trying to reach.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Beach Head War Cemetery holds 2,316 Commonwealth burials of the Second World War, 2,025 of them identified. It was begun during the siege of the beachhead, and most of those buried here fell in the defensive battles of February and March 1944 along the Via Anziate, around the Factory, Carroceto, the Flyover and the gullies known as the Wadis. The great majority are British, but Canadians, South Africans, Australians, Indians and New Zealanders are also here.

The battles fought by the British 1st and 56th Divisions at Anzio were among the most costly of the Italian campaign for the British Army. Overall figures for the beachhead differ widely between sources; one estimate gives around 43,000 Allied casualties, of whom 7,000 killed, and around 40,000 German. The men here remind us that Anzio was not only an American battle.

The cemetery, designed by Louis de Soissons, lies on the Via Nettunense about 5 km north of Anzio. It is quiet and well kept, with the land of the beachhead around it. Aprilia, the German objective, is only about 12 km to the north.

On the ground: The Guards and London regiment graves, the personal inscriptions, and the view inland towards Aprilia.

DIG DEEPER

Battle of Anzio (Wikipedia) ↗

Operation Shingle (US Navy History) ↗

Museo dello Sbarco di Anzio ↗

41.48194, 12.62500 HIGH exact spot known

21 Sicily–Rome American Cemetery, Nettuno

1943–44 · 7,858 American graves · on the classic tour

HIGH

Dedicated in 1956 on 77 acres at Nettuno, it holds 7,858 American war dead from Sicily to just north of Rome, with the names of 3,095 missing on the chapel walls. A visitor centre opened in 2014 explains the campaign.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The Sicily–Rome American Cemetery at Nettuno covers 77 acres on ground taken by the US 3rd Infantry Division on 22 January 1944. It holds 7,858 American war dead, most of them killed in the Sicily landings, the landings at Salerno, the fighting north of Naples, at Cassino and Anzio, and on the way to Rome. On the walls of the chapel are the names of 3,095 missing. The cemetery was dedicated in 1956 and is maintained by the American Battle Monuments Commission.

Among those buried here are men of the Rangers destroyed at Cisterna, the 36th Division lost on the Rapido and the many units that fought at Anzio. The map room has a bronze relief map and fresco maps of the operations in Sicily and Italy, and a visitor centre opened in 2014 uses photographs and films to tell the story.

The headstones stand in gentle arcs beneath Roman pines, with a cenotaph on an island in a pool. It is one of the most beautiful American cemeteries in Europe, and a good place to end a day on the beachhead.

On the ground: The curving rows under Roman pines, the chapel, the map room and the visitor centre.

DIG DEEPER

Museo dello Sbarco (Comune di Nettuno) ↗

Sicily–Rome American Cemetery (ABMC) ↗

41.46528, 12.65833 HIGH exact spot known

22 Mausoleo delle Fosse Ardeatine, Rome

24 Mar 1944 · 335 men murdered · on the classic tour

HIGH

The site of the worst German massacre in occupied Rome, carried out in reprisal for the Via Rasella attack. The memorial of 1949 is a landmark of Italian postwar architecture and the

focus of national remembrance every 24 March.

Its role in the war: see this same place earlier in the guide.

> **On the ground:** The quarry tunnels, the bronze gates, the sculpture of three men and the shrine of 335 tombs.

DIG DEEPER

Mausoleo delle Fosse Ardeatine: visit ↗

Ardeatine massacre (Wikipedia) ↗

41.85705, 12.51008 HIGH exact spot known

23 Florence American Cemetery and Memorial

US · 4,402 burials · on the classic tour

HIGH

The American Battle Monuments Commission cemetery for the campaign north of Rome: 4,402 graves on curved terraces in the Greve valley and 1,409 names on the Tablets of the Missing. The memorial chapel and map room tell the story of Fifth Army from Rome to the Alps.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The Florence American Cemetery is one of two American Second World War cemeteries in Italy, and the only one north of Rome. It covers about 70 acres on the western side of the Via Cassia in the Greve valley, and holds 4,402 American dead, most of whom fell after the capture of Rome in June 1944: in the pursuit to the Arno, the Gothic Line battles at Il Giogo, Futa and Monte Battaglia, the winter in the mountains and the final offensive to the Alps.

The graves are set in curved rows on the hillside below a memorial with a tall pylon, a chapel with marble and mosaic decoration and marble operations maps of the campaign. The Tablets of the Missing record 1,409 names; rosettes mark those whose remains were later recovered and identified. The dead come from every American formation that fought north of Rome, from the divisions that broke the Gothic Line to the mountain troops of the final spring.

The cemetery is run by the American Battle Monuments Commission, open daily from 09:00 to 17:00 except 25 December and 1 January, and free. Staff can help relatives find a grave.

On the ground: Operations maps in the memorial, the Tablets of the Missing with rosettes for men later found, and the terraces seen from the top.

DIG DEEPER

Plan your visit (ABMC) ↗

Florence American Cemetery and Memorial (Wikipedia) ↗

43.69183, 11.21043 HIGH exact spot known

24 Coriano Ridge War Cemetery

Commonwealth · 4–13 Sep 1944 · on the classic tour

HIGH

The main Commonwealth cemetery of Operation Olive, with 1,939 burials: British, 427 Canadians, New Zealanders, South Africans and Indians. It lies on the ridge that blocked Eighth Army's road to Rimini for nine days in September 1944.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

Coriano Ridge War Cemetery was begun in April 1945, with graves brought in from the battlefields around Rimini, and holds 1,939 Commonwealth burials. Its register reads like a roll-call of Eighth Army: 1,413 British, 427 Canadian, 52 New Zealand, 28 South African, 8 Indian and single graves from other nations, with a few unidentified.

The ridge above was the last major German position blocking the road to Rimini and the Romagna plain after the Gothic Line broke. The fighting for the ridge lasted from 4 to 13 September 1944, and the Commission's history notes that in the week of heavy fighting that followed its capture Eighth Army was losing about 150 killed a day. The Canadian graves here are mostly men of the 1st Division and the 5th Armoured Division, which captured Coriano on 13 September and went on to the San Fortunato ridge and Rimini.

The cemetery lies on Via Piane, 3.5 km west of Riccione, reached by turning west off the Rimini–Riccione road. It is well kept and peaceful. Walk to its upper edge and look towards the crest of the ridge, where Coriano village, rebuilt after the war, now stands.

On the ground: The Canadian plots, and the view up the slope to Coriano village on the crest.

DIG DEEPER

Coriano Ridge War Cemetery (CWGC) ↗

Coriano Ridge War Cemetery (Veterans Affairs Canada) ↗

Coriano Ridge War Cemetery (Wikipedia) ↗

43.98485, 12.60404 HIGH exact spot known

25 German War Cemetery, Futa Pass

German · more than 30,600 dead · on the classic tour

HIGH

Italy's largest German war cemetery, built on the Gothic Line at the Futa Pass and dedicated in 1969. Its spiralling stone wall and hilltop crypt make it one of the most striking war cemeteries in Europe.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The Futa Pass, at 903 m on the old Florence–Bologna road, was one of the strongest points of the Gothic Line, with an anti-tank ditch and prepared positions. The Americans avoided a frontal assault by breaking through at Il Giogo, a few kilometres east, in mid-September 1944, and the Futa was abandoned and taken on 22 September.

After the war the German War Graves Commission gathered its dead from across central and northern Italy into a few large cemeteries. The Futa Pass cemetery, begun in 1959 to a design by Dieter Oesterlen and dedicated on 28 June 1969, is the largest, with more than 30,600 graves; figures of 30,653 and 30,683 are both published. A stone wall two kilometres long spirals up the hill between lawns of flat headstones, rising to a sharp prow-shaped summit above a crypt.

Most of the men buried here were young conscripts, many of them killed in the last year of the war. It is a place for reflection on the cost of the whole campaign, not a celebration of the Gothic Line. From the top you can see the ridges of the Apennines towards Il Giogo.

On the ground: The 2 km spiral wall, the crypt at the summit and the view over both Apennine passes.

DIG DEEPER

Cassino military cemetery (Volksbund) ↗

44.09678, 11.27165 HIGH exact spot known

26 Polish War Cemetery, Bologna

Polish · 1,432 burials · on the classic tour

HIGH

The resting place of 1,432 men of the Polish II Corps killed in 1944–45, including the last battles for Bologna, which Polish troops were among the first to enter on 21 April 1945.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The Polish II Corps under General Władysław Anders was formed largely from Poles deported to the Soviet Union in 1939–41 and released in 1941–42. After Monte Cassino and Ancona it fought through the Gothic Line on the Adriatic in August–September 1944, spent the winter in the Apennines and Romagna, and in April 1945 advanced along the Via Emilia towards Bologna, crossing the Senio and Santerno and fighting through Imola.

Polish troops were among the first to enter Bologna on 21 April 1945. The cemetery on the eastern edge of the city holds 1,432 soldiers and officers of II Corps who died in 1944–45 in battle, of wounds or of illness. The inscription at the entrance dedicates it to the soldiers of II Corps who fell on Italian soil fighting for a free Poland. For most of them there was no free Poland to return to: after Yalta the country fell under Soviet control, and many veterans stayed in exile.

Next door on Via Dozza, the private Museo Memoriale della Libertà displays Second World War vehicles, reconstructed scenes and a deportation wagon; it opens by appointment and on the last weekend of each month.

On the ground: The entrance inscription to the soldiers of II Corps who fell on Italian soil fighting for a free Poland.

DIG DEEPER

Monte Cassino Polish war cemetery (Wikipedia) ↗

Memorial Museum of the 2nd Polish Corps ↗

44.47408, 11.40051 HIGH exact spot known

27 Brazilian Votive Monument, Pistoia

Brazil · FEB cemetery 1944–1960 · extra, not on the 14-day tour

HIGH

The Brazilian Expeditionary Force buried its dead here, 463 men, until they were repatriated to Rio de Janeiro in 1960. A modernist votive monument by Olavo Redig de

Campos, opened in 1967, now marks the site, with the tomb of an unknown Brazilian soldier.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The Brazilian Expeditionary Force fought in the northern Apennines from September 1944 to the end of the war, with about 25,900 men and a fighter group of the Brazilian Air Force. Its dead are usually given as 948 across all Brazilian services, of whom most of the army dead lay at Pistoia. Its dead were buried at a cemetery near Pistoia, in the hills north of the city, close to the Brazilian rear area.

The cemetery held 463 Brazilians. In 1960 their remains were taken home to the National Monument to the Dead of the Second World War in Flamengo Park, Rio de Janeiro. In 1967 the site was reopened with a modernist votive monument designed by Olavo Redig de Campos: stone terraces, an open sculptural pavilion and the tomb of an unknown Brazilian soldier.

The monument stands on the site of the former cemetery and is still maintained by Brazil, a place of pilgrimage for Brazilian visitors and veterans' families. Combine it with the Brazilian monument on Monte Castello above Gaggio Montano, about an hour's drive north through the mountains, to follow the story of the only Latin American army to fight in Europe.

On the ground: The open pavilion, the stone terraces of the former cemetery and the tomb of the unknown soldier.

DIG DEEPER

Pistoia Brazilian war cemetery (Wikipedia) ↗

Military Votive Brazilian Monument (Visit Tuscany) ↗

`43.94500, 10.94306` HIGH exact spot known

28 Sant'Anna di Stazzema National Park of Peace

Civilians · 12 Aug 1944 · extra, not on the 14-day tour

HIGH

The mountain village where about 560 civilians, most of them women, children and elderly, were killed by SS troops in a single morning. The whole village is now a memorial, with a museum, the church square and an ossuary monument above the coast.

Its role in the war: see this same place earlier in the guide.

On the ground: The church square where many were killed, the Via Crucis path and the ossuary monument overlooking the Versilia coast.

DIG DEEPER

Sant'Anna di Stazzema massacre (Wikipedia) ↗

Historical Museum of Sant'Anna di Stazzema ↗

Sant'Anna di Stazzema (NS-Täter in Italien) ↗

43.97417, 10.27361 HIGH exact spot known

29 Sommocolonia — Lieutenant Fox memorial

US 92nd Division · 26 Dec 1944 · extra, not on the 14-day tour

HIGH

In this Garfagnana hill village about 70 soldiers of the African-American 92nd 'Buffalo' Division and 25 Italian partisans were overrun on 26 December 1944. Lieutenant John Fox called artillery fire onto his own position to cover the withdrawal and was killed; his Medal of Honor came only in 1997.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The Serchio valley and the Apuan Alps formed the western end of the Gothic Line, held in the winter of 1944–45 by the US 92nd Infantry Division, the only African-American infantry division to fight in Europe. Its soldiers, called Buffalo Soldiers after the black cavalry of the American West, served under white officers in a segregated army and were often blamed for failures beyond their control.

On 26 December 1944 German and Italian Fascist forces struck down the Serchio valley in Operation Wintergewitter. At Sommocolonia about 70 American soldiers and 25 Italian partisans were surrounded. First Lieutenant John Fox, a forward observer of the 598th Field Artillery Battalion serving with the 366th Infantry, from a house in the village called fire closer and closer and finally onto his own position to cover the withdrawal. He was killed; the barrage is said to have killed about 100 of the attackers. Only in 1997, after a review of racial discrimination in wartime awards, did he receive the Medal of Honor.

In April 1945 the 92nd, with the Japanese-American 442nd, broke the western Gothic Line in the Apuan Alps. Sommocolonia's Memory Park, opened in 2000, stands by the tower ruins opposite the parish church.

On the ground: The Memory Park at the ruined tower opposite the parish church, a 10-minute walk from the lower car park.

DIG DEEPER

John R. Fox (Wikipedia) ↗

Lieutenant John Fox's Medal of Honor (National WWII Museum) ↗

North Apennines campaign of the 442nd (Go For Broke) ↗

`44.09222, 10.49139` HIGH exact spot known

MUSEUMS & MEMORIALS

The museums worth your time, from the Sicily landing museum in Catania to the Gothic Line and the Po, with the day of the classic tour they sit on. Opening hours change — check before you go.

1 Museo Storico dello Sbarco in Sicilia 1943

Catania · Day 2

HIGH

The island's main museum of the 1943 campaign, opened in December 2002 in the Le Ciminiere cultural centre. Photographs, documents, uniforms and weapons from all sides are combined with walk-through reconstructions of wartime Sicilian life and a large exhibition of photographs by the American war photographer Phil Stern. A good overview before or after visiting the battlefields.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The Museo Storico dello Sbarco in Sicilia 1943 opened in December 2002 in Le Ciminiere, a former sulphur refinery turned cultural centre near Catania's railway station. It is the island's main museum of the invasion and tells the story of the campaign from the Allied, Axis and Sicilian civilian sides.

Exhibits include uniforms, weapons, documents and a large collection of photographs, among them the Sala Phil Stern, added in 2017, with more than 70 pictures by the American photographer who covered the landings with the Rangers. Walk-through reconstructions show a Sicilian village square, an air-raid shelter during a bombing raid and wartime interiors, with wax figures and sound effects. The museum does not avoid the harder themes: the bombing of Sicilian cities, the hunger of 1943, and the violence that sometimes hit civilians and prisoners.

Allow at least an hour and a half. It gives useful context for the battlefields and cemeteries of Day 2 and is open every day. In 2026 the full ticket costs €8; check the metropolitan city website for current hours before you go.

1 h 30 min

DIG DEEPER

Città Metropolitana di Catania: museum page ↗

37.51170, 15.09780 HIGH exact spot known

2 Museo della Fotografia Robert Capa

Troina · Day 2

HIGH

Opened on 1 October 2021 in the Palazzo Pretura, this small museum displays 62 prints, many little known, from Robert Capa's negatives of the Sicily campaign. His pictures of Troina's shattered streets and its civilians remain some of the most powerful images of the war in Italy. Combine it with a walk to the upper town.

Its role in the war: see this same place earlier in the guide.

1 h

37.78450, 14.59750 HIGH exact spot known

3 Museo dello Sbarco e Salerno Capitale

Salerno · Day 4

HIGH

Opened in September 2012 for the 69th anniversary of the landings, this museum displays about 200 items on Operation Avalanche and on Salerno as seat of the Badoglio and Bonomi governments in 1944. Uniforms and weapons of all three armies, a Sherman tank, a jeep and a deportation wagon. Visits by reservation only.

> ITS ROLE IN THE WAR
>
> The Museo dello Sbarco e Salerno Capitale opened in September 2012, on the 69th anniversary of the landings, in the Istituto Gallotta building on Via Generale Clark, a street named after the US Fifth Army commander. It brings together about 200 objects from the collections of the Parco della Memoria della Campania: uniforms, weapons, flags, photographs and film of the landings.
>
> The museum tells two stories. The first is Operation Avalanche, the landing of some 170,000 to 200,000 Allied soldiers in the Gulf of Salerno. The second is less well known: from February to July 1944 Salerno served as the seat of the Italian government, under Marshal Pietro Badoglio and then Ivanoe Bonomi. In April 1944, in the so-called 'Salerno turn', the anti-fascist parties of the Committee of National Liberation joined the government for the first time. Outside stand an M4 Sherman tank, a jeep and a sealed railway wagon of the type used to deport Italian Jews.
>
> Visits are by reservation only, so book ahead. The exact building should be confirmed when booking; the pin marks Via Generale Clark only approximately.

1 h

DIG DEEPER

Città Metropolitana di Catania: museum page ↗

40.66000, 14.79900 HIGH exact spot known

4 Archaeological Park and Museum of Paestum

Capaccio Paestum · Day 4

HIGH

Not a war museum, but the temples stood in the middle of the American beachhead in September 1943 and both sides spared them. The museum's painted Tomb of the Diver is world famous. Combine with the 36th Division memorial on the beach, 1 km away. Open daily.

> ITS ROLE IN THE WAR
>
> Greek colonists founded Poseidonia around 600 BC; the Romans called it Paestum. Its three Doric temples, among the best preserved in the world, stood about a kilometre behind the beaches where the US 36th Infantry Division landed on 9 September 1943. The ruins lay inside the American beachhead throughout the battle, with German guns on Monte Soprano to the east and Allied warships offshore.
>
> Remarkably, the temples came through almost unharmed. Both sides treated them as off limits, and Allied medical units set up aid stations and Red Cross tents around them. Photographs of American trucks and soldiers among the columns are some of the best-known images of the Salerno campaign. The Allied armies in Italy increasingly had to weigh military need against the protection of monuments, a debate that would reach its most bitter point at Monte Cassino a few months later.
>
> Today the archaeological park and museum are a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Allow time for the Temple of Neptune, the Basilica and the Temple of Athena, and for the museum's painted Tomb of the Diver. Then drive the kilometre west to the beach and the 36th Division memorial to see the ground from the soldiers' side.

1 h 30 min

DIG DEEPER

Salerno to Cassino, ch. 6: The Landings (US Army official history) ↗

Operation Avalanche (Wikipedia) ↗

Paestum and Velia archaeological parks ↗

40.42222, 15.00528 HIGH exact spot known

5 Galleria Borbonica

Naples · Day 5

HIGH

A tunnel dug for King Ferdinand II in the 1850s and old aqueduct cisterns, used as an air-raid shelter by thousands of Neapolitans during the Allied bombing of 1940–1943. Beds, graffiti and household objects survive, along with cars and motorbikes dumped here after the war. Guided tours only, Friday to Sunday.

> ITS ROLE IN THE WAR
>
> Naples was one of the most heavily bombed cities in Italy; by raid count only Milan was attacked more often. There were about 200 Allied air raids between 1940 and 1944, 181 of them in the first nine months of 1943; the biggest, on 4 August 1943, destroyed the medieval church of Santa Chiara. Estimates of civilian dead range from 20,000 to 25,000. After liberation, German aircraft bombed the city in turn. Allied bombing of Italian cities remains a painful subject, weighed against its military aims.
>
> To survive, Neapolitans went underground into the tuff rock on which the city stands. The Galleria Borbonica was dug in the 1850s for King Ferdinand II as an escape route from the royal palace to the barracks, cutting through older aqueduct cisterns. In the war it became a public shelter, and families lived there for long periods. After 1945 the tunnels were used as a municipal pound, and wrecked cars and motorcycles were left behind.
>
> Today guides lead visitors past wartime graffiti, beds, stoves and personal objects, and the vehicles abandoned after the war. Other shelters can be visited with Napoli Sotterranea beneath the old centre. Tours run from Friday to Sunday and must be booked.

1 h 15 min

DIG DEEPER

Galleria Borbonica: tours ↗

40.83552, 14.24626 HIGH exact spot known

6 Royal Palace of Caserta

Caserta · Day 5

HIGH

The Bourbon royal palace, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, housed Fifth Army and then Allied Force Headquarters. The surrender of the German and Italian Fascist forces in Italy was signed here on 29 April 1945. The visit is mainly the royal apartments and park, with little on the war, so read up before you go.

Its role in the war: see this same place earlier in the guide.

2 h

DIG DEEPER

Reggia di Caserta: opening times ↗

Reggia di Caserta: tickets ↗

Surrender at Caserta (Wikipedia) ↗

`41.07333, 14.32639` HIGH exact spot known

7 Monte Lungo war museum

Mignano Monte Lungo · Day 5

HIGH

A small museum beside the Italian military shrine, with documents, photographs, weapons, and Italian and Allied vehicles and guns from the battles of December 1943. It tells the story of the Italian 1st Motorised Group, the first unit of the new Italian army to fight alongside the Allies. Free entry; hours vary.

Its role in the war: see this same place earlier in the guide.

30 min

DIG DEEPER

Sacrario militare di Montelungo (Wikipedia, Italian) ↗

Salerno to Cassino, ch. 16: San Pietro ↗

`41.42249, 13.96877` HIGH exact spot known

8 Museo Parco della Memoria Storica

San Pietro Infine · Day 5

HIGH

Opened in December 2008 in a restored olive-oil mill, this immersive museum uses darkness, sound and seven staged scenes, including John Huston's 1943–44 film footage, to recount the battle and the destruction of the village. Weekend opening; weekdays by booking. Pair it with a walk through the ruins.

Its role in the war: see this same place earlier in the guide.

1 h

41.44604, 13.96727 HIGH exact spot known

9 MUBA — Museo della Battaglia di Ortona

Ortona · Day 6

HIGH

Founded in 2002, the museum has halls on the civilians, with photographs and a model of the destroyed centre, on the combatants, with objects donated by veterans, and on wartime propaganda. It remembers the 1,314 civilian dead as well as Canadian and German soldiers. Temporarily closed for renovation at last check.

Its role in the war: see this same place earlier in the guide.

1 h

DIG DEEPER

Battle of Ortona (Wikipedia) ↗

MuBa43, Comune di Ortona ↗

42.35306, 14.40361 HIGH exact spot known

10 Museo Linea Gustav

Castelforte · Day 7

HIGH

A local museum created by the Associazione Linea Gustav Fronte Garigliano and opened in recent years in the old centre. It gathers weapons, equipment, documents and photographs from the Garigliano front and gives particular weight to the civilians of Castelforte and

neighbouring villages, whose homes were almost completely destroyed in 1944. Visits must be arranged in advance by phone or email.

> ITS ROLE IN THE WAR
>
> Castelforte, a hill town above the Garigliano, lay right on the Gustav Line. In January 1944 the British 56th (London) Division fought across the river towards it, and the London Irish Rifles and other battalions suffered heavy losses on the approaches and on Monte Damiano. The town stayed in German hands until the French Expeditionary Corps attacked in May 1944 and took it during the first days of Operation Diadem.
>
> For the inhabitants the war meant evacuation, forced labour, mines, shellfire and hunger, and the town was almost completely destroyed. The villages of this sector also suffered violence against civilians during the spring of 1944, both from occupying forces and, after the French breakthrough, the mass rapes known as the Marocchinate.
>
> The Museo Linea Gustav, set up in recent years by a local association, is housed in the rebuilt town. It displays weapons, equipment, documents and photographs collected locally and tells the story of the front from a civilian as well as a military point of view. It opens by appointment; from the town there are good views over the lower Garigliano and towards Monte Maio.

1 h

41.29390, 13.83060 HIGH exact spot known

11

Historiale di Cassino

Cassino · Day 8

HIGH

Cassino's multimedia museum, opened in 2004 for the 60th anniversary of the battle and dedicated to the fallen of all nations. Rooms designed by Carlo Rambaldi take visitors through the Gustav Line, the bombing of the abbey, military strategy, civilian life and the rebuilding of the town. Guided visits run at set times on weekdays; check current hours before going.

> ITS ROLE IN THE WAR
>
> Cassino town, home to about 20,000 people before the war, was destroyed as completely as any town in Western Europe. Evacuations, bombing, shelling and the street fighting of February and March 1944 left almost nothing standing; local sources suggest that about

> 2,000 inhabitants died. After the war the town was rebuilt on a new plan slightly away from the ruins, which is why modern Cassino looks so recent.
>
> The Historiale museum was opened in 2004 for the 60th anniversary of the battle and is dedicated to the fallen of all nations. Its multimedia rooms, designed by Carlo Rambaldi, the Oscar-winning creator of special effects, explain the long history of the abbey, the two world wars, the Gustav Line and the bombing, the strategies of both sides and, importantly, the experience of civilians and the rebuilding.
>
> It is the best place in Cassino to set the military story in its human context before or after visiting the cemeteries. Guided visits run at set times, mainly on weekday mornings, and hours change seasonally, so check with the museum or tourist office in Piazza De Gasperi before you go.

1 h

DIG DEEPER

Historiale museum (Comune di Cassino) ↗

Historiale tickets ↗

`41.48386, 13.82869` HIGH exact spot known

12

Memorial Museum of the 2nd Polish Corps

Monte Cassino · Day 8

HIGH

Opened on 17 May 2014 for the battle's 70th anniversary, at the entrance to the Polish cemetery. Large photographic displays in Italian, Polish and English, films and battlefield relics follow General Anders' soldiers from Soviet captivity through Cassino to the liberation of Bologna in April 1945. It was funded by donors in the countries where many veterans settled after the war.

Its role in the war: see this same place earlier in the guide.

45 min

DIG DEEPER

Monte Cassino Polish war cemetery (Wikipedia) ↗

Memorial Museum of the 2nd Polish Corps ↗

`41.49391, 13.80575` HIGH exact spot known

13 Museo dello Sbarco di Anzio

Anzio · Day 9

HIGH

The Anzio landing museum in the 17th-century Villa Adele, opened for the 50th anniversary in 1994. Four sections (American, British, German and Italian) display uniforms, weapons, medals, documents, plans and photographs, plus finds recovered from the seabed, including from HMS Spartan and HMS Janus. Entry is free; opening days and afternoon hours vary, so check first.

> ITS ROLE IN THE WAR
>
> The Museo dello Sbarco di Anzio opened for the 50th anniversary of the landing in the 17th-century Villa Adele, close to the railway station and the harbour. It works as a museum and a research and documentation centre on the landing and the four-month battle for the beachhead, and it is run with the help of volunteers.
>
> The collection is divided into American, British, German and Italian sections, with uniforms, weapons, decorations, documents, battle plans and many photographs, as well as objects recovered from the sea, including from the British cruiser HMS Spartan and destroyer HMS Janus, both sunk off Anzio by German air attack. A library, archive and flag collection continue to grow through gifts from veterans' associations.
>
> The museum is a good introduction to the whole beachhead story before visiting the cemeteries and the battlefield around Aprilia. Entry is free, but opening days and afternoon hours are published differently by the museum and the town, so check before going. The harbour where the Rangers landed on 22 January 1944 is a short walk away.

1 h

DIG DEEPER

Città Metropolitana di Catania: museum page ↗

41.44991, 12.63126 HIGH exact spot known

14 Museo dello Sbarco Alleato

Nettuno · Day 9

HIGH

Nettuno's museum of Operation Shingle, housed in the Forte Sangallo, a seafront fortress of 1501. The collection covers the landing of 22 January 1944 and the beachhead battle

with documents, furnishings, uniforms, helmets, period photographs, maps, war correspondents' reports, newspapers and objects found in the Anzio–Nettuno area. Free entry during opening hours.

> ITS ROLE IN THE WAR
>
> Nettuno, Anzio's twin town, received much of the US landing on 22 January 1944, and the headquarters of VI Corps was set up here: a plaque marks a house where Generals Lucas and Truscott lived. The town and its harbour were shelled and bombed throughout the siege, including by the huge German railway guns the Americans nicknamed 'Anzio Annie'.
>
> The Museo dello Sbarco Alleato is housed in the Forte Sangallo, a seafront fortress built in 1501 for Pope Alexander VI to guard against raids from the sea. It displays documents, furniture, uniforms, helmets, period photographs, maps, reports by war correspondents, copies of newspapers of the time and military objects found around Anzio and Nettuno.
>
> The fort is also Nettuno's cultural centre, with exhibitions and a small antiquarium. From its walls you look out over the sea where the invasion fleet lay, and over the beaches where supplies were landed day and night for four months under fire. Nettuno's old medieval quarter, next to the fort, is worth a short walk. The Sicily–Rome American Cemetery is only a few minutes' drive inland, and the two visits combine naturally at the end of a day on the beachhead.

45 min

DIG DEEPER

Città Metropolitana di Catania: museum page ↗

`41.45540, 12.65800` HIGH exact spot known

15

Museo Piana delle Orme

Latina (Borgo Faiti) · Day 9

HIGH

A large private museum founded in 1997 by Mariano De Pasquale, with about 50,000 objects in many pavilions. Besides farming, toys and the draining of the Pontine marshes, it has major Second World War halls: dioramas of the Anzio landing (including the Rangers' battle at Cisterna) and Cassino, and a large collection of military vehicles. Adult ticket €13 in 2026.

ITS ROLE IN THE WAR

The Pontine plain around Latina was marshland until the Fascist regime drained it in the 1930s and built new towns such as Littoria (now Latina), Aprilia and Pontinia. In 1944 it became part of the Anzio battlefield: the Germans flooded parts of it again, and malaria returned. The Rangers fought and died near Cisterna at its northern edge.

The Museo Piana delle Orme was founded in 1997 by the entrepreneur Mariano De Pasquale on his estate near Borgo Faiti, and holds about 50,000 objects in many pavilions. Its Second World War halls include large dioramas of Italy's war, the North African campaign, the Anzio landing (with the Rangers' battle and civilian shelters) and Cassino, and two pavilions of military vehicles, plus a C-119 transport aircraft outside.

It is a private, very large museum, also covering farming, toys and the draining of the marshes, and is excellent for families and vehicle enthusiasts. The war content is less focused and less critical than the town museums at Anzio and Nettuno, so treat it as an addition for longer trips. Allow at least two hours; there is a restaurant on site.

2 h

DIG DEEPER

Museo Piana delle Orme: tickets and hours ↗

`41.44000, 13.00500` HIGH exact spot known

16

Mausoleo delle Fosse Ardeatine and museum

Rome · Day 10

HIGH

The national memorial to the 335 victims of the massacre of 24 March 1944, inaugurated on 24 March 1949. Visitors enter by Mirko Basaldella's bronze gates, pass Francesco Coccia's sculpture of three bound men, walk through the quarry tunnels and reach the shrine of 335 granite tombs. A small museum explains the occupation, Via Rasella and the trials. Free.

Its role in the war: see this same place earlier in the guide.

1 h 15 min

DIG DEEPER

Mausoleo delle Fosse Ardeatine: visit ↗

Ardeatine massacre (Wikipedia) ↗

41.85705, 12.51008 HIGH exact spot known

17

Museo storico della Liberazione

Rome · Day 10

HIGH

Housed in the apartments at Via Tasso 145 that the German security police under Herbert Kappler used as a prison from 1943 to June 1944. Preserved cells with prisoners' graffiti, arrest files, photographs and documents tell the story of the occupation, the Resistance and the persecution of Rome's Jews. Donated to the state in 1950, it opened fully in 1957. Free.

> ITS ROLE IN THE WAR
>
> After the armistice of 8 September 1943 Rome was occupied by the Germans for nine months. The apartment block at Via Tasso 145, built in the late 1930s and rented to the German embassy, became the headquarters and prison of the Sicherheitspolizei, the security police, under Herbert Kappler. From January 1944 its rooms were turned into cells with walled-up windows. An estimated 2,000 people passed through, many of them interrogated and tortured.
>
> Among the prisoners were leaders of the military and civilian Resistance, such as Colonel Giuseppe Cordero Lanza di Montezemolo, head of the clandestine military front, who was later murdered at the Fosse Ardeatine, as were many other inmates of Via Tasso. On 4 June 1944, as the Germans left the city, the prisoners still held here were freed.
>
> Princess Josepha Ruspoli in Savorgnan di Brazzà donated the flats to the state in 1950 for a museum, which opened in 1955 and fully in 1957. Today the cells are preserved with prisoners' graffiti, and exhibitions cover the occupation, the Resistance and the persecution of Rome's Jews. The nearby metro station is named Manzoni–Museo della Liberazione.

1 h 15 min

41.88861, 12.50639 HIGH exact spot known

18 Museo Storico della Resistenza, Sant'Anna di Stazzema

Sant'Anna di Stazzema · off the main route

HIGH

Opened in 1982 by President Sandro Pertini in the old village school, the museum tells the story of the war, the Resistance and the massacre of 12 August 1944 through photographs, testimonies and objects. It is part of the National Park of Peace, which includes the church square, the Via Crucis and the ossuary monument. Entry is free; check days before you go.

Its role in the war: see this same place earlier in the guide.

1 hr 30 min

DIG DEEPER

Sant'Anna di Stazzema massacre (Wikipedia) ↗

Historical Museum of Sant'Anna di Stazzema ↗

Sant'Anna di Stazzema (NS-Täter in Italien) ↗

`43.97417, 10.27361` HIGH exact spot known

19 MuGot — Museo Gotica Toscana

Ponzalla (Scarperia e San Piero) · Day 12

HIGH

Founded in 2019 between the Futa and Giogo passes, this volunteer museum collects documents, filmed testimonies, uniforms and equipment from the 1944 battles in the Mugello. Its guides run battlefield visits to the bunkers and trenches of the Gothic Line. Open Wednesday and Friday mornings and weekends; €5, guided tours extra.

> ITS ROLE IN THE WAR
>
> The Mugello, the upper valley of the Sieve north of Florence, was where the US Fifth Army met the Gothic Line in September 1944. The Germans had fortified the two passes into Emilia, the Futa and the Giogo, with bunkers, trenches, anti-tank ditches and minefields, built largely with conscripted Italian labour. The valley's villages were caught between the lines, bombed and shelled, and many men were rounded up for forced work on the defences.
>
> The Museo Gotica Toscana, known as MuGot, was set up in 2019 by the Gotica Toscana association at Ponzalla, between the two passes. It presents documents, maps, filmed

> testimonies of veterans and civilians, and military objects recovered from the battlefields, and it is also the Italian base of the Military Vehicle Preservation Association.
>
> The museum is small but well informed, and its volunteers know the ground intimately. Its guided museum and battlefield visits are the best way to find the surviving positions on Monte Altuzzo and around the passes, which are otherwise hard to locate in the woods. Opening days are limited, currently Wednesday and Friday mornings and weekends, so plan ahead.

1 hr

DIG DEEPER

Museo Gotica Toscana ↗

MuGot (Visit Tuscany) ↗

`44.02491, 11.37020` HIGH exact spot known

20

Monte Sole Historical Park

Marzabotto · Day 12

HIGH

A regional park created in 1989 on the massif where about 770 civilians were killed between 29 September and 5 October 1944. Marked paths link the ruined churches, hamlets and cemeteries of Casaglia, San Martino, Caprara and Cerpiano. The Scuola di Pace Monte Sole and the Il Poggiolo visitor centre run guided visits and education programmes.

Its role in the war: see this same place earlier in the guide.

1 hr 30 min – half day

DIG DEEPER

Marzabotto massacre (Wikipedia) ↗

Historical context (Scuola di Pace Monte Sole) ↗

Casaglia (Scuola di Pace Monte Sole) ↗

`44.31102, 11.21793` HIGH exact spot known

21 Museo della Linea dei Goti

Montegridolfo · Day 13

HIGH

A small, heartfelt village museum on Via Borgo, built largely from objects donated by local families: newspapers, postcards, photographs, weapons, grenades and gas masks from 1943–44, plus period films. It explains the Gothic Line from the viewpoint of the valley that saw it broken. Admission by donation; opening days are limited, so phone ahead.

Its role in the war: see this same place earlier in the guide.

45 min

43.85826, 12.68995 HIGH exact spot known

22 Museo della Battaglia del Senio

Alfonsine · Day 14

HIGH

Founded in 1981 in the town liberated on 10 April 1945, the museum covers the winter front on the Senio embankments and the spring offensive, with weapons, uniforms, flags and photographs arranged along three paths: Allied operations, the partisans and civilian life. Free entry; weekday mornings, Wednesday afternoons, closed in August.

> ITS ROLE IN THE WAR
>
> Through the winter of 1944–45 the front in Romagna ran along the Senio, a small river between very high flood embankments. The Germans dug into the northern bank and the Allies into the southern; in places the two sides were only the width of the levee apart, throwing grenades over the top. Canadian, British, New Zealand, Polish and Italian troops, with the partisans of the 28th Garibaldi Brigade, held this front through the cold and the floods.
>
> The final offensive opened here on 9 April 1945 with a massive bombing and artillery bombardment, flame-throwers and assault boats; Eighth Army crossed the Senio that night and Alfonsine was liberated on 10 April. The Italian Cremona Combat Group, part of the new co-belligerent army, fought in this sector alongside the British.
>
> The Museo della Battaglia del Senio, founded in 1981 in Piazza della Resistenza, tells the story along three paths: Allied military operations, the local Resistance and civilian life under occupation. Entry is free, weekday mornings, Saturday 09:00–12:00 and Wednesday afternoons; the museum is closed in August.

1 hr

DIG DEEPER

Visiting the Museo della battaglia del Senio (Comune di Alfonsine) ↗

Cassino to the Alps, ch. 26 (US Army CMH) ↗

44.50768, 12.03743 HIGH exact spot known

SOURCES

US Army Center of Military History official histories (the "Green Books": Garland & Smyth, Blumenson, Fisher); the British, Canadian (Nicholson), New Zealand and Indian official histories; Commonwealth War Graves Commission; American Battle Monuments Commission; Veterans Affairs Canada; NZHistory; Imperial War Museums; the museums' own websites; English, Italian, German and Polish Wikipedia for cross-checks. Every text was written by one researcher and checked by another; the disputed points are listed in the Briefing.

KEY FIGURES

A CAMPAIGN OF MANY NATIONS

The Italian campaign was fought by generals who often disliked each other and by soldiers from five continents. These are some of the people who shaped it, from Sicily in July 1943 to the German surrender on 2 May 1945.

▼ Read how the command worked ▾

At the top. Eisenhower ran the Mediterranean from Algiers until January 1944, then the British general Maitland Wilson, then Alexander from December 1944. Alexander commanded the Allied armies in Italy for most of the campaign; Clark took over from him in December 1944.

Two armies side by side. The US Fifth Army (Clark, then Truscott) fought on the western, Tyrrhenian side of the Apennines; the British Eighth Army (Montgomery, Leese, then McCreery) on the eastern, Adriatic side. Each held troops of many nations: French, Brazilians and South Africans served under the Americans at times, and Poles, Canadians, New Zealanders and Indians under the British.

The other side. Kesselring commanded the Germans for most of the campaign, with corps commanders such as von Senger holding the line. Mussolini's Social Republic fought beside them in the north, while Italian partisans, and a royal Italian army on the Allied side, fought against them.

22 people who shaped the war in Italy. Tap a name to read their story, the medals they earned and what became of them. Coloured ribbons are shown only for decorations with a matching ribbon; others are listed inside the card.

ALLIED COMMANDERS

1

Harold Alexander

"Alex"

Commander of the Allied armies in Sicily and Italy, then Supreme Allied Commander Mediterranean

Born 10 Dec 1891, London · died 16 Jun 1969, Slough

An Irish Guards officer decorated for bravery in the First World War, Alexander commanded the Allied ground forces in Sicily and Italy under a string of titles — 15th Army Group, then Allied Armies in Italy. Charming and unflappable, he managed Americans, British, French, Poles and many others by tact rather than orders. Critics, Montgomery among them, thought his grip too loose and the campaign short of direction. He accepted the bombing of the Monte Cassino abbey in February 1944 and planned the May 1944 offensive, Operation Diadem, that finally broke the Gustav Line. Made field marshal with seniority from 4 June 1944, the day Rome fell, he became Supreme Allied Commander Mediterranean in

December 1944 and received the German surrender in Italy, signed at Caserta on 29 April 1945 and effective on 2 May.

DECORATIONS

Military Cross — Battle of Loos, 1915 (gazetted January 1916)

Distinguished Service Order — the Somme, 1916

After the war: Governor General of Canada 1946–52 and Minister of Defence 1952–54; created Earl Alexander of Tunis.

2

Bernard Montgomery

“Monty”

Commander, British Eighth Army, in Sicily and southern Italy

Born 17 Nov 1887, Kennington, London · died 24 Mar 1976, Alton, Hampshire

Fresh from El Alamein and Tunisia, Montgomery had the Sicily plan changed so that his Eighth Army and Patton’s Seventh Army landed side by side in the south-east on 10 July 1943. His drive up the east coast stalled south of Catania, around Primosole Bridge and the slopes of Etna, while Patton swept west and north; their rivalry became legend. On 3 September 1943 his army crossed the Strait of Messina to Reggio Calabria (Operation Baytown), then pushed up the Adriatic side of Italy, crossing the Sangro and the Moro rivers in the winter mud while his Canadians fought for Ortona. At the end of December 1943 he handed over the Eighth Army and left for England to prepare the Normandy invasion.

DECORATIONS

Distinguished Service Order — Méteren, near the Belgian border, 13 October 1914, where he was shot through the lung

After the war: Commanded 21st Army Group from Normandy to the Baltic; Chief of the Imperial General Staff 1946–48; Viscount Montgomery of Alamein.

3

George S. Patton Jr.

“Old Blood and Guts”

Commander, US Seventh Army, in Sicily

Born 11 Nov 1885, San Gabriel, California · died 21 Dec 1945, Heidelberg, Germany

Patton’s Seventh Army landed around Licata, Gela and Scoglitti on 10 July 1943 and held off counter-attacks at Gela. Given a supporting role, he swung west, entered Palermo on 22 July and then raced Montgomery along the north coast, reaching Messina on 17 August — by which time more than 100,000 German and Italian troops had escaped to the mainland.

Caveat. Sicily also stained his name. On 3 and 10 August he struck two soldiers suffering from battle fatigue in field hospitals, Privates Charles Kuhl and Paul Bennett. Eisenhower made him apologise; when the story broke in November he was left without a fighting command for months. The same campaign saw the Biscari massacre of prisoners by men of the 45th Division; their defence cited Patton’s pre-invasion speech, and how far his words encouraged the killings is still argued.

DECORATIONS

- Distinguished Service Cross — wounded leading tanks in the Meuse-Argonne, 26 September 1918

> **After the war:** Led Third Army across France and Germany in 1944–45; died after a road accident in Germany in December 1945.

4 Mark W. Clark

Commander, US Fifth Army, then 15th Army Group

Born 1 May 1896, Madison Barracks, New York · died 17 Apr 1984, Charleston, South Carolina

Clark led the Fifth Army ashore at Salerno on 9 September 1943, and when German counter-attacks nearly split the beachhead he went forward under fire, winning the Distinguished Service Cross. In May 1944 his troops broke out of Anzio; in December he took over the whole Allied army group and on 2 May 1945 the German surrender in Italy took effect.

Caveat. Two decisions still divide historians. The 36th Division’s crossing of the Rapido in January 1944 failed with about 1,700 casualties; Texan veterans demanded a Congressional inquiry in 1946, which cleared him. And after Anzio he turned most of his force north-west towards Rome, which he entered on 4–5 June, instead of driving everything to Valmontone to cut off the retreating German 10th Army. Critics call it vanity; defenders say the trap could not have been closed.

DECORATIONS

- Distinguished Service Cross — under fire on the Salerno beachhead, September 1943

> **After the war:** US High Commissioner in Austria, then UN commander in Korea who signed the 1953 armistice; president of The Citadel 1954–65.

5 Oliver Leese

Commander, British Eighth Army, end of 1943 – September 1944

Born 27 Oct 1894, London · died 22 Jan 1978, Wales

A Coldstream Guards officer wounded three times on the Western Front, Leese had led a corps under Montgomery from El Alamein to Sicily. He took over the Eighth Army at the turn of 1943–44, when it was stuck in the Adriatic mud. In spring 1944 he moved most of the army in secret across the Apennines to the Cassino front, and in May its British, Canadian, Polish and Indian divisions broke into the Liri valley in the last battle of Cassino. In August he persuaded Alexander to switch the main effort back to the Adriatic, and Operation Olive broke into the Gothic Line between Pesaro and Rimini. The breakthrough was costly and did not end the war in Italy that year. In late September he left for South-East Asia.

DECORATIONS

Distinguished Service Order — the Somme, 1916

> **After the war:** His South-East Asia command ended after a failed attempt to remove General Slim. Later a noted grower of cacti and president of the MCC.

6 Richard McCreery

X Corps commander at Salerno, then commander of the Eighth Army

Born 1 Feb 1898, Market Harborough, Leicestershire · died 18 Oct 1967, Templecombe, Somerset

A cavalryman who walked with a limp after a wound at Arras in 1917 cost him several toes, McCreery commanded the British X Corps inside Clark’s Fifth Army: it landed at Salerno in September 1943, crossed the Volturno in October and the Garigliano in January 1944. On 1 October 1944 he took over the Eighth Army, the only cavalryman ever to lead it, as it slogged through the rain on the Romagna plain. His best moment came in April 1945: with amphibious tracked carriers across the flooded ground by Lake Comacchio he forced the Argenta Gap, a narrow strip of dry land between floods and marsh, and opened the way to the Po. In February 1945 he pinned Italy’s Gold Medal on the partisan leader Arrigo Boldrini in Ravenna.

DECORATIONS

Military Cross — mounted patrol near Solre-le-Château, 9 November 1918

After the war: Commanded British forces in Austria, then the British Army of the Rhine 1946–48.

7 Lucian K. Truscott Jr.

Commander, US 3rd Division, VI Corps at Anzio, then Fifth Army

Born 9 Jan 1895, Chatfield, Texas · died 12 Sep 1965, Alexandria, Virginia

A former cavalryman, Truscott trained the US 3rd Infantry Division to march at the fast “Truscott trot” and led it in Sicily, where he won the Distinguished Service Cross, and through the first winter in Italy. In February 1944 he replaced Lucas at Anzio, held the beachhead against the German counter-offensive and in May led VI Corps’ breakout towards Cisterna and Rome. After commanding the corps in the landings in southern France he returned in December 1944 to lead the Fifth Army to the Po and the Alps. At the American cemetery at Nettuno on Memorial Day 1945, the cartoonist Bill Mauldin later wrote, he turned his back on the dignitaries and spoke to the graves.

DECORATIONS

- Distinguished Service Cross — Sicily, 11 July 1943
- Legion of Merit
- Purple Heart
- Army Distinguished Service Medal, several awards

After the war: Succeeded Patton at the head of Third Army in Germany; later a senior CIA officer.

8 John P. Lucas

Commander, US VI Corps, Salerno to Anzio

Born 14 Jan 1890, Kearneysville, West Virginia · died 24 Dec 1949, Great Lakes, Illinois

Lucas took over VI Corps in September 1943 in the last days of the Salerno battle and led it through the autumn in the mountains. On 22 January 1944 his corps landed at Anzio almost unopposed; about 36,000 men were ashore by midnight. Instead of striking at once for the Alban Hills, he spent a week building up the beachhead, and by the time he attacked on 30

January Kesselring had ringed it with troops. Weeks of desperate defence followed, and on 22 February Clark replaced him with Truscott.

Caveat. His caution is usually blamed for Anzio's failure; Churchill complained that he had hoped for a wildcat and got a stranded whale. Many historians reply that two divisions could not have held the hills, and that the plan itself was too thin.

DECORATIONS

- Army Distinguished Service Medal (two awards)
- Navy Distinguished Service Medal
-  Silver Star
-  Purple Heart

> **After the war:** Commanded Fourth Army in the United States for the rest of the war; then headed the US military advisory group in China (1946–48) and was deputy commander of Fifth Army in Chicago.

9

Alphonse Juin

Commander, French Expeditionary Corps in Italy



Born 16 Dec 1888, Bône (Annaba), Algeria · died 27 Jan 1967, Paris

Born in French Algeria, Juin brought the French Expeditionary Corps to Italy from November 1943: Moroccan, Algerian, Tunisian, African and French soldiers who proved superb in the mountains. They fought on the Belvedere heights north of Cassino in the winter. In May 1944, in Operation Diadem, Juin argued for and led the decisive move: his Moroccan and Algerian divisions and goumiers crossed the Aurunci mountains, which the Germans thought impassable, and broke the Gustav Line in two days. That opened the Liri valley and the road to Rome. The corps left Italy in July 1944 for the landings in southern France.

Caveat. The same advance brought the *marocchinate*, mass rapes and killings of civilians in southern Lazio by soldiers of his corps. A story that Juin promised his men a free hand has never been documented.

DECORATIONS

-  Legion of Honour — Grand Cross

After the war: Resident-General in Morocco, a senior NATO commander, and from 1952 Marshal of France; buried at Les Invalides.

10 Władysław Anders

Commander, Polish II Corps

Born 11 Aug 1892, Krośniewice-Błonie, Russian Poland · died 12 May 1970, London

Wounded and taken prisoner by the Red Army in 1939, Anders spent nearly two years in Soviet prisons, including the Lubyanka in Moscow. After Germany invaded the Soviet Union in 1941 he was freed to raise a Polish army from deported prisoners, and in 1942 led it out through Iran. Many of its men, and their families, had come straight from the gulag. In May 1944, in the last battle of Cassino, his two divisions attacked the ridges above the monastery; after a week of heavy losses the Poles raised their flag over the ruined abbey on 18 May. The corps went on to take Ancona in July 1944, broke into the Gothic Line and entered Bologna on 21 April 1945 — by which time Yalta had handed their home provinces to Stalin.

After the war: Stripped of his citizenship by communist Poland, he lived in exile in London. At his wish he is buried among his soldiers in the Polish cemetery at Monte Cassino.

11 Bernard Freyberg

“Tiny”

Commander, 2nd New Zealand Division and the New Zealand Corps at Cassino

Born 21 Mar 1889, Richmond, Surrey · died 4 Jul 1963, Windsor

Raised in New Zealand, Freyberg won the Victoria Cross on the Somme in 1916 and led New Zealand’s division throughout the Second World War. It arrived in Italy in October 1943 and fought on the Sangro and at Orsogna that winter. In February 1944 he led a New Zealand Corps at Cassino. Sure that the Germans were using the abbey, he pressed for its bombing on 15 February; his attacks then and in March, including the Māori Battalion’s fight at the railway station, failed at great cost. His deputy, Howard Kippenberger, lost both feet to a mine. The division fought on north and raced to Trieste, arriving on 2 May 1945, where Yugoslav partisans were already in the city.

Caveat. After the war it became clear that German troops had not been inside the abbey before the bombing.

DECORATIONS

Victoria Cross — Beaucourt, Battle of the Somme, November 1916

Distinguished Service Order and three Bars (First and Second World Wars)

> **After the war:** Governor-General of New Zealand 1946–52; made Baron Freyberg.

12

João Baptista Mascarenhas de Moraes

Commander, Brazilian Expeditionary Force (FEB)

Born 13 Nov 1883 · died 17 Sep 1968, Rio de Janeiro

Brazil declared war on Germany and Italy in August 1942 after U-boats sank its ships, and Mascarenhas, then about sixty, was chosen to lead the only Latin American ground force to fight in Europe. About 25,900 Brazilians reached Italy from July 1944 and fought under the US Fifth Army in the Serchio valley and the northern Apennines. After failed attacks in the winter, they took Monte Castello in February 1945 and Montese in April, their costliest battle. At the end of April, around Collecchio and Fornovo di Taro, Mascarenhas received the surrender of the German 148th Infantry Division and Italian Fascist units — some 14,700 men and two generals.

> **After the war:** Made marshal by the Brazilian Congress in 1946; chief of the armed forces general staff 1951–54.

ALLIED SOLDIERS

13

Audie Murphy

Rifleman to platoon sergeant, 15th Infantry Regiment, US 3rd Infantry Division



Born 20 Jun 1925, Kingston, Texas · died 28 May 1971, air crash in Virginia

Slight and baby-faced — he had enlisted at 17 with a falsified birth date — Murphy landed with the 3rd Division at Licata on the first day of the Sicily invasion and was made corporal within days. He fought on the mainland from the Salerno beachhead through the winter mountains, suffering repeated bouts of malaria. He missed the Anzio landing in hospital but rejoined his company for the battle of Cisterna at the end of January 1944 and became a platoon sergeant. On 2 March 1944, near Anzio, he knocked out a German tank with rifle grenades after his men had shot its crew — his first Bronze Star. He left Italy with his division for southern France in August 1944, where he earned the Distinguished Service Cross and, in January 1945, the Medal of Honor.

DECORATIONS

- Medal of Honor — near Holtzwihr, France, 26 January 1945
- Distinguished Service Cross — southern France, August 1944
- Silver Star, twice — France, 1944
- Legion of Merit
- Bronze Star with “V”, twice — the first for the tank near Anzio, 2 March 1944
- Purple Heart, three times — all for wounds in France

After the war: Became a Hollywood actor and played himself in *To Hell and Back* (1955); buried at Arlington.

14 Paul Triquet

Company commander, Royal 22e Régiment, 1st Canadian Infantry Division

Born 2 Apr 1910, Cabano, Quebec · died 8 Aug 1980, Quebec City

In the battles for Ortona in December 1943 the Canadians had to cut the road behind the town. On 14 December Captain Triquet’s company of the “Van Doos”, French Canadians of the Royal 22e Régiment, attacked towards a farmhouse called Casa Berardi with tanks in support. Half his men and all his other officers were soon killed or wounded. Surrounded, he told the survivors, according to his citation, that the only safe place was on the objective, and pushed on; his group and the tanks knocked out four German tanks and several machine-gun posts. He reached the house with two sergeants and 15 men, told them “Ils ne passeront pas” — they shall not pass — and held it until the rest of the battalion arrived next day.

DECORATIONS

- Victoria Cross — Casa Berardi, 14 December 1943
- Legion of Honour (France)

After the war: Stayed in the reserve army, rising to brigadier.

15 Kamal Ram

Sepoy, 3rd Battalion, 8th Punjab Regiment, 8th Indian Division

Born 17 Dec 1924, Bholupura, Rajputana · died 1 Jul 1982, Bholupura, Rajasthan

On the opening night of the last Cassino battle, 11–12 May 1944, the 8th Indian Division crossed the fast-flowing Gari river south of Cassino under heavy fire. Next morning Kamal Ram's company was pinned down by machine-guns. Aged 19, he volunteered to work round the flank, crept up to the first post and attacked it alone, shooting the gunner and killing a second German with the bayonet. He knocked out a second post, then helped a comrade finish a third. Later that day he shot a German in a slit trench and captured two more, clearing the way for his company. King George VI presented his Victoria Cross in Italy that summer, during his visit to the troops.

DECORATIONS

Victoria Cross — Gari river, 12 May 1944 (London Gazette, 27 July 1944)

After the war: Stayed in the Indian Army after independence and retired in 1972 as an honorary lieutenant.

16

Daniel K. Inouye

Platoon leader, 442nd Regimental Combat Team



Born 7 Sep 1924, Honolulu · died 17 Dec 2012, Bethesda, Maryland

Inouye was a Honolulu teenager when Japan attacked Pearl Harbor. He joined the 442nd, a regiment of Japanese Americans raised while many mainland Japanese American families were held in camps. He fought with it north of Rome in summer 1944 and in the Vosges mountains of France, winning a battlefield commission. In spring 1945 the 442nd returned to Italy to attack the western end of the Gothic Line. On 21 April 1945, on the Colle Musatello ridge near San Terenzo, he was shot in the stomach but kept attacking German machine-gun posts until a rifle grenade shattered his right arm. He prised a live grenade from his shattered right hand, threw it, and kept directing his men until he was carried away.

DECORATIONS

Medal of Honor — Colle Musatello, 21 April 1945 (first awarded as the Distinguished Service Cross, upgraded in 2000)



Bronze Star



Purple Heart with oak leaf cluster

After the war: Lost his right arm. US senator for Hawaii from 1963 until his death in 2012.

17

Vernon Baker

Platoon leader, 370th Infantry Regiment, 92nd Infantry Division

Born 17 Dec 1919, Cheyenne, Wyoming · died 13 Jul 2010, St. Maries, Idaho

The 92nd “Buffalo” Division was the only African American infantry division to fight in Europe, in an army that kept Black and white soldiers apart. On 5 April 1945 Lieutenant Baker’s platoon attacked the German strongpoint around Castle Aghinolfi, above the coast north of Viareggio. He knocked out machine-gun posts, an observation post and a dugout, killing nine Germans himself; most of his 25 men were killed or wounded. The next night he volunteered to lead a battalion advance through minefields and heavy fire. He received the Distinguished Service Cross. Only in 1997, after an Army-commissioned study found that Black soldiers had been passed over, was it upgraded to the Medal of Honor.

DECORATIONS

- Medal of Honor — Castle Aghinolfi, 5–6 April 1945 (presented by President Clinton, January 1997)
- Silver Star
- Bronze Star with “V”, twice
- Purple Heart, twice

> **After the war:** Stayed in the army until 1968, then worked for the Red Cross for nearly 20 years. The only one of the seven Black Second World War soldiers honoured in 1997 still alive to receive his medal.

18

Wojtek

A curiosity: the bear of the 22nd Artillery Supply Company, Polish II Corps

Found as a cub in Iran, 1942 · died 2 Dec 1963, Edinburgh Zoo

Wojtek was a Syrian brown bear cub bought in 1942 near Hamadan, Iran, by Polish soldiers who had just come out of the Soviet Union. He grew up with their supply company, wrestling his friends, riding in their lorries and famously fond of beer and cigarettes. To get him aboard a ship to Italy he was enlisted as a private, with a paybook and a number. His comrades said that at Monte Cassino in May 1944 he helped carry crates of artillery shells, and a bear holding a shell became the company badge. The story is hard to prove, though at least one British soldier later described seeing a bear carrying crates.

> **After the war:** Went with the company to Scotland and lived in Edinburgh Zoo from 1947. Statues stand in Edinburgh, in Poland and, since 2019, at Cassino.

AXIS & ITALIANS

19 Albert Kesselring

“Smiling Albert”

German Commander-in-Chief South-West and Army Group C

Born 30 Nov 1885, Marktsteft, Bavaria · died 16 Jul 1960, Bad Nauheim

A Luftwaffe field marshal, Kesselring persuaded Hitler that Italy could be held far to the south rather than abandoned up to the Alps. From Salerno onwards he fought a skilful delaying war along a chain of fortified lines — the Gustav Line through Cassino, the Hitler Line, the Gothic Line — making the Allies pay for every river and ridge. He had the Anzio beachhead ringed within days. His harsh anti-partisan orders of 1944 promised officers backing for severe measures, and reprisal killings followed under his command. In March 1945 he left Italy to command in the west.

Caveat. In 1947 a British military court in Venice sentenced him to death for the Ardeatine Caves massacre and for inciting the killing of civilians. The sentence was commuted to life imprisonment and he was freed in 1952, officially on health grounds.

DECORATIONS

Knight’s Cross with Oak Leaves, Swords and Diamonds

> **After the war:** Wrote his memoirs and led the Stahlhelm, a right-wing veterans’ league.

20 Fridolin von Senger und Etterlin

Commander, German XIV Panzer Corps at Cassino

Born 4 Sep 1891, Waldshut · died 9 Jan 1963, Freiburg

An unusual German general: a devout Catholic and a Rhodes scholar at Oxford before 1914. In Sicily he was the German liaison officer with the Italian 6th Army; afterwards he brought the German garrisons out of Sardinia and Corsica. From October 1943 his XIV Panzer Corps held the southern front around Cassino through all four battles. German troops were kept out of the abbey before the Allied bombing; afterwards his paratroopers turned the ruins into a fortress. When the Poles and French broke through in May 1944 his

corps fell back towards Rome, and in May 1945 he came to Allied headquarters in Florence to receive the terms of the German surrender.

DECORATIONS

Knight’s Cross with Oak Leaves

> **After the war:** Wrote the memoir *Neither Fear nor Hope* and advised on the creation of the new West German army.

21

Benito Mussolini

“Il Duce”

Fascist dictator, then head of the Italian Social Republic

Born 29 Jul 1883, Predappio · died 28 Apr 1945, Giulino di Mezzegra

Italy’s dictator since 1922, Mussolini fell fifteen days after the Allies landed in Sicily: on 25 July 1943 the Fascist Grand Council voted against him and the King had him arrested. On 12 September German paratroopers freed him from a hotel on the Gran Sasso — the SS officer Otto Skorzeny took most of the credit — and Hitler set him up as head of the Italian Social Republic, based on Lake Garda and wholly dependent on Germany. In April 1945 he fled north with a German column; partisans caught him at Dongo on 27 April and shot him and Clara Petacci the next day.

> **Afterwards:** Their bodies were hung up at Piazzale Loreto in Milan on 29 April 1945. He is buried at Predappio.

22

Arrigo Boldrini

“Bulow”

Partisan commander, 28th Garibaldi Brigade, Ravenna

Born 6 Sep 1915, Ravenna · died 22 Jan 2008, Ravenna

A former army officer, Boldrini took his battle name from the Prussian general von Bülow and organised Communist-led partisans in the flat marshes and pinewoods around Ravenna, country where guerrillas were not supposed to survive. His plan for the liberation of Ravenna, carried out with the advancing Allies in early December 1944, helped them take the city without a battle for its Byzantine monuments. Wounded in the German counter-attacks, his brigade held its ground and then fought alongside Allied units along the

Senio front. On 4 February 1945, in Piazza Garibaldi in Ravenna, General McCreery pinned the Gold Medal of Military Valour on him.

Caveat. Later writers tried to link him to the killing of Fascist prisoners at Codevigo in 1945. The killings were investigated after the war, but he was never named as a suspect or charged.

DECORATIONS

Gold Medal of Military Valour — liberation of Ravenna, pinned on 4 February 1945

> **After the war:** First president of the partisans' association ANPI (1947–2006) and a member of parliament from 1946 to 1994.

▼ Myths and disputes

These bios follow the best-supported version. Where the record is still argued over, this is what the argument is about.

The abbey of Monte Cassino

Allied commanders, Freyberg above all, believed the Germans were using the monastery; they were not inside it before the bombing of 15 February 1944, though their positions ran close by. The ruins then became a German strongpoint.

Clark and Rome

Whether turning towards Rome in late May 1944 let the German 10th Army escape, or whether it would have escaped anyway, is still debated.

Lucas at Anzio

Blamed for caution; defended by historians who argue that a quick dash inland would have been cut off.

Patton

The slapping incidents are well documented. His share of blame for the Biscari prisoner killings is disputed; the soldiers tried cited his speech, and one was convicted, one acquitted.

Juin and the marocchinate

The crimes are documented; French military courts convicted over 150 soldiers. The alleged "licence" speech by Juin has no documentary source.

Kesselring

Admired as a defensive general, convicted as a war criminal; his early release in 1952 caused outrage in Italy.

Mussolini's rescue

The Gran Sasso raid was planned by the Luftwaffe paratroop command and led by Major Harald Mors' men; Skorzeny's role was later inflated by propaganda and his own memoirs.

Kamal Ram

Often called the youngest Indian VC; some sources rank him second-youngest.

Wojtek

The shell-carrying at Cassino rests on his comrades' accounts; there is no official record of it.

Boldrini

Accused by later writers over the Codevigo killings; post-war investigations never named him as a suspect and he was never charged.

Truscott at Nettuno

The famous Memorial Day scene comes from Bill Mauldin's account.

THE ARMIES

WHO FOUGHT IN ITALY

No campaign of the war in the West was more international. Between the landings in Sicily on 10 July 1943 and the German surrender on 2 May 1945, soldiers from five continents fought their way up the peninsula in two Allied armies: the US Fifth Army on the western side of the Apennines and the British Eighth Army on the eastern, Adriatic side, both under a single Allied army group. Facing them was the German Army Group C, with Mussolini's Italian Social Republic behind its lines. Italy itself was split: from October 1943 the royal government fought on the Allied side, and partisans fought the Germans and Fascists in the occupied north.

All numbers here are approximate. Divisions came and went, and totals differ between official histories, cemetery records and later research, depending on whether Sicily is included and whether "casualties" means the dead only or also the wounded, missing and captured. Where sources disagree, a range is given.

THE WHOLE CAMPAIGN IN NUMBERS

Sicily and Italy, July 1943 – May 1945

At the peak, in May 1944, the Allies had a ration strength of about 620,000 men in Italy against some 365,000 Germans; counting everyone in the theatre, totals of about 1.3 million Allied and 440,000 German troops are given. Sicily alone cost the Allies about 5,700 dead and the Axis about 9,000 dead and some 127,000 prisoners; over 100,000 German and Italian soldiers escaped across the Strait of Messina.

On the mainland the US official history counts 312,000 Allied casualties of all kinds (killed, wounded, missing) from September 1943 to May 1945, and 434,646 German casualties, including 48,067 killed and 214,048 missing, most of them captured. Other estimates put Allied dead at about 59,000–70,000, and German dead anywhere from under 40,000 to 150,000, depending on the source. At least 150,000 Italian civilians died in bombing, shelling, massacres and hunger; partisan dead are counted at 35,000–50,000, and German and Fascist reprisal killings claimed roughly 15,000–22,000 civilians.

Allied dead (mainland) ≈ 59,000–70,000 · Allied casualties ≈ 312,000–330,000 · German dead ≈ 48,000 (US official history), other estimates higher · civilians ≥ 150,000 dead · totals vary by source and by what is counted

THE ALLIED ARMIES

US Fifth Army

Formed in North Africa and landed at Salerno on 9 September 1943, the Fifth Army fought up the western side of Italy to the Po and the Alps under Clark and then Truscott. Its American core changed over time. The 3rd, 36th (Texas) and 45th (Thunderbird) Divisions fought from Sicily or Salerno through Cassino and Anzio before leaving for southern France in August 1944. The 34th (Red Bull) served from Salerno to the end, including Cassino and Anzio; the 1st Armored Division fought at Anzio and to the Po; the draftee divisions 85th, 88th and 91st fought from the spring and summer of 1944 through the Gothic Line.

Three formations stand out. The 92nd “Buffalo” Division, the only African American infantry division to fight in Europe, held the Ligurian coast and Serchio valley from late 1944. The 442nd Regimental Combat Team, Japanese Americans with the 100th Battalion that had fought since Salerno, became one of the most decorated units in US history for its size. The 10th Mountain Division arrived at the turn of 1944–45, climbed Riva Ridge at night in February and opened the Fifth Army's spring offensive on 14 April. The army also led British, French, Brazilian, South African and Italian troops.

US divisions in Italy: up to 7–8 at a time · US dead: ≈ 20,400 on the mainland + ≈ 2,800 in Sicily · Fifth Army casualties, all nations: 188,746 (US official history)

British Eighth Army

Montgomery’s desert army landed in south-east Sicily and crossed to Calabria on 3 September 1943, then fought up the Adriatic side under Montgomery, Leese and McCreery. Its British divisions included the 78th (Battleaxe), 4th, 46th, 56th (London) and 1st Infantry Divisions and the 6th Armoured Division, with the 1st Airborne landing at Taranto; the 50th and 51st Highland Divisions fought in Sicily before leaving for Normandy. British X Corps (46th and 56th Divisions) served inside the American Fifth Army at Salerno and on the Garigliano, and the British 1st Division fought at Anzio. Commandos fought at Termoli and Lake Comacchio.

The Eighth Army was really an imperial and allied army: at different times it contained the Canadian, Polish and New Zealand corps and divisions, three Indian divisions, South Africans, Greeks, the Jewish Brigade and Italian combat groups. Its hardest battles were Primosole in Sicily, the Sangro, the last battle of Cassino, the Gothic Line and Coriano ridge in September 1944, and the Argenta Gap in April 1945.

UK dead: ≈ 18,700 on the mainland, plus a share of the ≈ 2,900 British and Canadian dead in Sicily

Canadians — I Canadian Corps

The 1st Canadian Infantry Division and 1st Canadian Armoured Brigade landed near Pachino on 10 July 1943, fought through central Sicily, and crossed to the mainland in September. In December 1943, after hard fighting on the Moro River, they took Ortona in eight days of house-to-house fighting; the month cost the 1st Division several hundred dead (sources give from about 500 to 700). The 5th Canadian Armoured Division joined them, and as I Canadian Corps they broke the Hitler Line in the Liri valley in May 1944, broke into the Gothic Line and fought at Coriano and Rimini in September, then across the rivers of the Romagna. In February–March 1945 the corps moved to north-west Europe. Canadians also made up a large part of the joint US-Canadian 1st Special Service Force, which fought at Monte la Difensa and Anzio.

More than 93,000 served · peak ≈ 76,000 · 25,264 casualties, including more than 5,900 dead, Sicily included (Veterans Affairs Canada)

New Zealand — 2nd New Zealand Division

Freyberg's division, including the 28th Māori Battalion, arrived in Italy in October 1943. It fought on the Sangro and at Orsogna in the winter of 1943, then as part of the New Zealand Corps in the second and third battles of Cassino (February–March 1944), attacking the railway station and the bombed town. It went on to Florence in August 1944, Faenza in December and the Senio in April 1945, and reached Trieste on 2 May 1945.

More than 2,100 killed and 6,700 wounded in Italy (NZHistory; another tally gives ≈ 1,700 dead from September 1943)

Indian Army — 4th, 8th and 10th Indian Divisions

Soldiers from every part of undivided India, and Gurkhas from Nepal, served in three divisions with British units mixed in. The 8th Indian arrived at Taranto in September 1943 and crossed river after river on the Adriatic — Biferno, Trigno, Sangro, Moro — before its night crossing of the Gari at Cassino in May 1944 and the fighting on to the Gothic Line and the Senio. The 4th Indian fought on the ridges above Cassino in February and March 1944, where Gurkhas held Hangman's Hill below the abbey, and left for Greece late in 1944. The 10th Indian arrived in 1944 and fought in the Tiber valley, the Apennines and the final offensive. Kamal Ram's Victoria Cross was one of several won by Indian soldiers in Italy.

Three divisions plus Gurkha units · dead ≈ 4,100 (India, Pakistan and Nepal, September 1943 – May 1945, one widely cited tally; other counts differ)

Polish II Corps

Anders' corps was built largely from Poles deported to the Soviet Union in 1939–41 and released in 1941. It came to Italy in early 1944 with the 3rd Carpathian Rifle Division, the 5th Kresowa Infantry Division and the 2nd Armoured Brigade (later a division). In May 1944 it attacked the ridges above Monte Cassino and raised its flag over the abbey on 18 May. It then fought up the Adriatic, taking Ancona in July 1944, broke into the Gothic Line and entered Bologna on 21 April 1945. The corps kept growing by recruiting Poles who had been forced into the German army and later captured.

≈ 50,000 in May 1944, over 100,000 by the end of 1945 · 11,379 casualties, 2,301 killed in action · over 1,000 buried in the Polish cemetery at Monte Cassino

French Expeditionary Corps

General Juin's corps arrived at Naples from November 1943. Most of its soldiers came from French North Africa and the colonies: the 2nd Moroccan Infantry Division, the 3rd Algerian Infantry Division, the 4th Moroccan Mountain Division and the 1st Motorised Infantry Division (the former 1st Free French Division, with many West and Central African tirailleurs), plus Moroccan goumiers — irregular mountain troops in units called tabors. Tunisians, Senegalese, Malagasy and French from France and Algeria served alongside them. After hard fighting on the Belvedere heights in early 1944, they broke through the Aurunci mountains in May 1944, the key move that unlocked the road to Rome, and went on to Siena before leaving in July 1944 for southern France.

Caveat — the marocchinate. During and after the May 1944 breakthrough, soldiers of the corps, mostly North African troops and especially goumiers, committed mass rapes, killings and looting in the villages of southern Lazio (the Ciociaria). Estimates of victims range from 2,000–3,000 women (Italian Ministry of Defence, 1997) to about 12,000 or more (victims' associations); about 800 men were also killed. French military courts tried 207 soldiers and convicted 156, and France compensated 1,488 victims in 1947. The crimes shaped Italian memory of the liberation, for example in Moravia's novel *La ciociara*.

Peak ≈ 110,000–112,000, average ≈ 76,000 · dead ≈ 5,200–6,600+ · about 23,000 wounded (French Ministry of the Armed Forces)

South Africans — 6th South African Armoured Division

The division landed at Taranto in April 1944, with a British Guards brigade attached, and joined the pursuit north of Rome through Chiusi to Florence in August 1944. It spent the winter in the Apennines under American command and in April 1945 took Monte Sole and Monte Caprara south of Bologna before crossing the Po. South African Air Force squadrons also flew throughout the campaign.

One armoured division · ≈ 710–800 dead (the division reported 711 killed, 2,675 wounded, 157 missing)

Brazilian Expeditionary Force (FEB)

Brazil was the only Latin American country to send ground troops to Europe. The first 5,000 men reached Naples on 16 July 1944, and the FEB fought under the US Fifth Army in the Serchio valley and the northern Apennines. After costly winter attacks it took Monte Castello on 21 February 1945 and Montese in April, then trapped the German 148th Division at Collecchio and Fornovo, taking some 14,700 prisoners. A Brazilian fighter squadron flew P-47s alongside the Americans. The dead were buried at Pistoia before being moved to Rio de Janeiro in 1960.

≈ 25,900 sent · ≈ 450–470 killed in action (some tallies higher or lower) · over 20,000 prisoners taken

The Jewish Brigade

Formed in late 1944 from Jewish volunteers of British-ruled Palestine, the brigade of about 5,000 men landed at Taranto in November 1944 and went into the line on the Senio in March 1945, fighting at Alfonsine and in the final offensive. After the war its men helped Holocaust survivors reach Palestine. In 2018 Italy awarded its flag the Gold Medal of Military Valour.

≈ 5,000 men · 30–57 killed (sources differ) · 33 buried at Ravenna War Cemetery

Greeks and other contingents

The Greek 3rd Mountain Brigade, a few thousand men raised in the Middle East from the Greek government in exile, fought under I Canadian Corps at Rimini in September 1944 and was renamed the Rimini Brigade. Many smaller groups served too, among them Newfoundland gunners, Cypriot and Palestinian units, African pioneer companies and Australian air squadrons.

Greek dead ≈ 115

Italian co-belligerent forces

After the armistice of 8 September 1943 the King’s government declared war on Germany on 13 October. A small Italian motorised group of about 5,700 men went into the line in December 1943 at Monte Lungo, near Cassino, failing at first and then taking the hill. It grew into the Italian Liberation Corps, which fought up the Adriatic in 1944, and by 1945 into six combat groups (Cremona, Friuli, Folgore, Legnano, Mantova, Piceno) of about 9,000 men each, four of which fought in the final offensive. Tens of thousands more served the Allies as muleteers, labourers and support troops, and the Italian navy and air force fought on the Allied side.

Combat troops ≈ 20,000–50,000; with support units ≈ 266,000–326,000 · ≈ 1,900 killed in the combat units, plus ≈ 740 in auxiliary units

The partisans and the CLN

The resistance began in September 1943, when Germany occupied Italy and disarmed its army. The Committees of National Liberation (CLN), set up by the anti-Fascist parties, directed the struggle; in the north it was led by the CLNAI in Milan. The biggest formations were the Communist Garibaldi brigades and the Action Party's Giustizia e Libertà brigades, with Socialist, Catholic and non-party "autonomous" units, many of them ex-soldiers. They fought in the Apennines and the Alps, sabotaged roads and railways, sheltered escaped Allied prisoners and rose in the cities, from Florence in August 1944 to Genoa, Turin and Milan in April 1945. 25 April is Italy's Liberation Day. The Germans answered with reprisals, among them the Ardeatine Caves, Sant'Anna di Stazzema and Marzabotto.

≈ 70,000–100,000 in summer 1944, over 200,000–250,000 by April 1945 (estimates vary widely) · partisan dead ≈ 35,000–50,000

THE AXIS FORCES

German Army Group C

Kesselring commanded the German forces in Italy from November 1943 to March 1945, followed by von Vietinghoff. The 10th Army held the southern front, including the Gustav Line at Cassino; the 14th Army, formed in late 1943, sealed off Anzio and later held the western Apennines; an Army Liguria guarded the north-west from 1944. The best German units in Italy were the paratroopers of the 1st Fallschirmjäger Division (Ortona, Cassino) and the 4th (Anzio); the Luftwaffe's Hermann Göring Panzer Division (Sicily, Salerno, Anzio, until summer 1944); the 15th, 29th and 90th Panzergrenadier Divisions; and the 16th and 26th Panzer Divisions. The 16th SS Panzergrenadier Division committed the massacres at Sant'Anna di Stazzema and Marzabotto in 1944. Army Group C surrendered under the Caserta agreement, signed on 29 April and effective on 2 May 1945.

Peak ≈ 365,000 ration strength, ≈ 440,000 in all (May 1944) · 434,646 casualties incl. 48,067 killed (US official history); other estimates of the dead run much higher

Italian Axis forces: 1943 and the Social Republic

In Sicily the Italian 6th Army fought beside the Germans; it lost about 4,700 dead, and many of its coastal troops surrendered quickly. After the armistice the Germans disarmed the Italian army and shipped some 600,000–700,000 soldiers to camps in Germany, where tens of thousands died. In the north Mussolini's Italian Social Republic raised its own forces: four divisions trained in Germany (Italia, Littorio, San Marco, Monterosa), which fought mainly on quiet sectors, on coast defence and in the Garfagnana attack of December 1944; the National Republican Guard; the Black Brigades of the Fascist party; and the Decima MAS naval commandos. Most of their fighting was against partisans, a civil war marked by atrocities on both sides.

Sicily: ≈ 4,700 Italian dead · Social Republic dead ≈ 35,000 · paper strength several hundred thousand (figures disputed)

AT A GLANCE

NATIONALITY	MAIN FORMATIONS	APPROX. PEAK STRENGTH IN ITALY	APPROX. DEATHS IN THE CAMPAIGN	WHERE THEY FOUGHT HARDEST
United States	Fifth Army: 3rd, 34th, 36th, 45th, 85th, 88th, 91st, 92nd, 10th Mountain, 1st Armored; 442nd RCT	up to 7–8 divisions (no single agreed figure)	≈ 23,000 incl. Sicily	Salerno, Rapido/Cassino, Anzio, Gothic Line, Apennines
United Kingdom	Eighth Army; X Corps; 1st, 4th, 46th, 56th, 78th Inf., 6th Armoured	the largest national contingent for most of the campaign	≈ 18,700 + share of ≈ 2,900 in Sicily	Primosole, Salerno, Sangro, Cassino, Anzio, Coriano, Argenta
Canada	I Canadian Corps: 1st Inf. Div., 5th Armoured Div., 1st Armoured Bde	≈ 76,000 (93,000 served)	≈ 5,900 incl. Sicily	Sicily, Ortona, Hitler Line, Gothic Line, Rimini
New Zealand	2nd NZ Division incl. 28th Māori Battalion	one reinforced division	≈ 1,700–2,100	Orsogna, Cassino, Florence, Faenza, Senio
India & Nepal	4th, 8th, 10th Indian Divisions; Gurkha battalions	three divisions	≈ 4,100 (counts vary)	Sangro, Cassino, Gari, Gothic Line, Senio
Poland	II Corps: 3rd Carpathian, 5th Kresowa, 2nd Armoured	≈ 50,000 (May 1944) → 100,000+	≈ 2,300	Cassino, Ancona, Gothic Line, Bologna

France & French Africa	CEF: 2nd Moroccan, 3rd Algerian, 4th Moroccan Mountain, 1st Motorised; goumiers	≈ 110,000–112,000	≈ 5,200–6,600	Belvedere, Garigliano, Aurunci, Siena
South Africa	6th SA Armoured Division	one armoured division	≈ 710–800	Chiusi, Florence, Apennines, Monte Sole
Brazil	FEB: 1st Expeditionary Infantry Division	≈ 25,900	≈ 450–470	Monte Castello, Montese, Collecchio
Jewish Palestine	Jewish Brigade	≈ 5,000	30–57	Senio
Greece	3rd Mountain (Rimini) Brigade	a few thousand	≈ 115	Rimini
Italy (Allied)	Italian Liberation Corps; six combat groups	20,000–50,000 combat troops	≈ 900–1,900 (counts vary; + ≈ 740 auxiliaries)	Monte Lungo, Filottrano, Senio, Po
Italian partisans	Garibaldi, Giustizia e Libertà, Matteotti, autonomous brigades	200,000–250,000+ (April 1945)	≈ 35,000–50,000	Apennines, Alps, northern cities
Germany	Army Group C: 10th & 14th Armies; paratroop, panzer and panzergrenadier divisions	≈ 365,000–440,000 (May 1944)	≈ 48,000 (US official history); other estimates much higher	Salerno, Ortona, Cassino, Anzio, Gothic Line
Italian Social Republic	Italia, Littorio, San Marco, Monterosa; GNR; Black Brigades; Decima MAS	disputed	≈ 35,000	anti-partisan war, Garfagnana

Deaths are for mainland Italy, September 1943 – May 1945, unless Sicily is stated; national figures come from different sources and do not add up exactly to the totals above.

WEAPONS & EQUIPMENT

The weapons and kit that both sides used in Sicily and Italy, from the landings of July 1943 to the German surrender on 2 May 1945 — rifles and machine guns, anti-tank weapons, guns, tanks, mines, landing craft and the mules that carried the war into the mountains. For each one you will see when it was used, how it worked, what it did well, where it fell short and which places in this guide it is linked to.

Filter the cards by type with the buttons, or tap a row in the timeline to jump straight to that card.

WHAT WAS USED, AND WHEN

Use in Sicily and Italy, from the landings of 10 July 1943 to the surrender that took effect on 2 May 1945. The shaded bands are the phases of the campaign that this guide follows; red ticks mark key moments. Some dates are approximate.



In general use · Few units, or first / last deliveries · Key moment

RIFLES & SMGS

M1 GARAND RIFLE

The American infantryman's semi-automatic rifle; Patton called it "the greatest battle implement ever devised"

IN USE: Whole campaign · US standard rifle since 1936

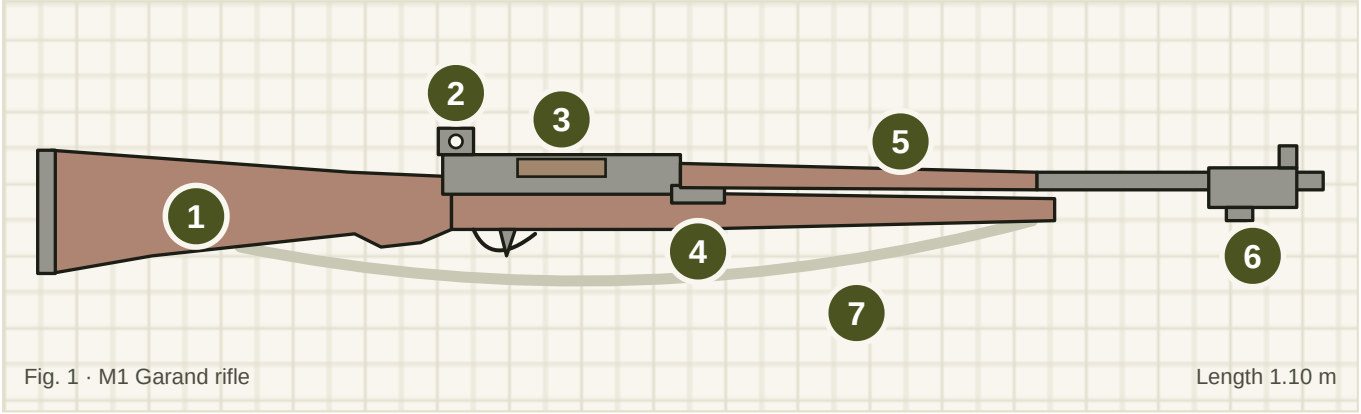


Fig. 1 · M1 Garand rifle — Length 1.10 m

1. Wooden stock
2. Aperture rear sight
3. 8-round clip, pushed in from the top and thrown out when empty

4. Operating rod handle: gas from the barrel works the action
5. Wooden handguards
6. Gas cylinder and bayonet lug
7. Sling

CALIBRE	.30-06 Springfield (7.62 × 63 mm)
ACTION	Gas-operated, semi-automatic
MAGAZINE	8-round en-bloc clip
WEIGHT	about 4.3 kg (9.5 lb) empty
LENGTH	1.10 m
EFFECTIVE RANGE	about 450 m (500 yd)
RATE OF FIRE	40–50 aimed shots a minute
BUILT	about 5.4 million (1936–57)

The standard rifle of American infantry throughout the campaign, and the first semi-automatic rifle to become the standard rifle of a major army. Every pull of the trigger fired a shot and loaded the next, so a squad of riflemen armed with Garands could put down far more fire than one with bolt-action rifles. Eight rounds came packed in a steel clip that was pushed into the top of the rifle; when the last shot was fired, the empty clip flew out with a distinctive “ping”.

STRENGTHS

+ Semi-automatic: as fast as the soldier could aim and pull the trigger
+ Powerful, accurate cartridge, the same as the BAR and the M1919 machine gun
+ Rugged and reliable in dust, mud and cold
+ Quick to reload with a fresh clip

WEAKNESSES

− Heavy: over 4 kg before sling and bayonet
− Hard to top up: men usually fired a part-used clip empty before reloading
− The empty-clip “ping” was said to warn the enemy — veterans still argue whether it mattered
− Long and awkward for fighting in houses and ruins

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

1936 Adopted as the US Army's standard rifle.

1943 M7 launcher clips onto the muzzle to fire rifle grenades.

1944 M1C sniper version with a telescopic sight, in small numbers.

IN ITALY

Before dawn on 30 January 1944, 767 men of the 1st and 3rd Ranger Battalions slipped out of the Anzio beachhead to seize Cisterna by surprise, carrying only light weapons — rifles, automatic rifles and bazookas. At first light they were caught in open fields by troops and tanks of the Hermann Göring Division and the 715th Infantry Division. After hours of fighting only a handful got back — the figure usually given is six — and most of the rest were taken prisoner.

Where it mattered: Cisterna — the Rangers' last fight · Anzio · Salerno · Gela

RIFLES & SMGS

LEE-ENFIELD RIFLES NO. 4 MK I AND NO. 1 MK III*

The bolt-action rifle of the British and Commonwealth soldier

IN USE: Whole campaign · the older No. 1 Mk III* served alongside the No. 4, which became more common in 1943–44

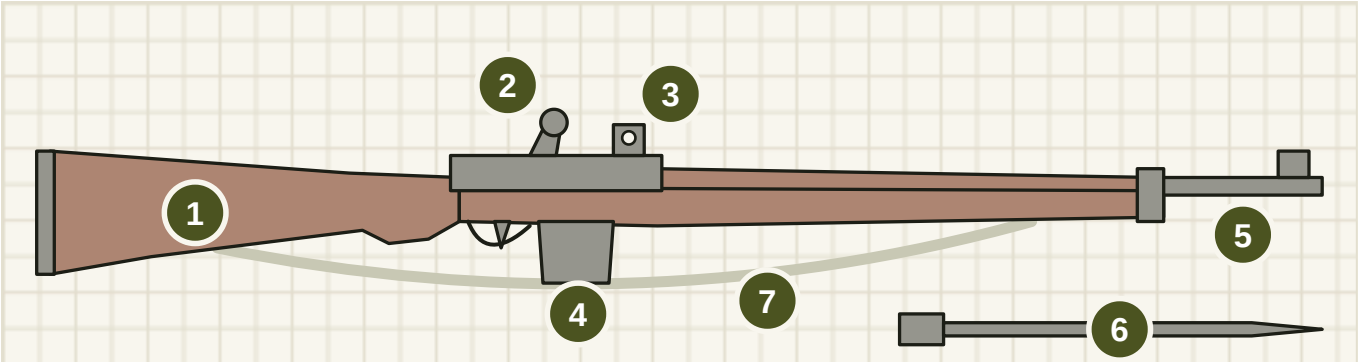


Fig. 2 · Lee-Enfield rifles No. 4 Mk I and No. 1 Mk III* — No. 4 Mk I · length 1.13 m

1. Wooden butt
2. Bolt (Lee action): fast and smooth
3. No. 4: aperture sight on the receiver
4. 10-round magazine, filled with two 5-round chargers
5. No. 4: barrel sticks out beyond the wood
6. No. 4 spike bayonet — the “pigsticker”
7. Sling

CALIBRE	.303 British (7.7 × 56 mm R)
ACTION	Bolt action (Lee system)
MAGAZINE	10 rounds, loaded with two 5-round chargers
WEIGHT	No. 4: about 4.1 kg
LENGTH	No. 4: 1.13 m
EFFECTIVE RANGE	about 500 m
RATE OF FIRE	15 or more aimed shots a minute for a trained rifleman

British, Canadian, New Zealand, South African and Indian troops, and the British-equipped Polish II Corps, all fought in Italy with the Lee-Enfield. The No. 4 Mk I was a simpler, heavier and sturdier version of the First World War SMLE, designed for mass production: its barrel sticks out beyond the wooden fore-end and it has an aperture sight on the receiver. Many units still carried the older No. 1 Mk III*, and the two were used side by side to the end.

STRENGTHS

WEAKNESSES

+ Fast, smooth bolt and a 10-round magazine — twice the German rifle's 5
+ Rugged and accurate
+ The No. 4's aperture sight was quick and precise
+ Same .303 round as the Bren gun

– Bolt action: slower than the American semi-automatic Garand
– The spike bayonet was useless as a tool
– Long and awkward in house fighting
– Refilling with 5-round chargers was slow in the middle of a fight

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

1941 No. 4 Mk I officially adopted; mass production in Britain, Canada (Long Branch) and the United States (Savage).

1942 Mk I*: simplified for faster production in North America.

1943–45 In Italy, No. 4s and the older No. 1 Mk III* serve side by side.

IN ITALY

At Ortona, from 20 to 28 December 1943, the Loyal Edmonton Regiment and the Seaforth Highlanders of Canada fought German paratroopers of the 1st Parachute Division house by house. Rather than move along the streets, they blasted “mouse-holes” through the walls between houses with PIATs or Teller mines, threw in grenades and fought through room by room. The battle became known as “Little Stalingrad”.

Where it mattered: Ortona — “Little Stalingrad” · Primosole Bridge · Monte Cassino · Coriano Ridge

RIFLES & SMGS

KARABINER 98K RIFLE

The standard German rifle, carried by army infantry and paratroopers alike

IN USE: Whole campaign · German standard rifle since 1935

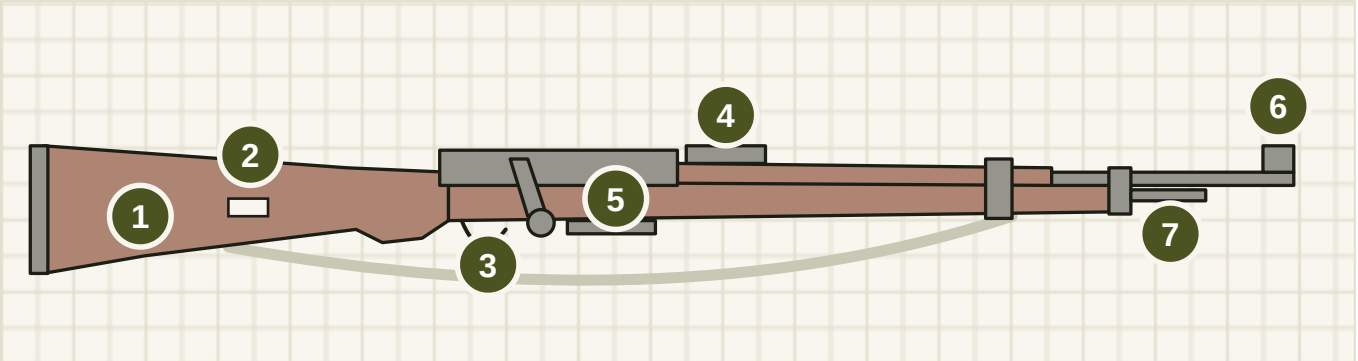


Fig. 3 · Karabiner 98k rifle — Length 1.11 m

1. Stock of walnut or laminated wood
2. Sling slot through the butt
3. Bolt with turned-down handle
4. Tangent rear sight
5. 5-round internal magazine, filled from a stripper clip
6. Hooded front sight
7. Bayonet lug

CALIBRE	7.92 × 57 mm Mauser

ACTION	Bolt action (Mauser)
MAGAZINE	5 rounds, internal; loaded with a stripper clip
WEIGHT	about 3.7–4.1 kg, depending on the wood
LENGTH	1.11 m
EFFECTIVE RANGE	about 500 m with iron sights; more with a telescopic sight
BUILT	over 14 million (1935–45)

A shortened version of the First World War Mauser rifle, carried by most German infantrymen and paratroopers in Italy. It was accurate and extremely strong, but held only five rounds and had to be worked by hand after every shot. The German army relied on its machine guns for firepower: much of the riflemen's job was to protect the section's MG 42 and carry its ammunition.

STRENGTHS

+ Very accurate, with a powerful cartridge
+ Extremely strong, reliable Mauser bolt
+ With a telescopic sight, a fine sniper's rifle
+ Shared its ammunition with the MG 34 and MG 42

WEAKNESSES

− Only 5 rounds before reloading
− Slower to fire than the Garand, and slower to work than the Lee-Enfield
− Long for fighting in houses and rubble
− Late-war rifles were more roughly finished

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

1935 Adopted by the German armed forces.

1937 on Laminated wooden stocks begin to replace solid walnut.

1944–45 Simplified wartime rifles with fewer machined parts.

IN ITALY

The German 1st Parachute Division held the town and the monastery hill at Monte Cassino from February to May 1944. On 15 March 1944 Allied bombers and some 746 guns flattened the town, yet the paratroopers who survived came up out of the cellars and rubble and stopped the New Zealand attack, while craters and debris blocked the New Zealand tanks. In fighting like this, among ruins at a few metres' range, the German rifleman often worked as a sniper covering the machine guns.

Where it mattered: Monte Cassino — the town and the monastery · Ortona · Anzio

RIFLES & SMGS

SUB-MACHINE GUNS: THOMPSON, STEN AND MP 40

Short-range automatic weapons for close fighting — and the partisans' favourite

IN USE: Whole campaign · Stens dropped to Italian partisans from 1944

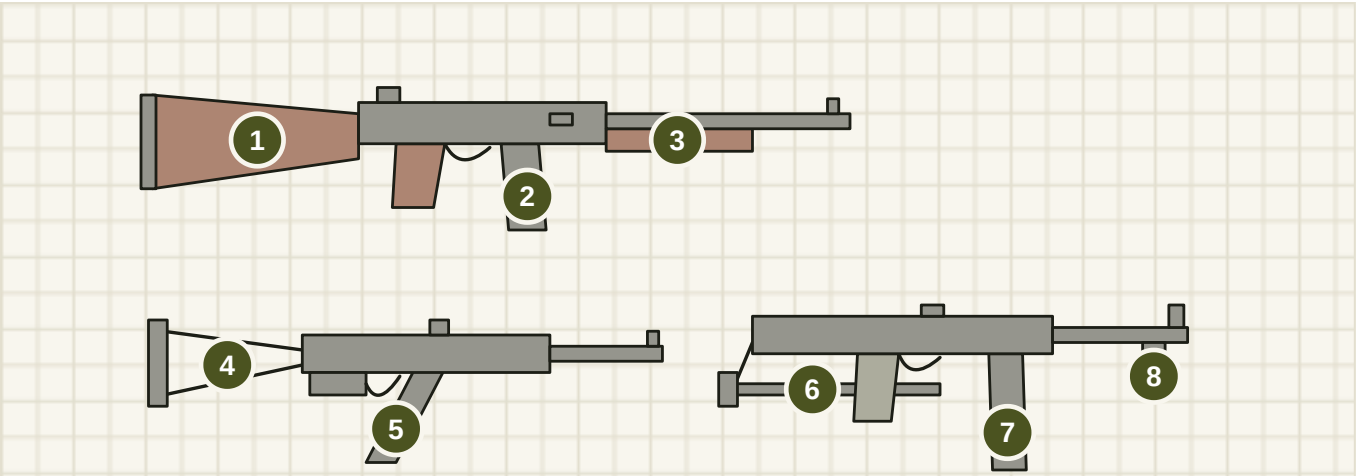


Fig. 4 · Sub-machine guns: Thompson, Sten and MP 40

Thompson (top) · Sten (left) · MP 40 (right) · not to scale

1. Thompson M1A1: wooden butt, heavy machined steel
2. 20- or 30-round box magazine (.45)
3. Plain barrel of the simplified M1A1
4. Sten Mk II: skeleton stock and a simple steel tube
5. 32-round magazine, fitted sideways on the left (drawn in perspective)
6. MP 40: folding steel stock (shown folded)
7. 32-round magazine (9 mm)
8. Bar under the barrel, for resting on vehicle sides

THOMPSON M1A1	.45 ACP; 20- or 30-round box; about 4.5 kg empty; 700–800 rounds a minute
STEN MK II	9 mm; 32-round side magazine; 3.2 kg; 500–600 rounds a minute
MP 40	9 mm; 32-round magazine; about 4 kg; 500–550 rounds a minute
EFFECTIVE RANGE	best under 100 m; about 60–200 m depending on weapon and source
BUILT	Thompson about 1.7 million in all; Sten about 4 million; MP 40 about 1.1 million

Sub-machine guns fired pistol cartridges automatically: no use at long range, but ideal in streets, houses and woods. The American Thompson was heavy and beautifully made. The British Sten was the opposite — a steel tube, a spring and a magazine that cost only a few pounds to make. The German MP 40, all steel and plastic with a folding stock, was carried by section leaders and paratroopers; Allied soldiers called it the “Schmeisser”, although Hugo Schmeisser did not design it.

STRENGTHS

+ Automatic fire at close quarters, in houses and ruins
+ Short and handy
+ Sten: cheap, simple and easy to hide — ideal for partisans

WEAKNESSES

− Short range and poor accuracy beyond it
− Thompson: heavy, and so was its ammunition
− Sten: could jam, and early ones could fire if dropped
− MP 40: its magazine was a weak point, especially if used as a hand-grip

+ Sten and MP 40 used the same 9 mm round, so captured ammunition could be used

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

1942 Thompson M1 (April) and M1A1: simpler and cheaper, box magazines only.

1942 Sten Mk II becomes the commonest version: about 2 million made.

1944–45 Allied air drops arm Italian partisans in the north, with Stens among the most common weapons.

IN ITALY

From 1944 the Allies parachuted weapons to the Italian partisans in the mountains of the north, and the Sten — cheap, light and simple — was among the most common. In the general insurrection that began on 24–25 April 1945, as the German front collapsed, partisans rose in Genoa, Milan, Turin and other cities, and Stens were a familiar sight among their weapons.

Where it mattered: Ortona · Monte Cassino · the partisan rising in the north, April 1945

MACHINE GUNS

BREN LIGHT MACHINE GUN

The backbone of every British and Commonwealth infantry section

IN USE: Whole campaign

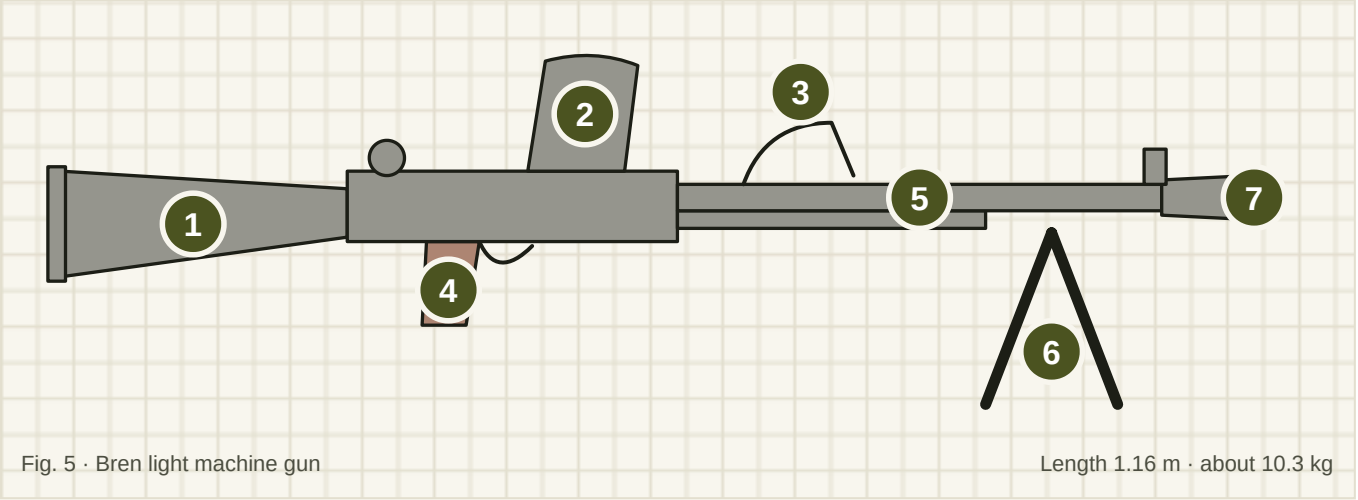


Fig. 5 · Bren light machine gun

Length 1.16 m · about 10.3 kg

1. Butt
2. Curved 30-round magazine on top (rimmed .303 rounds)
3. Carrying handle, also used for a quick barrel change
4. Pistol grip and trigger
5. Barrel, with the gas cylinder below it
6. Bipod
7. Conical flash hider

CALIBRE	.303 British
ACTION	Gas-operated, automatic, air-cooled
FEED	30-round curved box on top (usually loaded with 27–28)
WEIGHT	about 10.3 kg
LENGTH	1.16 m

RATE OF FIRE	500–520 rounds a minute; about 120 a minute in practice
EFFECTIVE RANGE	about 550 m (600 yd)
CREW	2: gunner, and a No. 2 with spare barrel and magazines

A British version of the Czechoslovak ZB vz. 26 — the name joins Brno, where it was designed, and Enfield, where it was made. Light enough for one man to carry, very accurate and easy to keep working, it gave every section its own machine gun: the riflemen's task was largely to move and protect it. When the barrel got hot it could be changed in seconds using the carrying handle. It also rode on the tracked Universal Carrier, often called the “Bren carrier”.

STRENGTHS

+ Very accurate: often used like a rapid-fire rifle
+ Reliable and simple to strip and clean
+ Quick barrel change
+ Same .303 ammunition as the rifle

WEAKNESSES

− Small magazine: only about 28 rounds before changing
− Much lower rate of fire than the German MG 42
− Magazines were heavy for the section to carry
− The top magazine meant the sights had to be offset to the left

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

1937 Bren Mk I in production at Enfield; the John Inglis plant in Toronto receives a Canadian contract in 1938.

1941 Mk II: simpler and cheaper to make.

1943–45 In Italy the infantry section fights around a single Bren; every man carries magazines for it.

IN ITALY

On the night of 13–14 July 1943 the British 1st Parachute Brigade dropped in Sicily to seize the Primosole Bridge over the Simeto, the gateway to the Catania plain. The drop was badly scattered and fewer than one man in six reached the bridge (about 295 of 1,856) — yet they took it, and held it with Brens, rifles and a few support weapons against German paratroopers who had arrived nearby only hours earlier. Forced back as their ammunition ran low, they were relieved by the Durham Light Infantry, who took the bridge for good on 16 July.

Where it mattered: Primosole Bridge · Ortona · Monte Cassino · Coriano Ridge

MACHINE GUNS

BROWNING AUTOMATIC RIFLE (BAR) M1918A2

The automatic weapon of the American rifle squad

IN USE: Whole campaign · M1918A2 approved in 1938

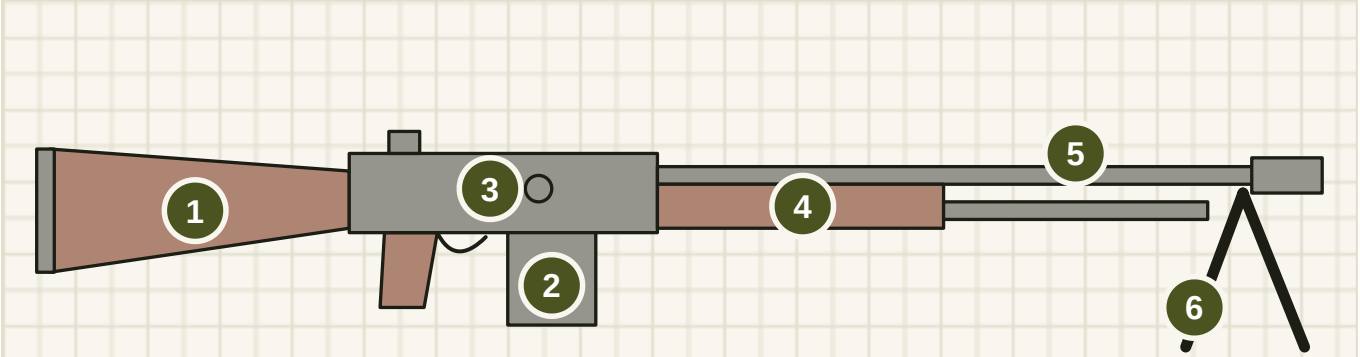


Fig. 6 · Browning Automatic Rifle (BAR) M1918A2 — Length 1.21 m · about 8.8 kg

1. Wooden butt
2. 20-round box magazine
3. Selector: slow or fast automatic fire
4. Wooden fore-end
5. Barrel (with gas cylinder below)
6. Bipod at the muzzle

CALIBRE	.30-06 Springfield
ACTION	Gas-operated; automatic only, at two rates
MAGAZINE	20-round box
WEIGHT	about 8.8 kg
LENGTH	1.21 m
RATE OF FIRE	slow 300–450 or fast 500–650 rounds a minute
CREW	gunner, plus an assistant and an ammunition bearer

A First World War design reworked as the automatic weapon of the 12-man American rifle squad. It was heavy for a rifle and light for a machine gun: it had a bipod, but only a 20-round magazine and no quick-change barrel, so it was fired in short bursts. American squads made up the difference with the volume of fire from their semi-automatic Garands.

STRENGTHS

+ Portable automatic fire for every rifle squad
+ Powerful, accurate .30-06 round
+ Could be fired on the move, from the hip
+ Rugged and dependable

WEAKNESSES

− Only 20 rounds per magazine
− No quick-change barrel: it overheated in long firing
− Heavy — almost 9 kg with its bipod
− Far lower sustained fire than the German MG 42

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

1918 The original BAR reaches France in the last months of the First World War.

1938 M1918A2 approved: bipod and two rates of automatic fire, no single shots.

1943–45 Squads often carry more than one BAR, and many gunners take off the heavy bipod.

IN ITALY

Near Altavilla, above the Salerno beachhead, on 13 September 1943, Corporal Charles E. Kelly of the 143rd Infantry, 36th Division, helped defend a building used as an ammunition store. He fired an automatic rifle until it overheated and could no longer be used; then he pulled the pins on 60 mm mortar bombs and threw them like grenades, and finally fired a bazooka from a window to cover his comrades' withdrawal. The press called him “Commando” Kelly, and he received the Medal of Honor.

Where it mattered: Altavilla — the Salerno beachhead · San Pietro Infine · Anzio

MACHINE GUNS

BROWNING M1919A4 MACHINE GUN

The American infantry's air-cooled .30-calibre machine gun

IN USE: Whole campaign

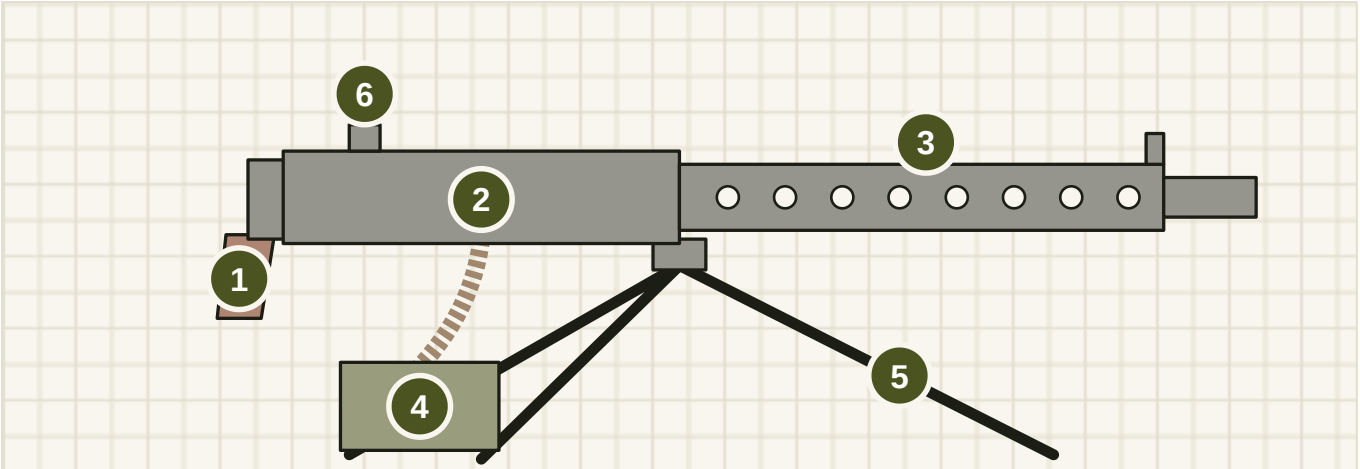


Fig. 7 · Browning M1919A4 machine gun

Gun about 14 kg · tripod about 6.4 kg

1. Pistol grip and trigger
2. Receiver
3. Perforated barrel jacket: the gun was cooled by air
4. 250-round cloth belt in its ammunition box
5. Low M2 tripod
6. Rear sight

CALIBRE	.30-06 Springfield
ACTION	Recoil-operated, automatic, air-cooled
FEED	250-round cloth belt
WEIGHT	gun about 14 kg; M2 tripod about 6.4 kg
LENGTH	about 0.96 m
RATE OF FIRE	400–600 rounds a minute
CREW	gunner, assistant and ammunition bearers

The light machine gun of American infantry companies, and also the machine gun of the Sherman tank, jeeps and trucks. Unlike the older water-cooled M1917, it had a perforated steel jacket that let air cool the barrel. On its low tripod it was steady and accurate, but it was heavy to carry up mountains and could not match the German MG 42's rate of fire.

STRENGTHS

+ Reliable and accurate on its tripod
+ Belt feed: long bursts without stopping
+ Same cartridge as the Garand and the BAR
+ Used everywhere: on tripods, jeeps, trucks and tanks

WEAKNESSES

− Heavy to carry in the mountains
− Slow barrel change, needing gloves and time
− Much lower rate of fire than the MG 42
− Slow into action because of the tripod

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

1919 Browning's air-cooled machine gun, first meant for tanks.

1930s M1919A4 with a heavier barrel becomes the infantry version.

1943–44 M1919A6 with bipod, butt and carrying handle — a lighter squad gun.

IN ITALY

On 20–22 January 1944 the 36th Division tried to cross the Rapido River below Cassino, at night and in fog. Boats were wrecked or lost, engineers could not build bridges under fire, and the men who reached the far bank were pinned among mines and the machine guns of the 15th Panzergrenadier Division, while American machine guns on the near bank tried to cover them. The division lost somewhere between about 1,700 and 2,100 men in two days (figures vary), in one of the most bitterly debated American actions of the war.

Where it mattered: Rapido River · Anzio · San Pietro Infine · the Gothic Line

MACHINE GUNS

MG 42 MACHINE GUN (AND MG 34)

“Hitler's buzzsaw”: the fastest-firing machine gun of the war

IN USE: Whole campaign · MG 42 since 1942, alongside the older MG 34

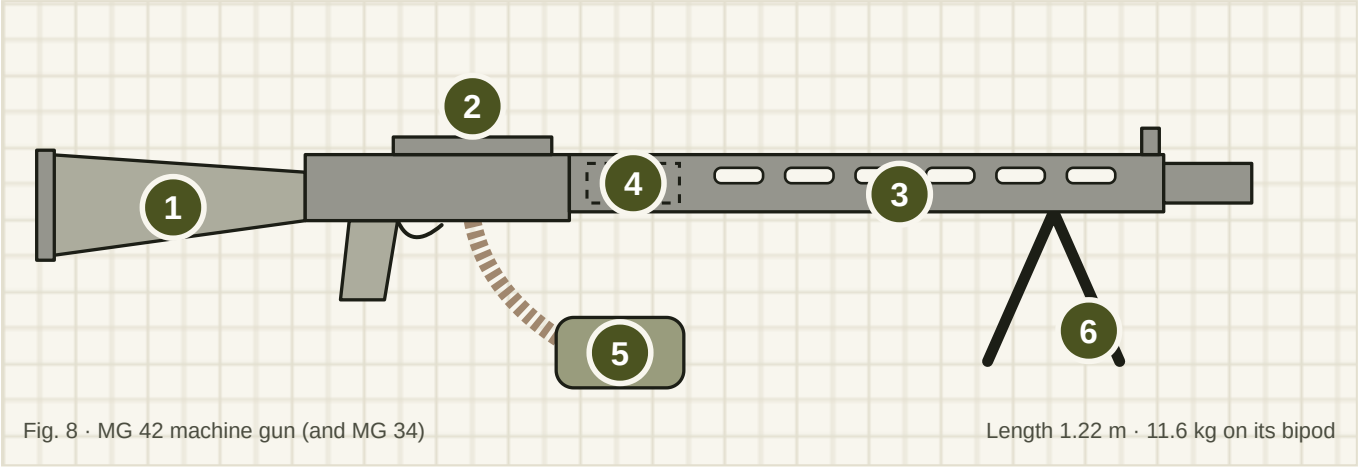


Fig. 8 · MG 42 machine gun (and MG 34)

Length 1.22 m · 11.6 kg on its bipod

1. Butt
2. Feed cover: the belt runs through here
3. Square barrel jacket with cooling slots
4. Hatch for changing the barrel in seconds
5. 50-round belt drum (or long belts from boxes)
6. Bipod (a tripod could be fitted for long range)

CALIBRE	7.92 × 57 mm Mauser

ACTION	Recoil-operated, automatic, air-cooled
FEED	50-round belts, linked into longer belts; 50-round drum
WEIGHT	11.6 kg; Lafette 42 tripod 20.5 kg
LENGTH	1.22 m
RATE OF FIRE	about 1,200 rounds a minute (900–1,500 depending on the bolt)
BARREL CHANGE	under 10 seconds
BUILT	about 424,000 (1942–45)

Designed for mass production from stamped steel, the MG 42 was the heart of the German infantry section, and much of the riflemen's work was to support it. Its extraordinary rate of fire made a sound like tearing cloth. On its bipod it went forward with the section; on a heavy tripod with a telescopic sight it could fire accurately at long range. A hot barrel was swapped in seconds through a hatch in the side of the jacket. The older MG 34 did the same job and remained in use throughout the campaign.

STRENGTHS

+ Enormous rate of fire
+ Very fast barrel change
+ Cheap and quick to make
+ Light enough for one man, steady enough on a tripod for long-range fire

WEAKNESSES

− Used ammunition at a huge rate: heavy loads for the crew
− Barrels overheated quickly and had to be changed often
− Hard to hold on target in long bursts from the bipod
− Its distinctive sound gave away its position

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

1934 MG 34: the first “general-purpose” machine gun, still used throughout the war.

May 1942 MG 42 first used in action, in North Africa.

1942–45 The Lafette 42 tripod turns it into a long-range heavy machine gun.

IN ITALY

At San Pietro Infine, on the Winter Line, the 36th Division attacked from 8 to 17 December 1943 across terraced hillsides covered by the machine guns and mortars of the 29th Panzergrenadier Division. On 15 December 16 Sherman tanks tried to push up the narrow road to the village; only four came back, stopped by mines and anti-tank fire. John Huston filmed the fighting for his documentary “The Battle of San Pietro”; the ruins of the old village are now a memorial park.

Where it mattered: San Pietro Infine · Monte Cassino · Ortona · Anzio

ANTI-TANK & MORTARS

ANTI-TANK LAUNCHERS: BAZOOKA, PIAT AND PANZERSCHRECK

The infantryman's answer to a tank — at very short range

IN USE: Bazooka and PIAT: whole campaign · Panzerschreck: from about 1944 (approximate)

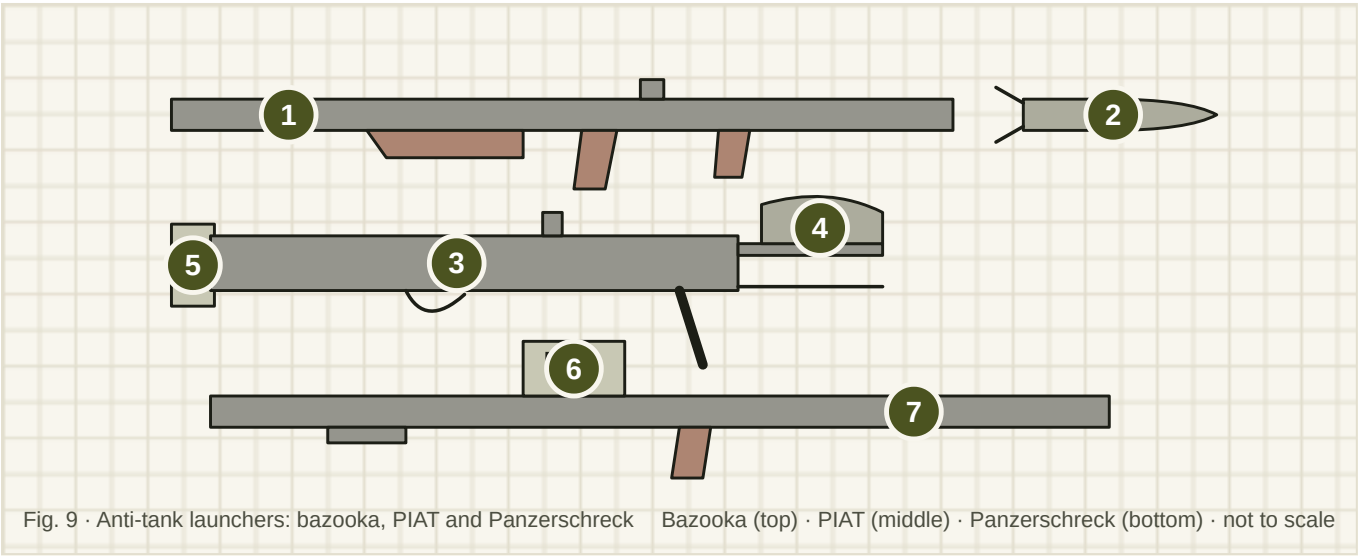


Fig. 9 · Anti-tank launchers: bazooka, PIAT and Panzerschreck Bazooka (top) · PIAT (middle) · Panzerschreck (bottom) · not to scale

1. Bazooka M1A1 (US): 60 mm rocket from an open tube
2. Rocket with shaped-charge warhead
3. PIAT (British): spring-and-cartridge launcher, no back-blast
4. Open trough that holds the bomb
5. Padded butt: the recoil was fierce
6. Panzerschreck (German): 88 mm, with a blast shield
7. Tube, open at both ends

BAZOOKA M1A1	60 mm rocket; launcher about 5.8 kg, 1.38 m; about 76 mm of armour; about 140 m (150 yd) claimed range
PIAT	bomb about 1.1 kg (2.5 lb); launcher about 14.5 kg, 0.99 m; about 105 m against tanks, about 320 m against buildings; up to about 100 mm of armour in theory
PANZERSCHRECK	88 mm rocket; about 11 kg with shield, 1.64 m; about 150 m; roughly 160–230 mm of armour (sources differ)
CREW	2: firer and loader

All three used a shaped-charge warhead, which focuses its blast into a jet that punches through armour. The American bazooka fired a small rocket from an open tube. The British PIAT worked differently: a powerful spring threw the bomb forward and a small cartridge in its tail finished the job, so there was no back-blast and it could be fired from inside a room — but the spring was very hard to cock. The German Panzerschreck, a larger copy of captured bazookas, hit much harder, but its rocket was still burning as it left the tube, so the firer needed the shield or a mask and gloves.

STRENGTHS

+ Let infantry fight tanks at close range
+ PIAT: no back-blast, so it could be fired from buildings — and was used to blow “mouse-holes” through walls

WEAKNESSES

− Very short range: the firer had to let the tank come close
− Bazooka and Panzerschreck back-blast gave away the position and made firing indoors dangerous

+ Panzerschreck: enough penetration for any Allied tank
+ All three were effective against houses and bunkers
– PIAT: heavy, hard to cock, and its bomb did not always go off
– Hard to hit a moving tank with a slow projectile

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

Nov 1942 Bazooka first in action in North Africa; the improved M1A1 fights in Sicily.

Mar 1943 PIAT first used, in Tunisia.

1943–44 Panzerschreck, based on captured bazookas, enters German service; the RPzB 54 adds a shield.

1944 Bazooka M9, with a longer tube that comes apart in two halves.

IN ITALY

On 16 May 1944, in the final battle for the Gustav Line near Cassino, German tanks counter-attacked a company of the 2nd Lancashire Fusiliers. Fusilier Frank Jefferson picked up a PIAT, ran forward under fire and knocked out the leading tank at close range; the second withdrew. Five months later, on the night of 21–22 October 1944, Private Ernest “Smokey” Smith of the Seaforth Highlanders of Canada used a PIAT to destroy a Panther tank while defending a bridgehead over the Savio River. Both men received the Victoria Cross. In Sicily, American bazookas had already been used against German tanks, reportedly including a Tiger.

Where it mattered: Monte Cassino — the Gustav Line · Savio River · Ortona · Gela

ANTI-TANK & MORTARS

NEBELWERFER ROCKET LAUNCHERS

“Moaning Minnie” to the British,
“Screaming Mimi” to the Americans

IN USE: Whole campaign · Werfer-Regiment 71 from Sicily to the end

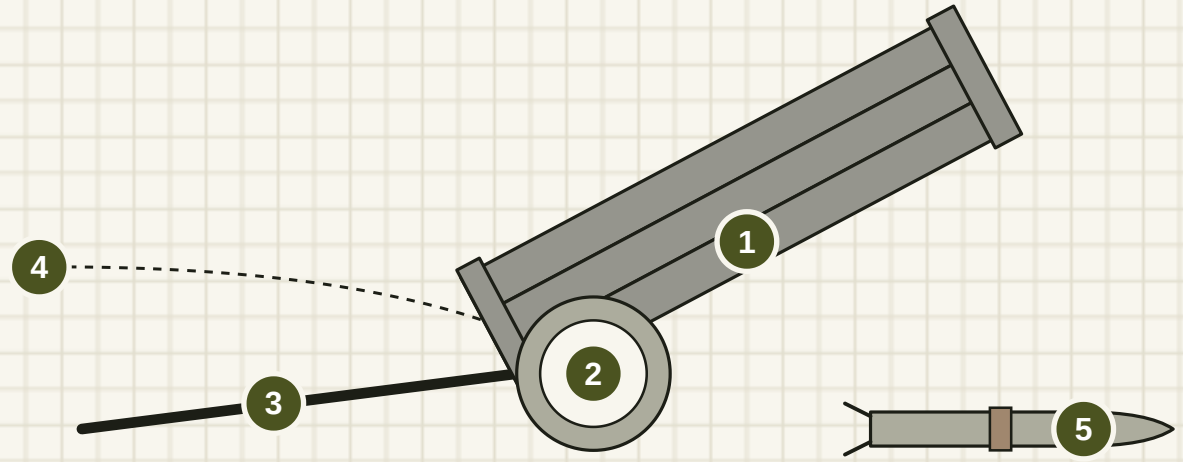


Fig. 10 · Nebelwerfer rocket launchers

15 cm Nebelwerfer 41 · not to scale

1. Six launch tubes, fired one after another
2. Two-wheeled carriage
3. Trail
4. Fired electrically, with the crew under cover
5. 15 cm rocket: motor in front, warhead behind

MODEL	15 cm Nebelwerfer 41 (six tubes); also the five-tube 21 cm Nebelwerfer 42
ROCKET	15 cm: about 32 kg (high explosive), 2.5 kg of explosive
RANGE	15 cm: up to 6,900 m; 21 cm: up to 7,850 m
WEIGHT	15 cm launcher: about 770 kg loaded
FIRING	electrically, tube by tube, from cover a few seconds apart
CREW	5

“Nebelwerfer” means “smoke launcher” — a cover name from the days when German rockets were officially for smoke screens. A launcher could put six rockets in the air within seconds, and a whole battery firing together drenched an area with blast. Rockets were less accurate than shells, but their sudden arrival was terrifying, and their howl in flight gave them their nicknames. The flash and smoke trails gave the launch site away, so crews fired and moved.

STRENGTHS

+ Sudden, concentrated blast over a wide area
+ Cheaper and lighter than guns of similar effect
+ Terrifying noise
+ Easy to move on its light carriage

WEAKNESSES

− Less accurate than artillery
− Smoke trails and dust revealed the launch site
− Slow to reload
− Rockets were bulky to supply

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

1941 15 cm Nebelwerfer 41 enters service.

1942 21 cm Nebelwerfer 42, five tubes: longer range, bigger warhead.

1943–45 Werfer-Regiment 71 fights in Sicily and then on the Italian mainland to the end of the war.

IN ITALY

At Anzio in February 1944, American troops waiting for the great German counter-offensive listened in the night for the sound of artillery and Nebelwerfer fire, the warning that an attack was coming; it came on 16 February. The rockets' howl became part of life in the beachhead, as it was on the Gustav Line at Cassino and later in the Apennines.

Where it mattered: Anzio · Monte Cassino · Sicily

ARTILLERY

8.8 CM FLAK 18/36/37 — “THE 88”

An anti-aircraft gun that became the most feared anti-tank gun of the war

IN USE: Whole campaign

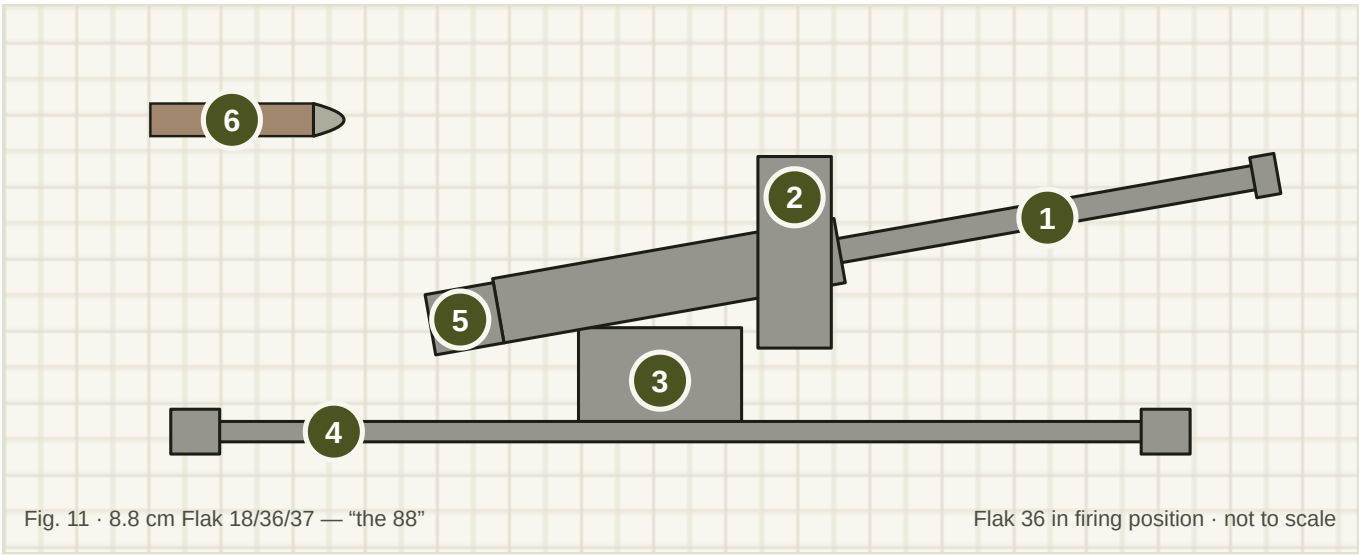


Fig. 11 · 8.8 cm Flak 18/36/37 — “the 88” Flak 36 in firing position · not to scale

1. 8.8 cm barrel (L/56)
2. Shield
3. Pedestal: it could turn a full circle
4. Cross-shaped platform, levelled on jacks
5. Breech
6. Round: shell of about 9–9.4 kg

CALIBRE	88 mm
SHELL	about 9–9.4 kg (high explosive)
MUZZLE VELOCITY	about 820–840 m/s
RATE OF FIRE	15–20 rounds a minute
RANGE	about 14,800 m against ground targets; effective ceiling about 8,000 m
WEIGHT IN ACTION	about 5–7.4 t, depending on model and source
CREW	up to 10

Designed to shoot down aircraft, the 88 fired a heavy shell very fast and very flat — which made it deadly against tanks at ranges where they could barely reply. It was a big, tall gun and hard to hide, so in Italy it was often dug in. The dedicated Pak 43 anti-tank gun and the Tiger's gun used the same 88 mm calibre, and Allied soldiers tended to call any German high-velocity gun “an 88”.

STRENGTHS

+ Flat trajectory and long reach against tanks
+ Two roles: aircraft and ground targets
+ Fast-firing for its size
+ Heavy, effective high-explosive shell

WEAKNESSES

− Tall and hard to conceal
− Heavy: needed a tractor and time to set up
− Crew exposed behind a thin shield
− Vulnerable to artillery once spotted

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

1933 Flak 18 enters service.

1936–37 Flak 36 and Flak 37: improved carriage and fire control.

1943–45 The Pak 43 anti-tank gun and the Tiger's KwK 36 use the same 88 mm calibre.

IN ITALY

When VI Corps landed at Anzio in January 1944, German long-range 88 mm and 170 mm batteries soon began dropping shells on the ships lying off shore, and nowhere in the flat beachhead was out of range. In the Liri valley and at Cassino, the 88's long, flat reach made every Allied advance along a road or across open ground costly.

Where it mattered: Anzio · Liri Valley · Monte Cassino

ARTILLERY

ORDNANCE QF 25-POUNDER

The field gun of British and Commonwealth artillery

IN USE: Whole campaign

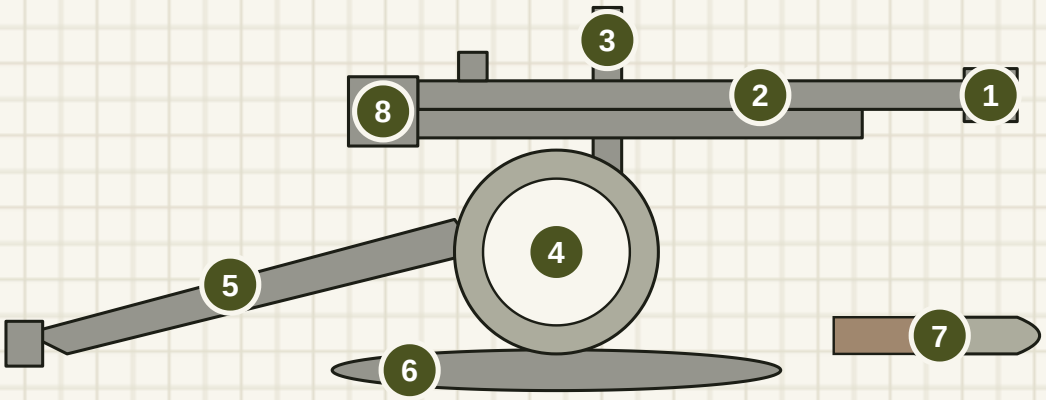


Fig. 12 · Ordnance QF 25-pounder

Calibre 87.6 mm · not to scale

1. Muzzle brake
2. 87.6 mm barrel
3. Shield
4. Wheel
5. Box trail
6. Round firing platform: the gun could be swung right round
7. Shell and brass cartridge, loaded separately
8. Breech

CALIBRE	87.6 mm (3.45 in)
SHELL	about 11.3–11.5 kg (25 lb) high explosive; also smoke and armour-piercing
RANGE	about 12,250 m
RATE OF FIRE	6–8 rounds a minute at the fastest rate
WEIGHT	about 1.6 t
CREW	6
BUILT	over 13,000

Towed by a “Quad” tractor, the 25-pounder could fire like a field gun, with a flat trajectory, or lob its shells high like a howitzer. Its round firing platform, lowered under the wheels, let the crew swing it quickly in any direction. In Italy the field regiments of Eighth Army fired huge barrages to open each offensive and answered calls for fire from the infantry day and night.

STRENGTHS

+ Versatile: gun and howitzer in one
+ Quick into action, and quick to turn on its platform
+ Rugged, reliable and accurate
+ Good rate of fire

WEAKNESSES

− Lighter shell than the American 105 mm or the German 10.5 cm
− Limited effect on concrete and strong stone buildings
− Heavy to manhandle along mountain tracks
− Barrels wore out under constant firing

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

1940 The 25-pounder Mk II on its Mk I carriage becomes standard.

1942 on Muzzle brake added so it could fire armour-piercing shot with a “super” charge.

1943–45 Also used in Italy by New Zealand, South African, Indian and Polish gunners, and by Italian co-belligerent forces.

IN ITALY

At 23:00 on 11 May 1944 more than 1,600 Allied guns opened fire along the Gustav Line from Cassino to the sea. It was the start of Operation Diadem, the offensive that finally broke the line at Cassino and led to the fall of Rome on 4 June. Many of the guns in that barrage were British and Commonwealth 25-pounders.

Where it mattered: Monte Cassino — Operation Diadem · Ortona · Coriano Ridge · Argenta Gap

ARTILLERY

M2A1 105 MM HOWITZER

The workhorse of American divisional artillery

IN USE: Whole campaign

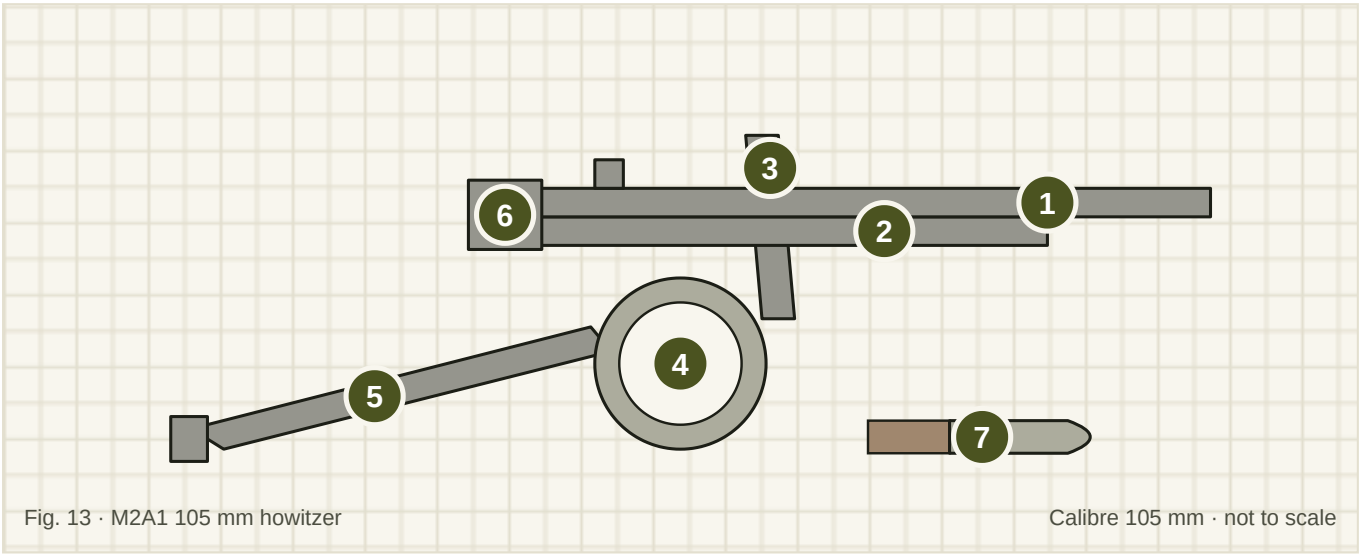


Fig. 13 · M2A1 105 mm howitzer

Calibre 105 mm · not to scale

1. 105 mm barrel
2. Recoil mechanism under the barrel
3. Shield
4. Wheel on a pneumatic tyre
5. Split trail: the two legs spread apart to fire
6. Breech
7. Semi-fixed round: shell in a brass case

CALIBRE	105 mm
SHELL	about 15 kg high explosive (complete round about 19 kg)
RANGE	about 11,270 m
WEIGHT	about 2.26 t
RATE OF FIRE	about 2–4 rounds a minute sustained, more for short periods
CREW	about 8
BUILT	about 8,500 by August 1945

Each US infantry division had three battalions of 105 mm howitzers and one of 155s. The ammunition was “semi-fixed”: the crew could remove bags of propellant from the brass case to change the range. With radios, forward observers and fire-direction centres, American artillery could bring many battalions onto a single target within minutes, and time the shells to arrive together.

STRENGTHS

+ Heavy, effective shell
+ Superb fire control: many guns quickly massed on one target
+ Reliable and easy to maintain
+ Also mounted on the M7 “Priest” self-propelled carriage

WEAKNESSES

− Heavy to move in mud and mountains
− Shorter range than longer-barrelled guns
− Huge ammunition needs
− Slower to swing onto a new direction than the 25-pounder on its platform

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

1940 M2A1 standardised.

1942 M7 Priest: the howitzer on a self-propelled tracked chassis.

1942–45 About 8,500 built by August 1945.

IN ITALY

In the defence of the Anzio beachhead, VI Corps had 432 artillery pieces by mid-February 1944, not counting the infantry's own cannon companies, and by 14 February they were firing about 20,000 rounds a day. During the German offensive of 16–20 February, according to the US Army's official account, VI Corps fired back fifteen to twenty shells for every one the Germans fired.

Where it mattered: Anzio · Salerno · Rapido River · the Gothic Line

ARTILLERY

K5 RAILWAY GUN — “ANZIO ANNIE”

Two German 28 cm railway guns, “Robert” and “Leopold”, that shelled the Anzio beachhead

IN USE: Anzio, February–May 1944

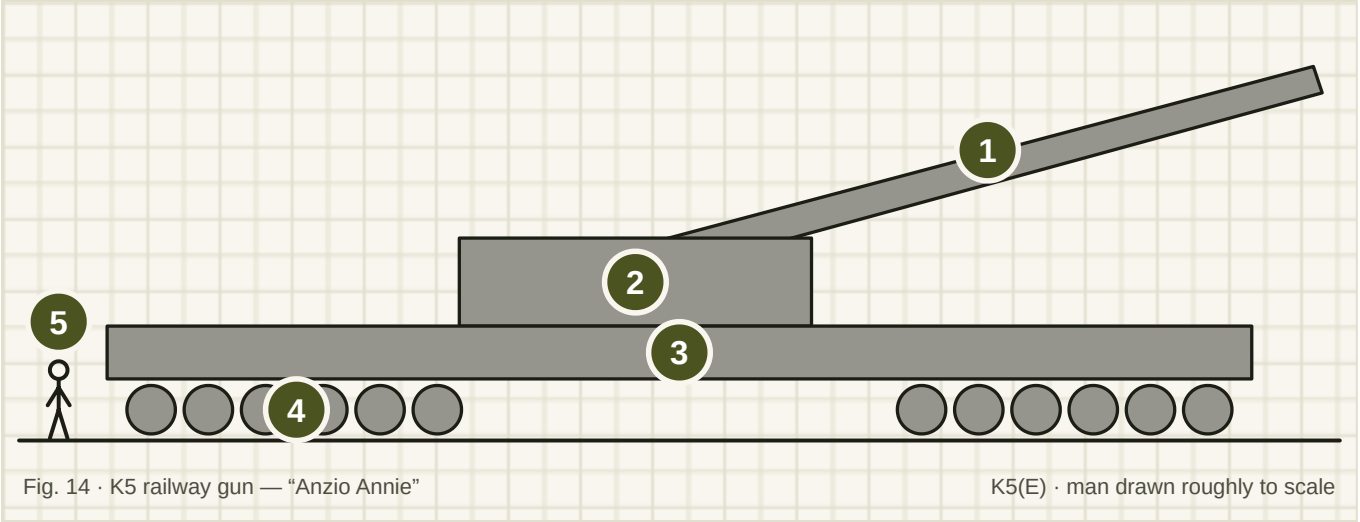


Fig. 14 · K5 railway gun — “Anzio Annie” K5(E) · man drawn roughly to scale

1. 28 cm barrel, about 21 m (70 ft) long
2. Gun mount on the railway carriage
3. Carriage: 218 tonnes in all
4. Two sets of bogies run on the rails
5. A man, for scale

CALIBRE	283 mm (known as 28 cm)
WEIGHT	218 t
BARREL	about 21 m (70 ft), 116 t
SHELL	about 243–255 kg (sources differ)
RANGE	about 62–64 km with standard shells
MUZZLE VELOCITY	about 1,120 m/s

A huge gun on a railway carriage, the K5 could throw a quarter-tonne shell more than 60 km. At Anzio the two guns fired from the Alban Hills on the whole beachhead — the port, beaches, dumps, hospitals and ships — and, according to most accounts, sheltered between shoots in railway tunnels, which made them very hard to find from the air. Allied soldiers named them “Anzio Annie” and “Anzio Express” after the sound of the shells rushing in.

STRENGTHS

+ Enormous range: nowhere in the beachhead was safe
+ Each shell could leave a crater big enough to swallow a Sherman tank, according to the US Army
+ Could hide in tunnels between shoots

WEAKNESSES

− Few shots per hour, and inaccurate at long range
− Tied to the railway: vulnerable when the lines were bombed
− Needed a large crew and supply train
− Could not escape once the railway was cut

+ Huge effect on morale

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

1930s Developed by Krupp as a long-range railway gun.

Feb 1944 “Robert” and “Leopold” brought to Italy to shell the Anzio beachhead.

7 Jun 1944 Both found on a railway siding at Civitavecchia, wrecked by their own crews.

1944–today A single gun assembled from the two went to Aberdeen Proving Ground (Maryland); since 2010 it has been with the US Army Ordnance collection at Fort Lee, Virginia (named Fort Gregg-Adams in 2023–25).

IN ITALY

In mid-May 1944, with the Allies about to break out of Anzio and Rome soon to fall, the crews ran the guns north along the coastal railway. They could get no further than Civitavecchia, where on 7 June 1944 the Allies found them on a siding, wrecked by their crews. The US Army shipped them home for testing, and the gun now on show in Virginia was assembled from the parts of both.

Where it mattered: Anzio · Nettuno · Civitavecchia

ARMOUR

M4 SHERMAN MEDIUM TANK

The Allied tank of the Italian campaign, used by almost every Allied army

IN USE: Whole campaign · 17-pounder Firefly in Italy from 1944

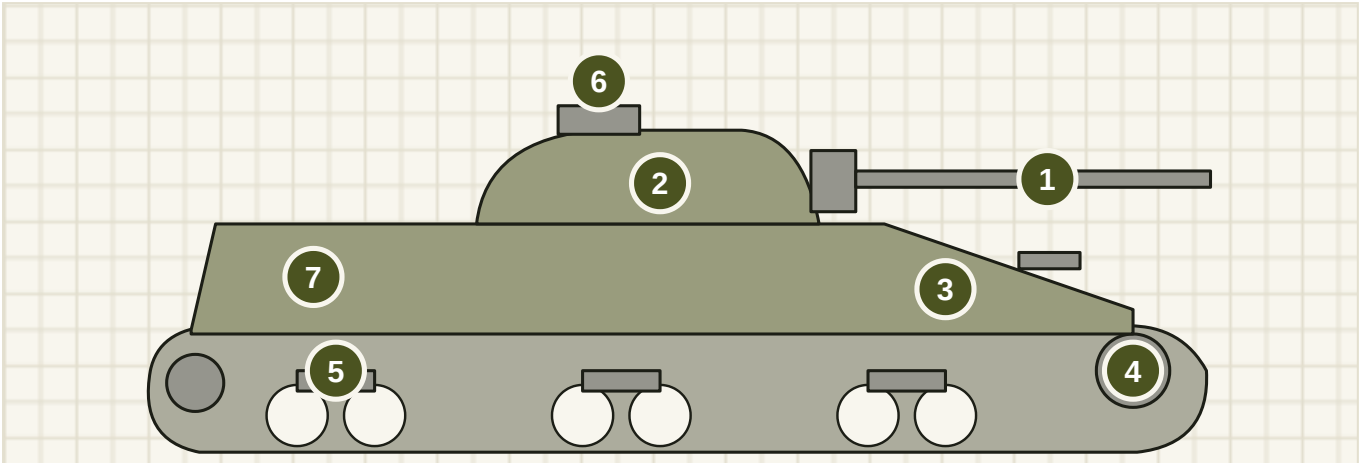


Fig. 15 · M4 Sherman medium tank

M4 with 75 mm gun · about 5.8 m long (hull)

1. 75 mm gun
2. Turret: armour up to about 76 mm at the front
3. Sloped front armour
4. Drive sprocket at the front
5. Bogie with two road wheels
6. Commander's hatch
7. Engine at the back

WEIGHT	about 30 t
CREW	5
MAIN GUN	75 mm M3; later 76 mm; British Firefly: 17-pounder

ARMOUR	about 51 mm on the sloped front hull; about 76 mm on the turret front
ENGINE	several types, petrol or diesel (e.g. radial petrol, twin diesels)
SPEED	about 38–40 km/h on roads
BUILT	about 49,000 (1942–45)

Reliable, easy to repair and built in enormous numbers, the Sherman equipped American, British, Canadian, New Zealand, South African and Polish armoured units in Italy. The country was bad for tanks — narrow roads, terraces, rivers, mud and mountains — and the Sherman often worked as mobile artillery for the infantry. Its 75 mm gun could not easily knock out a Tiger or Panther from the front, and early models caught fire easily when hit, a problem later reduced by armoured and “wet” ammunition stowage.

STRENGTHS

+ Reliable, and easy to maintain and repair in the field
+ Good high-explosive shell for supporting the infantry
+ Fast turret traverse: it often got the first shot
+ Built in huge numbers, so losses were quickly replaced

WEAKNESSES

− 75 mm gun too weak against Tiger and Panther front armour
− Tall, and early models caught fire easily
− Struggled on mountain roads, terraces and river banks
− Outranged by German guns in open country

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

1942 Shermans in action with the British at El Alamein.

1944 Sherman Firefly, with the British 17-pounder gun, reaches Italy.

1944 Versions with the 76 mm gun and “wet” ammunition stowage arrive.

IN ITALY

At Ortona in December 1943, Shermans of the Three Rivers Regiment fought alongside the Canadian infantry in the narrow streets. On the Gothic Line in September 1944, British and Canadian armour fought for Coriano Ridge, near Rimini, and the battles cost Eighth Army dearly: by late September its commander, General Leese, reported 210 tanks lost beyond repair.

Where it mattered: Ortona · Coriano Ridge · Liri Valley · Argenta Gap

ARMOUR

TIGER I HEAVY TANK

Few in number, but the most feared German tank in Italy

IN USE: Sicily, July–August 1943 · Anzio and the rest of the campaign from late January 1944

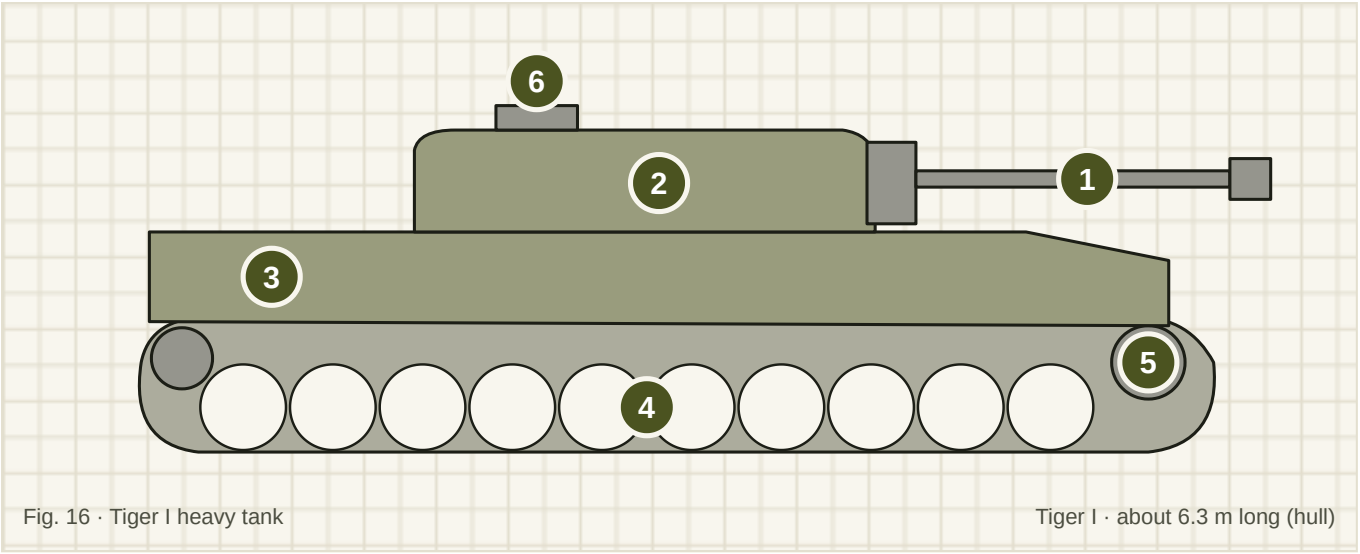


Fig. 16 · Tiger I heavy tank

Tiger I · about 6.3 m long (hull)

1. 8.8 cm gun, from the same family as the “88”
2. Turret: 100 mm of frontal armour
3. Thick, flat, almost vertical armour plates
4. Large overlapping road wheels
5. Drive sprocket at the front
6. Commander's cupola

WEIGHT	54–57 t
CREW	5
MAIN GUN	8.8 cm KwK 36 L/56
ARMOUR	100 mm on the hull and turret front
ENGINE	Maybach V-12 petrol, about 700 PS
SPEED	about 38–45 km/h on roads; 20–25 km/h cross-country
RANGE	about 195 km on roads
BUILT	1,347 (1942–44)

Only a few battalions of Tigers fought in Italy, but their thick front armour and powerful gun meant they could knock out a Sherman at long range and shrug off most return fire from the front. They were too heavy for many Italian bridges and roads, used a great deal of fuel and broke down often: more were lost to breakdowns, and to their own crews blowing them up during retreats, than to enemy fire.

STRENGTHS

+ Powerful, accurate 88 mm gun
+ Very thick front armour
+ Excellent sights
+ Huge effect on Allied morale

WEAKNESSES

− Mechanically unreliable and hard to recover
− Too heavy for many Italian bridges and mountain roads
− Very thirsty
− Slow turret traverse; expensive and few in number

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

Jul 1943 Sicily: the 2nd Company of heavy tank battalion 504 (s.Pz.Abt. 504), 17 Tigers, with the Hermann Göring Division.

Jan–Feb 1944 Anzio: Panzer-Kompanie Meyer (8 Tigers) from 26 January, then s.Pz.Abt. 508 with about 45 Tigers, in action from mid-February.

Jun 1944–May 1945 s.Pz.Abt. 504 returns to Italy; in February 1945 it takes over the last 15–17 Tigers of 508 (sources differ) and fights on until the surrender.

IN ITALY

On 11–12 July 1943 the Tigers of s.Pz.Abt. 504 joined the Hermann Göring Division's counter-attack against the American beachhead at Gela. Stopped by naval gunfire, artillery and bazookas, the unit lost about ten Tigers in two days, many of them broken down or abandoned; of the 17, only one was ferried back across the Strait of Messina in August. At Anzio, s.Pz.Abt. 508 lost 22 Tigers in three days during the Allied breakout of 23–25 May 1944 — only one of them, by most accounts, to enemy action.

Where it mattered: Gela · Anzio · Cisterna · the Gothic Line

MINES & ENGINEERS

GOLIATH REMOTE-CONTROLLED DEMOLITION VEHICLE

A miniature tracked bomb, steered by cable

IN USE: Anzio, February–April 1944

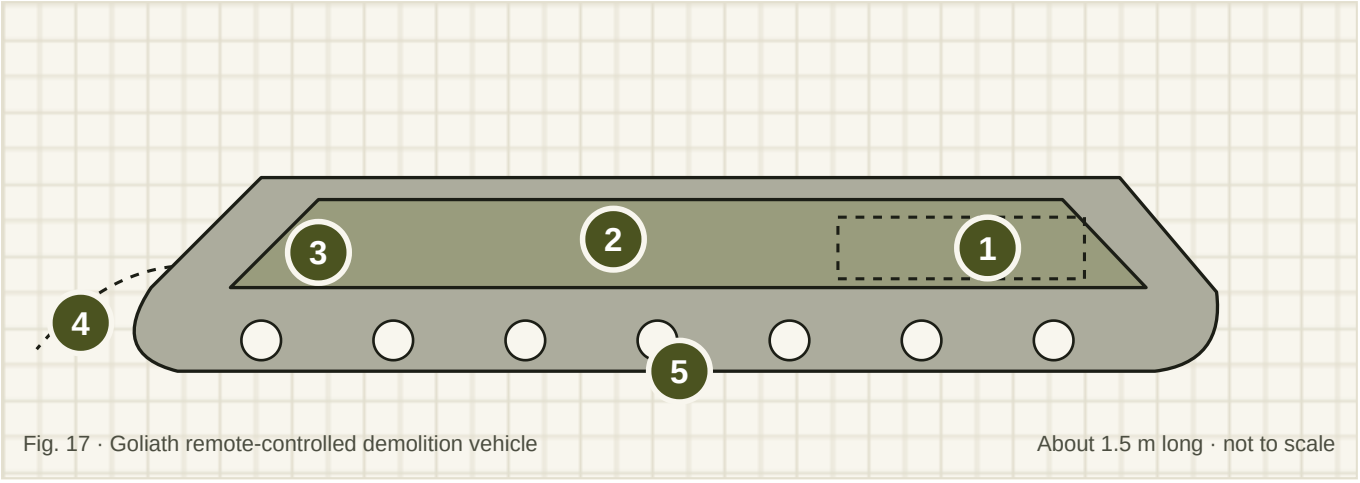


Fig. 17 · Goliath remote-controlled demolition vehicle

About 1.5 m long · not to scale

1. Front compartment: 60–100 kg of explosive
2. Engine or electric motors in the middle
3. Cable drum at the back
4. Control cable, up to about 650 m
5. Tracks run right round the body

TYPES	Sd.Kfz. 302 (electric motors) and Sd.Kfz. 303 (petrol engine)
EXPLOSIVE	60 kg (302); 60 or 100 kg (303)
LENGTH	about 1.5 m
WEIGHT	about 370 kg (302)
SPEED	about 6 km/h (302)

CONTROL	by wire, up to about 650 m
BUILT	7,564 of all types

Goliath was a small, low tracked vehicle carrying a large explosive charge. An operator steered it by cable from a hand-held control box, drove it up to a bunker, an obstacle or a tank, and set it off. It was meant to blast gaps in minefields, wire and fortifications. It could be used only once.

STRENGTHS

+ No crew at risk
+ Large charge for its size
+ Small, low target
+ Could blast through obstacles

WEAKNESSES

− Very slow
− The control cable was easily cut
− Thin armour: bullets and shell splinters could stop it
− Very low: bogged down easily in mud

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

1942 Goliath first used in action.

1942–44 The electric Sd.Kfz. 302 is replaced by the petrol-engined 303: longer range and a bigger charge.

Feb and Apr 1944 Used at Anzio.

IN ITALY

In the great German attack on the Anzio beachhead on 16 February 1944, Goliaths were sent forward to blast gaps in the Allied line. The US Army's history of the battle calls the new “secret weapon” a dud: all 13 bogged down, Allied artillery destroyed three and the Germans recovered the other ten. Goliaths were tried again at Anzio in April.

Where it mattered: Anzio

MINES & ENGINEERS

MINES: TELLER, S-MINE AND SCHÜ-MINE

Hidden in roads, verges, riverbanks and doorways the length of Italy

IN USE: Whole campaign · above all in the Gustav, Hitler and Gothic Lines and on every German withdrawal

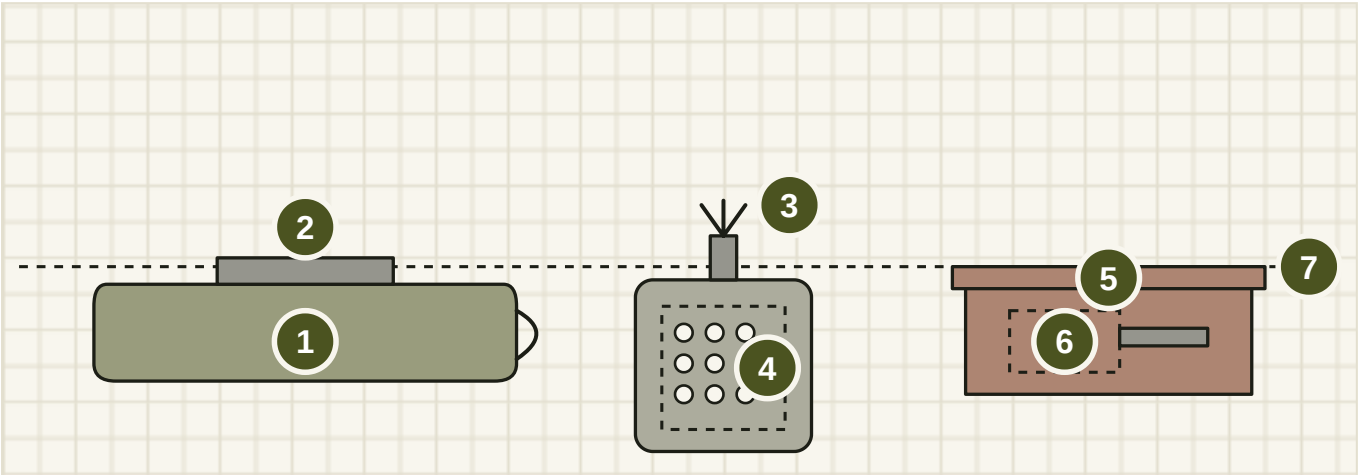


Fig. 18 · Mines: Teller, S-mine and Schü-mine

Tellermine (left) · S-mine (centre) · Schü-mine 42 (right) · not to scale

1. Teller mine: about 5.5 kg of TNT, against vehicles
2. Pressure plate: needs a vehicle's weight to fire
3. S-mine: only the three-pronged fuze shows above the ground
4. Inner canister packed with steel balls
5. Schü-mine: a wooden box that detectors could barely find
6. 200 g charge
7. Ground level

TELLERMINE 42	anti-tank; 9.1 kg; 5.5 kg of TNT or amatol; 100–180 kg of pressure to fire; wells for anti-handling fuzes
S-MINE	anti-personnel “bounding” mine; about 4.1 kg; about 360 steel balls; jumps 0.9–1.5 m before bursting; lethal to about 20 m
SCHÜ-MINE 42	anti-personnel; wooden box; 200 g of TNT; almost no metal
CLEARING	mine detectors, and prodding the ground by hand with a bayonet

Mines slowed every Allied advance in Italy. German engineers laid them in fields and road verges, at river crossings and fords, in ruined buildings and doorways, often linked to booby traps. Anti-tank mines stopped vehicles; anti-personnel mines killed and maimed infantry. Americans called the S-mine the “Bouncing Betty”. Allied engineers cleared paths by hand, often at night and under fire, crawling forward and prodding the ground; detectors could hardly find the wooden Schü-mine.

STRENGTHS

+ Cheap and quick to lay
+ Slowed attackers and funnelled them into killing zones
+ The S-mine and Schü-mine were very hard to find
+ Anti-handling devices made clearance dangerous

WEAKNESSES

− Big minefields needed time and engineers to lay
− Could hamper the defenders' own counter-attacks
− Determined engineers could clear a path
− Left a deadly legacy for civilians after the war

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

1935 Tellermine and S-mine enter German service.

1942 Schü-mine 42 and Tellermine 42.

1943–44 The German Tenth Army is said to have laid over 23,000 S-mines in its defences in Italy (one widely repeated figure).

IN ITALY

At the Rapido in January 1944, the first American casualties were caused by mines on the near bank, before the troops even reached the water. At San Pietro in December 1943, mines helped stop the Sherman attack up the village road. Mines laid in 1943–45 went on killing and maiming civilians in Italy long after the war ended.

Where it mattered: Rapido River · San Pietro Infine · Monte Cassino · the Gothic Line

LANDING & TRANSPORT

LANDING AND AMPHIBIOUS CRAFT: DUKW AND LST

The “Duck” amphibious truck and the ship its sailors called the “Large Slow Target”

IN USE: DUKW: from Sicily (July 1943) to Lake Garda (April 1945) · LST: every landing

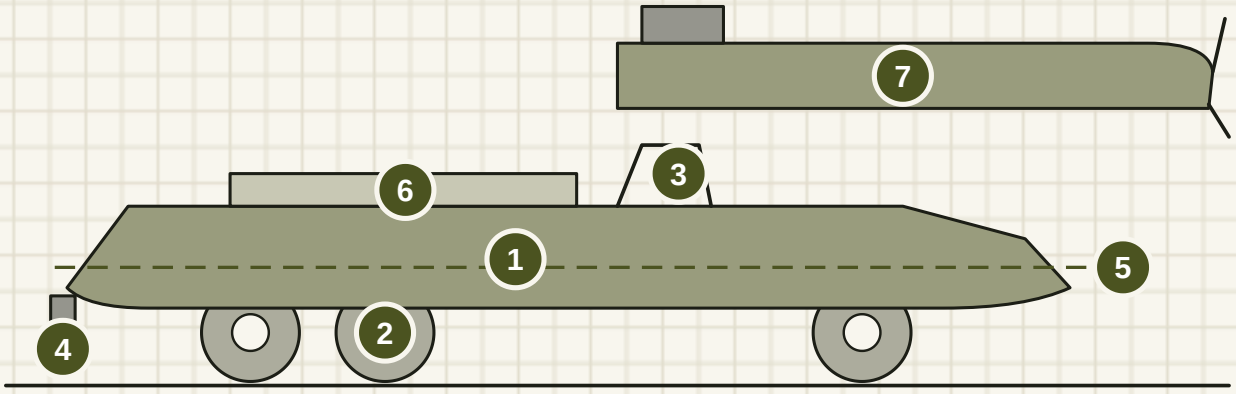


Fig. 19 · Landing and amphibious craft: DUKW and LST DUKW (below) about 9.5 m long · LST (above) about 100 m · not to scale

1. Boat-shaped steel hull round a six-wheel truck
2. Six wheels; tyre pressure could be changed from the driver's seat
3. Driver's position
4. Propeller and rudder at the stern
5. Waterline when afloat
6. Cargo: about 2.3 t, or 24 men
7. LST: bow doors and a ramp land vehicles straight onto the beach

DUKW	6×6 amphibious truck; about 6.2 t empty; 9.45 m long; up to about 80 km/h (50 mph) on roads, about 10 km/h (6.4 mph) in water; about 2.3 t (5,000 lb) of cargo or 24 men; 21,147 built
LST	ocean-going landing ship, about 100 m long, with bow doors and a ramp; carried about 20 tanks or equivalent vehicles and cargo; 1,051 built by the US
LVT “FANTAIL”	tracked amphibian, used by the British in the final offensive of April 1945

The DUKW — the “Duck” to its crews — was a GMC truck built into a boat-shaped steel hull, with a propeller and a rudder. It could swim from a ship to the beach, drive up it and carry its load straight to a supply dump. The LST was an ocean-going ship with a flat bottom and doors in the bow: it ran up onto the beach and tanks and trucks drove straight off. Italy was a testing ground for supply across open beaches: Sicily, Salerno and Anzio were all kept going this way.

STRENGTHS

+ DUKW: no port needed — from ship to dump in one trip

WEAKNESSES

− DUKW: heavily loaded, it could swamp and sink in rough water

+ DUKW: six-wheel drive and adjustable tyre pressure on soft sand
+ LST: landed tanks and trucks directly onto the beach
+ LST: huge cargoes, shuttled back and forth from Naples

– DUKW: thin hull, easily holed by shell splinters
– LST: slow, and a big target on an open beach
– Never enough LSTs in the Mediterranean: they were wanted for Normandy

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

Jul 1943 Sicily: the first invasion in Europe to use DUKWs.

Jan 1944 Anzio: by 31 January, 201 LSTs and 7 Liberty ships had been unloaded (US Army official account).

Apr 1945 LVT “Fantail” amphibians carry British troops across flooded ground and Lake Comacchio in the battle for the Argenta Gap.

30 Apr 1945 A DUKW sinks on Lake Garda with 25 men aboard; 24 drown, almost all from the US 10th Mountain Division.

IN ITALY

At Anzio the beachhead lived by sea supply. Trucks were loaded at Naples, driven onto LSTs and driven off again at Anzio — a method used for the first time in the Mediterranean — and on 29 January 1944 alone 6,350 tons were landed through the little port and over the beaches. DUKWs shuttled between the ships and the dumps day and night, often under shellfire.

Where it mattered: Gela · Salerno · Anzio · Argenta Gap · Lake Garda

LANDING & TRANSPORT

MULE TRAINS

Where the roads ended — which near the front was almost everywhere — supply went by mule

IN USE: Whole campaign, above all in the mountains

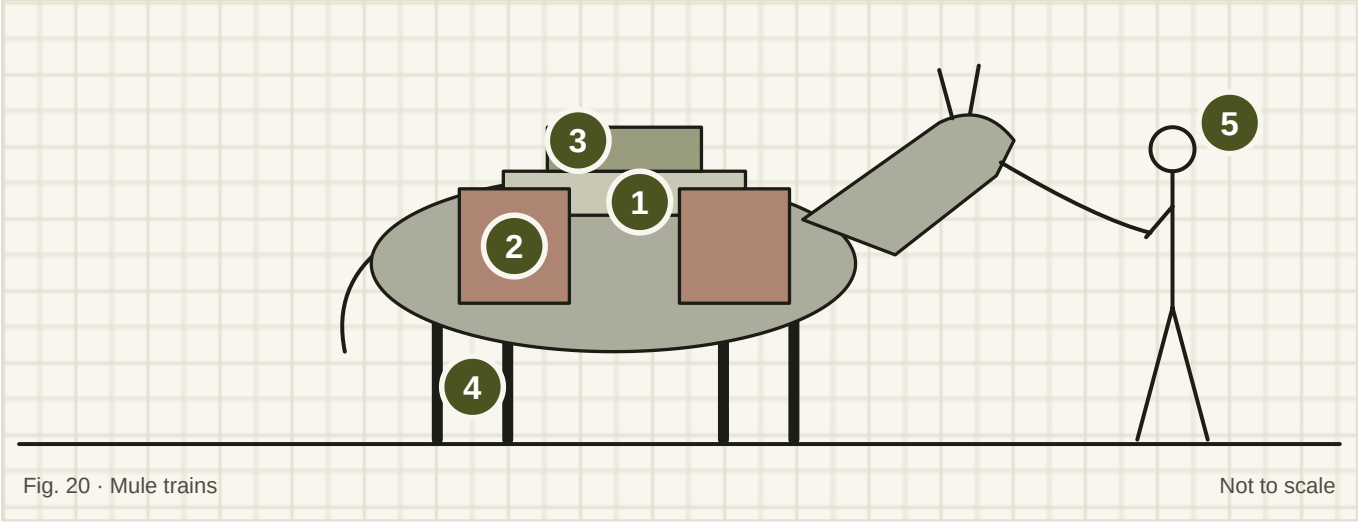


Fig. 20 · Mule trains — Not to scale

1. Pack saddle
2. Loads on both sides: ammunition, rations, water
3. Top load
4. Sure-footed on steep, narrow tracks
5. Muleteer: often Italian, Indian or Cypriot

DEMAND	by one account, an infantry regiment in the mountains needed about 250 animals a day to keep it supplied
LOAD	a standard pack load was about 90–115 kg (200–250 lb), according to the US Army Transportation Corps history of pack mules
UNITS	Allied pack companies, Indian and Cypriot muleteers, and nine Italian Army pack mule companies after the 1943 armistice
CAMOUFLAGE	pale mules were sprayed with potassium permanganate to darken them; it lasted up to two months
BEYOND THE MULES	on the steepest paths, men carried the loads on their backs

In the Apennines, trucks and jeeps could often get no further than the valley floor. From there everything — ammunition, food, water, wire, mortar bombs, even the wounded on the way down — moved by mule, at night, along tracks under enemy observation. The Allies bought Italian mules by the thousand, and after the Italian armistice of September 1943 Italian soldiers and their mule companies worked for the Allies.

STRENGTHS

+ Went where no vehicle could
+ Sure-footed and hardy
+ Needed no fuel, and lived partly off the land
+ Quiet — useful on tracks under enemy observation

WEAKNESSES

− Slow, and could carry only a limited load
− Needed fodder, water and skilled handlers
− Mules and men were shelled on exposed tracks
− Pale animals stood out, and German gunners used them as targets

CHANGES DURING THE WAR

1943 Seventh and Fifth Army commanders find they need pack mules in the mountains of Sicily and Italy.

1943–44 Italian pack companies join the Allied side after the armistice.

1944–45 Mule trains supply the Gustav Line at Cassino and then the Gothic Line in the Apennines through the winter.

IN ITALY

In the mountains around Cassino in the first months of 1944, almost every round of ammunition, every ration and every can of water for the troops on the heights went up by mule or on men's backs, along tracks watched by German observers; animals and drivers were shelled on the way. Cypriot mule companies were among those that supplied the troops at Monte Cassino. When the front reached the Apennines in the autumn of 1944, the same story began again along the Gothic Line.

Where it mattered: Monte Cassino · the Gothic Line · the Apennines

AMMUNITION

Each army had its own rifle cartridge, so Americans, British and Germans could not share rifle and machine-gun ammunition. Within each army, though, the rifle and the machine guns fired the same round. The one exception

was 9 mm: the British Sten fired the same pistol cartridge as the German MP 40, so captured German ammunition could be used.

AMMUNITION	FIRED BY	TYPES	HOW IT WAS CARRIED	NOTES
.30-06 Springfield 7.62 × 63 mm	M1 Garand, BAR, Browning M1919	M2 ball M2 armour-piercing M1 tracer	Garand: 8-round clips in a 10-pocket cartridge belt (80 rounds), plus cloth bandoliers. BAR: 20-round magazines in a belt. M1919: 250-round cloth belts in steel boxes.	A powerful, long-range round shared by the whole US rifle squad and its machine guns.
.303 British 7.7 × 56 mm R	Lee-Enfield rifles, Bren, Vickers	Mk VII ball Tracer and armour-piercing	Rifle: 5-round chargers in cloth bandoliers of 50. Bren: 30-round magazines, usually loaded with 27–28 rounds, in webbing pouches — every man in the section carried some.	A rimmed cartridge, the reason for the Bren's curved magazine. Used by all British and Commonwealth forces and by the British-equipped Polish II Corps.
7.92 × 57 mm Mauser “8 mm Mauser”	Karabiner 98k, MG 34, MG 42	s.S. ball SmK armour-piercing Tracer	Rifle: 5-round stripper clips in leather pouches on the belt. MG: belts of 50, linked into long belts, in steel boxes; 50-round drums for the assault.	The MG 42's enormous rate of fire meant the whole section carried ammunition for it.
9 × 19 mm Parabellum “9 mm”	MP 40, Sten, pistols	Ball	32-round box magazines in pouches.	Common to the Sten and the MP 40: British troops and Italian partisans could use captured German ammunition.
.45 ACP 11.43 × 23 mm	Thompson, M1911A1 pistol	Ball	Thompson: 20- or 30-round box	Heavy, slow bullet: hard-hitting close up, weak beyond about 100 m.

AMMUNITION	FIRED BY	TYPES	HOW IT WAS CARRIED	NOTES
			magazines in canvas pouches.	
Anti-tank rockets and bombs	Bazooka, PIAT, Panzerschreck	Bazooka: 60 mm rocket (M6A1) PIAT: bomb of about 1.1 kg Panzerschreck: 88 mm rocket	In tubes or cases carried by the loader and other men of the team; PIAT bombs in three-round carriers.	All used a shaped-charge warhead, which punches a jet of metal through armour. Also used against houses and bunkers.
Artillery shells	25-pounder, 105 mm, 88 mm, K5	High explosive Smoke Armour-piercing	25-pounder: shell and cartridge loaded separately. 105 mm: “semi-fixed” — shell in a brass case whose propellant bags could be removed. 88 mm: one-piece rounds.	At Anzio, by 14 February 1944, VI Corps artillery was firing about 20,000 rounds a day (US Army official account).
Rockets	Nebelwerfer	15 cm high explosive and smoke 21 cm high explosive	By truck to the launch site; each 15 cm rocket weighed some 32–36 kg.	The 15 cm rocket had its motor at the front and its warhead behind, so the warhead burst above the ground.

The drawings are simplified diagrams that show the main parts; they are not to scale. Figures vary with the model and the source: where sources disagree, a range or an approximate value is given.